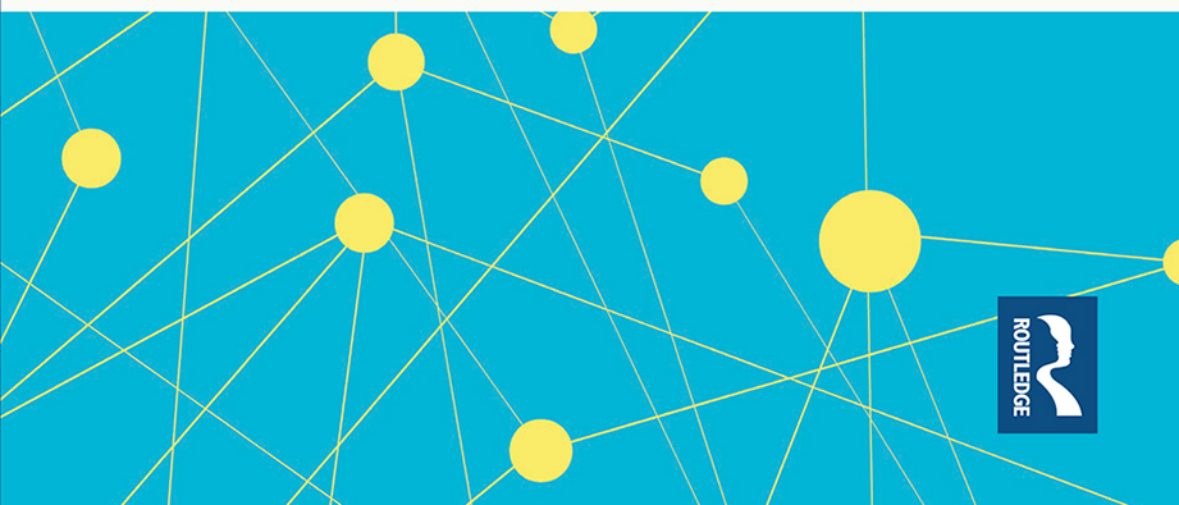


World Association for Sport Management Series

SPORTS SPONSORSHIP AND BRANDING

GLOBAL PERSPECTIVES AND EMERGING TRENDS

Edited by
Ho Keat Leng and James J. Zhang



ROUTLEDGE

Sports Sponsorship and Branding

This book takes a close look at branding and sponsorship in sport in the age of digital media. It examines how branding and sponsorship have evolved in response to the challenges and opportunities of new technologies.

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The book is an essential resource for advanced students, researchers, practitioners, and policymakers working in sport business and management, sport marketing, digital marketing, marketing communications, or brand management.

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Sports Sponsorship and Branding

Global Perspectives and Emerging Trends

Edited by Ho Keat Leng and James J. Zhang

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Chapter 1

Emerging Trends in Sport Sponsorship and Branding

An Introduction

Ho Keat Leng and James J. Zhang

Introduction

There are many contemporary issues facing the sport industry today. Like other industries, the sport industry is going digital. There is a lot of interest in understanding how artificial intelligence and big data can be harnessed in sport marketing activities. Social media, as a new marketing communication platform, is upsetting traditional marketing practices, and brand owners are still learning how to use it effectively. Besides new platforms, there are also new sports. Both academics and industry practitioners are excited about esports as it offers new marketing and sponsorship opportunities for brand owners. With esports making its debut in the Hangzhou 2022 Asian Games, there will be even more interest in the sport. Sport consumers today are also getting increasingly sophisticated and involved. They are aware of social issues and willing to vote with their consumer dollars to let their voices be heard. For example, the issue of green marketing practices and sustainability has remained important for consumers. New social causes such as diversity, equality, inclusivity, human rights, and ethical corporate behaviors are also becoming fundamental in sport programming and marketing. In the last couple of years, the COVID-19 pandemic has ravaged the sport industry, changing many of the practices and creating new norms. This has inevitably affected sport management practices. The sport industry is still finding its way to strike a balance between the wants and safety of consumers in the wake of the pandemic. The above is not an exhaustive list of issues affecting sport marketing today.

The aim of this book is to provide a platform to collate the most important contemporary issues in the area of sport branding and sponsorship for a global audience of scholars and practitioners. In this introductory chapter to the book, a review on sport sponsorship and branding acts as a prelude to the chapters of the book. In particular, it will examine how sport sponsorship and branding has changed in tandem with the external environment. Following the introductory chapter, 15 chapters are divided into two parts: (a) sponsorship and branding and (b) emerging trends.

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In the part on sponsorship and branding, with the growing popularity of esports, it is only appropriate that there should be some discussion on esports in this book. "Sponsorship Strategies and Branding in Esports" describes some of the general aspects in marketing and sponsorship in esports. In contrast, "Antecedents and Outcomes of Sponsorship in the Context of Esports" focuses on the sponsorship of esports using a case study to illustrate some of the arguments. Together, the chapters demonstrate the growing importance of esports in the sport marketing literature. Other chapters in this section examine the important issue of branding and association in sponsorship. The sport industry had often relied on logos as a part of branding in their marketing practices. "Emergence of Logo-less Branding" raises the possibility on the use of logo-less branding in the sport industry. The chapter first provides an overview of the concept and suggests that there are potential applications of logo-less branding in sports. In particular, the chapter highlights several areas of research including brand association that may help develop this strategy further. The chapter "Student-Athlete Name, Image, and Likeness" offers a discussion on the use of student-athletes in sponsorship, a segment that has been discussed less in the literature and often overlooked by the industry.

In the latter section on emerging trends in the industry, several chapters in this book will examine the role of technology in sport marketing. In "Harnessing the Power of Machine Learning in Sport Consumer Behavior Research", the role of information technology in sport consumption research is illustrated with an example using machine learning and big data to identify season ticket holders' defection behavior. "Consumerization of Information Technologies in Sports" examines how information technology is used in consuming sports from different perspectives including from sport spectators, athletes, and sport participants. Through the discussion, it can be surmised that information technology is now firmly entrenched in the consumption of sports. The advent of technology has also brought about new opportunities and threats. Social media allows many members to be connected and share information with each other. With social media becoming a common communication platform for many people, there is the potential for sport entities such as the Olympics to gain higher level of awareness through the sharing on social media. However, such sharing could also potentially allow the images and intellectual properties of the Olympics Games be exploited and affect the income of the governing body. The chapter "Sports Information, Social Communication, and Protection of the Olympic Brand" examines how the International Olympic Council navigates this new media as it attempts to regulate the use of social media in the Olympics.

The COVID-19 pandemic has changed the sport industry. "Impacts of COVID-19 on Sports and Sponsorship" attempt to document how the pandemic has changed the sport industry. It described how the pandemic has reduced the number of sport events, including the postponement of the Tokyo 2020 Olympics (Statista, 2021c). The chapter also examines how the

pandemic affected athletes and other demographic segments. Focusing on physical activity, "Resilience in the Face of Adversity" is a case study examining the effect of the pandemic on physical activity and the sporting industry in Singapore. The chapter found that during the pandemic, the population has taken up alternatives, including online visual programs, to continue to engage in physical activity. As can be seen from the overview of the chapters above, this book will examine many emerging trends in sport marketing particularly in branding and sponsorship.

Sponsorship and Branding in Sport Events

Sport sponsorship is a common marketing communication strategy. It complements other marketing communications tools such as advertising by reaching out to target consumers in creating positive associations and raising brand awareness (Boronczyk, Rumpf, & Breuer, 2018; Meenaghan, 2001b; Nufer & Bühler, 2010; Walliser, 2003). More importantly, it can overcome consumers' negative attitudes toward advertising by leveraging on its universal appeal and its unique wholesome image (Mullin, Hardy, & Sutton, 2007; Pyun, Kwon, Chon, & Han, 2012). It is more than advertising as it also enhances the image of the company with key stakeholders (Meenaghan, 2001a). Sport sponsorship can come in many forms, including the sponsorship of sport events, teams, leagues, stadiums, and athletes (Desbordes & Richelieu, 2019). When companies sponsor sport events, their logos appear in marketing collaterals such as advertisements and brochures. More importantly, their logos are placed prominently within the sport event venue, providing the brand with exposure and association with the sponsored event. Consequently, the effectiveness of sport event sponsorship is often measured by the level of brand awareness among target consumers, including sponsor recall and recognition (Bennett, 1999; Biscaia, Correia, Ross, & Rosado, 2014; Breuer & Rumpf, 2011; Lardinoit & Derbaix, 2001; Leng, 2017; Meenaghan & O'Sullivan, 2013; Walliser, 2003).

Sponsor recall requires respondents to correctly recall the sponsor without any aid. As such, it is sometimes termed unaided recall. Conversely, in sponsor recognition, respondents are presented with a list of brands from which they are to identify the sponsors. This list will contain both dummy and actual sponsors. As such, sponsor recognition is sometimes termed aided recall. Sponsor recall rates are usually lower compared to sponsor recognition rates as they require more cognitive effort. However, sponsor recall is regarded as a more valid measure as it reflects the respondent's salient knowledge of the event or sponsor (Meenaghan & O'Sullivan, 2013). Many studies have found that the rate of sponsor recall is relatively high. Consequently, it is generally concluded that sport event sponsorship is effective (Biscaia et al., 2014; Dekhil, 2010; Leng, 2017; Walliser, 2003). However, sponsor recall and recognition rates can differ across studies as they are affected by many different factors (Walliser, 2003). Mere exposure to the logos of sponsors within a

sporting venue does not necessarily lead spectators to process the message extensively and encode it for retrieval at a later stage (Lardinoit & Derbaix, 2001; Maxwell & Lough, 2009).

Firstly, sponsor recall rate can be affected by the duration of exposure. When spectators at a sport event are exposed to sponsors for a prolonged duration or repeatedly, they have more opportunities to process the visual stimuli (Bennett, 1999). Consequently, they are more likely to remember the sponsors (Breuer & Rumpf, 2011; Cornwell & Humphreys, 2013; Lardinoit & Derbaix, 2001; Leng, 2017). The prominence of the logos is another factor that can affect recall rates. Sponsor logos which are placed in strategically prominent locations, for example, near scoreboards or on athletes, are more likely to be recalled by respondents (Biscaia et al., 2014; Breuer & Rumpf, 2012; Moore, Pickett, & Grove, 1999; Olson & Thjømøe, 2009; Park & Choi, 2011). This is because spectators are more likely to view the logos at such locations. The sponsor recall rate is also dependent on the brand itself. The recall of sponsors can involve a substantial degree of construction and cognitive effort (Johar & Pham, 1999). Brands which have a dominant market share are more familiar to the general population. Due to perceptual fluency, familiar brands require less cognitive resources to process and more likely to attract visual attention (Acar, 2007; Gunaratne et al., 2019; Lang, 2000; Toh, Leng, & Phua, 2022). Consequently, dominant or familiar brands are more likely to be recalled (Breuer & Rumpf, 2011; Herrmann, Corneille, Derbaix, Kacha, & Walliser, 2014; Johar & Pham, 1999; Leng, Wu, & Zhong, 2019). Similarly, when a brand has a strong association with the event, the recall rate is likely to be high as spectators expect the brand to sponsor the event (Dekhil, 2010; Quester & Farrelly, 1998; Robinson & Bauman, 2008).

Some brands may also have logos that possess salient properties that attract visual attention. These include properties such as brightness, contrast, and color which are more likely to attract visual attention and to be recalled by spectators (Itti & Koch, 2000; Leckner, 2012; Milosavljevic, Navalpakkam, Koch, & Rangel, 2012; Nothdurft, 2000; Schindler, 1986). Breuer and Rumpf (2015), in their study on sport telecasts, found that a greater color contrast between sponsor signage and its surroundings resulted in increased attention to sponsor signage. Yet, Park and Choi (2011) did not find sufficient empirical support that any one color was more effective in sport sponsorship. Interestingly, despite the lack of research in this area, some commercial organizations have embarked on marketing strategies that involve changing colors of their logos in sport sponsorship (Henderson, Mazodier, & Sundar, 2019). However, a recent study found that this strategy may not be viable as changing the colors of the logos can affect spectators' familiarity with the logo and reduce visual attention and sponsor recall (Toh et al., 2022).

Studies in sponsorship and brand familiarity provide insights for companies building an international presence. The sponsorship of an international sporting event allows commercial organizations to raise awareness for their

brands in the global market. However, given the difference in brand familiarity across countries, the literature suggests that this can play a role in determining the success of an international marketing strategy (Carrillat, Lafferty, & Harris, 2005). As such, brand owners should first consider whether their brands are familiar with the target spectators before sponsoring a sport event. While sport sponsorship can be used to create brand awareness and communicate with target consumers, this is limited to brands that are already familiar to the target spectators. Commercial organizations who aim to enter a new market with a brand that is unfamiliar to the target spectators may find sponsorship as a strategy limited in its effectiveness (Leng, Wu, & Zhong, 2019). This is especially relevant for Asian brands trying to break into the global market.

Sports had arguably been dominated by western countries in the past (Horton, 2011). As a result, some of the largest and most established sport brands originated from countries in the western hemisphere. However, after the end of World War II, many Asian countries experienced economic growth and demonstrated their ability to host successful major sporting events, beginning with the Tokyo 1964 Olympics. This has created a shift toward the Asianization of sports, driven by Asian commodities, market, and money (Horton, 2011; Lee & Tan, 2019). Many Asian sport brands, e.g., Asics, Giant, and Li-Ning, are now gaining recognition and popularity globally (J. W. Lee & Tan, 2019). Following their western competitors, many have embarked on sport sponsorship as a strategy. It remains to be seen whether sport sponsorship is as effective for these emerging brands when compared with more established, familiar brands. This is an area that will require further research.

Endorsements

Sponsorship is not limited to sport events. When companies sponsor athletes, the athletes are expected to endorse the companies' products. This can come in the form of wearing or using the companies' products in sporting events to provide exposure for the brands. In addition, athletes may also endorse the companies' products in advertisements or any other marketing communications. Endorsements can affect consumers' perception of the advertised product through the halo effect. Athletes possess many attributes. When they endorse a product, they transfer meaning or attributes associated with themselves to the products. As a result, consumers will purchase products with associated meaning or attributes that are congruent with their self-concepts or identity (Erdogan, 1999; Escalas & Bettman, 2005; McCracken, 1989).

When there is congruence or fit between the endorser and the product advertised, the advertisement will be more effective in influencing behavior. This fit of the endorser is dependent on several factors, including physical attractiveness, perceived expertise, and trustworthiness (Eisend & Langner, 2010; Fink, Cunningham, & Kensicki, 2004; Wright, 2016). In particular, when

an endorser is perceived to be an expert in the advertised product, the advertisement is more likely to influence consumption behavior (Amos, Holmes, & Strutton, 2008; Fink et al., 2004; Freiden, 1984; Ohanian, 1991). Hence, athletes who excel in their sports are perceived to be skillful and possess expertise. Consequently, consumers perceive that they are credible when endorsing sport-related products (Behnoosh, Naylor, & Dickson, 2017; T. C. Boyd & Shank, 2004; Felbert & Breuer, 2021; Fink et al., 2004; Kim & Na, 2007; Peetz, Parks, & Spencer, 2004; Yoon & Choi, 2005). When athletes appear regularly in the media, they become celebrities. Consequently, consumers become familiar with them and they can become even more effective as endorsers (Behnoosh et al., 2017; Boyd & Shank, 2004; Bush, Martin, & Bush, 2004; Felbert & Breuer, 2021; Kim & Na, 2007; Peetz et al., 2004; Wright, 2016; Yoon & Choi, 2005). Celebrities can create meaning as they offer a vivid and precise meaning of specific lifestyles and personalities (McCracken, 1989). They act as socialization agents and can affect consumption behaviors, especially among younger consumers (Bush et al., 2004; Dix, Phau, & Pougnet, 2010).

While there are many studies conducted on the effectiveness of athletes as endorsers, the majority of these studies have focused on able-bodied athletes, particularly on athletes who excel in their sports. In comparison, there are few studies examining the effectiveness of para-athletes as endorsers. This is because there is generally less research interest in disability sport, and as such, there remains much that is unknown (Macdougall, Nguyen, & Karg, 2014; Yamashita & Muneda, 2021). The small number of studies has suggested that there is a positive effect on consumers' purchase intention in sponsoring disability sports (Nam & Lee, 2013). In particular, consumers who have a person with disability in the family or hold beliefs on the importance of corporate social responsibility are more likely to have positive attitudes and purchase intentions toward corporations which sponsor disability sports (Park, Yoh, Choi, & Olson, 2011).

Consumers are now more aware of social issues. They are more willing to participate in consumer activism, including boycotting brands and raising awareness on social media. Social issues that have drawn consumer activism in the past include environmental protection, child labor, and discriminatory practices. Consequently, many organizations, including sport organizations, are taking steps to be more socially responsible. For example, the Olympics have over the years tried to be more environmentally friendly. In the 1990s, the International Olympic Council has taken steps to integrate environment as the third dimension of Olympism, together with sport and culture. Since then, host cities of the Olympic Games have demonstrated their commitment to sustainable environmental development in sports and through sports. The 2000 Sydney Games became the first "Green Games". Subsequently, other editions of the Olympic Games have put in place measures to protect the environment. For example, in the 2008 Beijing Olympics, there were more

than 200 environmental programs implemented to tackle environmental issues ranging from air pollution, waste management, and environmental education (Jin & Zhang, 2015).

Disability sports have also been gathering attention in the sport industry. The organized disability sporting movement started in 1949, and the first Paralympics Games was held in 1960. However, in the early years, the media had not been interested in disability sports. In part, this was because the media did not believe disability sports were sufficiently newsworthy (Goggin & Hutchins, 2017). In addition, there was a lack of knowledge among journalists on disability sport competitions to report them accurately and in sufficient depth (Goggin & Hutchins, 2017). As a result, disability sports tend to receive less media coverage when compared to able-bodied sports (Brittain, 2017; Goggin & Hutchins, 2017; Thomas & Smith, 2003). This changed in the 1988 Seoul Olympics when the Paralympics decided to have its own opening ceremony. This provided the Paralympics with a media event, making it more newsworthy. From then on, there has been increasing coverage of the Paralympics (Brooke & Khoo, 2021; Goggin & Hutchins, 2017). However, the coverage of disability sports in the media can still be patronizing and insensitive (Goggin & Hutchins, 2017). This is because para-athletes are inevitably compared to able-bodied athletes (Goggin & Hutchins, 2017; McRuer, 2006). They are considered to be not performing at the same elite level as able-bodied athletes as disability sports are perceived to be inferior, less legitimate, and easier to play (Brooke & Khoo, 2021; Legg & Dottori, 2017). According to Garland-Thomson (2001), images of general disability generally fall into four broad categories. The wondrous category shows the disabled as having amazing achievements; the sentimental category places the disabled in a pitiable, diminished position; the exotic category depicts the disabled as a strange and freakish spectacle; and lastly, the realistic which normalizes the disability, minimizing any difference (Garland-Thomson, 2001; McRuer, 2006).

The images of para-athletes in the media follow this general categorization. Realistic images of para-athletes in the media are designed to hide the disability to minimize differences between able-bodied and para-athletes. The media also shows sentimental images with para-athletes in passive poses that accentuate their weakness. Other sentimental images in the media may focus on the para-athletes' impairment such as the prosthetic limb to invoke the pitiable and diminished status of the para-athlete (Brittain, 2017; Goggin & Hutchins, 2017; Thomas & Smith, 2003). Finally, as the media often adopts the superscript narrative in reporting disability sports, images in the wondrous category are used to emphasize how para-athletes need to overcome their impairments or personal tragedies through heroic feats to secure success (Brittain, 2017; Goggin & Hutchins, 2017; McPherson, O'Donnell, McGillivray, & Misener, 2016; Thomas & Smith, 2003). In sum, while the coverage of disability sports may have improved over the years, there is still some way to go before para-athletes are treated on the same level as able-bodied athletes

(Brooke & Khoo, 2021). This is true in sport marketing as well. As disability sports have fewer spectators, they have less sponsorship interest from commercial organizations. Consequently, there is less interest in sport marketing and sponsorship research in this area. With the growing awareness of disability sports, it is expected that this is an area that is likely to emerge in future. It may be time to examine para-athletes and their personal brand in sport sponsorship studies.

Building a Brand on Social Network Sites

Many people are now on social networking sites, accessing them on a regular basis as a communication tool (Duffett, 2015; Gangadharbatla, 2008; Ting, Wong, de Run, & Lau, 2015). Sport organizations and athletes are also leveraging on this new platform to communicate with spectators and their fans (Abeza, O'Reilly, & Seguin, 2019; Castellano, Khelladi, Chipaux, & Kupferminc, 2014; Frederick, Pegoraro, & Smith, 2021; Laurell & Söderman, 2018; Su, Baker, Doyle, & Yan, 2020; Thorpe, 2017; Wallace, Wilson, & Miloch, 2011). Sport event organizers need to provide timely and relevant event information to spectators (Beech, Chadwick, & Tapp, 2000; Filo, Funk, & Hornby, 2009). As such, they have used social media to connect with spectators and provide timely updates on the event, including images of the event as it unfolds (A. Lee & Leng, 2016; Leng & Chiu, 2019). Sport clubs, particularly those that enjoy a high level of popularity and fan commitment, use social media to achieve their commercial goals, including drawing spectators to the games (McCarthy, Rowley, Ashworth, & Pioch, 2014; Nisar, Prabhakar, & Patil, 2018; Parganas & Anagnostopoulos, 2015; Parganas, Anagnostopoulos, & Chadwick, 2015; Vale & Fernandes, 2018). Finally, athletes are also on social networks sites to engage and share photos of their daily activities with their fans to maintain a connection with them (Geurin-Eagleman & Burch, 2016; Hutchins, 2011; Pegoraro, 2010; Smith & Sanderson, 2015).

Social networking sites are defined as web-based services that allow individuals to construct a public profile within a bounded system, articulate a list of other users whom they share a connection, and view and traverse their list of connections (Boyd & Ellison, 2008). On social network sites, members are likely to have shared interests and know each other. Consequently, messages on social media are more likely to be considered credible. This aspect of social media is attractive to marketers as marketing communications can now be sent to specific targets based on disclosed interests with a high level of credibility. However, marketing on social network sites is different from traditional marketing. Members on social network sites are not only passive receivers of marketing messages but can also actively create shared meaning of the brand with other members (Deighton & Kornfeld, 2009; Geurin & Burch, 2017; Kozinets, De Valck, Wojnicki, & Wilner, 2010). Specifically, social network sites allow members to raise brand awareness, influence brand image,

and state their preferences for specific brands. As such, they can be a source of social influence as members may rely on the perception and judgment of other members in consumption choice, including the development of positive attitudes and consumption behavior toward specific products or brands (Phua & Ahn, 2016; Ruiz-Mafe, Bigne-Alcañiz, Sanz-Blas, & Tronch, 2018).

Social influence is not a recent phenomenon occurring only on social media. Consumers have often relied on others' perceptions and judgments as sources of evidence. This susceptibility to social influence includes consumption choices where consumers learn about products through seeking information from others, conforming to others' expectations to receive rewards or avoid punishments, and establishing one's identity with others through the acquisition of certain products or brands (Bearden, Netemeyer, & Teel, 1989; Deutsch & Gerard, 1955). In the past, social influence can occur on different platforms, including personal communications, television commercials, and printed advertisements. However, on social media, the effects of social influence can become even more accentuated due to the high level of trust among members with existing relationships or shared interest. Comments on social network sites can become a conversational human "voice" (Beukeboom, Kerkhof, & de Vries, 2015). Due to the high level of trust between members of social network sites, information shared on this platform is likely to be perceived as credible. Positive information of a product on a social network site is thus likely to be translated into positive word of mouth (Sandes & Urdan, 2013; Yaylı & Bayram, 2012). Consequently, many studies have found that social influence exists on social network sites, affecting members' perception of quality and purchase intention (Chew & Leng, 2014; Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Duffett, 2015; Koh & Leng, 2017; Phua & Ahn, 2016; Schivinski & Dabrowski, 2015; Wang, Yu, & Wei, 2012).

In comparison, there are fewer studies examining the effect of negative comments on social network sites. Due to negativity bias, it has been suggested that negative comments are likely to attract more attention (Sen & Lerman, 2007). However, it remains inconclusive as to whether negative comments on social network sites can affect consumption behavior, particularly when consumers have preexisting attitudes toward specific brands or behaviors (Ong & Leng, 2022; Sandes & Urdan, 2013). For example, fans of an existing football club are unlikely to change their perception or behavior when exposed to social media posts (Ong & Leng, 2022). This is because the fans already hold existing beliefs about the club and may not rely solely on social media for information (Clavio & Walsh, 2014; McCarthy et al., 2014). Other studies have found that features such as "like" votes and shares can also influence consumption behavior (Beukeboom et al., 2015; Phua & Ahn, 2016; Richard & Guppy, 2014). As such, social influence is not limited to only the comments but also indicators of popularity such as "like" votes. Ratings alone, however, may not have an effect on purchase intention (Duan, Gu, & Whinston, 2008).

While there are many social media platforms, Facebook was one of the earliest popular social network sites. Naturally, many studies have used Facebook as the platform in conducting studies on social media (Abeza, O'Reilly, Séguin, & Nzindukiyimana, 2015). With technological advancements since the launch of Facebook, social network sites have become more visual-centric. For example, Instagram was founded in 2010 primarily for members to share photos and images (Ting et al., 2015). Members also use Instagram to search for information about other people, document their life, demonstrate to other members their coolness and creativity, and share their interests with others (Sheldon & Bryant, 2016). Today, image-sharing social media platforms have evolved to video sharing platforms such as TikTok. As both image and video sharing social media platforms are comparatively new, there are a smaller number of studies on visually centered social network sites (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Sheldon & Bryant, 2016; Su et al., 2020). These studies have found that there were differences in the motivation and gratification sought in using different types of social media (Billings, Broussard, Xu, & Xu, 2019; Lewis, Brown, & Billings, 2017; Machado, Martins, Ferreira, Silva, & Duarte, 2020; Sheldon & Bryant, 2016; Su et al., 2020; Ting et al., 2015). Specifically, users of Instagram were more likely to have stronger social interaction motives in using the social network site (Blight, Ruppel, & Schoenbauer, 2017; Sheldon & Bryant, 2016).

Attitudes toward word-of-mouth communication can also differ across various digital channels due to the presence of images and videos (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; Gvili & Levy, 2016; Schivinski & Dabrowski, 2015). The nature of social network sites favors a quick emotive response rather than a prolonged, conscious, and cognitive response (Leng, 2013). Visual content on social network sites leverages on this nature and allows information to be transmitted to members quickly and in an entertaining manner (Gvili & Levy, 2016). As such, the effectiveness of social media marketing can differ across different types of social media. For example, while social influence in the form of comments by members of a social media network site can affect perception of quality and purchase intention on Facebook, the effect of social influence is more limited on a visual-centric social media platform such as Instagram (Teo, Leng, & Phua, 2019). Consequently, social media is not a single, universal platform but a broad spectrum of tools, each effective for different purposes. Effective social media marketing thus requires the use of more than one social media (Abeza et al., 2019).

The above suggests that sport organizations are likely to continue to use social media as a platform to engage with fans, spectators, and consumers. However, they will need to be mindful that social media marketing is distinct from traditional marketing. As social media is a many-to-many platform, the meaning of the brand is no longer determined solely by the brand owner. Instead, members of the social media site can co-create a shared meaning of the brand by influencing each other in their consumption

decisions. However, the extent of this social influence is dependent on many factors, including the level of existing knowledge of the consumer, the type of social influence, and the nature of the social media platform. Hence, social media marketing is more complicated and sophisticated than simply creating a social media account and posting on it.

Closing Remarks

This book is commissioned by the WASM Executive Board, representing this organization's leadership and commitment to develop, summarize, synthesize, and analyze knowledge that help enhance global sport industry. It covers a range of key sport management issues, particularly in branding and sponsorship, in both global and local settings. The book combines scholarly output derived from diverse inquiry protocols, such as review of literature, documentary analysis, qualitative research, and quantitative investigations. The co-editors of this book have selected research papers relevant to the topical issues. In addition to this introduction chapter, this book contains a total of 16 chapters. The chapters are contributed by a total of 36 scholars representing 10 countries or territories around the world, including Czech Republic, Greece, Iran, Italy, Japan, Malaysia, Singapore, Turkey, the United Kingdom and the United States. Co-Editor Ho Keat Leng and James J. Zhang would like to take this opportunity to thank these eminent scholars for their remarkable contributions to the completion of this book project.

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Part I

Sponsorship and Branding


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Chapter 2

Advertising Investment through Sport Media

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Introduction

Sports advertising investment has two components. The first is advertising the product as sport itself, for example, a sporting event, a competition, or the promotion of a specific team and athlete. The second marketing phenomenon is the communication and promotion of non-sports products through the use of a sporting event as a medium. In the case of the Olympic Games, for example, some sponsors' brands or products can be seen on display. Investment in sports advertising as a commercial practice began in the nineteenth century in Western countries with market economies. Cycling first appeared in the eighteenth century, and by the end of the nineteenth century, manufacturers were putting their own advertisements on cyclists' jerseys. Because road cycling required long rides, the advertising on the athletes' uniforms evolved into a mobile advertising campaign. As a result, over the last century, investment in sports advertising has become a pillar of the sports industry (Zhang et al., 2018). In the early twentieth century, a number of brand logos appeared one after the other in the stadium stands of football matches in the United Kingdom, and by the 1960s, rectangular billboards were erected around the perimeter of the lawn around the stadium, particularly during the 1966 World Cup, as the television medium came to the attention of the viewers. After a half-century evolution, the form of advertising has also evolved and innovated with technological advancement, from a single static advertising board to LED electronic advertising boards, and now to virtual advertising with virtual reality technology. Whatever form of advertising it takes, it has provided an excellent platform for investors and sporting events to be displayed in front of consumers (Shankar & Hollinger, 2007).

Bridges (2008) reports that by 1987, investment in sports advertising in the United States had reached US$3.6 billion, accounting for 7.63 percent of total sports spending. The sport has grown extremely quickly as a result of media broadcast, increasing public interest in sport and, to some extent, increasing sports consumption. Sports have developed rapidly as a result of media coverage, which has increased public interest in sports and, to some

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extent, increased sports consumption. Nonetheless, the growing demand for the scale and funding of large sporting events, combined with the decreasing availability of government funding, has necessitated the need for event organisations to raise funds by recruiting the sports advertising investment industry in order to better run their events (Ferrand & McCarthy, 2008; Müller, 2015). It is difficult to keep the event running smoothly if sufficient funding is not available.

Companies have gained enormous economic benefits from their investment in advertising at sporting events as society has progressed. According to statistics, the 1980 Moscow Olympics received advertising sponsorship from more than 60 companies, the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics had 30 consortia and companies with sponsorship totalling US$4 million (Dyreson, 2015; Kim, 2013), and the 1988 Seoul Olympics had 100 sponsors (Woo & Bae, 2019). The television broadcasting rights to the Sydney 2000 Olympics were purchased by NBC in the United States for $705 million (O'Reilly et al., 2022), the Salt Lake City 2002 Olympics for $545 million, and the television broadcasting rights for an additional $793 million (Beck, 2012). This was followed in 2011 by the agreement to broadcast the four Olympic Games from 2014 to 2020. The Olympic television rights, which include both the Winter and Summer Games, cost $2 billion for the Sochi 2014 and Rio 2016 Games and $2.38 billion for the PyeongChang 2018 and Tokyo 2020 Games (Brittain & Mataruna Dos Santos, 2018). Despite the risk of such a large investment, according to Brittain and Mataruna Dos Santos (2018), almost all of NBC's revenue came from advertising investments, which also helped the company grow from near bankruptcy to its current position as one of the three major US broadcast networks. Companies have reaped enormous financial benefits from their advertising investments in sporting events as society has grown.

Sporting Events as the Driving Force

Currently, the sports advertising investment market is the primary driver of total global advertising growth, which is heavily influenced by major events such as the Olympics and the World Cup. Dentsu, the world's largest advertising agency, has released its Global Advertising Payments Forecast 2022 report, which shows that global advertising spends in 2021 will exceed 2019 levels by 8.7 percent, up 17 percent year on year, and will grow by 8.9 percent due to the 2022 Winter Olympics and Paralympics in Beijing. Meanwhile, with the World Cup in Qatar, a new contribution to ad spending. According to the data, full-year ad spending for 2022 is up 7.2 percent year-on-year. Sport is an important part of the advertising industry, according to the major advertising agencies, particularly Dentsu. While Dentsu has leveraged its position in the Japanese advertising industry to become an integral part of global athletics and swimming finances, but it also has strong connections with FIFA and Major League Baseball in the United States. Currently, the sports advertising

investment market is the primary driver of total global advertising growth, which is heavily influenced by a number of major events such as the Olympic Games and the World Cup.

For many advertising agencies, the sports industry has become a crucial aspect of their business. This is particularly evident for Dentsu, the world's largest advertising agency, which has utilized its position in the Japanese advertising industry to establish itself as a major player in the global sports finance sector. Dentsu has also developed strong partnerships with organizations such as FIFA and Major League Baseball. According to the newly released Global Advertising Payments Forecast 2022 report, global advertising spend will exceed 2019 levels by 8.7 percent in 2021, up 17 percent year on year, with the 2022 Winter Olympics and Paralympics in Beijing driving an 8.9 percent year on year increase. The hosting of the World Cup in Qatar generated nearly $6.5 billion in revenue, which has surpassed all previous tournaments (Calladine & Loyer, 2022). Major sporting events are a key driver of increased advertising spending because advertisers are looking to capture the attention of global audiences. According to the World Advertising Research Centre's (WARC) Global Advertising Trends Survey 2020–2021, the global sports sponsorship market has been growing rapidly for nearly a decade (2010–2020), with overall sports advertising increasing by 5 percent to US$48 billion.

Apart from the Olympics and the European Cup, other major world events such as the NFL, NBA, and MLB have seen major advertising investment spending reach record highs, according to the report. In addition to the Olympics and Euros, the report stated that three of the world's top sporting events, such as the NFL, NBA, and MLB, saw a record $3.97 billion spent on major advertising investments (WARC, 2020). According to Integrate Engineering Group (IEG), the NFL and its 32 teams earned more than US$1.47 billion in sports advertising for the 2019–2020 season, a figure that is nearly 6 percent higher than the previous year's figure of US$1.39 billion (Carp, 2020).

The Tokyo 2020 Olympics served as a good example for the advertising investment market in general. Despite the fact that the entire Olympic Games cycle was affected by the global epidemic of COVID-19, the IOC, TOP sponsors, and local Japanese sponsors all contributed to the Games' smooth running. According to statistics, the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Organizing Committee received US$3.3 billion in advertising funds from domestic sponsors, far exceeding the previous Olympics and the 2016 London Olympics. The impact of the Tokyo Olympics has boosted investment in sports advertising in Asia like never before. In particular, the Chinese advertising industry invested up to $649 million in the PyeongChang Winter Olympics and the World Cup in Russia in 2018, significantly increasing the level of sports advertising investment in Asia.

As can be seen, the advertising and investment industry is heavily reliant on major sporting events to generate large sums of money, despite growing

rapidly in its own right. Dentsu, for example, as the largest investor in the 2020 Tokyo Olympics, took on the task of contacting sponsors and promoting and marketing the event, laying a solid foundation for the Tokyo Olympics' success. Certainly, by investing in major international sporting events, it has contributed to Dentsu's rise to the status of advertising powerhouse in Japan (Calladine & Loyer, 2022).

Advertising Investors' Challenges

The global environment of the COVID-19 outbreak has forced a number of major sporting events to be postponed one after the other, which is not only a shock to the events themselves but also a new challenge to the advertising investment industry. During the COVID-19, the sporting event organisation and advertising investment industries have been exploring ways to connect with consumers digitally. Sports event organisers, as well as advertising investors, face the more difficult task of keeping a large number of consumers engaged even in the absence of major sporting events. Of course, the NHL has relaxed its free digital video content policies in order to protect consumers' content needs and to retain them. FIFA, for its part, has made its entire video archive of World Cup matches available, with over 30 classic matches being released one after the other on FIFA's official website, YouTube, and Weibo. This is undoubtedly a fantastic opportunity for consumers, and the ability to vote for their favourite and supported teams via social media has increased consumer engagement to some extent.

The NHL and FIFA have both made efforts to secure and retain content for consumers, with the NHL liberalising its free digital video content (Rajala & Korhonen, 2020). FIFA, for its part, has made available its entire video archive of World Cup matches, launching more than 30 classic matches on FIFA's website, YouTube, and Weibo (Petersen-Wagner, 2022). This is undoubtedly a fantastic opportunity for consumers, and the fact that they can also vote for their favourite and supported teams via social media has not only increased consumer engagement but also, to some extent, brought in new revenue for advertising investors. In contrast, there is no similar initiative for the media industry as there is for sports organisers. While ESPN has increased its news and original programming, as well as showing videos of a few classic events that are only allowed, Burke Magnus, ESPN's Executive Vice President of Programming, stated that there has been strong consumer acceptance of replaying classic sports events, but the number one hurdle for ESPN right now is resolving the rights issue (ESPN, 2017). Magnus (2020) added, "The challenge now is to replicate this dynamic across multiple networks 24 hours a day, seven days a week. That is the long-term strategy we have in mind".

It is not only a matter of original content or copyright, but it is almost certain that the promotion and collaboration of sports events and advertising

investment industries, which are now heavily reliant on digital platforms, will become pivotal in the future, posing a significant challenge to sports organisers and advertising investment industries. As a result, it is critical for stakeholders to be aware of this issue and changing trends, and to make changes as soon as possible. Of course, a number of experts in the field have already made a series of interventions on this issue, but the important thing is to truly identify and solve the problem in terms of how to face the development and challenges of society and realise the value of the entire value chain.

The broadcast media serves as a conduit between the sporting event and the viewer, and its revenue is generated by advertising fees from advertisers and viewer subscriptions. In the new environment, whether it's original content or copyright issues, advertising investors' investments in sporting events must consider not only how digitally dependent platforms are promoted and partnered, but also the usage habits of group consumers. This is the only way to increase revenue and attention, posing a significant challenge to both sports organisers and the advertising investment industry. As a result, the stakeholders involved should be well aware of this issue and trend and make changes as soon as possible. Of course, many experts in the field have already attempted and had some success in addressing this issue. ESPN, the world's largest sports network, in particular, has attracted a large number of consumers with its quality sports programming, attracting not only a large number of advertising investors for the company's future, but also higher revenues for existing advertising investors. As a result, how advertising investors can truly face societal development and challenges while realising the value of the entire value chain necessitates a true identification of problems and solutions from the ground up.

Advantages and Returns of Investing

Advertising investment in sporting events refers to investment activities conducted through sport, both at the explicit operational level, where investors can invest in tangible entities like events, sports teams, sports facilities, and athletes, and at the invisible level, where investors can invest in broadcasting rights, television, or the internet. Investors gain rights and benefits in exchange, including the ability to show their brand or logo on events and athletes' uniforms, mentions in hosts' broadcasts, and other opportunities to improve their visibility and product sales (Pegoraro et al., 2010; Pyun & James, 2011). Commercial advertising revenue is one of the most important sources of revenue for sports teams. According to the financial statements of the football club Borussia Dortmund, the 2018–2019 season saw a 76 percent increase in advertising placements due to the use of virtual billboards, with total earnings of €377 million, up €60 million from the previous year. Revenue from commercial advertising investments accounted for 40 percent of the club's overall revenue in terms of revenue composition (CoinYuppie, 2021).

Advertising investment efficacy is proved by focusing on three primary areas: media exposure, customer perception, and changes in goods sales, with media exposure being the most obvious form for advertising investors (Cheong et al., 2019). This is usually accomplished by assessing the reach and duration of television or video, as well as the size and audience of the internet or platform. Tracking these media exposure rates and their comparable advertising spend yields media value (Pyun et al., 2020). For example, if a company invests $5 million in a sports team and receives the equivalent of $50 million from media coverage, this means that the company has received $10 in value for every dollar invested in that sports team. But this only counts the time or number of times people see the advertiser or brand when they do, and there is no way of knowing how much information people are getting.

As a result, Sander and Altobelli (2011) looked into the relationship between sports advertising investment and users' willingness to buy, and discovered a positive correlation between users' level of identification and the willingness to buy associated with the advertising investor, implying that users' willingness to buy varies depending on the sporting event or sport in which the advertising investor invests. Park and Inou (2018) also proposes a study for the effects of advertising investment, suggesting that advertising investment has a positive impact on sport and can lead to users feeling good about the brand, which in turn influences their perceptions and attitudes towards the advertising investor. Advertising investors are recognising the potential of investing in sporting events and are pouring large sums of money into the most prestigious events in the hopes of reaping massive profits.

Advertising investors operate with internet, TV, and other media utilising CPT (Cost per Time), which means they charge for fixed advertising space in the form of a contract based on exposure time, in order to achieve fine-tuned management. As a result, many advertising investors target relevant ads based on user gender and habits, allowing them to be more exact in their placement and, as a result, enhance revenue to some level (Weeks et al., 2008). For example, during a game in Barcelona in La Liga, the DBR (DigiBOARD) technology allowed the billboard in the corner to broadcast four different ad investors' advertisements to four live signals in Asia, America, Europe, and the home country at the same moment. This new technology not only multiplies the revenue for the sports teams, but also reduces wastage for the advertisers and allows them to find brand users more precisely (Sport Industry Group, 2017).

Relationship between Advertising and Sporting Events

Advertising investment provides funding, services, and technical support for sporting event organisers; for advertising investors, spending heavily on sporting events increases exposure and visibility of their products or companies. Both are mutually beneficial and supportive of one another, resulting in a

win-win situation (Nufer & Bühler, 2010). Throughout the industry's history, the advertising investment industry initially invested in sporting events for a personal purpose or need, which was considered a charitable act at the time to demonstrate the investment industry's social responsibility. Although the role of this motive is still present today, the primary form has been transformed into a commercial investment decision in the hope of receiving a corresponding report in sporting events, so the purpose of the advertising investment industry has changed qualitatively. According to advertising statistics, 45 percent of TV viewers pay attention to advertisements, 26 percent are doing something else at the same time, and 29 percent choose to skip or ignore them. And only 9 percent of those 45 percent are drawn to the advertisements (Goran, 2022). According to statistics, a company must invest US$20 million in advertising for every 1 percent increase in brand awareness, but if the same amount of advertising money is invested in a major sporting event, the marketing impact can be increased by 10 percent (Perić, 2018). As a result, you get twice the results with half the effort.

The proliferation of sports media and the acceleration of digital adoption have altered how viewers interact with sport, as well as the channels and methods of the advertising investment industry. Nowadays, 40.7 percent of sports fans worldwide watch live sporting events via digital and new media, which not only increases viewership compared to the past, but also benefits the advertising investment industry and, to some extent, the sporting events themselves. According to Nielsen Sports' World Football Report 2018, 43 percent of those polled globally expressed a strong interest in football, ranking it first among all sports, with approximately 57 percent of these fans believing that advertising investors appearing at top sporting events are more credible and more likely to catch the attention of viewers. During the 2018 World Cup, Hisense TVs in China had a sales share of 20.16 percent, ranking high in the top 10 best-selling products for five consecutive weeks, according to statistics. This demonstrates that when brands invest in larger sporting events, they benefit from increased brand awareness and product sales (Nielsen, 2018). In addition to the presentation of the product mentioned above, the manner in which the advertising investment industry exposes itself to consumers at sporting events is unquestionably important in terms of promotion. The relationship between the brand and the event is highlighted in this process, for example, by using a combination of the event's logo and the brand's logo in advertising, or by using advertisements that are closely related to the event, such as broadcast programming, event image material, and event resources, all of which increase consumer awareness and recognition of the advertising investor and the sporting event.

In conclusion, the advertising investment industry provides significant funding for sporting events, laying the economic foundation for event promotion and staging, while sporting events provide a diverse platform for the advertising investment industry, increasing the efficiency of the advertising

investment industry's revenue. The two are mutually dependent, and positive cooperation results in a win-win situation. Commercial investment in the advertising investment industry, on the other hand, serves two primary purposes for sports event organisers. To begin, in order to be more appealing to advertising investors, event organisers must help provide value for money returns to advertising investors to the best of their available resources, including not only revenue from the use of tickets, tangible assets, and various intangible assets, but also some benefit-related procurement arrangements. Second, because mega sporting events are typically government events, the right to solicit and adopt advertising investors should be granted by the government rather than simply accepted as a donation. To avoid a situation of illegality or breach of contract, arrangements containing exclusive procurement rights should be governed by government procurement procedures.

Case Study 1 Olympic Games in Tokyo

As we all know, the Tokyo 2020 Olympic Games are arguably the most special in modern Olympic history. The games were not only postponed for up to a year due to the COVID-19 pandemic, but they were also held without live spectators and in a fully enclosed "Cloud Olympics" format for the first time. The "Cloud Olympics" is a digital technology developed by Alibaba and Olympic Broadcasting Services (OBS) that allows broadcasters to not only manage and create content, but also edit it remotely. This allows any OB work that would otherwise require the use of hardware to be moved to the cloud, making the work more efficient and less expensive while also meeting epidemic prevention requirements. As a result of the various uncertainties, advertising investors have been forced to adopt a conservative investment strategy. The Tokyo Olympic Games are used as an example in this chapter to explain the fundamentals and unique circumstances surrounding advertising investment in the Games.

The success of any Olympic Games cannot be achieved without strong financial support and external publicity from the advertising investment industry. Against the backdrop of the severe epidemic, Japanese advertising behemoth Dentsu Group has been the driving force behind the Games' success, taking on the task of contacting sponsors and marketing the Tokyo Olympics. Dentsu is a multinational advertising company that began in Japan and has grown to become the world's

largest single advertising agency. The company is more than just an advertising behemoth with unparalleled authority and influence in Japan. After successfully bidding to host the Olympic Games, the Tokyo Organizing Committee selected an exclusive advertising partner, which has managed to secure a record-breaking investment of US$3.6 billion for the success of the Tokyo Games even prior to their commencement. The advertisers for the Tokyo Olympics have been categorized into four groups, namely 14 Olympic Global Partners, 15 Gold Partners, 32 Official Partners, and 20 Official Supporters (Calladine & Loyer, 2022).

On the contrary, not all advertising investors have had the same level of success as the Dentsu Group. A series of campaigns, including publicity and promotions, were scheduled to begin several months before the opening ceremony, but they were cancelled or scaled back due to the severe impact of COVID-19. As a result, some major clients have withdrawn their investments at the last minute, fearing that the Tokyo Olympics will damage their brand image (Gallo, 2021; Oi, 2021). Toyota, the highest-ranking top-tier investment firm, announced on July 19, 2021, that it would not place any advertisements related to the theme of the Tokyo Olympics, and the current Toyota president and company executives did not attend the July 23 opening ceremony. In an interview, Toyota's Deputy Executive Officer Jun Nagata and Executive Chairman Jun Tian, who is in charge of public relations, both said the same thing: "The Tokyo Olympics are becoming a difficult event to get support for 'various reasons'" (McGrath, 2021). With today's situation and environment, advertising investors may believe that withdrawing advertising is the safest course of action. Indeed, it is not difficult to see that the advertising industry is also hesitant and struggling with these withdrawal decisions.

Furthermore, the general public's indifference, if not outright opposition, to the Games has made advertising investors even more hesitant. According to a Saito (2021) Asahi Shimbun poll, 68 percent of respondents questioned the Tokyo Organising Committee's ability to control the COVID-19, and 55 percent said the Olympics should not take place as planned in light of the epidemic. As a result, Toyota has only been able to feature issues related to the Games and the spirit of the athletes in its own media, "Toyota lms", and by providing facilities such as sponsorship vehicles to the Games, it not only contributed to the games but also demonstrated the advanced technology of Toyota products for mobility, which amounted to a massive amount of soft advertising.

Even in the face of numerous distractions, other advertising investors had discovered their own marketing development strategies through

another channel. Back in 2014, NBC, a behemoth in US television syndication networks and sports broadcast television, signed a deal to broadcast the Tokyo Olympics, acquiring the rights to do so in the United States. However, according to NBC statistics, 16.7 million people watched the opening ceremony of the Tokyo Olympics on television, a 45 percent decrease from the 2016 Rio Games (Reuters, 2022). Both prime-time viewing and live and taped broadcasts were down 51 percentage points over the same period compared to previous Olympic Games, the lowest ratings for an Olympic event in the previous 33 years. With the opening ceremony receiving such low ratings, NBC shifted their focus from traditional media to digital and streaming platforms, giving advertisers more exposure and marketing opportunities. More young viewers were attracted through this channel, setting a new record for the number of people who watched the live broadcast. According to Annie, an app analytics company, Peacock saw a dramatic 60 percent increase in mobile terminal downloads in the days leading up to the opening ceremony (Munson, 2021). According to data, 12 percent of users watched the Games on Peacock, and 25 percent subscribed to Peacock for the first time as a result of the Tokyo Games.

The addition of streaming not only expanded the distribution coverage of the Tokyo Games, but also created a new revenue stream for NBC (Lafayette, 2021). Not only that, but since the successful bid for the Tokyo Games, NBC has signed up more than 40 premium advertisers, booking an investment of US$1.25 billion alone, which not only offsets the broadcast fees previously paid to the IOC, but also sets a record for advance advertising sales for previous Olympics. As per Dan Lovinger, the Executive Vice President of Sports Marketing and Partnerships, NBC has made a noteworthy contribution to the Tokyo Olympics, with advertising marketing exceeding the double-digit percentages of the Rio Olympics (Steinberg, 2022). This underscores the commitment of significant advertising and investment industries towards the success of the Tokyo Olympics, despite the challenging circumstances. Consequently, this serves as a testament to the dynamic nature of the entire sports marketing market. More money is added to sporting events and the advertising investment industry by creating a strong marginal effect. Even with numerous interventions, major global events such as the Olympics can maintain their position at the top of the advertising investment revenue pyramid.

Case Study 2 Beijing Winter Olympics

The Beijing Winter Olympics was the first comprehensive global sporting event to be held on schedule since the COVID-19. The games were held on schedule, igniting the passion for snow and ice sports and uniting the Olympic spirit for athletes and spectators around the world. A world top sporting event cannot be held without the support of athletes and spectators alike, and also without the support of adequate advertising investment funds (Nuseir, 2020). This chapter will therefore take the Beijing Winter Olympics as a case study to analyse the plight of the Beijing Winter Olympics and the investment and return on advertising investment and what economic effects it has brought.

The run-up to the Beijing Winter Olympics has been met with a number of political issues around the world, such as the political turmoil in Ukraine and Russia, the announcement of a diplomatic boycott of the Beijing Winter Olympics by President Biden and other Western leaders, etc. (Chappelet, 2021; Enos, 2021). These sensitive political issues have put many advertising investors in a difficult position of either being increasingly driven out of the increasingly sensitive Chinese market or dealing with the reputational risks in China. Nevertheless, some of the most famous brands in the world were still present at the Winter Olympics, for whom the sporting event is a very good platform to showcase their brands and strengths, and cannot let political issues affect their own development. For example, Samsung and Audi cycled their advertisements on the electronic boards of the competition, Coca-Cola decorated the five Olympic rings on their cans, P&G opened a beauty salon in the Olympic Village, etc. These prominent multinational companies are unmoved by the repressive campaign to boycott human rights in Xinjiang in the face of multiple national mouths, steadfastly choosing to continue to keep China and its emerging nationalist consumer base satisfied (Koenigstorfer, 2020; Li, 2021).

The choice of advertising investors determines their positioning. They have stated that their advertising investment in the Olympic Games is not related to politics and have stated that it is not just the Beijing Winter Olympics, as they have continued to invest hundreds of millions of dollars in investment contracts in the Games for many editions. In particular, OMEGA, the official timekeeper and data provider for the Winter Olympics, says that since they began working with the Games in 1932, they have explicitly excluded themselves from certain political issues as this is not conducive to promoting sport (International Olympic Committee, 2017). As a result, despite the international situation in which the Beijing Olympic Games find themselves, the Games, always

a top-level global sporting event, still attract investment from many well-known companies and sponsors both at home and abroad. According to the "Beijing 2022 Winter Olympic and Paralympic Games Economic Legacy Report" released by the Beijing Winter Olympic Organizing Committee, in addition to the 14 Olympic Global Partners, the Beijing Winter Olympic Games signed up 45 advertising investors, including 11 official partners, 11 official sponsors, 10 exclusive official suppliers, and 13 official suppliers (Beijing 2022 Olympic and Paralympic Winter Games Organizing Committee & Beijing Sport University, 2022). This compares with the data published on the official website of the International Olympic Committee for understanding the advertising investment revenue of the Winter Olympic Games, the investment and sponsorship revenue of the Beijing Winter Olympic Games market has far exceeded similar figures for previous Olympic Games.

According to media reports, 72 percent of the amount invested in the Beijing Winter Olympics came from advertising investors, 22 percent from the International Olympic Committee, and 6 percent from government subsidies (China News, 2015). These investments were not only used in medical, transportation, and venue construction, but also applied to the overall operation of the Winter Olympic Games venues and related infrastructure. The total investment is approximately US$31.1 billion, second only to the US$51 billion invested in the 2014 Winter Olympics in Sochi, Russia (Sina, 2022). At the same time, many advertising investors are targeting internet platforms. Since the Winter Olympics, all the major APP terminals and social media platforms have made efforts around the Winter Olympics, for example, by putting the slogans "Winter Olympics" and "Ice and Snow" under the app icons, or by creating special channels on the platforms for " Winter Olympics" channel on the platform. According to the data, since the opening ceremony, MIGU video has become the second most downloaded app in China (Jiemian News, 2022). During the week of the competition, from 2 February to 7 February, the daily active user base of MIGU video increased by 50.4 percent compared to the week before the competition (China Network, 2022b). On top of these basic user figures, advertising investors leveraged the internet's Winter Olympics platform for marketing, which became an important opportunity for branding as well as boosting user goodwill. This shows that relying on a top event such as the Beijing Winter Olympics has brought considerable exposure to advertising investors.

In addition, the Beijing Winter Olympic Games has not only exploded on the internet and become the top stream in the world, but also

brought new revenue points for advertising investors. By the end of 2021, the Beijing Winter Olympic Games had developed more than 5,000 licensed merchandise in 16 categories, covering more than 190 licensed merchandise retail shops in 19 provinces and cities in China offline. According to the data, the revenue from the sales of licensed merchandise for the Winter Olympics exceeded approximately US$373 billion (Beijing 2022 Olympic and Paralympic Winter Games Organizing Committee & Beijing Sport University, 2022). Besides the explicit benefits described above, the success of the Beijing Winter Olympics has activated China's snow and ice economy, bringing hidden long-term benefits for advertising investors (He et al., 2020). As of October 2021, the number of Chinese residents who have participated in snow and ice sports since the successful bid to host the Beijing Winter Olympics in 2015 is 346 million (China Network, 2022a). China is currently the only fast-growing ski market in the world, and according to data from the China Snow and Ice Industry Development Research Report (2021), in 2020–2021, China's snow and ice leisure tourism revenue exceeds US$58.25 billion, and it is expected that by 2025, the number of Chinese snow and ice tourists will exceed 500 million people and revenue will exceed US$164.3 billion (Xinhuanet, 2022). It is clear that the Beijing Winter Olympics has become a catalyst that not only provides more opportunities for major, medium, and small advertising investors, but also promotes the development of China's snow and ice economy. It makes snow and ice not only a sport, but a modern industry.

Discussion

Although both Games encountered problems of one kind or another in the environment of the COVID-19, the organisers and advertising investors responded positively and made efforts to make the Games run smoothly. In the end, however, any previous Olympics will serve as a lesson for the future. Only by taking stock of the experience and capitalising on the Games' business opportunities can advertising investors earn the highest possible returns, which is the ultimate goal of top Olympic advertising investors. The postponement of the 2020 Tokyo Olympics to 2021 due to the COVID-19 pandemic has disrupted the marketing campaigns of investors who had planned for the original schedule, forcing them to navigate contract extensions or cancellations. In addition, the withdrawal of advertising investors and other factors have resulted in the organizers of the Olympics having to reduce costs and

rely on government funding to fill the budget gap. This presents a significant challenge for both event organizers and advertising investors.

The organisers of the Beijing Winter Olympics, on the other hand, knew exactly what it meant to postpone the games. The government's and the country's approach to COVID-19 prevention and control not only allowed the games to run smoothly, but also drew on the successful experience of the Tokyo Olympics, which saw a complete upgrade of live streaming and broadcasting technology to provide viewers with higher-quality viewing resources. The Beijing Olympics consequently attracted a sizable online audience, giving advertisers more opportunities to present their brands and make sizable profits. The world's top sporting event, the Olympic Games, has been a major platform for advertising investors to present themselves and generate effective revenue, but this does not mean that the Olympic platform should be used as a showcase. It is important to take advantage of the hidden benefits of the Games for long-term economic gain. This will not only promote the development of the advertising investors themselves, but will also better promote the sport.

Advertising and sport are inextricably linked, with advertising investors supporting modern sport and laying a solid economic foundation for the preparation of sporting events. This is because sport itself has a strong interaction function and a very urgent need for the economy. This function and demand are objective, intrinsic, and not subject to the will of humans. The success of the Beijing Winter Olympic Games has brought unprecedented economic development to China and promoted the progress of ice and snow sports in China and even in Asia. Sports events have therefore become a special form of advertising medium, offering considerable opportunities and huge economic benefits for advertising investors.

To summarise the role and impact of advertising investment in sporting events, advertising investors can attract consumers through forms of publicity or marketing such as sporting events, which serve as a link between sport and the public. It is the link between sport and the public. It is mainly reflected in building the brand image of the investor, increasing market share and creating social and economic benefits. However, in the process of development and competition, advertising investors still need to pay attention to some issues. Firstly, before investing in a sporting event, sports investors need to consider the internal and external environment of the sporting event in various aspects in order to formulate a proper investment strategy. Secondly, when dealing with top sporting events such as the Olympic Games and World Cup, it is important to supplement publicity with other communication tools such as marketing and public relations before the event. At the same time, advertising investors should make good use of their advantageous projects or brand effects, and choose their investment forms carefully according to their investment objectives and investment projects to achieve the purpose of risk avoidance.

In terms of the current and future trends in the sports market, event broadcasting rights and commercial advertising are very good investment opportunities. As an advertising investor, it is important to fully understand the importance of sporting events. At the moment, sports are the best communication target for both traditional and new media. In the view of advertising investors, it can attract more consumers, especially when the game is interrupted by timeouts, fouls, and other game intervals, all of which are excellent advertising opportunities, making a natural connection between the game and advertising. This allows viewers to leverage the atmosphere and emotions of the game to achieve brand enhancement and emotional migration for the advertising investor. This not only raises brand awareness while spreading the word about the event and expanding its reach. Of course, the Olympic Games, as the most highly recognised sporting competition, has a kind of incomparable status in the hearts of the audience, and it is all the more important for advertising investors to seize the opportunity to perfectly integrate with the event and make comprehensive use of diverse means of resource integration to achieve their revenue goals.

The advances in technology and the internet have not only affected the organisation of sporting events, but have also opened up more investment opportunities for advertising investors. Advertising investors should be more responsive to social developments and trends and make full use of the sports market platform to explore new areas of investment. By using the network and technological resources as a basis, they can establish a variety of targeted partnerships to bring advertising investors and sporting events closer together, forming a win-win model of mutual reliance, mutual influence, and mutual promotion in the sports market.

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Chapter 3

Sponsorship Strategies and Branding in Esports

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Introduction

There is not an overall accepted definition for esports. Not all electronic games are necessarily considered as esports. Typically, the term "esports" (electronic sports) refers to organized competitive video gaming among professional players. Here, we should emphasize that any game to be included in esports category should meet three criteria: (1) It should have organization, (2) it should be competitive, (3) it should be professional. Playing games at home or as hobby is not considered to be esports. Esports are usually practiced in a league tournament format, with a specific goal or prize, such as winning a championship title or prize money. Therefore, we can consider competitive video gaming as a synonym for Esports. It simply refers to a computer game played in professional competitions, especially when it is watched by fans and broadcast on the internet or on television. Moreover, the element of teamwork or multiplayer battle is important in order to categorize a game among esports, or else there are many other games meeting the above criteria. In the other words the games should have the following criteria other than the above ones: (1) fighting, first-person shooter (FPS) and (2) multiplayer online battle arena (MOBA). Some examples are the video game versions of classic sports (such as FIFA football) or motor racing games (Pfeiffer et al., 2022). Sponsorship is a well-known tactic involving two factors: sponsor and sponsee. Sponsor refers to the organization that provides another organization financially or by products in return for the other organization to promote their brands to the target group. Sponsee refers to the organization that receives the amount of money or product to promote the brand of the sponsor to the target group in return (Meenaghan, 1991).

The people did not take esports as serious a decade ago and made fun of it when someone spoke about sponsorship in esports (Kramer et al., 2021). It is not surprising to see that gaming hardware and peripherals are trying to develop sponsorship in esports because they know their target customer completely. However, the industry has flourished in the past few years by absorbing more people in different parts and enlarging the industry in different ways.

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If we are going to name some of the characteristics of esports, we can say: (1) a great number of fans and audiences, (2) market complexity, (3) development of technological appliances, and (4) well-known gamers. All these are the elements required for a company, industry or sport in order to be successful in its marketing methodologies and reaching its goals (Crompton, 2004). The aim of this chapter is to analyze sponsorship and marketing in esports.

Sponsorship

The popularity and importance of sport in past 50 years has changed it into an industry, the sports industry. The speed has been doubled in the past 30 years (Tufail et al., 2014). Customer relationship management (CRM) is the main factor for an industry to be successful. Customer loyalty and retention is the result of quick delivery of accurate and descriptive information to the consumers (Kluegel & Smith, 1982). The function of professional sport organizations is dependent highly on the revenues resulting from commercial activities (Khosromanesh et al., 2019). Holding sport events requires sport organizations to take sponsorship as serious as possible (Gawrysiak et al., 2020). The role of sports sponsorship in promoting and financing games is undeniable (Houghton et al., 2014). Donlan (2014) stated, "Brand quality and loyalty are the results of successful sponsorships" (Donlan, 2014). Koronios et al. (2016) asserted, "sport sponsorship is a means of promoting sport through solving financial problems and supplying sponsors" with products and services (Koronios et al., 2016).

We cannot pass over the role of sponsorship in holding event marketing which has been performed in the past 30 years very seriously. "Marketing through sports" is a branch of event marketing in which major sport events like the Olympic Games, the Union of European Football Associations (UEFA), Champions League, the World Marathon Majors, and the Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) are sponsored, with live advertisements of companies' products and services. It is a sign of a great prospect for marketing (Bennett et al., 2002). There is a strong relationship between sports sponsorship and marketing of companies' products and services. Commercialization of sports is a reason for great promotion and sponsorship in sports events. Another privilege of sponsorship is brand awareness and a strengthened brand image. Doshybekov et al. (2016) explained that involving sponsorship is the most important factor for the success of holding event by which the organizations can afford the great expenses of the games (Doshybekov et al., 2016). On the other hand, increasing brand exposure and communicating a positive image of the business to stakeholders is the benefit that the sponsors can get through sponsoring.

The advent of internet made the most benefit to gaming and has made many changes in it. Already, the people used to play games or esports in closed places. But nowadays, the gamers can do it in any place (Carter & Gibbs, 2013).

Esports are a new and well-organized form of games with the best and most skilled players who get involved in the games to get socially respected, win money, prize, etc. (Moorman, 2008). Esports are a collective term that encompasses a wide number of disciplines (i.e., videogames) and even tournaments can feature various games (Scholz, 2020). From 2010s, esports' popularity grew more and more (Scholz, 2020) so that it is a global phenomenon now (Pfeiffer et al., 2022). According to the statistics, esports have speeded over other sports in their progress (Sylvester & Rennie, 2017), and are generally among fastest-growing industries (Stein & Scholz, 2016). Popularity, economic relevance (Hiltscher, 2013), and worldwide reach (DiFrancisco-Donoghue & Balentine, 2018) are all the reasons why many people and industries in the world are trying to attach themselves to the games. That is why, just in 2016, over 600 brands started sponsoring esports (Hiltscher, 2013).

Besides the reasons mentioned above for the companies sponsoring esports, there are some other reasons. First, some believe that sponsoring esports may improve the sponsor's image. Maybe, the reason is that the esports fans accept sponsorship in an unexpected manner (Freitas et al., 2020a; Scholz, 2020). In other words, in esports industry, the audiences have more understanding of esports expenses and how much they need to survive unlike the ones in traditional games (Scholz, 2020). Since fans believe that taking part in competitions requires financial sources for the games, they put much into sponsors and try their best to keep them (Hiltscher, 2013). They think that this makes a mutual understanding between them (Chung et al., 2019). Second, sponsorship helps people make their selection through the many brands that exist in the market. People are bewildered by the bands that dominate market (Freitas et al., 2020a). It is hard for them to choose from among them. At this atmosphere, organizations can make advantage of this factor and create a good brand image for themselves and also use it as a great competitive advantage (Freitas et al., 2020b). This process is facilitated by advertisement, but what we should pay attention to is that sponsorship is less commercial (Bennett, 1999). Brands are subject to benefit from their improved image if they do not get so much involved with commercial environments (Scholz, 2020). Additionally, the low cost of sponsorship in esports in comparison with sports is considered as an important and essential advantage for it (Scholz, 2020).

SWOT Analysis of the Esports Industry

Knowing external and internal factors effecting any organization is important in order to stablish strategic marketing for the organization and draw its final mission. Here, we introduce SWOT analysis of esports. The strengths include the following: (a) audience – the supporting audience of esports industry is a great wealth for this industry. According to the studies conducted by GameScape report by Interpret LLC on demographics of gamers: the audience is

consisting of all ages. The average age of esports viewers is 28, and 39% of the audience are in the range of 25–34. More than half of the viewers are graduated, and 55% of them are full-time employees (Wardle et al., 2020); (b) "brand vacuum" – development rate of esports industry in the world is surprising (Wardle et al., 2020). Many companies made a mistake in their considerations and did not put much into esports industry. As a result, they ended into failure and regret. About 2016–2017 great brands like Red Bull and Monster Energy changed their opinion and eventually agreed to roll up their sleeves in order to take part in the market, smaller players appeared, and many successful marketing brands were published; (c) the charismatic personality of the ideological leaders in the market. Ideological leaders are very influential in the gaming environment in general and esports in particular. It is a benefit for these games that their leaders are marketers and mainly try to promote esports market instead of getting overwhelmed in collecting money and thinking about their cash, as is the case with many careers and businesses; and (d) infrastructural formation of the market: It is an honor for esports that the physical and software structure is so well organized that any company with any budget can take part in the games from 2020. The diversity seen in the games adapted to the fans and gamers is a reason for their great structure. This great structure should be broadcast by media.

Weaknesses include the following: (a) lack of awareness – familiarity of the people with esports and its mechanism is a great point. Most of the people in the world are not familiar with this wide-reaching phenomenon. It can be considered as a weakness or deficit for the games and its industry; lack of data – only a few companies in the world are dealing with esports professionally and collect and analyze data. That is a reason why many industries willing to get involved in this scope get hopeless when they are confronted with the great amounts of the reports and information required in order to enter this industry; (c) this should be regarded as a money-making business – the officials in this industry do not pay so much attention to money obtained from receiving advertisement. They prefer to keep the respect of their crew consisting of their customers and also workers. That's right that money and advertisement are not the first priority. But they should not be ignored anyway.

Opportunities include the following: (a) professionalism – esports players are somehow addicted to computer. It requires esports organizations to hold training sessions and studying routine for the professional players. Because in the close future they will play the role of a model or pattern for other generations. That's why the officials and those involved with the games usually have a good behavior toward professional players who get engaged in producing harmful and bad content and try to show it in the multimedia. It brings about great opportunities for the industry to hold courses and classes around moral doctrines and working as a model for other industries and careers; and (b) mobile esports – mobile esports have made different audiences and careers to flourish in this industry. Besides working as an endemic sponsorship, it helps

make people more familiar with the games and also make them interested. The use of mobile for the games has increased greatly especially in Asian countries in the 2010s. Come companies such as Riot Games, Activision, and Valve publish mobile version of their products worldwide. In all mobile esports is a great source of revenue, and it is a great opportunity because only few mobile esports have been announced.

Recognized threats include the following: (a) segmented fan base – targeting a specific audience is very hard for the brands. The reason is that each game or set of games have their own specific audience. This atmosphere, in which there is a lack of knowledge about the games and most of the people are not familiar with the games, is very detrimental to the investment process in esports industry by other organizations. It makes the sponsors doubtful of the industries plan and prevents them from investing in the industry; and (b) advertising unhealthy lifestyle – typically, the people attribute esports and gaming to unhealthy lifestyles. Prompting lazy health and wrong fitness habits are some of the threats in esports, which make parents unwilling to let their children follow this sport (Wardle et al., 2020).

Viewership of Esports

With the growth of networks, mobile infrastructures, and internet technologies, esports will be potentially capable of attracting more fans. The development of 5G networks has paved the way for the people to add to this ever-growing industry. This rise has led the video game developers to consider several factors when they approach the game design to engage larger audiences, such as bringing in a strong competitive element that offers a variety of meta and room for players to experiment. An important factor for game developers is to take two elements into consideration: (1) the game should be fun to play, (2) the game should be exciting to watch. This contributes to the exciting atmosphere of the games and also the freshness of the game for players. The policy makers should think of a way to push the people more and more toward this industry by making appropriate rules. For example, they can consider a course in the educational schedule of the schools and universities regarding esports. Besides, esports can bring those excluded from the society together and attach them to the communities where they belong to. Also, those grown in underserved communities can fund their studies and make a glorious future for themselves (esports overview). All these contribute to the growth of this industry and viewership.

The spread of COVID-19 at the first quarter of 2020 cause many countries in the world to close their league and rethink how to do their business. As these traditional sports were stalled, many are turning to esports, for both involvement and enjoyment. As such, the already fast-growing industry is set to expand more rapidly. As the popularity of esports grows faster and faster, we face a variety of risks in the industry. Physical injuries, emotional disorders,

and cyber hacking are some of the risks facing the players. Therefore, the industry officials should think of a way to neutralize these risks. The process includes the following: (a) an evaluation of the geopolitical atmosphere of the event location, (b) close attention to critical infrastructure required to support the event, (c) taking all the stakeholders into consideration, and (d) monitoring any destructive factor such as environmental ones (esports insights). In the end, we should assume a great future for Esports as the rising trend of Esports viewership has attracted millions on social media.

Market Segmentation

What attracts people to electronic games, in the first stage, is the interaction and communication of players with each other in these games virtually. In this respect, involving with the game itself is in the second stage. At the next levels we have the fun nature of the games and ultimately the feeling of winning in people (Oviatt & Seneff, 2004). This system is fully consistent with the theory of the hierarchy of needs proposed by Maslow. Just as in the theory of the hierarchy of needs, the sense of enjoyment and the sense of being social and belonging to the group and society are important aspects of involving with the games. Research in this field shows that online and offline games equally satisfy the sense of belonging to a community and group in people. In this way, the players connect with each other by having a common goal (Eklund, 2015).

What are the motivational components of esports players? A 2006 study identified three motivational components: the development component, the social component, and the immersion component (Yee, 2006). Therefore, at least three different approaches can be considered for these players in the esports industry: The first approach states that players are attracted to these games due to their competitive and sports consumerism. The second approach states that players participate in electronic games according to Maslow's hierarchy of needs to socialize and join groups and communities. The last approach points out that players are attracted to esports because they have a desire to enjoy. To be more precise, when players are immersed in the content of the game and its various parts, the feeling of enjoyment is best expressed. One of the available statistics in this field states that the players present in these games are 26 years old on average. These people usually spend 22 hours a week in these environments (Yee, 2006). In recent years, the average age of players has changed to 35 years. Also, the researches show that 56% of men and 44% of women take part in the games (Tseng, 2019).

As mentioned, the criterion is not just playing and playing video games. Some people watch the games and participate in the games as well. Many people prefer to watch games online or use services like Twitch instead of spending time playing games. In fact, this is one of the motivational components in this field (Sjöblom & Hamari, 2017). What makes people spend their time watching games? In their research, Hamari and Sjöblom concluded that

people who watch games can reduce their stress in this way, and this works for them as a stimulus in order to control their stress. This is an important factor that has made esports decision makers think about providing the necessary conditions for the broadcast of games on global networks and media.

Social Media Marketing in Esports

Social media marketing (SMM) increases customer access and profit, and promotes brand image and other business goals through social media channels (Wilson et al., 2010). Proper implementation of this technique will increase revenue, innovation, and product improvement; increases brand awareness and customer satisfaction; and creates favorable conditions for customers to search about products and ultimately increases their loyalty (Nair, 2011). Social media marketing plays an important role in esports because the life of organizations in this sport depends on sponsors and investors. We need to be able to present a good image of the audience in the community in order to attract more sponsors. In other words, sponsors in esports prefer to negotiate with a well-known team that has a well-known audience. It is important to note that attracting audience in this way is difficult, but retaining the audience is much more difficult. If social media marketing strategy is implemented well and in the right channel, we will see a great impact on the audience (Cvitanović, 2021).

Usually, the content of the social media pages of sports teams is not different from each other and is similar: match results, interviews with players, promotional posts of organizations, video reports, and mentioning sponsors in each post. The fact is that esports should try to present different and distinctive content to retain and keep the audience. Interaction rate is an indicator that can be used to calculate the effectiveness of content. The level of interaction means how much the audience has understood and is interested in the content, so conducting statistical research qualitatively and quantitatively can help a lot (Cvitanović, 2021).

Sponsorship Strategies

According to Tomlinson (2021), it is predicted that by 2022, the global esports revenue reaches $1790. Most of this revenue is generated by sponsorship. As a result, esports turns into a great priority for all brands. Therefore, it requires a sponsorship strategy to fulfill this mission by esports industries. Here we introduce nine strategies regarding esports industry to have a more splendid future:

- Find the right esports audience. Designing a marketing plan requires you to know the esports community as much as possible. This plan should ensure that all esports fans are included. Like traditional games, the audiences can be classified according to the type of sport they like. Some of

these are player vs. player (PvP), first-person shooter (FPS), real-time strategy (RTS), multiplayer online battle arena (MOBA), and massively multiplayer online role-playing games (MMORPG).

- Identify the right channels. After knowing and getting familiar with the audiences, it is essential to recognize where they are going to spend their gaming time. Here we introduce some of the streaming platforms. The most popular ones are Twitch, Hitbox, Azubu, YouTube Gaming, Bigo Live, and Gosu Gamers.
- Partner with esports influencers. After getting the right channel, we should go for finding a good influencer which can attract audiences. An influencer can be a character in the game wearing, for example, a branded shirt. This brand has been promoted everywhere. As a result, the game gets more fans and becomes more celebrated.
- Launch an esports team. Teams are group of gamers having a mutual feeling about a game. We can look for partners in Facebook and in the social accounts and websites.
- Host team events. As a beginner, you should start from a small scale and look for businesses that may be willing to sponsor the event.
- Use an agency for team building. Getting help from agencies can be a great hand if you have a lack of time and energy. Consulting these agencies can be a great wealth for you in order to make your fortune.
- Co-Sponsor an event. If you are trying to get more fans in the future, the best way is to co-sponsor an event.
- Focus on content marketing. Content marketing is about information delivered thoughtfully. It is promoting your brand or business by sharing entertaining, educational, and enlightening information that will add value to your audience's lives. Content marketing makes a good memory of the brand in the minds of the audiences. You can use your partner influencers to create exclusive content for you. Moreover, the content can be promoted through websites and social accounts.
- Evaluate and revise your strategy. All the above steps are arranged in a way to get good results. If not, they are all fruitless. In order to make sure about the efficiency of this process, evaluation is a must. We should be realistic and accept the deficits and try to mend them in the future.

Who Are the Major Esports Sponsors Today?

In spite of esports being in its early days, a number of brands, including endemic and non-endemic, ones are gathering around it. In esports, endemic firms include tech-centric companies such as Asus, Dell, Logitech, Microsoft, Nvidia, Razer, Samsung, and other technology-related companies (Chung et al., 2019). And non-endemic ones are brands having no relationship with esports such as energy drinks and credit cards. For example, Twitch, the social media platform specific to esports, is classified as an endemic sponsor, while

Audi, a manufacturer of luxury automobiles, is positioned as an example of a non-endemic sponsor. Energy drinks and caffeinated drinks are classified as non-endemic because they are not only allocated to esports industry, but, also, they cover a variety of markets. However, some people say that we can categorize them among endemic brands because they provide the necessary energy needed for a gamer while playing. No information has been revealed regarding their agreements. But it seems that they are earning great revenues in this respect as they are so persistent to continue their involvement. In spite of the industry's small structure in all aspects, sponsorship plays a great role in getting the revenues. It is a hint of this industry for a splendid future.

Esports and Endemic Sponsors

Endemic sponsors are the brands that create products used in the production or playing of esports, such as software and computer component manufacturers. In other words, endemic sponsors work around esports-specific products. These products are either the components of esports industry or the gaming itself. Therefore, it is easier to have access to endemic sponsors in comparison with non-endemic ones (O'Reilly & Huybers, 2015). Conversely, non-endemic sponsors are more profitable than endemic ones (Shapiro & Pitts, 2014). As a result, non-endemic sponsors are a must for esports industries. Reaching an agreement with endemic sponsors is very important for any esports industry because it is a sign of getting support from within the industry itself. Endemic sponsors represent the easiest method of selling from a sponsorship sales perspective. Thus, it is recommended that any start-up, or early-stage esports league, club or athlete, look for endemic sponsors at the first step. When trying to analyze the 20 top sponsors of esports teams and 19 sponsors of esports event, we can easily come to the great role of endemic sponsors as they cover the average 76% of the sponsors. Non-endemic sponsors, brands creating products not necessarily related to esports, such as Coca-Cola or Geico, are at the second stage after endemic sponsors.

What's the reason that endemic sponsors dominate esports sponsorship? Why are non-endemic brands not as active as endemic ones? How can they involve more actively in this process? The first major issue that esports has to counter if it wants to become more popular with non-endemic brands is the levels of public understanding, awareness, and mainstream exposure. The reason why non-endemic sponsors are moving slowly in reaching esports markets is the lack of public understanding of esports and their brands. Some events such as the League of Legends World Championship receive enough media exposure and, as a result, have large enough attendance figures to be attractive to non-endemic sponsors. Individual teams do not have the same level of attendance and should wait for a miracle to happen so that they can find non-endemic sponsors. The inclusion of esports in major, multi-sport games (it featured in the 2022 Asian Games) could be a turning point for the

sport as it could provide an opportunity to finally place it in the public consciousness. Also, we should take it into consideration that there are still people who don't believe in esports as a sport (Wardle et al., 2020).

Esports and Non-Endemic Sponsors

Endemic brands as the main source of importing revenue into the industry has always been under close scrutiny. But non-endemic sources have not been attended as they deserve till now. Endemic sponsors are trying their best to help the industry and promote their brands. However, some external brands are willing to participate in this profitable market as they can prognosticate the great future waiting for them. These brands are trying to get involved with the audiences in this market. The popularity of gaming content has engrossed them in esports. This is a great opportunity for these brands in order to make advantage of the male as the main addressees in this industry. Twenty-two percent of the male population in America watch esports. Therefore, it's much more profitable to invest in this market than in alcohol, entertainment, automotive, and fashion, etc. Non-endemic brands can get involved with esports through sponsorships, advertising, and partnerships.

Brand sponsorship refers to the sponsors who have previously been working with traditional sports, but now they are trying their luck in esports. There are some typical sponsors in esports. For example, Coca-Cola as a non-endemic brand sponsorship, has been trying in this field from 2001, but they have been mostly involved with traditional sports. Sponsorships in this way are a prominent instrument for the brand to be conspicuous to the fans of esports. Another creative example of how brand sponsorships are working in the esports industry is KIA's sponsorship of the League of Legends European Championship (LEC). KIA committed to provide vehicles in order to move LEC players during the tournament. They also accepted to create online content. The 2020 LEC games was the first time that the games were held entirely remotely, so we can consider video content and social media as a key factor. The sponsorship was accompanied by a music which said, "We wish LEC to be repeated" along with the key players providing the vocals and showcased KIA motors during the clip. The clip was ticked by over 600,000 people. It was itself more than a mere music and worked as a sponsorship for the games and sponsors.

Advertising directly during esports are a great potential which has been put to practice this year. Riot Games performed this sort of advertisement during official matches to observe their effect in comparison with real advertisements. It was a big step in esports advertising which went beyond the limits of typical advertisements for the games. It was an innovative method, introducing advertisements during competitions as a way of attracting audiences. MasterCard, a non-endemic brand, and Alienware, a computer hardware brand, were the first industries using this method. One of the benefits of this method

was that in comparison with traditional advertisements which diverted the attention of the players, in this method the advertisements were only at the sight of the spectators alone. Moreover, this method gives a chance to digital advertisements to turn up in this complex environment. Therefore, it paves the way for more brands to take courage to come into this industry and make the proceeding for its evolution in the future.

Brand partnership, as the name offers, occurs when two or more brands cooperate with each other to cause a different and also stronger experience for the people. The Riot Games and Spotify partnership were among the first which delivered this sort of partnership! For example, when a non-endemic brand cooperates with a music studio, it creates a synergy which is much more influential and attractive for the fans. This method was a symbol of innovative content creation for the gaming fan base. It brings about a synergy effect. In this way, 1+1 will not be 2 anymore, but something more than two. It creates an outstanding effect (influencer-marketing, 2020).

Endemic and Non-Endemic Development through Time

Endemic and non-endemic companies are the companies authorized by esports to benefit from esports over time. It means that both these companies and esports have gone through drastic changes to adapt themselves to this environment and allow for mutual beneficence. Endemic and non-endemic sponsors grew up along with the evolution of esports. The games (esports) have been consistently popular over time. But, on the contrary, the brand potential for growth and advancement is dependent on internet. Along with the usage of internet, drastic changes occurred in this industry (Kluegel & Smith, 1982). The entrance of mobile and internet technology in this market shifted the attention of the fans and officials from solitary games toward cooperative ones as well as mass consumption. This evolution prompted the official in this industry to think about new methods of considering an important population: the men aging 12–35 (Zue & Glass, 2000).

The evolution of esports and the gaming industry has passed four stages. The early days were solitary, because the people were not familiar with the games and they were not willing to utilize it to promote brands because the games were mostly out of reach. By 1990s advertisers did not consider the games into their schedule and did not pay attention to it. In this stage, games were considered as a means of amusing people and the sellers earned their life by transacting hardware. The quality and quantity of the games developed. Subsequently, competition was added to the games. The people could not get along with technological pace of the video games (Moore, 2006). The people could not watch the games collectively, as the games were held in a place or console. The second phase is simultaneous with advancements in internet and practice internet in all aspects of life, including esports. It was used as a vehicle for mass consumption. The players competing with each

other or cooperating with each other was a result of internet involvement in the games as the players did not have to play, for example, in a console. The games took an international identity. A player from South Asia could played with a player from North America. In this stage computer and hardware industries entered the market as endemic sponsors. Therefore, endemic sponsors took control of the market. Many companies such as Sega, Microsoft, and Sony used the games to attract people. The internet used in a widespread and accessible way opened the way for social media into the culture and also let computer giants such as Google and Yahoo to play their appreciative role. The media contributed to the advancement of the games more than ever.

In the third phase, the games, gamers, and the industry with its subscales got professionalized. The next step in the evolution of competitive video gaming was the professionalization of sites, event, and players. In this phase the popularity of video gaming grew so much. As a result, the venues were allocated for holding the games (i.e., esports). The professionalization of sites, event, and players brought about non-endemic brands into this field to facilitate the involvement of mass audience (Yeh et al., 2018). Now, we have more viewers as our demographic sample is somehow clear that was not clear and accessible in previous steps. In the last phase, all companies tried to take advantage of esports players as the simulation of the traditional games was implemented in esports (e.g., NBA, NFL). In this phase contracts were arranged with the players and they were not allowed to join other teams. Marketing campaigns were very active trying to reach the target population which was not apparent in the previous stages. The games got personalized. For each category of people, there was an appropriate game. In this way, all companies could structure a sound marketing campaign designed for a specific city and to a player who can connect with particular audiences.

Also, companies should work on this market so that their plans fit tightly with esports market. Understanding key consumers plays the most important role in this field. Therefore, industries should invest a lot on this point. Specific job positions should be allocated to recognize these key consumers. The researches show that the companies which have been hesitant in order to participate in esports marketing campaigns have finally come to the conclusion that taking part in esports marketing campaigns are very profitable. These companies understand the importance of spectators and viewers. That is why they try to enter this industry. As esports grow, the stakeholders get more inclined to increase their share in the market and try to eliminate the hurdles in front of sponsorship and marketing in this profitable market.

Branding through Esports

The companies are branded by esports in many ways. Companies are trying to get involved with esports to have more access to the people. Esports benefit

mostly from the market of males of ages 16 to 24. That is what traditional sports are starving for (Burton & O'Reilly, 2019). Generally speaking, companies focus on the characteristics of the products (Esports in here) which have not been attended so much previously, and in this way enter a win-win game which leads to the flow of revenue and money to the esports industry. These ways range from team, league, or event sponsorship to jersey and equipment. Between 2016 and 2017, about 600 contracts have been signed between esports and sponsors such as IT/Computer (59%), online services (10%), non-alcoholic drinks (8%), and online media (7%) (Chung et al., 2019). Professional esports leagues and gamers were a launching pad for esports sponsorship and media coverage (e.g., Twitch). Professionalization of esports has contributed to easy access to the followers of each game. Like traditional games, brands can make advantage of personalities and places. Brand involvement has been positively estimated by about half of the consumers. It has been negatively estimated by about 7% of them (Chung et al., 2019). Besides, esports supporters feel more comfortable with endemic sponsors. It is reported that they believe technology companies and internet service providers are most favorable, while insurance, financial services, and alcoholic drinks are not so appropriate for the games (Chung et al., 2019).

In all, we cannot practice marketing in esports through traditional methods. It is reported that 25% of esports fans in U.S. support sponsorship through social media. They state that digital and social media marketing is the optimum method of marketing in esports in order to attract audiences (Chung et al., 2019). It makes some opportunities for endemic and non-endemic brands. Relegation is another reason why some brands stop sponsoring some esports teams anymore. Relegation refers to a condition where a team is downgraded or defeated by other teams. This relegation causes some sponsors to hesitate sponsoring the teams. It is what sometimes happens in traditional sports as well (Abdolmaleki et al., 2022). Anyway, experience shows that traditional sports and specially soccer leagues know how to handle these circumstances. It is in this field that esports officials should get more experienced (Gau & James, 2014). As another deficit in esports industry, which emanates from the raw and young structure of this industry, we can say that some players are just wandering around without any contracts being arranged with them. All these explain why some companies, endemic and non-endemic, are not willing to sponsor esports industries (Burton & O'Reilly, 2019).

Conclusion

As an industry in its infancy and according to the indices we can predict a great future for the games. Yet, there are many reasons for the stakeholders to be doubtful of the campaigns which have been attended to in this chapter. Esports industry is growing day by day. According to specialists, it is a source of income and revenue for sponsors and industry which has not been explored

so much until now. So, there are many chances for research in this field remaining untouched, such as esports and digital marketing, esports and mobile technologies, gambling in esports, and esports and cultural settings. One of the biggest challenges, but also opportunities, for the brand's potential partners in e-sports, is the fact that there are no centralized rules or specific legal regulations for the games. The industry is dominated by a number of traditional games, formats, and sports. Therefore, we must provide solutions to separate the traditional formats from these games and provide the necessary ground for the independence of these games. Otherwise, great endemic and non-endemic sponsors will stop supporting the games.

Clearly, if you are a brand looking for sports sponsorship opportunities, you should consider e-sports. Sponsorship packages in e-sports are not only very relevant compared to traditional sports with similar viewing statistics, but you can also use the benefits available to startups and be creative in terms of the assets you buy and the way to get those benefits. Shake a leg and take advantage of this platform and its impressive statistics to reach a great amount of young audience. Of course, the key point, just like traditional sports marketing, is that the platform should be privatized for different groups of audiences and it should build credibility for the audience, which creates value for the audience's experience as a result and helps deliver on brand promises. If brands do not help create added value for e-sports over time, they will eventually face public outrage and go out of date. On the contrary, if brands perform their duties properly, brand equity will peak sharply and can play a very important and fundamental role in the market.

Audiences are always our beacons in this direction. If a brand loses its credibility in e-sports for a variety of reasons, it will best reflect the audience's reaction. Audiences like to expose their lives and games online to everyone and express their opinions about the lives and games of others. Brands, especially in e-sports, must learn to listen to the community and be active in the community. Finally, e-sports need time to prove to sponsors that they can use them as a marketing tool. Some brands are cautious and "unprepared to take the risk of becoming the first brand to fail," Loat said. "Brands want evidence that the concept of sponsoring e-sports can be successful." If e-sport can clarify its structure and prove that it is worth the investment, then it will attract more sponsors, and when one big brand steps in and invests, others are more likely to follow.

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Chapter 4

Antecedents and Outcomes of Sponsorship in the Context of Esports

Olga Polyakova and Kostas Alexandris

Introduction

Evidence suggests that the esports industry has developed rapidly in recent years and transformed from niche sector into the mainstream (Insider, 2021). Between 2019 and 2021 the global esports audience grew from 398 million to 474 million, with an even split between esports enthusiasts and occasional viewers (Newzoo, 2021). Apart from growing markets of people who watch professional esports content more than once a month (i.e. of esports enthusiasts) and those who watch esports less than once a month (i.e. occasional viewers), the games live-streaming audience is on the rise and will reach 729 million in 2021, with projections of 920 million by 2024. With the growing revenue streams from main three esports markets, i.e. Asia-Pacific (APAC), North America, and Europe, most of the revenue (69%) comes from sponsorships and advertising (Insider Intelligence (2023)). By the end of 2021 sports sponsorship alone is expected to generate $641.0 million which accounts for 59% of the entire market (Newzoo, 2021).

Many brands have identified esports environment as a new field, where they can explore new possibilities to engage with their targeted groups through unique activations and branding (Ke & Wagner, 2020), as well as build on different aspects to raise their brand equity and have an effective return on their investment (Finch et al., 2020). However, an opportunity of sponsorship success comes with such challenges as volatility of fast-paced esports industry and pressure on sponsors to convey a genuine interest in the esports world (McKinsey & Company, 2020). Sponsorship decisions should be made with even more care since research provides evidence that esports fans tend to rather exhibit love to the esports industry than concern for themselves; they would like sponsors to improve the overall esports industry and its sustainability, rather than simply try improve fans' experience through creating relevant content (Freitas, Contreras-Espinosa & Correia, 2020). This means that in order to create a better environment for the fans to enjoy esports, sponsors need to be seen as helping to the pro-players and tournaments and focusing on supporting the general esports industry.

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Over the years, sport sponsorship became a powerful marketing medium for generating value to both the sponsor and the property being sponsored (Cheong, Pyun, & Leng, 2019). The benefits for sponsor may include such outcomes as sponsorship awareness, positive customers' attitudes towards sponsors, perceived congruence between sponsors and sponsored property as well intentions to buy products from the sponsoring company (O'Reilly & Madill, 2009). For example, a brand's association with a successful team or a player helps the brand differentiate from other competitors in consumer's mind (Ke & Wagner, 2020), while brand recall facilitates consumer loyalty (Sasmita and Suki, 2015). Yet, evaluation of sponsorship effectiveness has historically been underutilized by businesses. In 2004, it was reported that 40% of 200 companies with major sponsorship investments spent nothing to evaluate their investment and only 35% of the companies spent 1% or less of their budget for sponsorship evaluation (Crompton, 2004). Fast-forward to 2017, IEG (2017) report, based on 208 companies, indicated that 31% of businesses spent nothing to evaluate their sponsorship contracts and additional 47% of the companies invested 1% or less. The reported numbers demonstrate a shift towards an increase in the amount of money spent on research; however, in the span of 13 years this increase proves to be insignificant.

Despite continuous growth of esports sponsorship, there is a lack of empirical evidence on the state and trends of sponsorship in the esports industry (Finch et al., 2020). Previous literature (Cunningham et al., 2018; Hallmann & Giel, 2018) identified the need to develop models for explaining and predicting esports consumer behaviours as well as pointing out at limited knowledge generated in relation to esports consumers (Jang & Byon, 2020). There is still a significant gap in empirical research which explores consumers' experiences with esports and leads to establishing distinct segments (Jang et al., 2021). Previously, researchers focused on exploring factors of esports consumption related to gameplay consumption (Jang & Byon, 2020), esports event spectating motivation (Pizzo et al., 2018), and game experiences (Jang et al., 2021), while other studies (Seo, 2016; Taylor, 2012) examined relationship between esports and serious leisure. Studies on leisure consumers suggested that highly involved consumers are also more likely to be aware of sponsoring companies (Lardinoit & Derbaix, 2001; Lascu et al., 1995), develop a positive image of those sponsors (Javalgi et al., 1994; Turco, 1995), and report an intention to purchase sponsors' products (Ko et al., 2008). Moreover, businesses whose products or services are not associated with an esports market (i.e. non-endemic sponsors) may benefit from sponsoring esports events through increased goodwill and purchase intentions (Huettermann et al., 2020). Yet, no studies have yet categorized esports consumers according to their involvement with esports, neither investigated the relationship between esports consumer involvement and outcomes for companies sponsoring esports.

The present study addresses an existing gap in literature on esports consumers and contributes to the limited literature on segmentation of esports consumers and their recall of esports sponsors.

As defined by the International Esports Federation, esports (or electronic sports) is a competitive sport where gamers use their physical and mental abilities to compete in various games in a virtual, electronic environment (International Esports Federation, 2021). Another definition comes from Newzoo (2021), the world's leader in games market insights and analytics: 'professional or semi-professional competitive gaming in an organized format (tournament or league) with a specific goal/prize, such as winning a championship title or prize money' (p. 8). There has been an ongoing debate as to whether esports can be considered as sports. According to Rodgers' (1977) established definition, sport, as a minimum, should always involve physical activity and be practiced for recreational purposes and, ideally, involve an element of competition and have a framework of institutional organization. The European Sport Charter (Council of Europe, 2001) defines sport as 'all forms of physical activity which, through casual or organised participation, aim at expressing or improving physical fitness and mental well-being, forming social relationships or obtaining results in competition at all levels'. As with other activities such as chess and darts, the physical activity element creates contrasting opinions. Unlike traditional sports, esports take place in virtual worlds, can be accessed quickly and have a shorter game length (Jang & Byon, 2020). Also, traditional sports tend focus on development and performance of complex motor skills, whereas gamers rely more on cognitive skills (Himmelstein, Liu, & Shapiro, 2017).

This study does not intend to follow the footsteps of contentious debate, nor does it focus on reviewing pros and cons as to whether esports can indeed be considered as sport; the latter is beyond the scope of the study. Yet, it is important to mention that due to differing definitions of esports, the esports market boundaries stay fluid and can extend to amateur competitions and live streaming around non-organized competitive gaming. This happens because esports and live-streaming formats do overlap, for example, when popular streamers who usually broadcast themselves playing online start competing in pro-level esports more often and some tournaments are allowing their competitors to live-stream themselves competing.

Review of Literature

As with any market, the market of esports consumers is not homogeneous and is becoming ever more fragmented: it now involves not only those who play esports, but also those who watch esports and game video content. Due to the fact that the boundaries of esports market are blurred, the process of dividing, or segmenting (Mullin et al., 2007), this market into heterogeneous groups that hold common characteristics becomes crucial for understanding preferences

of specific groups. In leisure services, market segmentation is used to support development of targeted marketing strategies, more relevant service design and ultimately meet consumers' needs better (Liu et al., 2008). In the context of esports, there is still a significant gap in empirical research which explores consumers' experiences with esports in a manner that cultivates distinct segments (Jang et al., 2021). To date, previous studies have focused on exploring factors and moderators of esports consumption, in particular segmentation factors related to gameplay consumption (Jang & Byon, 2020), esports event spectating motivation (Pizzo et al., 2018) and game experiences (Jang et al., 2021).

Newzoo's Gamer Segmentation (Newzoo, 2019a) offered a way of segmenting esports consumers on the basis of their engagement with games, i.e. playing, viewing, and owning. The segmentation is presented in the form of nine unique personas that encompass all aspects of consumer engagement with games; they are: the Ultimate Gamer; the All-Round Enthusiast; the Conventional Player; the Subscriber; the Lapsed Gamer; the Back Seat Viewer; the Popcorn Gamer; the Hardware Enthusiast; and the Time Filler. The segmentation demonstrates that two biggest segments are the Subscribers (21%) who enjoy playing high-quality free or discounted games without buying hardware unnecessarily, and the Time Fillers (23%) who game when they have spare time, preferably on mobile devices. In addition, insights from another report from Newzoo (2019b) revealed that over a third of all female game enthusiasts fall within Time Fillers and almost two-thirds of all Time Fillers are women.

Esports and Leisure Involvement

With different types of esports consumers come different types of involvement with esports. Seo (2016) suggested that involvement in esports presents a form of serious leisure, defined by Stebbins (1992) as 'the systematic pursuit of an amateur, hobbyist, or volunteer activity that participants find so substantial and interesting, in the typical case, they launch themselves on a career centred on acquiring and expressing its special skills, knowledge and experience' (p. 3). Taking into account the Popcorn Gamers, esports can be seen as a combination of active serious leisure and casual passive entertainment (Seo & Jung, 2016). A move from participating in gaming as a casual activity to a serious occupational pursuit represents a transition from serious leisure into a profession. Yet, regardless of the level, esports present a competitive activity (which resembles professional sports) surrounded by cultural norms in the esports community and it requires dedication in order to progress in gaming. There were previous studies (Seo, 2016; Taylor, 2012) which examined relationship between esports and serious leisure, with primary focus on setting of competitive players; however, more recently there has been a call to pursue more research in this direction (McCauley et al., 2020).

As a psychographic variable for segmentation, involvement has been successfully used in segmenting recreational tennis players (Alexandris, 2013),

dancers (Alexandris et al., 2012), runners (Kyle, Kerstetter, & Guadagnolo, 2002), and adults in fitness market (Havitz et al., 1994). The involvement construct was used as a segmentation criterion by most of these studies, yet they did not utilize more psychographic variables for further profiling the involvement groups. The study on tennis players (Alexandris, 2013) extended this approach and profiled the involvement groups with both demographic and psychographic variables. The results indicated that while psychographic segmentation, with the use of the variables of involvement, constraints, and motivation, is useful in segmenting recreational tennis players, the demographic variables were not found to be a useful approach in that context.

Leisure involvement represents how an individual and the external stimulus are related (Kyle et al., 2007), and it represents the extent to which an individual is involved in leisure and recreational activities. Involvement subsequently enhances individuals' sensitivity to certain activities and their perceptions of a particular activity's importance as well as the individuals' commitments to specific services or places (McIntyre & Pigram, 1992). The first two models developed for measuring involvement were the personal involvement inventory (PII) (Zaichkowsky, 1985) and the consumer involvement profile (CIP) (Laurent & Kapferer, 1985). Subsequently, the one-dimensional PII model was improved through introduction of the dimensions of importance and pleasure (McQuarrie & Munson, 1987), and later – dimensions of cognitive and affective involvement (Zaichkowsky, 1994) Both PII and CIP models were used for the development of adapted involvement models in leisure context.

The key model for measuring involvement was developed by McIntyre and Pigram (1992) and subsequently used in many other leisure and recreation studies. The model seemed to have accommodated a consensus on the number and nature of dimensions for measuring the involvement; involvement was presented as a function of attraction, self-expression, and centrality to one's lifestyle. Attraction refers to the concepts of importance and pleasure, implying activities that are important to an individual. Self-expression refers to personal impressions that individuals convey to others through their participation in leisure activities. Finally, centrality to life relates leisure participation to an individual overall lifestyle by judging the extent to which an individual's life is organized around that activity.

Evaluation of Sponsorship Effectiveness

Previous literature (e.g. Jensen & White, 2018) argued that evaluation of sponsorship programme often faces challenges when attempting to isolate a sponsorship programme and test its unique influence on sponsorship-related sales. This is due to the fact that sales are also influenced by other marketing and communication activities as well as macro environmental factors. Therefore, communication data and consumer surveys present more accurate tool when

evaluating the development of positive outcomes for the sponsor. Customer surveys form the basis for attitude research which is often used to understand the sport sponsorship process (Funk, Alexandris, & McDonald, 2022, in press). Some of the most common sponsorship outcomes include attitudinal variables, e.g. attitude towards sponsors and consumer interest, and behavioural constructs, e.g. sponsorship awareness (or recall) (Maanda, Abratt, & Mingione, 2020), consumer purchase intentions, and word-of-mouth communications (Alexandris, Tsaousi, & James, 2007).

Certain attitudinal variables can positively influence the success of a sport sponsorship and act as antecedents of positive sponsorship outcomes; they include: involvement, perceived fit (or congruence) between sponsor and sponsored entity, attitudes towards sport sponsorship, fans' attachment level with the team (or team identification) (Funk et al., 2022, in press). Furthermore, Crompton (1996, 2004) proposed an integration of the communication and product adoption processes which integrated consumer decision-making with the sponsorship outcomes. It was proposed that four stages of product adoption – awareness, interest, desire, and purchase actions – are linked with four sponsorship benefit categories respectively: awareness, image enhancement, product trial or sales opportunities, and hospitality opportunities. In line with the previous literature, an overview of main sponsorship outcomes is presented, namely: involvement, sponsorship awareness, attitude towards sponsors (image), perceived fit between sponsor and sponsored entity, purchase intentions. and word-of-mouth communications.

Sponsorship Outcomes

Involvement

Previous research established that involvement is associated with positive behavioural and attitudinal consequences, such as commitment, attachment, increased participation levels, and loyalty (Alexandris, 2012; Beaton et al., 2011; Iwasaki & Havitz, 2004; Kyle, Graefe, Manning, & Bacon, 2004). Studies on leisure consumers (including fans or spectators) suggested that highly involved consumers are also more likely to be aware of sponsoring companies (Lardinoit & Derbaix, 2001; Lascu et al., 1995), to develop a positive image of those sponsors (Javalgi et al., 1994; Turco, 1995) and to report an intention to purchase sponsors' products (Ko et al., 2008). The study by Dees et al. (2008) which measured the effectiveness of sponsorship of an elite intercollegiate football programme found that fan involvement (similar to attitude) was correlated with attitude towards the sponsor. This was supported by Huettermann et al. (2020), who found that esports brand attitude significantly predicted attitude towards the sponsor.

The results of Huettermann et al.'s (2020) study were relevant to businesses whose products and/or services are not associated with an esports market

(i.e. non-endemic sponsors); they suggested that these such businesses sponsoring esports events can achieve increased goodwill and purchase intentions. Mao and Zhang's (2013) research into branding effectiveness of event sponsors at Beijing Olympic Games found that consumer's attitude towards the sponsored event was partially determined by consumer's involvement. Finally, Singh and Singh's (2018) study of the Indian Premier League showed that sponsor's brand image was positively impacted by event involvement and that high involvement of the attendees with an event positively influenced their purchase intentions.

Sponsorship Awareness

Sponsorship awareness is defined as 'the percentage of sport consumers who are able to recall (unaided) or recognize (aided) the sponsor of a sport club, event, or athlete' (Funk et al., 2022, in press). Despite being a behavioural variable, sponsorship awareness linked with positive attitudinal sponsorship outcomes (Eddy & Cork, 2019; Maanda, Abratt, & Mingione, 2020). Studies on leisure consumers suggested that highly involved consumers are more likely to be aware of sponsoring companies (Lardinoit & Derbaix, 2001; Lascu et al., 1995). There is also evidence from relatively recent studies (Mazodier & Quester, 2014; Simmons & Becker-Olsen, 2006) that, as a part of effective sponsorship, positive brand awareness and image can be consequences of perceived fit between sponsor and sponsored entity (Pappu and Cornwell, 2014). According to McKinsey & Company (2020), over the past ten years recall of non-endemic brand sponsors in esports has increased and was recently 53%, which is higher than for endemic brands (43%). This echoes Nielsen's (2018) research into Twitch esports fans that revealed that 90% could recall at least one non-gaming-related sponsor within esports.

Attitude towards Sponsors (Image) and Purchase Intentions

Keller (1993) defined attitude towards the sponsor as a consumer's overall evaluation of a sponsor. There is evidence that strong positive attitudes towards sponsorship can positively impact attitudes towards the actual sponsors (Lee, Sandler, & Shani, 1997). Esports brand attitude was also found to predict attitude towards the sponsor, yet the amount of variance explained in sponsor attitude was not meaningful (Huettermann et al., 2020). Theory of Planned Behaviour (Ajzen, 1991) established that consumer attitudes directly influence their behavioural intentions and, subsequently, their purchasing behaviour. This means that while consumer purchase intentions (i.e. behavioural intentions) do not always predict actual buying behaviour, they still serve as a strong indicator of this behaviour. In the area of sport consumer behaviour research, intentions to buy sponsors' products have been the most common attitudinal variable used in leisure and sport sponsorship

studies (Alexandris, Tsaousi, & James, 2007; Gwinner & Swanson, 2003; Madrigal, 2001).

Perceived Fit between Sponsor and Sponsored Entity

There is a plethora of definitions of sponsorship fit, yet most of them are centred around 'congruence' as a central concept which can mean 'relevance' (Johar & Pham, 1999), 'similarity' (Gwinner & Eaton, 1999), or 'compatibility' (Ruth & Simonin, 2003). Becker-Olsen and Hill (Becker-Olsen & Hill, 2006) defined sponsorship fit as the perceived match between a sponsor's and a sponsored organization's target groups, mission, organizational values, corporate goals, and strategic focus. Positive association of a brand and the sponsored entity plus consistency in the characteristics of either party forms the sponsorship fit – the degree to which a sponsor is perceived by consumers to be congruent with the sponsorship (Roy & Cornwell, 2003). Congruence effects in marketing can be explained by several theories, for example, balance theory (Heider, 1958), congruity theory (Osgood & Tannenbaum, 1955), and schema theory (Alba & Hasher, 1983). The study by Maanda et al. (2020) examined the influence of sport sponsorship on brand equity in South Africa and found that sponsorship fit has a positive impact on brand recall. This finding aligns with a notion that 'the brand associations [are] held in consumers' memory' (Keller, 1993, p.3) and, therefore, high perceived fit makes the memory more accessible.

Tsordia, Papadimitrioua, and Parganas (2018) investigated the influence of sport sponsorship on brand equity and purchase behaviour in the case of the Greek basketball team (sponsee) and Microsoft's videogame console X-Box (sponsor). The results confirmed that perceived fit plays an important role in the development of positive sponsorship outcomes, such as brand engagement, brand loyalty, and purchase behaviour. Yet, in the context of sport events, perceived fit can have indirect effects, through sport involvement, on three antecedent variables: credibility, attitudes towards the sponsor, and purchase intentions (Koo & Lee, 2019). In esports context, previous studies suggest that esports consumers seek validation for esports as a socially acceptable activity (Schiano et al., 2014); thus, non-endemic sponsorships may be perceived as a signal of mainstream social acceptance (Santos & Eisenhardt, 2009), growth, and endorsement for the industry (Huettermann et al., 2020), which may have implications for perceived fit. Burton (2017), however, notes that sponsorships must logically connect the brand's products with the esports culture, and as long as they make the brand an integral component of the scene, they will find acceptance of esports.

Empirical literature on esports sponsorship is very scarce, and mentions of perceived fit are predominantly limited to conference papers and degree dissertations. Nevertheless, there are first indications that sponsor-event fit has the strongest impact on attitude towards the sponsor in esports (Forster, 2019). It has also been mentioned that ubiquity of the sponsors and perceived

benefits for the esports scene can have positive influence on fans' perception of the sponsorship fit (Baldvinsson & Isopahkala, 2019). Finally, an EASM conference paper (Kim et al., n.d.) suggested that there is an interaction between esports news consumption and perceived sponsor-team fit, i.e. the higher perceived fit between the sponsor and the esports team, the greater the influence of esports news consumption on brand image and loyalty.

Models of Sponsorship Evaluation

Several attitudinal and behavioural variables have been used by researchers to develop theoretical models and presented in the models as positive sponsorship outcomes (consequences) and antecedents of sport sponsorship. For their pioneering model, Lee et al. (1997) conducted a study in the context of three sport mega-events and proposed that spectators' attitudes towards the event and towards sponsorship are antecedents of sponsorship outcomes (consumer behavioural intentions). The assumption of the model was that individual's attitude towards an event is stable because the attitude is based on expected benefits from the event (e.g. fun and enjoyment). Another study conducted by Speed and Thompson (2000) in an event setting assessed college students' attitudes towards potential sponsorship; it proposed two event-related factors ('personal liking of the event' and 'event status'), one sponsorship factor ('sponsor-event fit'), and three sponsor factors ('attitude toward sponsor', 'sincerity of sponsor', and 'ubiquity of sponsor') as antecedents of such sponsorship outcomes, as 'interest toward sponsorship', 'favourability', and 'use of the sponsor's products'. 'Attitude toward the event' (labelled 'personal liking of the event' in Speed and Thompson's model) was found to be significantly related with respondents' willingness to consider the sponsor's products, which was in line with Lee et al.'s findings. Also, 'sincerity of sponsors' and the 'attitudes toward sponsors' were found to be the key variables in predicting sponsorship outcomes.

Two other notable studies by Madrigal (2001) and Gwinner and Swanson (2003) empirically tested the influence of attitudinal constructs on sponsorship outcomes in the context of collegiate sports. Madrigal's (2001) findings confirmed the suitability of their proposed model which included variables of team identification, beliefs about the benefits of sponsorship, the perceived importance of these beliefs, attitudes towards buying products from a sponsor, and purchase intentions; in particular, they revealed the important role of team identification as antecedent of favourable sponsorship reactions. The latter was supported by Gwinner and Swanson (2003), who concluded that team identification had a positive direct effect on such sponsorship outcomes as sponsor recognition, attitude towards sponsor, sponsor patronage, and satisfaction with sponsor.

One of the variables found by Gwinner and Swanson (2003) to predict team identification was 'domain involvement'. The 'domain involvement' had

been previously reported by Lascu et al. (1995) in their study on golfers: it was found that individuals highly committed to golf were more likely to remember the sponsors of the event than individuals with low commitment to golf. Similar to the 'domain involvement' construct was used by Alexandris, Tsaousi, and James (2007) in the setting of a basketball all-star game in Greece. The study tested the relationships between attitudinal variables ('attitude toward the event', 'activity involvement', and 'beliefs about sponsorship') and consumers' behavioural intentions; it proposed the construct of 'activity involvement' as an antecedent of sponsorship outcomes. Alexandris, Tsaousi, and James (2007) used multi-dimensional involvement construct which was originally proposed by McIntyre and Pigram (1992) and later found in the studies by Iwasaki and Havitz (2004) and Kyle et al. (2004) It was one of the first studies which tested the construct of activity involvement as opposed to widely researched sponsorship antecedents such as fan involvement and team identification (Madrigal, 2001; Meenaghan, 2001).

Case Study: Consumers of Esports

The case study is based on the results of the research on adult esports consumers who watched esports. Its objectives were to: (a) create a demographic and behavioural profile of esports viewers and (b) explore the recall rate of sponsors among esport viewers. Quantitative data was collected via online survey from adults (over 18 years of age), via SIRC Survey platform – an online survey tool for the Sport Industry Research Centre at Sheffield Hallam University. SIRC Survey platform is dedicated to professional data collection in sport and physical activity for the research purposes. Convenience sampling was utilized to recruit participants to the study using research platform Prolific (www.prolific.co). Initial population selection was done through Prolific filters qualifying individuals who watched esports tournaments. Overall, the initial screening identified 42,815 eligible participants, and the questionnaire was sent to 381. Out of 381 responses, 311 were usable and were included in the final sample; 58 responses were returned incomplete, and 5 responses were excluded from analysis due to being ineligible, with additional 7 participants withdrawing their consent to participate in the study.

Sociodemographic Profile

The respondents were esports consumers of 18 years old or over who watched esports. The total sample of 311 respondents comprised 163 males (52%) and 136 females (44%). Table 4.1 shows the breakdown of female and male respondents across locations. The largest group of responses came from North and Central America (N = 163) followed by Europe (N = 118). The largest proportion of female respondents came from North and Central America (N = 91). The youngest group of respondents (i.e. 18–22 years old) comprised

Table 4.1 Gender of Respondents (by location)

Location	*Gender*				*Total*
	Male	*Female*	*Other*	*Preferred Not to Say*	
North America/Central America	63	91	3	6	163
South America	2	0	0	0	2
Europe	80	36	1	1	118
Africa	11	2	0	0	13
Asia	4	1	0	0	5
Australia	2	2	0	0	4
Other	1	4	1	0	6
Total	**163**	**136**	**5**	**7**	**311**

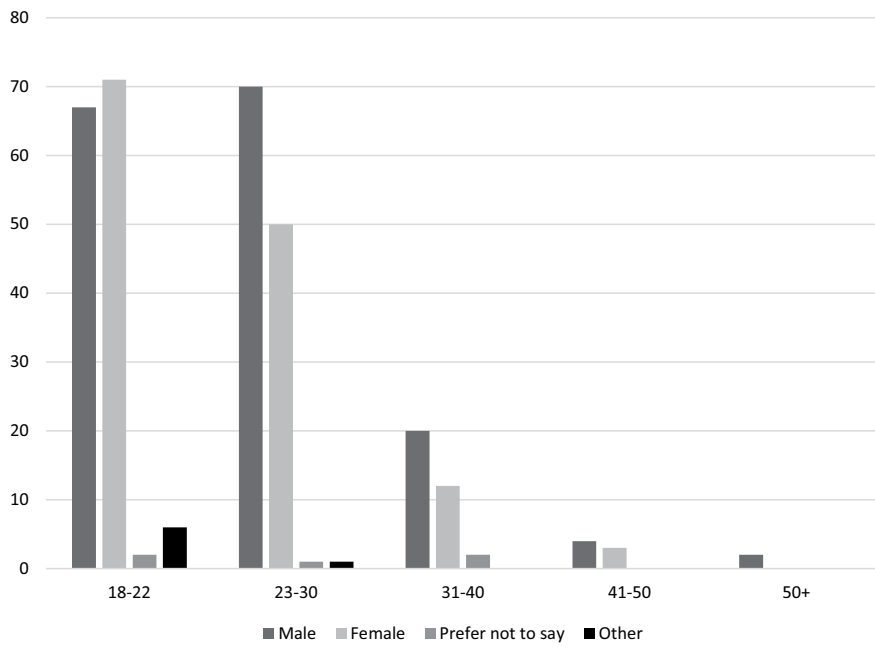


Figure 4.1 Gender distribution of respondents (by age groups).

a largest proportion of females across all age groups (N = 71); this was followed by 23–30 years old (N = 70) and 18–22 years old (N = 67) males (Figure 4.1).

Approximately, 47% of the respondents (N = 144) spent less than 1 hour a day watching esports. In terms of recall of sponsors, 35% of all respondents

(N = 108) were able to remember a sponsor of an esports tournament that they watched in the past 12 months. This means that one out of three respondents remembered the sponsor. The most experienced group had the largest proportion of respondents (43%) who could remember sponsors of tournaments, followed by the group who has been watching esports for 1–3 years (33%) (Tables 4.2–4.5).

Table 4.2 Time Spent Watching Esports Per Day

Type of consumption	*Time spent per day*					*Total (N)*
	Less than 1 hour	*2–3 hours*	*3–4 hours*	*4–5 hours*	*More than 5 hours*	
I watch esports	**144 (47%)**	**119 (39%)**	**29 (9%)**	**9 (2%)**	**10 (3%)**	**311**

Table 4.3 Experience in Watching Esports

Type of consumption	*Experience in esports*				*Total respondents (N)*
	Less than a year	*1–3 years*	*4–5 years*	*More than 5 years*	
I watch esports	**37 (12%)**	**123 (40%)**	**50 (16%)**	**101 (32%)**	**311**

Table 4.4 Recall of Sponsors and Experience in Watching Esports

Recall	*Experience in esports*				*Total (N)*
	Less than a year	*1–3 years*	*4–5 years*	*More than 5 years*	
Yes	5 (5%)	36 (33%)	20 (19%)	47 (43%)	108 (100%)
No	32 (16%)	87 (43%)	30(15%)	54 (26%)	203 (100%)
Total	**37**	**123**	**50**	**101**	**311**

Table 4.5 Recall of Sponsors amongst Males and Females

Recall	*Gender*				*Total (N)*
	Male	*Female*	*Prefer not to say*	*Other*	
Yes	70 (65%)	36 (33%)	0	2 (2%)	108 (100%)
No	93 (45%)	100 (49%)	5 (3%)	5 (3%)	203 (100%)
Total	**163**	**136**	**5**	**7**	**311**

Discussion

Most of the respondents (86%, N = 268) in the study were aged between 18 and 30 years old. This is in line with Sutton's (2016) suggestion that esports are particularly appealing to younger consumers. The sample in the study was balanced in terms of binary gender representation with 52% males and 44% of females. The youngest group – 18–22 years old respondents – comprised the largest proportion of females across all age groups which accounted to 23% of overall sample.

The study discovered that 35% of all respondents remembered a sponsor of a tournament that they watched in the past 12 months; it means that only one out of three respondents remembered the sponsor. In comparison, previous studies reported between 60% of respondents (Lee & Bang, 2005) and 85% of respondents (Biscaia et al., 2014; Moore, Pickett & Grove, 1999; Turley & Shannon, 2000) who correctly could identify at least one brand. It should be noted that previous studies on sponsorship recall were predominantly focused on sports fans or spectators in the events, whereas the context of current study included esports players. The group with more than five years of experience had the largest proportion of respondents (43%) who could remember sponsors of esport tournaments. While this supports the notion from previous literature that the frequency and duration of exposure have an effect on the recall rate of sponsors among spectators (Breuer & Rumpf, 2011; Cornwell & Humphreys, 2013), it can also be an early indication that sponsorship recall rate may vary in different modes of esports consumption. It is also worth mentioning that only 33% of females could remember a sponsor as opposed to 65% of males.

As a global phenomenon, esports and its viewership continue growing year after year (Hiltscher & Scholz, 2017). Newzoo (2021) reports there were 200.8 million occasional viewers and 197 million esports enthusiasts, making the total audience 397.8 million. The year-over-year growth continued in 2020, with a combined esports audience of 435.9 million. By 2024, Newzoo (2021) predicts that the total audience will be 577.2 million. Increased viewership drives opportunities for brand sponsorships and advertising creating cash flow for gamers, streamers, and team owners. The fact that generation of revenue from media rights in esports sector is still in its infancy places a particular importance on sponsorship. With its high economic significance and large international reach (BI Intelligence & Elder, 2017), esports can provide enormous benefits to its sponsors, such as brand visibility and awareness. On the other hand, player wages are rising, and ambitions of the esports are expanding; therefore, the future commercial success of esports heavily depends on the attraction of new sponsors and sponsorship sectors.

In our case study, most of the respondents were aged between 18 and 30 years old (86%). The sample in the study was balanced in terms of binary gender representation with 52% males and 44% of females. The youngest

group – 18- to 22-year-old respondents – comprised the largest proportion of females across all age groups which accounted for 23% of overall sample. In our sample only one out of three females remembered the sponsor (as opposed to two out of three males). This indicates a lack of appropriate target marketing; a marketing gap into which forward-thinking brands have a great potential to tap into, through sponsoring female esports teams and promoting inclusivity for women.

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Chapter 5

Emergence of Logo-Less Branding

Application to the Context of Sports

Don Lee, Michael Cottingham, Jae Hee Park, and Minseok Cho

Introduction

The term 'brand' conventionally signals a name, design, slogan, or symbol (i.e., logo), or any other characteristic that can be used to distinguish itself from other companies (Keller, 2013). These types of brand features allow the associated entities under each brand (e.g., products, services, organizations) to be marketed differently from competitors. In modern business contexts, brands have become an essential driver of consumer behavior, as they carry various important meanings on which consumers routinely rely to make their consumptive choices (Belk, 1998; Keller & Lehmann, 2006). Consequently, successful branding results in a distinctive brand identity in the minds of consumers. This brand identity can then allow businesses to leverage sales benefits such as higher profit margins, increased sales, and brand loyalty (Mao, 2010; Lewis et al., 2016).

In the practice of branding products, the use of the logo has become standardized. This is because brands' visible markings imply consumptive benefits, such as prestige and social status (Erdem et al., 2006). In line with Spence's (1973) concept of signaling theory, the presence of a brand logo can make a product more identifiable, which subsequently allows consumers to identify the brand owner's status and social position in relation to the product. As such, brand logos can secure social benefits for the consumer in addition to the product's intended functionality (Grossman & Shapiro 1988). Brand managers often utilize various brand features such as scarcity and status to enhance the perceived value of a product (Lynn, 1991). For example, premium brands in various product categories (e.g., high end brands such as Chanel or Louis Vuitton) often target consumers with high socio-economic status while implying limited access to their products by setting the price at a higher rate (Lee et al., 2015; Rodrigues et al., 2018). As such, brands play a dynamic role in how consumers perceive a product.

Existing literature describes various elements of brands that are designed to function for different purposes. A number of existing studies explain how the presence of brand logos on products brings about different effects in various

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consumptive situations. For example, Childs and Jin (2016) investigated how brand logo presence on a product (as opposed to the absence in the same product) influences consumer evaluations. Their findings indicate a positive relationship between the two, which signifies the important role that brand logos play in the consumptive experience. Additionally, Childs and Jin noted gender differences between product evaluations, which suggested that females exhibited more positive product evaluations when brands (and logos) were present on product displays than their male counterparts. Similarly, Wolter et al. (2016) found that the symbolic value of a brand often carries greater importance than the physical attributes and functions of the product or service.

Other existing literature on branding consistently indicates that one of the known benefits associated with brand names in product offerings is product differentiation, as brand names often reflect product categories (Kohli & LaBahn, 1997). Brand naming literature further indicates that brand names can convey information about the product or product-related benefits, such as the product's semantic or symbolic values (Arora et al., 2015). Accordingly, brands help build consumer awareness, empathy, and recall (Singh & Sonnenburg, 2012). Brands contribute to the generation of consumer self-brand connection (referred to as self-brand congruity), which often leads to favorable brand/product evaluations (Granitz & Forman, 2015). To summarize, the existing research on branding supports the notion that brand elements and logos positively impact consumer perceptions toward products.

The Concept of Branding

The role of brands in consumptive behaviors can also be understood through the lens of fulfilling a human need. Existing literature consistently indicates that human needs direct brand choices in consumptive situations (e.g., Midgley, 1983; Park et al., 1986). Among a myriad of human needs, three primary types have emerged as drivers of consumptive behaviors: functional needs, symbolic needs, and experiential needs (Park et al., 1986). Existing literature supports that brands chosen on the basis of functional needs can be expected to fulfill a consumer's problem-solving task (e.g., TaylorMade's golf drivers as products that offer the benefit of straighter shots). Whereas brands chosen on the basis of symbolic needs can be expected to enhance self-image or fulfill in-group membership (e.g., consumers owning Apple devices expressing social status). Experiential needs drive consumers to choose a brand that fulfills variety-seeking or cognitive stimulation desires (e.g., brands offering products with innovative technology that's introduced to market for the first time; Park et al., 1986).

In order to understand a brand's role in consumer perception, as well as subsequent influence to consumptive behaviors, researchers try to assess these facets from various angles. Researchers often assess perceptions

(e.g., perceived brand associations in which individuals cognitively link a brand with something), benefits (perceived brand equity or brand values that individuals consider important), or attitudes (brand attitude, satisfaction, or brand loyalty, etc.). Keller (1993) defines brand associations as 'informational nodes linked to the brand node in memory and contain the meaning of the brand for consumers' (p.3). Keller separates brand association types into three categories. These three categories include attributes, benefits, and attitudes. Attributes are defined as characteristic features that describe a product or service and are either product-related or non-product-related (Keller, 1993). Benefits are defined as a consumer's perceived values, which are believed to create (functional, experiential, or symbolic) consumptive advantages of a product or service. Added value is also referred to as 'brand equity' (Nandan, 2005). Strong brand equity can lead to a multitude of commercial benefits. These benefits can range from the creation of a solid foundation for a new product launch, licensing, or an increased resistance to competition (Aaker, 1991).

Marketing literature indicates that businesses utilize marketing-mix elements to signal product quality (e.g., charging a high price, offering a certain warranty, distributing through certain channels; Erdem et al., 2006). Strong brand perception thus creates higher perceived product quality (Aaker, 1991). The third form of brand association types, brand attitudes, delineates affective component of consumer evaluations of brands, which is ultimately linked to purchase behaviors. In sum, there is a common view on the role of brands in products serving brands as a source for consumers' cognitive, affective, and behavioral evaluation of brands and associated products. Further, the concept that consumers rely on brands to form self-identity is supported in much of the existing research, including brand personality (Aaker, 1997), extended self (Belk, 1998), and brand attachment (Park et al., 2010). The consumer-brand identification process is understood as 'a cognitive state of self-categorization' in which consumers perceive a brand as representing their self-concept (Bhattacharya & Sen, 2003, p. 77). Therefore, this self-brand attachment reflects the essential role of brands as a driving force in consumptive behaviors.

Emerging Trend of Logo-Less Branding

While branding literature has been consistently prevalent, there has recently been an emerging trend in brand management that highlights potential benefits of logo-less branding in the consumer goods segment. Existing business literature has provided several typologies for this tactic, known as either 'no-brand' or 'brandless/logo-less' branding (Aaker, 2011). This unique and relatively new marketing tactic strategically offers consumer goods at an affordable price while keeping styles and self-expressive benefits when a brand logo is excluded in the product (Aaker, 2011). One of the original

references to this movement is 'Muji', dated in 1983 with its very first branch in Japan. Since its debut, it has spurned across international consumer markets. Aaker (2011) breaks down Muji into four values of production: simplicity, moderation, humility, and self-restraint. This emerging marketing approach can be viewed as a breaking away from the norm in conventional marketing of including a brand logo on products. It's worth noting that there has not been much debate if this new marketing tactic can benefit branding across contexts.

The practice of no-brand (or logo-less) branding has been applied in other contexts such as retail branding, or place branding. Govers (2013) claimed that 'the contribution that logos and slogans can make to the management of places as brands is rather limited' (p. 71). His justification is that logos have more influence in retail environments, where quick purchase decisions are anticipated, whereas place branding may not necessarily require the use of logos, due to the presence of relevant brand resources (i.e., city names). The retail segment, 'Brandless' is known for being one of a kind, which enables this American e-commerce company to sell a wide array of consumer goods without the use of a traditional brand name/logo. This company takes a direct-to-consumer model in selling goods at affordable prices (Schwab, 2017). Schwab emphasizes that such brandless products have a price advantage because they are not restricted by a 'brand tax' (in which traditional branded goods are sold at around a 40% higher price). It is worth noting that 'brandless' is actually a trademarked brand that emphasizes authenticity, transparency, and trust by minimizing expenditure on packaging. Although the emergence of logo-less branding has already been noted, there has not been sufficient discussion on how this approach could affect brand management, especially when context specific.

Although the practice of logo-less (or brandless) branding has become more prevalent across marketplaces, its application to the sports industry is limited. Because the sports industry and its business operations have long been heavily reliant on brands (often with the presence of brand logos on products or relevant services), potential adoption of the brandless tactic in the practice of sports marketing will need to be made with caution. Consistently, we argue that more research can benefit us by showing how a brandless branding can succeed in a new business segment, in which the sports industry encounters the dynamic business environment. For instance, branding, in the context of sport, often occurs within various entities, such as product level, player level, team level, or league level. Lee et al. (2017, p. 293) operationalized the definition of team brand authenticity as a 'perceived evaluation of genuineness ascribed to a team (as a brand) by sport consumers', which adds to the narrative that teams are treated as brands in the sport context. Kunkel et al. (2014) suggest that sport leagues can be considered their own brand. Their research on how individuals perceive professional

leagues as a brand reflects varying consumer perspectives that uniquely occur in specific contexts. Also, their research provided multiple aspects in which sport consumers associate themselves with sport leagues, including tradition, management, logo design, game representation, competition, community pride, etc.

To expand the views on brand association research to the context of sports, Aaker (1997) and Keller's (1993) framework has served as a theoretical foundation for sport brand association scales named TAM (Gladden & Funk, 2002) and TBAS (Ross, James, & Vargas, 2006). The TAM describes 16 constructs depicting sport fan association types in connection with favorite teams they actively follow. This list of team association types exemplify that sport consumers cognitively associate themselves with their favorite teams. It should be reminded that teams were treated as a brand in this context. Consistently, the TBAS illustrates 11 types of fan associations sport fans perceived as important links with their favorite sport teams. Besides both 'brand mark' in TBAS and 'logo design' in TAM, non-logo brand/team association types included team history, tradition, non-player personnel, stadium community, team success, players, etc.

Consistently, Lee et al. (2020) have provided views on perceived fan associations with MLB teams. They claimed both BIRF (basking in despite reflected failure) and CORS (cutting off in spite of reflected success) concepts present unique fan association or dissociation, and have indicated that there are unique logo and non-logo team elements that serve as means for fans to engage (or disengage) in sports consumption. More specifically, they presented a visual map that collectively shows the various aspects of favored teams with which fans often associate, or dissociate, themselves So, their examination on how the fan association types influenced either BIRFers or CORSers introduces teams (as a brand) elements that sport consumers perceive as an important consideration which subsequently leads to ultimate consumption. A total of 16 fan association types and their relative distances are illustrated by plotted locations in the map. Their plotted locations within the visual maps illustrate the similarities and/or differences in participant's cognitive association with MLB teams. Based on the proximity, BIRFers and CORSers tend to share similar team perceptions as well as differentiate their associated images of the MLB teams. Many of the data points in the visual maps plotted within proximate radius indicated similarity in fan perceptions. Yet, what's worth noting is that there were several data points plotted in very different positions when comparing BIRFing and CORSing groups. Their findings provided empirical evidence for sports consumers' perceived images of the MLB teams-fans that are beyond the conventional wisdom of team performance being the dominant influence to sports consumption. Perceived fit between brands plays an important role in consumer evaluation of brands (Aaker & Keller, 1990; Monga & Lau-Gesk, 2007).

Lee et al. (2012) stated, 'under the concept of co-branding, it is relatively unknown whether multiple brands cannibalize each other due to a lack of perceived fit' (p. 161). Another view on this type of brand extension is that that consumer's brand evaluation could vary depending on its dimensionality; that is a single-personality dimension as opposed to a dual-personality dimension (Monga & Lau-Gesk, 2007). A single-dimension represents a situation when cobrands are from the same product category, while dual-dimension represents a situation when cobrands are derived from distinctive types of product category.

Traditionally, the sports industry has heavily relied on its brand marketing to reach consumers, and so the application of the 'no-brand/brandless' approach has been minimal until now. This vacancy warrants a need to assess no-brand branding in sport marketing, since this practice has increasingly been implemented across other business contexts, especially given the current increased recognition for its potential advantages over traditional logo-dependent branding tactics. For instance, omitting brand logos could lower the price of licensed (sport/team) merchandise. However, due to the historical dependence on logos, it could create issues with product identification. It is also worth noting that sport merchandise often copresents multiple brand logos in the same product (e.g., Dallas Cowboys in NFL as a team brand and Nike as a merchandise brand). This dynamic market environment of the sport industry can challenge the application of logo-less branding into sport contexts, which warrants a systematic investigation of the topic.

After a comprehensive review of existing branding (including brandless branding) literature, it can be concluded that the emerging trend of no-brand branding practices has been limited in the sport context. The aim of this chapter is to provide a comprehensive review of the concept of no-brand (i.e., brandless or logo-less) branding and theorize its potential application to the context of sports. The need for this type of review can be justified threefold. First, timeliness is key since no-brand branding is both fast emerging and has not been tested in the context of sport. Second, varying types of sports brands exist at different levels (e.g., individual, product, institutional, event, national/international) which makes branding efforts in the context of sports very unique. While no-brand branding gradually gains its attention from practitioners and researchers, there has not yet been solid ground in the literature explaining how this marketing trend can affect logo-less branding within the realm of the sports industry. And third, the role of brand logos in sports marketing is essentially imbedded in its branding process, since sports products and their related services are often symbolic. Yet again, systematic investigation on this emerging marketing trend has not been sufficiently developed within the sport context, and this vacancy leaves the sports marketing trend obsolete. There are only a few articles that explicitly use the terms 'no-brand' or 'brandless' (Table 5.1). However, none of these articles use the terms 'no-brand', 'logo-less', or 'brandless' in the context of sports.

Table 5.1 Relevant Literature Exercising Logo-Less Branding

Typologies	*Product/brand Classes*	*Key Branding Characteristics*
'Brandless', 'no-brand' branding (Aaker, 2011)	Retail brands (e.g., Muji)	• Highlight functional attributes • No logos, no labels • Simple designs • Cheaper price • Environment friendly • Anti-glitz • Eliminate self-expressive benefits that provides self-expressive benefits • Unique and compelling values • Sustainable • Simple and unassuming
'Brandless' (Schwab, 2017)	Retail brands	• Affordability • Sincerity • No brand tax (40% higher in price than without a brand) • Authenticity • Transparency • Trust • Simple design • Brandless™ • Photography of product itself • Online sales

Discussion

A critical question here is, 'Will logo-less tactics work in the realm of sports marketing?' While existing brand literature consistently highlights the essential role of brands to trigger consumptive behaviors across contexts, the recent emergence of 'no-brand (also, referred to as brandless or logo-less)' branding have initiated discussions on this new marketing tactic. There is a clear trend in the general branding context that logo-less branding can bring potential innovative opportunities for brand managers, though it also poses some uncertainties. Therefore, there is a need for research on this topic that is especially relevant to sports marketing, where the traditional role of brand (logo) in their marketing efforts seem to be inevitable. Consequently, it is important to identify the recent trends in logo-less (or no-brand) branding, and convey the broad landscape of emerging perspectives of the trend.

This chapter provides a monitoring opportunity for the recent emergence of logo-less branding, and delineates how it can be applicable to the practice of sports sponsorship, sports marketing, and/or sport management at large. It is equally important to realize the ongoing market saturation and stagnation prevalent across sports industry segments, which emphasize the role of tailored

branding tactics. There is a need to attest the application of this new branding tactic in sports contexts because the sports industry is one of most dynamic marketplaces. In this vein, several important questions remain unanswered regarding the exercise of logo-less/no-brand branding in sports contexts. This void in the current literature tends to expand across sports contexts. For example, because branding in sports occurs at varying levels (e.g., collegiate, professional sports, individual athletes, or product level), it creates a more dynamic market situation, which mandates a distinctive strategy in sports branding that considers various types/levels of sports brands. To name a few, there are team brands (e.g., Dallas Cowboys), league brands (e.g., NFL), player brands (e.g., Payton Manning), and product brands (e.g., manufacturer brands such as Under Armour). The existing studies on brand associations suggest various non-brand-dependent aspects that marketers could utilize.

To put it into perspective, it is widely recognized that perceived brand image strongly influences a consumer's product (and associated brand) choices, and is derived from various sources, including brand names (Kohli & LaBahn, 1997). This statement implies that there are many sources, other than brand logos, that consumers associate with each brand. Likewise, various non-logo brand elements help create a distinctive image of a brand over competing brands and relevant products. This is because consumers make inferences from brand information that are outside the limits of a brand's logo. Based on Brakus et al.'s (2009) study, non-brand logo elements can include various aspects of brand/product that are sensory, affective, intellectual, and/or behavioral. They referred it to 'brand-related stimuli' with examples of colors, shapes, typefaces, designs, slogans, mascots, or brand characters.

As indicated by Saari and Mäkinen (2017), it is vital to expand the research to the level of cross-cultural testing because brands are viewed differently across cultures. This can be attested to varying consumer experiences and values across nations. The need for this research is also justified by an earlier study done in consumer behaviors by Park et al. (1986). In this research, they highlight that consumer needs serve as a basis for brand selection, which they organize into the following categories: functional needs, symbolic needs, and experiential needs. In particular, this research highlighted 'brand attachment' that creates a bond between consumers and the brand. There is a strong agreement in the existing literature indicating that this type of brand-self connection is a key indicator to product consumption. This widely adopted brand management concept emphasizes the importance of monitoring consumer needs and utilizing such needs in brand conceptualization beyond brand logos within cultural settings. Our argument can be supported by the globalization trend in sports industry.

Where can researchers go from here? Empirical research on logo-less branding in relation to its application to sports context could generate fruitful insights for brand managers that could be used to optimize team merchandise sales. We believe that there is a growing need to research how

consumers perceive the absences of brand names and logos in the context of sports team merchandise as its contribution to team's revenue generation has been critical under market saturation. Findings could illuminate non-logo brand features that consumers rely on to make their product choices. Schmitt's (1999) study suggests that sensory, experiential, cognitive, and emotional elements serve as brand references that consumers consider during their product purchases. More research would lead to a better understanding of how individuals react to branded sport products when brand logos are absent.

In the context of brand management at large, there is existing literature that can offer useful guidelines for brand managers who want to implement logo-less branding in the context of sports. For example, in Keller's (1993) conceptual framework of 'brand associations', researchers in sport context (e.g., Gladden & Funk, 2002; Ross et al., 2006) have investigated the aspects that team followers perceive to be similar between themselves and their supporting team(s). Similarly, both Gladden and Funk (2002) and Ross et al.'s (2006) team association scales have provided a wide array of perceived association types that team followers frequently identify as a reflection of their self-image. More specifically, consistent with Keller's three-dimension (attribute-benefit-attitude) model, examples of 'attributes' related perceived team association types to include logo design, rivalry, venue, star player, etc. Benefits related to team association types included community pride, escape, excitement, nostalgia, peer group acceptance, and/or socialization. Attitude-related team association types included consumer knowledge, product importance, and/or consumer affect, which is conceptually equivalent to team loyalty. These specific attributes/benefits/attitudes indicate which images occupy team followers' minds, which are often translated into actual purchases associated with the sport/team's products and services.

The above research approaches can be expanded to the level of group comparison, as demonstrated by Childs and Jin's (2016) study on how brand presence in a product (as opposed to absence in the same product) positively affects consumer evaluations of a product, especially by female participants, which may suggest an interesting direction for future research. More specifically, when 'brand logo dependence' is measured, gender difference can also be investigated as to look if male and female consumers may display varying types of (non-logo) brand associations. An exploratory factor analysis could be used to see which homogeneous (as well as heterogeneous) dimensionalities emerge between groups (e.g., high- versus low-logo dependence groups). A general linear model such as a multivariate analysis of covariate could also produce useful information when logo-dependence is treated as a covariate. It could be used as a means to explore subject effects across (non-logo) brand association types.

There is a potential for the application of cognitive psychology into logo-less sport branding research. For example, eye tracking (ET) measures have been utilized in cognitive psychology, and in relevant consumer behaviors

and marketing communication research, much of which has investigated individuals' information processing associated with brand evaluations (Chae & Lee, 2013; Santos et al., 2015). This literature commonly indicates that because 95% of purchase decisions are made subconsciously (Zaltman, 2003), ET can be utilized to track non-logo brand elements that (sport) consumers consider important when purchasing logo-less team-licensed merchandise. Relatedly Boerman et al.'s (2015) ET study in 2015 showed that a logo-only product placement gained less consumer attention and weaker brand memory among their study subjects compared to a text-only product placement on television. As sport brands utilize TV as a means to expose their branded products, ET can identify non-logo branding elements to which sport consumers pay the most attention. It's worth noting that sport brands often carry symbolic meaning to the consumers, and thus being able to identify brand and product attributes is important for sport consumers in their consumptive decisions, and ensures better success when logo-less branding is applied to sports context.

We believe that logo-less branding in sports products is a worthy research topic, and ET technique can be a worthy addition to sport brand research. Existing research potentially provides direction for sport brand managers in that ET studies found that package design is an important element for consumers' purchase decisions (Stanley & Elrod, 2014; Wastlund et al. 2010). Additionally, Chae and Lee (2013) employed ET to measure participants' visual attention when presented with brand elements (names, images, logos, packaging, etc.) in the context of online shopping. This approach consistently demonstrates an emerging method of how sport brand managers can identify non-logo branding elements with which consumers engage, which often leads to purchasing behaviors.

The above methodological approach may be expanded to the concept of team identification. For example, Campbell et al.'s (2004) seminal framework depicts both positive fan associations and negative fan dissociations pertaining to teams that individuals follow. Both Basking In Reflected Glory (BIRG) and Basking In spite of Reflected Failure (BIRF) represent the positive fan engagement while both Cutting Off Reflected Failure (CORF) and Cutting Off Reflected Success (CORS) represent negative fan dissociation types. Once ET identified non-logo team brand elements that individuals perceive as important, they could be further examined to see how they could predict consumers' behavioral engagements. The aforementioned four behavioral types and their associative non-logo brand elements could then inform sport brand managers when practicing logo-less branding tactics in the context of sports.

Another possible research direction that sport brand managers may consider is co-branding. More specifically, co-branding that utilizes multiple brands in the same product has become mainstream in marketing during recent decades (Hillyer & Tikoo, 1995). This marketing approach is also known as 'dual' branding (Levin, 2002) because it simultaneously presents two or

more brands under the same product. Lee et al. (2016) have expanded this concept to the context of sports, indicating that this type of brand alliance can reap added benefits for team brands. Taking into account that a range of product features and branding elements impact consumer evaluations of products associated with brands, including team brands (e.g., Ross et al., 2006; Walsh et al., 2012), the significance consumers place on non-logo brand elements can provide guidance for brand managers in determining their strategic direction. Lee et al. (2016) indicated that brand fit serves a vital role in the overall process of team brand evaluations. So, non-logo elements and their perceived fit will then play a pivotal role in consumer's overall evaluation of sport co-branded products. In addition, they indicated that 'product category match' also serves an important function when sport co-branded products were being evaluated by the participants. To an extent, Lee et al.'s (2016) study is conceptually along the lines with other major sport brand studies, including Gladden et al. (2001) and Ross (2006). While conceptual insights from this study could benefit brand managers, it must be noted that their overall findings were based on a sample study that utilized fictitious brands that did not exist in the market.

As brands often play an essential role in building consumer-brand relationships, efficient utilization of brands can create increased chances for business success (Millán & Díaz, 2014). Brand management literature suggests that positive consumer-brand relationships result in a relationship that benefits both parties: increased consumer satisfaction causes brands to benefit from consumer loyalty (McAlexander et al., 2002). The existing literature suggests that more research on how brand elements influence consumer perceptions, attitude, and purchase behaviors will lead to better brand management. While there has been a plethora of research in the context of 'branding', the research on brandless branding is extremely limited, especially in the field of sports marketing. Because of this gap in the literature, this review chapter aims to contribute to sport management and marketing literature by proposing that brandless marketing could be used in a sport-specific context.

This chapter covers potential applications of no-brand branding in the context of sports marketing/management. Additionally, this chapter aims to point out that research on no-brand branding is underdeveloped in the literature at large, and that its application to sports context is currently nonexistent. It is important to note that various entities/organizations that provide and sell sports products/services heavily rely on marketing in their businesses. While no-brand branding has emerged as an attention-receiving marketing tactic that could be beneficial to the sport industry, it is apparent that brand managers need to monitor changes in marketing trends and incorporate them into their practices in order to meet changes in consumer preferences. Thus, it would be fruitful to conduct an empirical examination of which non-logo elements influence consumer perception, in an effort to move toward logo-less branding.

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Chapter 6

Sports Sponsorship and Brand Value

A Case Analysis of Tahincioğlu Basketball Super League Name Sponsorship

Özlem Işık İnan and Yeter Aytül Dağlı Ekmekçi

Introduction

In historical process it is seen that the moves which the humankind did to defend oneself or to hunt at the era of hunting and gathering forms the fundamentals of sports (Tekin & Eroğlu Eskicioğlu, 2015). Today, sport is seen as a mean of entertainment, leisure activity, a means of being healthy, education or a profession (Ekmekçi, 2009). With the increase of sports awareness, sports industry has become among the 20 biggest sectors (Alkibay, 2015). Sports industry includes sports facilities, sports organizations and activities, sports tourism, sports equipment, sports technology, sports hardware, e-sports, athlete nutrition, athlete health, and other relevant areas (Alkibay, 2015; Argan & Katırcı, 2002; Connor & Mazanov, 2010; Ekmekçi & Dağlı Ekmekçi, 2010; Tekin & Eroğlu Eskicioğlu, 2015; Ünsal & Ramazanoğlu, 2013).

As sports have become prevalent, the marketing of goods and services that are directly or indirectly related to sports came into view. Not only the companies that produce sports goods and services but also the companies that produce non-sports goods and services started to take part in sports marketing by recognizing the impact of sports on people (Argan & Katırcı, 2002). By sports marketing it can be meant marketing sports goods and services directly to the consumer and marketing goods and services from other sectors through sports sponsorships. Thus, sponsorship operations are an important subbranch of sports marketing (Kırdar, 2006; Tekin & Eroğlu Eskicioğlu, 2015). Sponsorship is a means of creating or corroborating the brand image and influencing people's purchase preference via placing the corporation, good, or service to be promoted to subconscious of the target market. Sponsorship is a fairly effective communication and marketing method to reach the target market (Karakaş et al., 2013). As the competition has increased and the crowd puller sports has taken more part on the media, which is one of the most important means of marketing, the importance of the sports sponsorship has increased (Bozkurt & Kartal, 2008).

In today's competitive conditions, sponsorship is an important, rapid, and convenient marketing means of creating brand awareness, creating brand

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awareness oncoming process or increasing brand awareness, distinguishing from the opponents, creating brand loyalty, establishing an emotional bond with the target market, and reaching the target market with the most correct budget. Contrary to people's perception, sponsorship is not a grant or donation. It is indeed a commercial partnership to influence people's buying preferences by supporting an organization, a team, or an athlete, creating or corroborating brand image of the sponsor in people's mind by promoting the good and service and increasing the brand name awareness of the brand. Sponsorship means covering the necessary resources to be able to organize programs and activities through sponsor or sponsors. In comprehensive commercial sponsorships, intermediary institutions play a huge role in the organization of big activities or leagues by throwing together the sponsors (Madrill & O'Reilly, 2010).

It is to remember that sports sponsorships have disadvantages besides its advantages. Sports events cannot be surveyed or controlled; thus, there might be unexpected and unforeseen results. That the sponsor enterprise and the sponsored organization are not coherent in terms of cultural norms and values may cause negative perceptions in public. Moreover, employees or the shareholders of the sponsor enterprise may think that the funds spent for the sponsorship could have been given to them and that thought may diminish their loyalty to the enterprise. That sponsored teams, athletes, or activities fail or behave disreputably may affect the sponsor enterprises. In such case, it may take a long time to overcome the impaired credit (Crompton, 2015). The main purpose that underlies behind the sponsorship agreements and the brand management efforts of the managers working for sports enterprises and enterprises in other sectors is creating "brand value" (Alkibay, 2015). In this study brand loyalty, brand awareness, and perceived quality are evaluated by being associated with sponsorship. When the Turkish literature was analyzed, that especially studies from the perspective of the fans are few had influence on determining the subject of this study.

Review of Literature

Sponsorship is a means of marketing communication which allows an enterprise to advertise correctly and effectively and create positive image on the target market devoted to the good or the brand via an activity or event (Bennett, 1999). Sponsorship is seen on the areas such as culture-art, adventure-travelling, social and sports sponsorships. Among the sponsorship areas, sports sponsorship takes the most common and popular place (Çoban, 2003; Tan & Pyun, 2018). It is seen that historical development of sponsorship dates back to 1st century BC. In those years, "patronage" started as mostly unrequited help, and it is the help artists and art received from nobles, royal or ruling family members, and aristocrats. Return of this help is the expectation of earning reputation and making their own names.

(Çamcı, 2009; MEB, 2011; Okay, 2012; Öztürk, 2013; Soyer & Can, 2010; Taşdemir, 2001; Yalaz Seçim, 2003). The first official (registered) example of sports sponsorship is the one Nottingham Forest Football Club realized with the beverage enterprise Bovril (Argan & Katırcı, 2002; Doğan, 2018; Karadeniz, 2009).

Kodak, who was the sponsor of the first modern Olympic games 1896 Athens Olympics, is still a world-known brand thanks to the success it gained (Çelik, 2016). Olympic Games after 1984 have become a profit-oriented industry, and enterprises have realized that their sales increase through sponsorship (Doğan, 2018). By 2000s, all over the world sponsorship has become popular because it allows enterprises to establish an emotional bond with the consumers, and it is more advantageous in terms of cost compared to other marketing practices (Tınaz, 2011). Besides, because of the prohibition on the advertisements of alcohol and tobacco products, sponsorship is used as another field of advertising (Coşkun, 1999).

In real terms, sponsorship agreements have been practiced in the last 20 years in Turkey. However, in Europe and the United States, sponsorship has been used as the most effective marketing communication tool (Gümüş & Erdem, 2014). Euroleague sponsorship of Turkish Airlines, official sponsorship agreements of Tadım, Nesine.com, and SEK brands are examples of international sports sponsorship. With sponsorship, while brands benefit from sports for effective branding and increasing market share, at the same time the main source of income of sports teams, athletes, leagues, and federations is formed (Tan & Pyun 2018: 1). Whereas in sports sponsorship practice, enterprises need to choose the most appropriate one according to their own purposes and goals (Çiftçibaşı, 2017). Sports sponsorship is realized as individual athlete sponsorship, sports team sponsorship, sports organizations sponsorship, sports broadcasting sponsorship, sports facilities sponsorship, and sports institutions sponsorship.

Marketing goals of sponsorship are placing the good to the market, advertising a new good or service, promoting the use or sale of the good, encouraging the dealers, supporting international marketing, and utilizing to new studies and making changes in marketing policies. Public relations goals of sponsorship are supporting and corroborating the enterprise (corporate) identity, making the name institution's name to the target market, supporting and strengthening the existing image of the brand or enterprise, gaining the public appreciation, appearing more on the media by attracting attention, and creating an entertainment environment by strengthening the relations within the corporate (Çamcı, 2009). Advertising goals of sponsorship are advertising the goods of which advertisements are prohibited, backing up the good sales, and benefiting from new advertising opportunities. Communication goals of sponsorship are creating brand name awareness and brand attitude (Jalleh et al., 2002). Personal goal of sponsorship is being used as an important tool for the personal promotion of the owner or the manager of the enterprise. In today's

egalitarian societies in the west, many enterprises and individuals sponsor with the effort to influence the people without causing the eyebrows to raise in spite of the fortune they have saved (Meenaghan, 1983). The sponsorship type through which enterprises realize this goal is sports sponsorship.

Concept of Brand, Branding, and Brand Equity

Brand is defined as the name, term, word, symbol, or different combinations of those created by producers in order to define goods and services, promote them, and distinguish them from the rival products (Ayhan, 2012; Tek, 1999). Though brand started as a way of expressing what an object is, afterward it became a way of naming something (Bastos & Levy, 2012). Evaluated from past to present, being someone and recognition, creating a personal and social identity, making oneself both like other brands and different from them at the same time, besides having a good reputation are the underlying fundamentals of branding (Bastos & Levy, 2012). Consumers should be on the base of brand conception because necessities, characteristics, and demands of the consumers are influential in the creation of the brand. That a bond is established between the consumer and the brand makes consumers feel loyal to the brand. Enterprises provides a competitive advantage by differentiating their products through the help of brand; moreover, they have the chance of giving romanticism and personality to their products (Dicle, 2018). Some disadvantages of branding are also mentioned in literature besides its benefits. These are unnecessary and unrealistic differentiation in the marketing of the products; thus, the biggest damage is the increase in the cost of advertising and packing. Moreover, it is also seen as a damage from the point of society that brands exploit their fame and set a price higher than it should be.

Brand value with the consumer-based perspective is defined as that when both have the same marketing stimulus and product features, consumers react differently to a focus brand and a generic product (Yoo & Donthu, 2001). Especially sports sponsorships provide advantage in creating brand value as a result of the effects of emotions and being exposed to intensive visual (Davies et al., 2006). Aaker (1992) explains brand value (brand equity concept) with five factors, including brand loyalty, brand name awareness, perceived brand quality, brand associations, and other proprietary brand assets. However, those brand value factors are related highly and complete one another.

Brand loyalty is the continuity of the purchasing behavior of consumers, and it stabilizes sales revenues of the enterprises. For brands customer satisfaction and customers have purchasing habits are a sign of a positive brand. Brand loyalty affects other factors composing the brand value, positively (Aaker, 1992). Today, it is difficult to earn the loyalty of consumers based on the diversity of product and brand. Delgado-Ballester and Munuera-Alemán (2001) highlighted the importance of perceived quality, overall satisfaction, and brand reputation for brand loyalty. It is known that herein sponsorship is

effective in increasing the perceived by adding value to the brand and creating brand reputation. Percy and Rossiter (1992) expressed brand name awareness as that consumers can define or recognize one brand detailed enough to purchase it. Consumers who are not aware of the existence of a brand in the market are the target market for that enterprise to reach as soon as possible (Çevikbaş, 2007). Brand name awareness and trustworthiness are highly important for the enterprise, and they underlie the success of the brands (Aaker, 1992). There are many methods used in creating brand name awareness. Buzz marketing, advertising, promotions, and sponsorship are the leading among them (Uslu et al., 2006). Such elements as the purchasing reasons that consumers find in the brand in terms of quality and superiority compared to competitors, product differentiation, price advantage, and profoundness of chain of distribution mean the perceived quality (Aaker, 1992). Perceived quality is not a sign of excellence or superiority of the product or the service about its real quality. On the contrary, it is the subjective opinion of the consumer. So, perceived brand quality is the overall or personal excellence or superiority opinion of the consumers about the product. In short, perceived quality is defined as the perception of quality when consumers compare a brand with another (Göktaş, 2017). Brand associations help awaking positive emotions of the consumers and carrying those positive emotions to the brand (Uslu et al., 2006). For instance, the relationship between a beloved athlete and a brand evokes positive associations in consumers.

Impact of Sponsorship on Branding

Though there are some difficulties in measuring the profound effects of the sponsorships, the relationship and the effects of brand image and brand value factors, perceived quality, brand name awareness, and brand loyalty can be measured. Thanks to the crucial effects such as especially brand name awareness and recognition, positive attitude toward the brand and buying behavior, especially sponsorship, has importance at the core of marketing policies of the enterprises (Stoyle & Cornwell, 2007). It is seen that in the United States the goals of the sponsor enterprises are 67% creating awareness, 63% increasing customer loyalty, 48% creating image or corroborating existing image, 47% backing up the sales, 30% trying the brand and providing accessibility, 30% supporting retail and distributors, 26% contributing to social responsibility, 20% entertaining the customer and the staff, 19% being able to promote a good or service, and 19% having press coverage (IEG Performance Research, 2014).

Impacts of sport sponsorships to develop positive attitude are: brand placing and creating brand reputation in the mind of the target market, creating brand/good name awareness, creating or developing brand image, increasing sales and improving social relationships (Başar, 2018; Drennan & Cornwell, 2004; Masterman, 2007). Thanks to sponsorships the attitude of the organization's

symbolizing entertainment and positive effect will be conveyed to the brands. However, for the bond to be strong, sponsorships need to be for a long time. It is seen that consumers perceiving rapport between the sponsor and the organization think positively about sponsorship for the organization. Thus, brand image transfers and awareness of sponsor enterprise increase, and a positive attitude is exhibited toward the sponsor brand. Brand name awareness and reputation of the sponsor brand that has a high level of positive attitude should increase as its consumers have more information (Donald & Cornwell, 2003). The power of sponsorship partnership represents the connection between the brand diagram in a person's mind and relationship diagram. In this case, as the strength of the connections between diagrams for the brand and the sponsorship relation diagram increases, the brand name awareness, the preference of the brand, and hence the strength of the sponsorship also increase (Zdravkovic & Till, 2012).

The very picture of the results brands get from sports sponsorships is the sponsorship in cricket of English insurance enterprise Cornhill when the enterprise was having difficulties during the 1970s. Cornhill enterprise realized its recognition was around 2% in a coincidental study, and this prompted it to this sponsorship. It was seen that after the sponsorship recognition increased to 8%, and in 1982 it increased to 21%. Thus, besides the brand getting recognized, it gained goodwill and its image increased thanks to its support to cricket which was in a tight spot (Okay, 2012). Another example is the sponsorship agreement Coca-Cola has done with IOC (International Olympic Committee). IOC announced that it extended the sponsorship agreement, which would end in 2020 and is worth 3 billion dollars, till 2032 (www.cumhuriyet.com.tr). Considering these examples sports has an important position as a product that can be consumed by uniting people from different races, cultures, and social status in both branding itself and supporting brads to their goals (Alkibay, 2015). By using focus group method in their research, Meenaghan and Shipley (1999) have analyzed the formed and transferred image on followers through different categories of sponsorships like sports, art, and environmental; the transferred image and tested whether differentiation according to sponsorship categories is beneficial or not. Return of the monetary cost which was paid for sponsorship differs from one sponsorship category to another. The areas in which effects of sponsorships are seen are sponsorships of "sports" and "art".

Enterprises which are sponsor to football in England started to sponsorship on purpose of reach different consumer groups, affect the society and increase the brand name awareness. Sponsorship is a powerful tool to communicate with the fans of sports competitions (Bennett, 1999). Davies et al. (2006) have analyzed the effects of team sponsorships on fans in the England Premier League. It is determined that though the name awareness of the brand increased, the attitude of some fans was indecisive. It is observed that fans supporting their teams do not vigorously support sponsorship, and contrary to

expectations, a positive relation is not found between the brand preference and the intensity of supporting. Zdravkovic and Till (2012) researched the effect of sponsorship on the brand. The goal is to determine the factors which are effective in establishing the bound between sponsors and the sponsored event. The important result of the study is that there is a positive relationship between sponsor and the sponsored event.

Tekin and Eroğlu Eskicioğlu (2015) evaluated the purposes why Turkish Airlines Corp, sponsoring nationally and internationally, sponsors sports events, their sponsorship preferences, and impacts of the sponsorship. Moreover, they evaluated how Turkish Basketball Federation was influenced by these sponsorships. It is stated that THY acts in accordance with sponsorship strategies, and they have the expected impact in the sense of marketing and communication. Turkish Basketball Federation emphasized that the sponsorship with Turkish Airlines is a strategy of institution, it is done to gain reciprocal advantage, and it had the expected impact in terms of communication. Çelik (2016) researched what kind of a brand perception sports sponsor brands make for the target spectators and team fans and the point of view of the target market for sponsorships. It is seen that generally fans of Konyaspor Club have a positive perception for the brand Torku. Çiftçibaşı (2017) analyzed the viewpoint of Beşiktaş Gymnastic Club for the main sponsor Vodafone and the effect of this sponsorship on the fans. It was seen that the brand had positive impacts on fans; as a result of these positive impacts, there is a tendency for the goods of this brand and the fans to trust the sponsor enterprise.

In brief, in the literature it is emphasized that sports sponsorship is an important and strong tool in creating brand image for brands, positive impacts on the present brand image, advertising the brand to different parts of the society, thus creating brand name awareness, placing the brand, increasing the purchasing intention of the target market, and increasing promotional activity with the trust consumers feel for the brand. This research aims to determine how strong sports sponsorship can influence brand value. As basketball catches many people's fancy in Turkey and as it has a high rating, sponsorship of the name sponsor of Turkish basketball league is chosen as the field to study. The research hypothesis was that there would be a relationship between the viewpoint of the basketball fans for sports sponsorship and the sub-dimensions of brand value of the sponsor enterprise.

Method

According to a research the number of spectator attendance was determined as 542,735 in Tahincioğlu Basketball Super League at 2017–2018 season. Moreover, at the same season 2,339 people attended Tahincioğlu Basketball Super League competitions on average. In the second half of 2018–2019 season, we went to the determined Basketball Super League competitions and

conducted a questionnaire to volunteer fans. To be able to reach different fan groups, we chose matches to go to the matches of at least five teams out of fifteen teams competing in the Turkey Basketball Super League during the 2018–2019 season, including (a) Banvit Sport Club vs. Gaziantep Basketbol Sport Club, (b) Afyon Belediyespor Sport Club vs. Beşiktaş Sompo Japan Sport Club, (c) Bahçeşehir Koleji Sport Club vs. Türk Telekom Sport Club, (d) Anadolu Efes Sport Club vs. Arel Üniversitesi Büyükçekmece Basket Sport Club, and (e) Pınar Karşıyaka Sport Club vs. Fenerbahçe Beko Competitions Sport Club. A total of 902 data were collected and 7 that were not suitable for analysis were removed. Considering for the data to represent the universe, it is approved that 660 data set should be collected of 99% confidence interval with the 5% error margin (Taherdoost, 2016: 25). It is seen that the collected 895 data set is between 99% confidence interval and 5% error margin and can represent the universe.

The "Communication Companies Sports Sponsorship Scale" with two sub-dimensions which validity and reliability tests were done by Ercan and Özbek in 2017 and "Brand Value Scale" developed by Yoo and Donthu (2001), which validity and reliability tests done by Taşkın and Koşat (2016) was used. The 332 data collected from the first two competitions were used to test the functionality of the questions added to the scales and statistically analyzed as the pilot schemce (Teijlingen & Hundley, 2001). The questionnaire was finalized by checking the functionality of the items on the scale in sub-dimensions and item reliability. The final version of the survey has 42 items.

Factor analysis and reliability analysis are in the base of plot scheme (Akkaya & Zerenler, 2017). With these analyses the validity and reliability of the questionnaire is checked (Özdamar, 2013). Bartlett test and Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) are the tests that are mostly used to check if the data is appropriate for the factor analysis, before conducting it. (Turanlı ad., 2012). While conducting explanatory factor analysis, KMO (Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin).70 and more is okay; between 08 and .09 is perfect for Sample Qualification Test and for the data to be appropriate for factor analysis Barlett Sphericity Test should be statistically significant (Field, 2009; Yaşlıoğlu, 2017). KMO is .924 for the sport sponsorship scale and .932 for the brand value scale. With these figures, scales are deemed valid.

Depending on the Cronbach's Alpha coefficient, there liability of the scale is interpreted as follows: 0,00 ≤α≤ 0,40 that means it is not reliable, 0,40 ≤α≤ 0,60 low reliability, 0,60 ≤α≤ 0,80 rather reliable and 0,80 ≤α≤ 1 highly reliable (Kayış, 2017). Reliability of sports sponsorship scale $\alpha = .923$, reliability of the sub-dimension viewpoint for sponsorship is $\alpha = .857$, reliability of the sub-dimension viewpoint for the sponsor brand is $\alpha = .801$'dir. The reliability of the brand value scale is $\alpha = .916$, brand name awareness sub-dimension is $\alpha = .765$, brand loyalty sub-dimension is $\alpha = .798$ and perceived quality sub-dimension is $\alpha = .816$. In accordance with the results, the reliability of both questionnaires and sub-dimensions is high in reflecting the present state.

Results

Analyzing the sex of the participants, there are 43.8% (n = 392) woman participants. Examining the frequency distribution of the participants according to age groups, it is seen that highest participation is the 21–25 age group 32.3% (n = 289). The lowest frequency distribution belongs to 51 and over with the rate of 6.5% (n = 58). Examining the frequency distribution of the participants according to educational background, it is seen that the highest participation is the participators with Master degree with 62.5% (n = 559). The lowest rate is 2.3% (n = 21), and it belongs to the high school graduate participants. Overall, analyzing the educational background of the participant Basketball fans, 76.9 % (n = 688) consists of people with bachelor's or master's degree. Lastly, in attendance state of the basketball matches frequency distribution of participants it is seen that the rate of attending 1–2 matches in a season is 48.9% (n = 438). With 15.5% (n = 138) participants going 3–5 matches are second. The lowest frequency distribution is 4.2% (n = 39) and belongs to the participants attending all the matches (Table 6.1).

Of the research participants, 77.9% (n = 697) stated the sector Tahincioğlu Realty Enterprise is in as construction. Food–agriculture 19.1% (n = 171) is second most marked sector. The reason of this is that Tahincioğlu Realty enterprise had partnership in the food sector before and the word "tahini" in the name, which means sesame butter in Turkish, and this situation is understood thanks to the interviews with some of the participants. To the question if they have heard the name of Tahincioğlu Realty Enterprise before the sponsorship agreement they signed with Turkish Basketball Federation, 63.5% (n = 568) answered no and 36.5% (n = 327) answered yes. Six hundred ninety-seven participants correctly guessed in which sector Tahincioğlu Realty operates.

For normality tests of sports sponsorship and brand value scales, Kolmogorov-Smirnov and Shaphiro-Wilk test results can be seen in Table 6.2. According to the table, sub-dimensions ($p < .05$) of the scales are not on the normal distribution curve. So, for nonparametric data which are not distributed normally, Spearman's correlation is used (Eymen, 2007). In addition, correlational and regression analyses are conducted (Eymen, 2007; Field, 2009). Correlation analysis is conducted to find if there was a relationship between the factors that belong to two scales used in the research and if there is a relation and to find the direction and severity of this relation. Spearman's correlation coefficient was not made use of because the data did not scatter normally (Kayış, 2017).

Correlation coefficient is interpreted as follows: r = (+/-) .00–.25 relation on a very low level, r = (+/-) .26–.49 low level relation, r = (+/-) .50–.69 medium-level relation, r = (+/-) .70–.89 high-level relation and r = (+/-) .90–.99 very high level (Sungur, 2017). Between the viewpoint for the sponsor brand sub-dimension and the perceived quality and brand loyalty sub-dimensions ($p < .01$) of brand value sale, there is a low and positive relationship (.451 and .484) in terms of significance; with brand name awareness sub-dimension ($p < .01$) there

Table 6.1 Demographic Data of the Participants and Their Knowledge about the Tahincioğlu Enterprise

	Qualities	*n*	%		*Qualities*	*n*	%
Sex	Female	392	43.8	**Educational Background**	High School	21	2.3
	Male	503	56.2		Associate Degree	109	12.2
					Bachelor's degree	129	14.4
	Total	**895**	**100**		Master	559	62.5
					PhD	77	8.6
					Total	**895**	**100**
Age	18–20	118	13.2	**Attendance State to Basketball Matches**	All Matches	39	4,2
	21–25	289	32.3		All Matches of the Favorite Team	105	11.2
	26–30	125	14.0		10 match and more in a season	79	8.9
	31–40	182	20.3		6–10 Match in a season	97	10.8
	41–50	123	13.7		3–5 Match in a season	138	15.5
	51 and over	58	6.5		1–2 Match in a season	438	48.9
	Total	**895**	**100**		**Total**	**895**	**100**
Sectors Tahincioğlu Business Operates In	Textile	8	0.9	**Hearing of Tahincioğlu Enterprise Before Basketball Sponsorship (Recognition)**			
	Construction	697	77.9		Yes	327	36.5
	Food – Agriculture	171	19.1		No	568	63.5
	Media – Communication	8	0.9				
	Transportation	5	0.6				
	Education	3	0.3				
	Tourism	3	0.3				
	Total	**895**	**100**		**Total**	**895**	**100**

Table 6.2 Kolmogorov-Smirnov and Shaphiro-Wilk Test Results of Sub-dimensions

Variables	*Kolmogorov-Smirnov*[a]			*Shapiro-Wilk*		
	Statistic	*df*	*p*	*Statistic*	*df*	*p*
View Point for Sport Sponsorship	,114	697	,000	,923	697	,000
View Point for the Sponsor Brand	,077	697	,000	,958	697	,000
Perceived Brand Quality	,078	697	,000	,981	697	,000
Brand Name Awareness	,104	697	,000	,964	697	,000
Brand Loyalty	,075	697	,000	,981	697	,000

[a] Lilliefors Significance Correction.

is a high and positive relationship (.783) in terms of significance. Besides, there is a very low relationship (.165 and. 244) in terms of significance, between viewpoint for the sponsorship sub-dimension and the sub-dimensions perceived quality and brand loyalty ($p < .01$), and with brand name awareness sub-dimension there is low level (.492) and positive relationship. In accordance with the results, the hypothesis is accepted. According to the results, generally the positive increase in viewpoint for the sports sponsor brand causes a significant positive increase in the sub-dimensions of brand value. Especially the positive change in the viewpoint for the sports sponsorship brand causes a high and positive increase in the brand name awareness with a value of .783 (Table 6.3).

Regression and correlation analyses are conducted to determine the form, direction, and severity of the relationship between variables. With correlation analysis it is seen that there is a relationship between variables. Regression analysis is used to estimate how much of the dependent variable (DV) is explained by one or more independent variables (IV) (Field, 2009; Küçüksille, 2017). Descriptiveness coefficient (R^2) is the most common measurement way of goodness of fit of linear model. According to the results of the regression analysis, it is seen that 62.7% of the total change in brand name awareness is explained by the fan's viewpoint on the sports sponsor brand (F = 1167,77; p = .000). When other variables are fixed, a unit of change in the sub-dimension of viewpoint for sport sponsor brand makes a positive impact of 0.84 on brand name awareness.

According to the results of the regression analysis, it is seen that 23.6% of the total change in brand loyalty is explained by the viewpoint on the sports sponsor brand (F = 214,44; p = .000). A unit of increase in viewpoint for sports sponsorship brand will make a 0.58 positive impact on brand loyalty while other variables are fixed. According to the results of the regression analysis, it is seen that 22.6% of the total change in perceived brand quality is explained by the viewpoint on the sports sponsor brand (F = 202.80,44;

Table 6.3 Relation Analysis between Sports Sponsorship Scale and the Sub-dimensions of Brand Value Scale

Variables		*View point for Sport Sponsorship*	*View point for the Sponsor brand*	*Perceived Brand Quality*	*Brand Name Awareness*	*Brand Loyalty*
Viewpoint for Sport Sponsorship	Spearman's rho Correlation	1				
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000				
	N	697				
View point for the Sponsor brand	Spearman's rho Correlation	**.661(**)**	1			
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	.000			
	N	697	697			
Perceived Brand Quality	Spearman's rho Correlation	**.165(**)**	**.451(**)**	1		
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	.000	.000		
	N	697	697	697		
Brand Name Awareness	Spearman's rho Correlation	**.492(**)**	**.783(**)**	**.572(**)**	1	
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	.000	.000	.000	
	N	697	697	697	697	
Brand Loyalty	Spearman's rho Correlation	**.244(**)**	**.484(**)**	**.716(**)**	**.730(**)**	1
	Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	.000	.000	.000	.000
	N	697	697	697	697	697

** Correlation is significant at the .01 level (2-tailed).

p = .000). A unit of change in viewpoint for sports sponsor brand will have a 0.58 positive impact on perceived quality.

Moreover, 32.7% of the total change in brand value is explained by viewpoint for sports sponsorship (F = 338.03; p = .000). A unit change in viewpoint for sports sponsorship can make a 0.48 positive impact on brand value.

Discussion

In the market where the competition increases day by day, enterprises are in an effort to distinguish themselves from others by receiving support from growing sport economy. Moreover, enterprises use different marketing methods to create or increase their brand values. Sponsorship is one of the methods whose importance has been recognized over time and whose impact is desired to be benefited more. In this study, the relationships between the viewpoint for the sponsorship of Tahincioğlu Realty and sub-dimensions of brand value are evaluated and interpreted. Analyzing the relationship between viewpoint for the sponsor brand and dimensions of brand value, there is a

medium and positive relationship. However, there is a very low and positive relationship between perceived quality of brand value scale with the sub-dimension of viewpoint for sport sponsorship and a significant, low and positive relationship with brand name awareness sub-dimension. The highest relationship is between the sub-dimension of viewpoint for the sponsor brand and brand name awareness sub-dimension of the brand value scale among its sub-dimensions. The relationship between viewpoint for the sponsor brand sub-dimension and the sub-dimensions for brand loyalty and perceived quality is almost medium, positive, and significant. According to this result, as viewpoint of the fans for sports sponsorship increases positively, brand name awareness increases at a high level and a medium increase is observed in the brand perceived quality.

Regression model analysis results show that viewpoint for the sponsor brand explains 62.7% of total change of the sponsor brand name awareness, 23.6% of total change of brand loyalty, and 22.6% of perceived quality. Besides analyzing the significance level of regression coefficient used for β coefficient regression quotation, it is confirmed that a unit of change in viewpoint for the sponsor brand sub-dimension has a .84 unit of positive influence on brand name awareness, .58 on brand loyalty, and. 58 on perceived quality. In the regression model results where the relationship between overview for sports sponsorship and brand value is shown, it is seen that 32.7% of the total change in brand value is explained by the general viewpoint for the sport sponsorship. While analyzing the significance level of Regression coefficient used in β coefficient regression quotation, it is seen that a unit of change in GENERAL viewpoint for the sport sponsorship has .48 unit of effect on brand value.

Considering the results of the study, it is seen that sport sponsorship is highly related with brand name awareness, brand loyalty, and especially perceived quality. Thus, choosing the appropriate sport sponsorship in accordance with the goals and the target market will increase the expected impact and choices should be made more carefully with detailed actions. Longer sponsorship agreements should be planned while setting the sponsorship goals, considering the importance of the revenues of sponsorships in long term. From the point of researchers who are going to study sponsorship to evaluate the impacts of sponsorship clearly, they can plan researches like collecting data before and after sponsorship. Besides, sponsorship impacts in terms of branches can be evaluated by comparing sponsorships with same status but different branches.

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Chapter 7

Passion in the Branding of International Football Clubs

Darrel Teo

Passion in the Branding of International Football Clubs

Passion for brands is increasingly considered the ultimate emotional connection between the consumer and brand (Swimberghe, Astakhova, & Wooldridge, 2014). It is understood that consumers with a particular brand passion consume neither out of habit nor out of functional utility, but because of a level of resonance and affective attachment to the brand (D'Lima, 2018). In extreme scenarios, consumers become passionately invested in the brands, sometimes more so than they would with their loved ones (McEwen, 2004). Consumer behavior research has indeed provided much evidence of highly passionate forms of consumer-brand relationships: consumers of Nike products (Herskovitz & Crystal, 2010), Apple products (Muniz & Schau, 2005), and Starbucks food and beverages (Ren, Choe & Song, 2023), to name a few.

The above are brands who have cultivated and maintained emotional bonds with their customers. Consumers with such passion thus cherish their favorite brands, and this bond serves important psychological functions. Put another way, the products/services of brands are consumed as consumers look toward the search of meaning and the satiation of deep-rooted psychological needs (Ahuvia, 2005; Huber, Meyer & Schmid, 2015). To this end, it has been contended that the creation of highly emotional consumer-brand relationships is one of the key driving forces in consumer marketing. Therefore, in practice, branding managers have attempted to generate and utilize brand passion because of its positive effects on consumer behavior (Swimberghe et al., 2014). In particular, brand passion has been shown to give rise to more word-of-mouth, higher premiums, higher purchase intentions, greater use of websites and social media accounts (Bauer, Heinrich, & Martin, 2007; Wakefield, 2016).

Turning to the arena of sport consumption, it is not uncommon to colloquially deem fans as passionate. Specifically, in football fandom, passion appears to drive the behaviors of the more enthusiastic football fans. Through this context, passionate football fans are consumers who developed special relationships with their favorite football club brands (Cayolla & Loureiro, 2014).

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For branding managers, such a line of reasoning lends well toward understanding the local fans where their passionate behaviors are on show at the local stadia or pubs (Vallerand et al., 2008). Consider the following theoretical illustration. In a packed football stadium, it is not difficult to regard the spectators as committed individuals whose love for the game is driven by boundless passion. But, this show of passion may be hard to detect in the fans who are based thousands of miles away. This fan segment has been termed distant fans; they are supporters who have no history or geography to speak of in relation to their affiliated foreign team (Kerr & Gladden, 2008; Pu & James, 2017). Watching from the comforts of their homes, they will arguably cheer and cry as hard as the live spectators. Does the same passion drive distant fans' mediated consumption as much as the local fans?

To be sure, although the answer may seem obvious to the layperson, the question has received limited scrutiny from researchers. There are several reasons for this gap in the literature. Firstly, passion as a psychological construct of interest is a relatively recent development (Vallerand et al., 2003) and limited work has been extended to brand passion (Swimberghe et al., 2014; D'Lima, 2018). Though novel in its conceptualization, some preliminary studies have posited passion as a determinant of consumptive behavior (Stenseng, Rise, & Kraft, 2012; Schellenberg & Verner-Filion, 2021). Secondly, although the concept of passion seems central to both commercial and public discourse, the research efforts appear insofar to be scant (Vallerand et al., 2008). Passion associated with sport fans have not been meaningfully examined at the domain (e.g., sports) or property (e.g., team) level (Wakefield, 2016). Furthermore, the distant fans belong to a largely understudied segment in the field of sport consumption (Pu & James, 2017). This is despite global distant fans being arguably as or even more important for the prosperity of many football teams vis-à-vis local fans. Today, distant fans make up the majority of the total fanbase of many internationally popular football clubs (Behrens, Yang, & Uhrich, 2021). Notwithstanding the importance of distant fans, the consumption factors of these fans, especially Asian-based ones who consume European football, have rarely been studied (Yoshida & Heere, 2015).

Taken together, passion is likely to be an important factor for fan's football consumption. Sport marketers who work on the branding of international football clubs must focus on the building of passion among distant fans. Hence, this chapter's purpose is twofold: a primary purpose and an auxiliary objective. Primarily, since passion has received limited empirical work on football fans, an effort was made to understand passion through fan behaviors. Uniquely, with football clubs being construed as international brands (McCarthy, Rowley, Ashworth & Pioch, 2014), understanding fan (or brand) passion as a likely determinant of consumptive behaviors is likely to be important for marketers who are concerned with deepening emotive connections between fans and clubs. Through this lens, fan (or brand) passion is then seen as the ultimate emotional connection between a fan (or consumer) and

a club (or brand) and it should serve as an important branding consideration. Auxiliary, this chapter also expands the understanding of the largely unexplored distant football fan segment.

In summary, through a qualitative enquiry, this chapter is positioned in the context of international branding of football clubs where passion is examined as a useful construct toward driving fan behaviors. The thick data collected is expected to reveal preferences, motivations, observations, and feelings of the distant football fans' brand passion. The chapter begins with a literature review, followed by methods, findings/discussion, and conclusion.

Review of Literature

Dualistic Model of Passion

According to the dominant group of researchers, passion as a psychological construct is a relatively recent development (Vallerand et al., 2003). Historically, passion focused more on the emotional than motivational aspects, and belonged to the purview of philosophy (Vallerand, 2012, 2015). The Dualistic Model of Passion (DMP) was developed by Vallerand and colleagues as the first attempt in legitimizing passion as a construct of psychology (Vallerand & Houlfort, 2003). The duality of passion was posited as harmonious and obsessive passions. Through this conceptualization, intrapersonal correlate studies concerning passion-well/ill-being, passion-motivation, passion-cognitive outcomes, and passion-behavior and performance have proliferated (Curran et al., 2015).

As an operational definition, the DMP defined passion as "a strong inclination toward an activity that people like or even love, that they find important, and in which they invest time and energy" (Vallerand et al., 2003). Implicit to this concept and definition, seven inherent features of passion are observed. These features set passion apart from other related constructs such as zest, grit, and flow (Vallerand, 2015). These features are: (1) passion emerges from a distinctive activity and not from random tasks; (2) the passionate activity becomes part of one's self; (3) passion captures an enduring fondness or love for the activity; (4) passion encompasses high levels of energy and effort; (5) the passionate activity is valued and meaningful; (6) passion is motivational; and (7) passion adopts a dualistic form which leads to adaptive or maladaptive outcomes. Figure 7.1 provides an adapted illustration of DMP and its features.

Two processes were hypothesized to shape the development of passion toward an activity, i.e., activity valuation and internalization (Vallerand et al., 2006). Activity valuation is understood as the subjective importance accorded by the individual to the object of interest. It is expected that if the object of interest is highly valued and meaningful, the individual will be more inclined to internalize the cherished object where it becomes consonant with one's

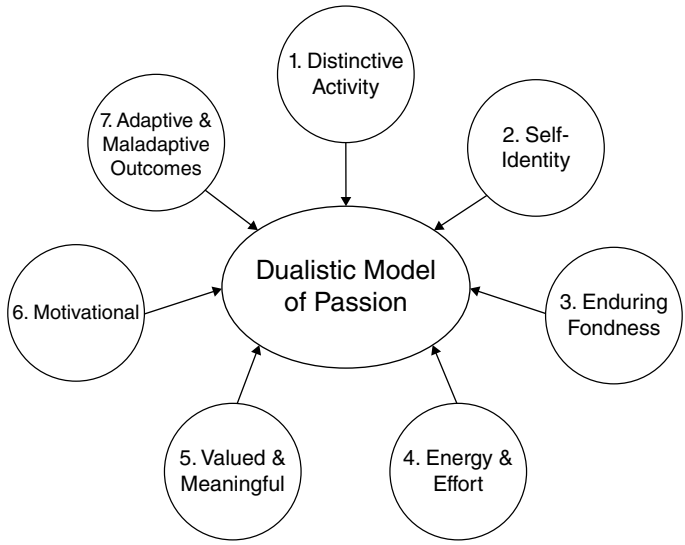


Figure 7.1 Adapted Illustration of the Seven Features of DMP.

self-identity. Depending on the type of internalization, post-activity valuation may result in either harmonious or obsessive passion. In line with the organismic integration mini theory within Self-Determination Theory (SDT), the self becomes more complex over time through the internalization of elements from the environment as well as the interrelations of self-constituents (Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000). Eventually, representations of regular activities that one engages in and enjoys will be incorporated into one's identity. Extending from SDT, DMP proposed that from a controlled internalization, obsessive passion results. In contrast, from an autonomous internalization, harmonious passion ensues.

Obsessive passion originates from a controlled, partial internalization of the activity into the individual's identity. This largely occurs from ego-invested structures within the person (Hodgins & Knee, 2002). This means that controlled internalization result from intrapersonal and/or interpersonal pressure either because some contingencies are bound to the activity, or because certain exigencies tied to the activity engagement are uncontrollable. For example, although fans like or even love football, they may feel compelled to partake in their consumption due to these compulsions that come to control them. These compulsions may serve important compensatory function such as desires to gain social status or guilt avoidance (Schellenberg, Verner-Filion, Quach, & Bailis, 2021). Rigid persistence characterizes activity engagement. The outcomes are described as less adaptive (or even maladaptive) and more related to negative affect (Vallerand et al., 2008).

Conversely, harmonious passion comes from an autonomous internalization of the activity into the individual's identity. That is, the passion emanates from the authentic integrating self of the individual (Hodgins & Knee, 2002). This form of internalization occurs when individuals have freely accepted the activity as important to them, but without contingencies attached to it (Mageau et al., 2009). It also produces a motivation force to engage in the activity willingly and engenders a sense of volition and personal endorsement about pursuing the activity (Curran et al., 2015). Flexibility characterizes the activity engagement. The outcomes are described as adaptive and associated with positive affect.

Contrasting both passion types, even though the outcomes and activity engagement approaches differ, one consistent finding for both types of passion is the underlying heavy involvement toward the distinctive activity of interest (Vallerand et al., 2008). This notion is extended to passion for brands such as football clubs, and it has been shown that both passion types can lead to positive outcomes in the marketplace (Swimberghe et al., 2014). Research has shown that passion drives behavioral involvement toward activities. From a fandom perspective, passion drives sport consumption. In more recent developments, passion was framed as a marketing-related construct where the intensity of passion relates to fan consumption and should be used by practitioners as a fan segmentation tool (Simmons, Popp, McEvoy & Howell, 2018). This agrees with most passion research which had shown that passion is a predictor of the consequences of activity engagement, and is not an outcome per se (Philippe, Vallerand, Houlfort, Lavigne & Donahue, 2010). In these recent studies, passion was found to relate and predict attendance as well as traditional and social media consumption of local sport fans (Wakefield, 2016; Simmons et al., 2018). However, the passion construct used in these studies was unidimensional. In this chapter, the DMP which has received wider empirical scrutiny is adopted to provide the main framework toward understanding fan (or brand) passion.

Method

A qualitative approach using purposive sampling is adopted to recruit football fans in Singapore. There are two reasons why this approach is preferred. Firstly, this design is aligned to calls by passion researchers to partially address the lack of complementary qualitative studies carried out under the DMP framework (Vallerand, 2015). As noted by Curran et al. (2015) in their meta-analysis of passion research, there is a gap to be filled by qualitative researchers who can subject the DMP to broader forms of empirical scrutiny. In addition, it has been observed that when passion is introduced into a new research arena, researchers supported the approach of first conducting qualitative research. Specifically, in their work on re-conceptualizing brand passion, Swimberghe et al. (2014) undertook qualitative research before conducting

three quantitative studies. Secondly, this sampling technique is selected as the main objective is to identify a representative sample who can contribute meaningfully to the central phenomenon to be examined (Patton, 1990). To ensure maximum representation, respondents were recruited from both genders, different age groups, and occupational backgrounds. No incentives were provided. However, as the research is designed for distant football fans, all recruited respondents must identify themselves as fans of foreign football clubs.

The end of the data collection process is guided by data saturation (Glaser & Strauss, 1967) which is achieved via an iteration of interviewing and transcribing the data, immediately analyzing it, and then continuing to collect and analyze new data until no more emergent patterns is identified (O'Reilly & Parker, 2013). In total, 13 eligible respondents (aged 20 to 57) were interviewed. All the interviews were individual, semi-structured, and lasted approximately 25–50 minutes (Smith & Sparkes, 2016). All sessions were carried out over synchronous video conferencing platforms, digitally recorded, and transcribed verbatim. A profile of each respondent is presented in Table 7.1.

The interviews consist of two parts. The first part focused on demographics, identification with favorite clubs and consumption behaviors. The second part is designed to understand the possible consumption factors of the respondents' distant football fandom. In this latter part, an interview guide was prepared. In it, broad questions such as "what have you experienced in football?" "what do you like about football?" "describe yourself as a football fan" "do you find following football meaningful?" and "why do you like football?" served as the base questions to elicit initial responses. For deeper insights, follow-up topical questions, based on the review of fan motivations, were asked depending on the respondents' initial responses to the broad questions. For example, when a respondent described himself as a passionate fan, the follow-up topical questions is either for him to describe moments when he can identify his passion or if he can explain how this passion came about. To encourage further contributions toward the end of the interviews, a final question was posted: "is there anything else you can share about your football fandom?"

In concurrence with good research practice, respondents' names were masked. For the transcriptions belonging to the second parts of the interviews, content analysis was used to interpret the data by providing context to the coded data and on the identified themes (Bengtsson, 2016). Extra care was taken in the development and evaluation of codes to ensure that the higher-order themes were a function of the meaning found in the responses. For instance, when the respondent said "I will support them till I die", this meaning unit is pre-coded as "diehard fan with rigid persistence". To reflect the interpreted latent meaning of the initial quote, this pre-code is further coded as "obsessive passion" and finally assigned to the overall theme of "passion". This was an important step as the respondents gave contextualized jargons

Table 7.1 Profile of Respondents

Pseudonym	*Gender*	*Age*	*Race*	*Occupation*	*Yrs as Fan*	*Socializing Agent*	*Favorite Team(s)*
Peter	M	29	Chinese	PhD Candidate	15–20	Father	Chelsea
Kat	F	20	Chinese	Undergraduate	3	Father	Barcelona & Liverpool
Jason	M	36	Chinese	Game Designer	25–26	School and classmates	Liverpool
Farah	F	20	Malay	Polytechnic Student	7	Friends	PSG
Henry	M	22	Chinese	Soldier	8	Close friends	Chelsea
Victor	M	57	Indian	Academic Manager	35–45	Friends	Liverpool
Sarah	F	44	Malay	Civil Servant	25–30	Friends	Liverpool
Hugh	M	23	Malay	Deliveryman	11	Family and friends, but mainly elder brother	Manchester United
Jon	M	58	Chinese	Lecturer	5	Sons	Manchester United
Phyllis	F	28	Indian	Entrepreneur	23–24	Father	Liverpool
Mick	M	37	Chinese	Finance Analyst	27	Media	Barcelona
Danny	M	35	Chinese	Bank Analyst	27–28	Brother	Liverpool
Leonard	M	38	Chinese	Marine Surveyor	26	School and friends	Manchester United

Table 7.2 Summary of Themes Identified from Content Analysis

Theme	*Description*
Passion	Motive to take part in an activity that one likes or even loves
Group Affiliation	Motive to foster interaction and connectedness
Self-esteem	Motive to enhance one's overall sense of self-worth and personal value
Aesthetics	Motive to consume an activity which is inherently artistic or stylistic
Eustress	Motive to take part in an activity which is psychological arousing
Escape	Motive to take part in an activity as a form of mental diversion
Learning	Motive to pick up new information or knowledge
Entertainment	Motive to find enjoyment through an activity
Economic	Motive to find an avenue to gamble
Accessibility	Motive to take part in an activity which is convenient

such as "the Reds" which is Liverpool's nickname and "You'll never walk alone" which is Liverpool's club motto and a highly symbolic phrase for all Liverpool fans. Next, to enhance the findings' validity, the research was externally reviewed by three marketing faculty members from universities in Germany and Singapore. The researcher first analyzed the data and forwarded the substantiated themes to the experts. The experts then discussed the contents of the thematic analysis and resolved any differences as a group.

Several overarching themes emerged from the analysis. These themes emanated from the elemental needs sought and sentiments of the distant fans. In line with the literature on sport fan behavior, several themes uncovered were those which had been articulated in previous fan motive studies. For instance, group affiliation and self-esteem. In all, ten themes were identified. Table 7.2 provides a summary of the identified themes. Most importantly for this chapter, passion has been identified as a determinant of football consumption.

Findings and Discussion

Passion Feature 1 (Distinctive Activity) and Passion Feature 2 (Self-Identity)

As pointed out by football scholars, football is deemed the 'serious life' where a fan's 'bounded' identity generally refers to deep affiliation to his or her team (Giulianotti & Robertson, 2004; Abosag, Roper & Hind, 2012). Following one's football club is a highly distinctive and self-defining activity. Aligned with expectations, all the respondents mentioned they support elite European clubs. Notably, when discussing their fandom, most of the respondents made

it a point to express distinct connections when discussing their clubs. They also emphasized that following their clubs is their main conduit into consuming football.

When asked if following their preferred clubs predominate their consumption of football, turn of phrases such as "it is the only team", "I only watch Manchester United games", "I think it's strictly just Liverpool", "it will just lead me to think of Chelsea", "I always focus on Man Utd more of course", "if I were to read any sports news, it always starts from Liverpool", and "revolve around Chelsea" were used to illustrate the importance of team-related news or contents. Plural pronouns such as "we" and "us" were also used. Respondents clarified that matters relating to their teams were granted much attention in their consumptive behavior. This finding is also consistent with the notion that one's team identification is more central to self-identity than one's general sport fandom (Koch & Wann, 2016).

However, an interesting observation was made in that the two youngest respondents (Kat and Farah, both are 20 years old) shared that player identification is more relevant to them than team identification. To illustrate, Farah follows Kylian Mbappe from PSG very closely. And when she said that she watched PSG, she meant watching this player more than watching the team. Conversely, the team-specific phrases above were made by the *older* fans who have followed the game for several years. This indicates that team identification lies on a continuum where the connection between the fan and team deepens over time through multiple interactions (Funk & James, 2016); and that either age or number of years as a fan is a potential moderator for this relationship.

It is known that when fans are asked to identify activities which they are passionate about, they often reported leisure pursuits which are often team sports-related (Philippe et al., 2010). Through the above findings, it is evident that certain features of passion and team identification are somewhat related (Vallerand et al., 2008). Indeed, there are overlaps in the theorizing of passion and team identification in that both entail certain levels of internalization. As such, football fans are not mere supporters, but fans of his or her club. Specifically, once formed, a highly identified fan's self-identity would be synonymous with his or her team identification. Therefore, it is expected that passion would have played a role in driving interactions with the objects of interest for such identification to take root.

Passion Feature 3 (Enduring Fondness) and Passion Feature 4 (Energy and Effort)

When asked to describe themselves as football fans, the duo of Mick and Leonard opened their remarks with:

> Maybe I'll describe myself as passionate.
>
> – Mick

> I am very passionate about football.
>
> – Leonard

Everyone has an idea what passion is, but when probed, different individuals will likely give slightly different answers. However, most of them will probably agree that passion points to a mix of intense motivations and fervent emotions. Passion thus drives football fandom and consumption through emotions (Philippe et al., 2010). Emotions are corollaries of passion, not components (Curran et al., 2015). When recounting leaner times for his favorite team, Mick was open about him shedding tears:

> But similarly, during very bad times, like the recent bad result against Bayern that we had, that was kind of like the first time I cried since I was a small boy, to be honest.
>
> – Mick

Similarly, Leonard spoke about how bad results may affect his mood miserably, yet he continues to follow his favorite team even as he could not articulate why:

> Oh, it affects your mood. Especially in the immediate aftermath when results don't go your way… No, I don't really understand why we are so fixated on the one team. Like the team I am supporting now, it is going through a very bad patch. But we are still very supportive of them.
>
> – Leonard

As related further by Mick, he articulated that no matter what happens to his team, he will continue to be a passionate fan. This is similar with Leonard who also shared that he has seen similar displays of emotions from fellow fans around him. There is an element of persistence underlying passion. Presumably, this persistence is characterized by an enduring fondness toward the team. Moreover, this persistence in one's fandom is naturally extended to the energy and effort put in by distant fans toward their football consumption.

According to the DMP's passion definition, football fans will invest resources in acting out one's fandom. As such, football fans recognize trading time, energy, and effort into consuming football as part of their passion toward their love for the game. To this end, Peter put it succinctly when describing himself as a passionate fan whose "digitally driven" leisure time is dominated by football:

> My passion is probably driven by the fact that the bulk of my leisure time spent on internet browsing or simply scrolling through social media … the algorithms on all the social media pages, the images or all my sponsored

> stuff tends to be football related … these are the things that I would stop and read … I would say I'm a passionate fan.
>
> – Peter

Similarly, though claiming that he doesn't see himself as a "hardcore" fan, Danny gave an estimate in that half of his time spent on devices such as TV and mobile phone is spent on football:

> I would not say hardcore, but I would try to watch every game that my favorite team plays. But if you take in the perspective of just watching something on TV or mobile phone… football related viewing takes up 50% of the time I spend on such devices.
>
> – Danny

Even among the respondents, there are those who recognized that even if they perceived themselves as less passionate, they know of others who are truly passionate. For example, Sarah commented that she is a more moderate fan now than when she was a younger, more fanatical fan. She is perhaps playing out her role identity as a middle-aged woman in relation to her identification with Liverpool, where there are more important roles to act out than being a football fan (Lock & Heere, 2017). She also spoke about how she consumes her football in isolation these days. Comparatively, she highlighted that she knows others who are more passionate about their favorite clubs. In this case, she was describing a fellow Liverpool fan who consumes football-related activities more than she does:

> He's one of the most passionate Liverpool fans … he will always send me articles about Liverpool when sometimes I just need to take a break from reading about them… Then he will also go to Anfield every year … he just enjoys hanging out with the rest of the other Liverpool fans in Singapore. So, I would say that he is more fanatical… Because for me, I prefer to read about Liverpool in isolation, which means that I just enjoy reading about them. Periodically, if I meet another Liverpool fan, I will just chat for a while. I don't go deep dive into those very in-depth discussions… They are more passionate.
>
> – Sarah

Passion's feature on spending time and resources is extended to material goods. Henry remarked about passion directed material consumption with regard to fellow Chelsea fans who he believes are more passionate than him (his self-rating stands at "7 out of 10" as a Chelsea fan). To this point, his main contention is that there are indeed very passionate fans as evident from their high frequency of procuring club merchandise and digital football news consumption:

> I have friends who are Chelsea fans, but between myself and them, they are more fanatical than me… I will say two things. The first is apparel. They will go down to the shop for jerseys when the new ones are released. So, they'll spend money on the jerseys and some merchandise. I find such merchandise a waste of money. It is like, don't you have pens or cups? So, I find that they are a bit over-the-top. And every time I see him over the weekend, he is always in the Chelsea jersey. I'll feel like, doesn't he have other shirts?
>
> – Henry

For Sarah and Henry, they are fans who recognized their passion toward their respective clubs. But, they also suggested that there are more passionate fans. This suggests a continuum exists for the passion construct and that it can be quantitatively measured (Vallerand, 2008). Furthermore, it can be seen from the findings above that distant football fans display enduring fondness and spend effort at following their football teams. Arguably, occasional insinuations directed at non-local fans' lack of authenticity appear premature.

Passion Feature 5 (Valued and Meaningful) and Passion Feature 6 (Motivational)

Aside from behaviors, activity valuation is expected to play an important role in the development of passion. With regard to perceiving following football as a highly valued, passionate activity, respondents also ruminated about the need for their football fandom to harmonize with their personal values. For instance, Peter recognized his passion, and is clear that he values his own opinions toward the game. In other words, he values this passion of his:

> I see myself as a passionate fan because I have strong opinions about the game and I will say that this passion can be undermined by perhaps, when I take certain stances about the sport, and I defend the stances.
>
> – Peter

For some people, the passionate activities they engage in are more aspirational, even ideological, or related to causes in nature (Vallerand, 2008). From a branding perspective, it is important to understand the symbolic meaning of these activities, and how this meaning relates to the consumers' aspirations. Both meaning and aspiration are closely interlinked as they concern the embrace of experiential, emotive, and subjective aspects of consumption over the functional and objective (Delia & James, 2017). Furthermore, just satisfying one's basic need for competence in that moment is insufficient (Deci & Ryan, 2000). It is expected that a passionate individual will view engaging the activity as representing a meaningful "possible selves" (Markus & Nurius, 1986) or future-mindedness (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000).

When asked if following football carries any meaning, respondents responded with answers which are aspirational, a positive desire to be better. That is, through passionate activities, they are seeking eudaimonic well-being: self-realization and personal growth (Ryff & Keyes, 1995; Vallerand, 2012). For instance, Victor spoke about needing to "live up to the game" and keep fit and healthy even as he crossed the wrong side of middle age:

> Oh, yes. I find it a lot, because meaning … gives me some kind of joy in watching something. Because you watch the game, you also want to live up to the game in that sense … if I was not watching the game, I think I would have given up playing personally. I was playing soccer even to the age of fifty, which means I had to keep my fitness up … I can go even further … I never found the need to pick up smoking because I found it useless because, hey, I'm a soccer player… It's meaningful as it steered me in some ways.
>
> – Victor

Beyond aspirations, when asked the same question on meaning, respondents also expressed views which are closely linked to the outcomes of SDT's intrinsic motivation, that is, purposeful behavior carried out solely for its own sake, i.e., the behavior stems from itself (Ryan & Deci, 2000). Vallerand and colleagues had documented the similarities between SDT and their theorizing of DMP. These views by the respondents further corroborated how intrinsic motivation and (harmonious) passion are correlated (Vallerand et al., 2003; Wang, Khoo, Liu & Divaharan, 2008). For example, Jason mentioned how football is meaningful as a form of entertainment for its own sake:

> I think it is meaningful entertainment. But the part I can say where it might be trivial or irrelevant is that it is not like I am ever gonna make a living out of it. It is purely entertainment. It just keeps me entertained and something I'm interested in, but it's not like I have a career in it or like we're gonna ever make money off my knowledge of it or anything like that.
>
> – Jason

Danny's remarks also displayed notions of intrinsic motivation when asked why he likes football and if he finds his fandom meaningful:

> I don't have very clear thoughts but I just love it… I find it meaningful because it is something that I am passionate about. We can find passion and dedication in it… I think it serves a purpose. You can imagine it like a religion. Like I am religiously following up all the news and live games of my team. I guess that's all I can do for the club, besides purchasing their merchandise. Show my moral support, even though they won't know that someone like me is watching their live games. But I think it is a part of my

> life which I find fulfilling as I am dedicated to it. I like to share the good experiences that I have when watching them, and share other positive things that I have with my family and friends when the team is performing well.
>
> – Danny

Though related, there are distinctive differences between intrinsic motivation and passion. Intrinsic motivation is not seen as being internalized in the person's identity and is best understood as emerging from the person-task interaction at the short-term level (Vallerand, 2008). Conversely, passion carries a notion of self-identification and activity perseverance (Philippe et al., 2010). On the latter point, the passion-directed activity lasts over a longer timeframe. This sense of passion over a longer period is reflected by how the older fans are more effusive when articulating this observation as compared with the younger fans.

The oldest respondent (Victor) summed it up best when he claimed how an authentic fan like himself is much in love with *the game* – almost the raison d'etre of the game. It is as if he is after the autotelic experience, and not the peripheral aspects of the game such as fancy merchandises/apparels:

> So, when you talk about passion, the passion is actually about the sport… We were more concerned about the strategies, the way we are playing, the tackles they were doing, the marking and the static positions. Then came another person who was watching the same game, but the observation was totally different. It was the color of the boots they were wearing… And you know the game changes, but it's not the merchandising, that's not so important. No, it's the game. So, I think the passion for me as far as I know is the game.
>
> – Victor

By declaring his passion toward *the game*, Victor thus hinted and "acknowledged" his expertise. As noted by Vallerand (2012), for individuals who engage in a long-term passionate activity, they become an "expert". Perhaps, this is true of Victor. These "experts" grow psychologically as individuals, and their self in this sphere of activity becomes increasingly complex. Consequently, the same activity offers opportunities for renewable elements that will sustain the increases in psychologically well-being. As such, long time passionate "expert" fans who have had repeated engagements with this self-defining activity will foster increments in psychological well-being.

Passion Feature 7 (Adaptive and Maladaptive Outcomes)

As hypothesized by DMP, passion results in a duality of adaptive and maladaptive outcomes. While some of the respondents reported experiencing

eustress (i.e., good stress) and self-esteem boosts by the vicarious achievements of their teams, several also reported being adversely affected in mood and daily functioning as part of their fandom:

> I guess I am passionate because when we see things that do not marry with whatever we were thinking about… Passion is something which affects you in some ways… So, I think when you're passionate about something … it affects you either positively or negatively in a sense. You can see … the drain of energy when your team loses, it is there and then the jubilation when your team wins. So, you can feel it, you can sense it… And when we talk about soccer, what they are doing, what they're not doing, how we are not performing as much as we know we can. So, it is part and parcel of the game itself. So, in that sense, yes, passionate.
>
> – Victor

In the above quote, Victor's comments about passion as a drive which affects individuals either positively or negatively point toward harmonious and obsessive passions resulting from different internalization processes. As expounded, harmonious passion yields adaptive outcomes while obsessive passion gives rise to more maladaptive outcomes. Both types of passion were reported by respondents.

For example, Farah felt that she is in harmony with her passion for football, but she knew of fellow fans who are obsessive. She highlighted that her peers are "hardcore" fans who will get very affected if things do not go their team's way; they will also watch live games in the wee hours due to time zone differences and this practice has detrimental effects on their general health and productivity during the day. For the distant football fan, watching live matches in unearthly hours may be a requisite sacrifice made in honor of the team:

> If you watch soccer… you shout at 3am in the morning, I believe that your heart is in soccer already.
>
> – Hugh

Other respondents reported that they generally exercise good self-control in that they will prioritize what matters more. This shows their flexible engagement with football, rather than rigid and conflicted persistence with a neediness to consume the game, i.e., more harmonious than obsessive passion. However, the more important point here is that respondents recognized both the adaptive and maladaptive effects of passion.

Conclusion

Through a qualitative study, the main purpose of this chapter is to understand the distant football fan behaviors by positing brand passion as a legitimate

construct of interest. On their own accord, respondents used the words "passion" and "passionate" frequently. They also shared how they follow football by distinctively supporting teams based in Europe, described the time/resources they channel toward football consumption, defended their opinions of the game, shared about themselves as well as fellow fans who display *passion*, related to the motivational and aspirational aspects of passion, and self-identified as long-term *true* football fans. Many of such responses corroborated with the seven definitional features of passion. These are empirical support that distant football fans identify with passion and that, notwithstanding the distant nature of this fan sample, passion as a consumption factor could explain the fan phenomenon, contribute to the sport management literature, and aid sport managers in their branding efforts.

Relations with other constructs such as team identification and intrinsic motivation were also reported. In particular, overlaps between team identification and passion were observed: both constructs describe an enduring fondness toward a distinctive, self-defining activity (i.e., following a distant football team) which requires energy and effort. However, passion differs as it encompasses a motivational quality and a duality of adaptive/maladaptive outcomes. By this, it suggests that deeper work can be undertaken to understand the relationship between the unidimensional team identification and bidimensional passion constructs. To this end, team identification has shown to produce both well-being and ill-being outcomes among fans, and this paradox could be further examined through the DMP (Vallerand et al., 2008).

Next, the findings lend a degree of richness toward how the understudied distant fans come to understand their football fandom. Most pertinently, it reflects distant fans having strong desires for passion-directed football fandom to be satiated. Table 7.3 summarizes the findings supporting passion as a determinant of fan behaviors. For branding practitioners, the qualitative findings of this chapter are clear. The concept of brand passion is important but appears underutilized in the world of international sports. Self-reported passion by these distant football fans reveals that as part of their international branding work, the conditions for the development of brand passion should be considered a focal endeavor. With passion, the creation of highly emotional consumer-brand relationship could then be established.

Finally, a more nuanced understanding of brand passion is provided. Harmonious passion is related to a healthy and balanced form of emotional attachment to the football club brand. Fans enjoy engaging with the brand and feel a sense of fulfillment from the brand interactions. On the other hand, obsessive passion is characterized by more intense and unbalanced emotional attachment to the football club brand. Such fans may become overly preoccupied with the brand and feel a sense of compulsion to consume. External factors such as social status or validation interfere with volitional consumption, and this may further conflict with personal values and goals. While obsessive passion may lead to high levels of brand engagement and

Table 7.3 Summary of Findings Supporting Passion as a Consumption Factor

Features of Passion	*Respondents' Articulation*
Distinctive activity	Respondents report strong support toward at least one European football team; respondents follow the game through their teams.
Self-identity	Respondents use plural pronouns such as "we" when talking about their teams.
Enduring fondness	Respondents have been supporting their teams for several years; respondents express love toward their teams both in good and bad times.
Energy and effort	Respondents share about spending time, money, resources and sacrificing sleep as part of their consumptive practices.
Valued and meaningful	Respondents find value in their fandom by describing how it is aligned with their thoughts, opinions, and beliefs.
Motivational	Respondents report a drive to both consume and be better (aspirational) because of their fandom.
Adaptive & maladaptive outcomes	Respondents recognize both the positive and less desirous effects of following football as distant fans.

even loyalty in the short term, it can also lead to negative outcomes (i.e., fatigue, burnout, and disillusionment, etc.) in the long term. Therefore, brand managers should be careful not to overemphasize external factors such as social status or validation in their marketing efforts. Taken together, brand managers should be aware that passion comes in two varieties, and they should cultivate harmonious passion by creating positive brand experiences that align with the fan's values and avoid overemphasizing external factors that are esteem-related, while also encouraging a healthy balance between engagement with the football club brand and other aspects of a fan's life.

By demonstrating passion as a salient factor of consumption, it opens fresh lines of enquiries for the study on sport fans. For instance, future quantitative studies can explore the more granular dimensions (i.e., brand loyalty, brand advocacy, brand awareness, brand trust, brand reputation, etc.) of football club brands and determine how they are related to brand passion. Next, it was reported that there are few notable studies on the mental and social benefits of fandom. Psychological health studies on fans who form their identification from afar are even rarer. What remains under-investigated is how mediated consumption for distant fans impacts the relationship between passion and intrapersonal/interpersonal outcomes. Such investigation may result in beneficial findings for branding managers of both large and smaller football clubs who are looking overseas for new segment of fans in solvent territories – away from their already saturated home markets (Manzenreiter & Horne, 2007).

There are also methodological limitations that must be considered. Firstly, this study is not framed as a comparison study between distant and local fans.

The study only interviewed Singaporean football fans who support European clubs. That means the findings may or may not apply to local fans. Future studies should adopt comparison designs to compare passion-directed behaviors between the two groups of fans. Secondly, distant fans reported flexible engagements with football. Comparing with local fans, whether this reflects higher levels of harmonious passion and/or lower levels of obsessive passion needs to be determined quantitatively. Similarly, the discussed correlations between passion and other constructs of relevance can be statistically examined.

In closing, through the findings, the passion construct found support as a salient determinant driving the distant fans' football consumption. Fans experienced and self-reported their passion toward *their* favorite football club brands. Both types of passion lead to positive, unambiguous outcomes in the often-crowded football marketplace. Passionate fans are more likely to provide positive word-of-mouth and more likely to become brand ambassadors for the clubs. Therefore, brand managers have empirical support to formulate "passion branding strategy" to allow their clubs to compete internationally (Swimberghe et al., 2014; D'Lima, 2018).

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Chapter 8

Student-Athlete Name, Image, and Likeness (NIL)

Sponsorship Opportunities and Challenges

John A. Fortunato

Introduction

On July 1, 2021, student-athletes received the ability to profit off of their name, image, and likeness. Student-athletes are able to be compensated for activities, such as: endorsement of brands, personal appearances at stores or businesses, autograph sessions, speeches, operating sports camps, giving private lessons in their sport, producing instructional videos, crowdfunding for charitable organizations, and social media opportunities, including postings, podcasts, and YouTube videos. Several student-athletes announced that they reached sponsorship deals on July 1 and in the subsequent months (Higgins & Radnofsky, 2021; Weil, 2021). Student-athletes being able to use their name, image, and likeness to endorse brands creates another opportunity for sponsors to reach and engage with the college sports audience. Sponsorship of collegiate athletics is appealing because companies are reaching an age group that has not established a brand preference in many product categories. College sports fans have also been shown to be passionate and loyal toward their university, with researchers demonstrating that these emotional characteristics can result in the purchase of the university's sponsors' products (Madrigal, 2000; Kirkpatrick & Eason, 2019).

Implementing name, image, and likeness policy is complex, with the NCAA offering limited guidelines, laws being enacted by some state governments, and multiple pieces of legislation introduced in the United States Congress. The purpose of this chapter is to analyze the practical implementation of name, image, and likeness by drawing upon an understanding of: (a) the sponsorship practice, (b) sponsorship and college sports economics, and (c) the name, image, and likeness regulatory environment. This chapter offers a sampling of student-athlete name, image, and likeness sponsorship agreements to demonstrate how brands are using this new asset to achieve their marketing objectives.

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Sponsorship Practice

Marketing efforts are designed to move consumers along the path toward using the brand, regardless of their perception of the brand or their need to purchase an item in that product category. Keller (2001) defines marketing objectives as trying to "inform, persuade, incite, and remind customers, directly or indirectly, about the brands they sell" (p. 819). Murphy et al. (2011) add, "a marketing program is intended to plan how products or services are taken from the point of production to the point of consumption in such a way as to develop a positive relationship between consumers and the producer that will foster additional or repeat usage" (p. 23). Their outcome of generating repeat usage speaks to behavior beyond onetime consumption and toward an objective of brand loyalty. In this ideal scenario, a consumer of a product category no longer debates between the brand options and continues to loyally support the same brand.

In its most general description, sponsorship is another form of marketing that can help a brand achieve its marketing objectives (Fortunato, 2013; O'Reilly & Lafrance Horning, 2013; Walraven, Bijmolt & Koning, 2014). Meenaghan (1991) defines sponsorship as "an investment, in cash or in kind, in an activity, in return for access to the exploitable commercial potential associated with that activity" (p. 36). The main benefit to the property (defined as any league, team, event, or individual endorser) is obvious upon entering into a sponsorship agreement as it adds another major revenue source to its business. Sponsorship offers a series of distinct benefits for a brand as well, including product category exclusivity, creating and communicating a brand association with a property and its audience, and developing a flexible and customizable activation program that offers opportunities for brand exposure, brand recall, enhancing brand image, communicating a brand theme, and achieving any other brand-specific marketing objectives (Fortunato, 2013; Meenaghan, 1991; O'Reilly & Lafrance Horning, 2013; Walraven, et al., 2014).

Brand exposure is often the most vital element to the success of the sponsorship and has to be the initial achieved objective. Other sponsorship objectives might not be achieved if the brand is not noticed in that location. Without the brand being noticed, any consumer reaction or behavior toward the brand is due to some other reason than that particular sponsorship. Brand exposure is essential in helping achieve the important objective of brand recall. It is not enough that consumers are aware of the product category (i.e., insurance), they need to be aware of and have the ability to recall the specific brand name (i.e., State Farm) at the time when the purchase decision is being made. Recall is especially important where there are several competing brands in a product category or when an individual is making a purchase for the first time in a product category. Sponsors often receive product category exclusivity to assist with brand recall. Exclusivity is valuable because it simply eliminates

any competition that a sponsor might receive from a rival within that product category at the sponsored event or location, or with the sports league or team (Miyazaki & Morgan, 2001; Papadimitriou & Apostolopoulou, 2009). The result of exclusivity could be a promotional communication advantage for the sponsor. Miyazaki and Morgan (2001) note that "the ability to be an exclusive sponsor in one's product category presumably aids in avoiding the competitive interference that typically is experienced in other media contexts" (p. 10). Papadimitriou and Apostolopoulou (2009) explain that exclusivity also acts as a barrier to competitors who might have tried to acquire that same sponsorship or at least diffuses the promotional attempts of competitors during the time that the company is sponsoring the property.

Brand association is another prominent sponsorship benefit. Sandler and Shani (1989) offer a definition of sponsorship that emphasizes the brand association that is created between a sponsor and a property. They describe a sponsorship agreement as "the provision of resources (money, people, equipment) by an organization directly to an event or activity in exchange for a direct association to the event or activity. The providing organization can then use this direct association to achieve either their corporate, market, or media objectives" (p. 10). Dean (2002) explains that "for the payment of a fee (or other value) to the sponsee, the sponsor receives the right to associate itself with the sponsee or event" (p. 78). He adds that "by associating itself with the sponsee, the sponsoring firm/brand shares in the image of the sponsee" (p. 78). Grohs and Reisinger (2005) point out that "the aim is to evoke positive feelings and attitudes toward the sponsor, by closely linking the sponsor to an event the recipient values highly" (p. 44). Stipp and Schiavone (1996) claim that the sponsorship objectives assume that the target audience for the sponsorship will transfer its loyalty from the sponsored property or event to the sponsor itself.

Sponsorship effectiveness due to a brand association is reliant upon the proper property selection (Connolly & Connolly, 2014; Prendergast et al., 2010). Connolly and Connolly (2014) contend that the strategic fit between the sponsor and the property is the most critical factor of sponsorship success. Any audience transfer from the sponsor to the property will be strongest between brands and properties that have a similar relevant image-based connection (Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Prendergast et al., 2010). As individuals perceive a relevant fit between a sponsor and a property, they are more likely to view the sponsor in a positive manner and their ability to identify and recall the correct sponsors of the property increases (Connolly & Connolly, 2014; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Madrigal, 2000).

Sponsors receive the right to use the property brand logos, trademarks, and footage in their marketing campaigns. Sports properties have developed iconic logos (i.e., the Olympic rings, the Dallas Cowboys star, or the University of Texas longhorn). The use of logos on product packaging and in other promotions helps to clearly communicate the brand association between a

sponsor and a property. For example, Coca-Cola can have the Olympic rings logo or a university logo on a case of soda and use those logos in its marketing communication. Brand association is especially relevant in the context of sports sponsorships because of the characteristics of sports fans. Experiencing sports has been shown to satisfy many emotional needs, with motivations greatly heightened when one's favorite team is playing in the game (Gantz, 2013; Wann et al., 2000). The popularity of these sports teams is such that a brand association could help achieve the desired transfer of the audience's support of the team to support toward the sponsor. In studying the relationship between fan identification and university sports apparel sponsors, Kirkpatrick and Eason (2019) reported in their survey research that more than 70% of respondents could accurately recall the sponsor of their favorite team's uniforms, and more than 66% claim to be more likely to buy apparel from the sponsoring brand of their favorite team.

Other researchers also indicate that developing a brand association transfer through a sponsorship could result in an increase in purchasing the products of the sponsoring brand (Dean, 2002; Harvey, 2001; Madrigal, 2000; Miyazaki & Morgan, 2001). Harvey (2001) claims that "sponsorship changes the consumer's perception of a specific sponsor – which can rub off positively on brands that sponsor in terms of willingness to purchase those brands" (p. 64). In examining college football fans, Madrigal (2000) found that fan behavior extended from support of a team to support of companies that sponsor that team. This positive behavior toward sponsors was more prevalent for more die-hard fans of the team. He states, "loyalty toward a preferred team may have beneficial consequences for corporate sponsors. Consistent with the idea of in-group favoritism, higher levels of team identification among attendees of a sporting event appear to be positively related to intentions to purchase a sponsor's products" (p. 21).

Sponsors need to develop a flexible and customized activation program that is designed to achieve their marketing objectives (Davies & Tsiantas, 2008; Fortunato, 2013; O'Reilly & Lafrance Horning, 2013). Cornwell et al. (2005) define activation as "collateral communication of a brand's relationship with a property" (p. 36). Fortunato (2013) explains that activation "can simply be thought of as the methods used by sponsors to communicate and associate their brand to the property and consumers" (p. 99). The design of an activation program is only limited by the creativity and imagination of the people representing the sponsor and the property, with ideas originating from either party. O'Reilly and Lafrance Horning (2013) stress the need for sponsors to devote resources for activation. They define activation as "the additional investment and activity in a sponsorship beyond the rights fee spent to initially acquire a property" (p. 425). Davies and Tsiantas (2008) argue that developing a quality activation program designed to achieve marketing objectives is more important than simply increasing the amount of activation spending. Researchers, overall, contend that sponsorship success

is determined by both the design of the activation program that is developed and the resources invested (Cornwell et al., 2005; Davies & Tsiantas, 2008; Fortunato, 2013; O'Reilly & Lafrance Horning, 2013; Papadimitriou & Apostolopoulou, 2009).

The core sponsorship principles of product category exclusivity, brand association, and activation extend to individual endorsers. Till (2001) claims that athlete endorsements influence the way that consumers view the image of the sponsored brand. Stone, Joseph, and Jones (2003) found that an emotional tie can be created with consumers through the use of an athlete endorser, improving both brand awareness and the image of a company. Koernig and Boyd (2009) comment on the authenticity of athlete endorsers, stating, "athletes present a special case as endorsers because our attitudes and knowledge about them derive not only from seeing them in contrived situations (i.e., movies or events), but also how they behave and perform in spontaneous situations on the field of play" (p. 26). It should be noted that the role of sponsors in the economic model of sports has received criticism (Jackson & Andrews, 2005; Jhally, 1989; Rowe, 2004). Schiller (1989) wrote extensively about the role that corporations have in influencing the types of content and events that exist or what becomes extinct within the culture. He contends that corporations are the proliferators of culture and ideas through their economic support. According to Schiller (1989) corporations take on the role of validating agents for certain images, expressions, ideas, and entire entities to have an existence within the culture. The criticism of corporate influence has specifically been raised in the context of collegiate athletics (McAllister, 1998, 2010; Sperber, 2000). This concern is undoubtedly heightened as a greater presence for sponsors in college sports is a certain outcome of student-athlete name, image, and likeness opportunities.

Sponsorship and College Sports Economics

The NCAA is registered as an unincorporated not-for-profit educational organization that is exempt from federal taxes. The NCAA surpassed $1 billion in revenue for the first time in fiscal year 2017, with an estimated 80% of its revenue generated through the television contract to broadcast the men's basketball tournament (Bauman & Davis, 2018). CBS and Turner pay the NCAA $10.8 billion over 14 years in a contract that runs through 2024. In 2016, these networks extended the contract to broadcast the NCAA men's basketball tournament through 2032 for an additional $8.8 billion (Smith & Ourand, 2016). Mark Emmert, NCAA President, explained, "we have 90 championships, but only one – basketball – generates virtually all of the revenue that comes into the association and goes back out to the schools" (Smith & Ourand, 2016, p. 6). The NCAA reports that only five Division I championship tournaments are financially self-sustaining: men's basketball, men's ice hockey, men's lacrosse, wrestling, and baseball

(www.ncaa.org/about/where-does-money-go; note: The Division I football playoff and bowl games are independent events that are not coordinated by the NCAA).

Sponsors play a vital role as a revenue source in the economic structure of the NCAA. The NCAA explains that its sponsors "provide a direct, positive impact on the academic and developmental opportunities afforded to nearly half a million NCAA student-athletes each year" (https://www.ncaa.org/championships-corporate-marketing). The NCAA also indicates that its sponsors are "dedicated to excellence and committed to developing marketing and promotional activities surrounding NCAA championships" (https://www.ncaa.org/championships-corporate-marketing). Bachman (2021a) points out that the attractiveness of being an NCAA sponsor is largely related to the men's basketball tournament.

The NCAA distributes more than 90% of its revenue to the college conferences and universities (Smith & Ourand, 2016). Revenues are distributed through a series of methods. The largest revenue distribution is through the Basketball Performance Fund (www.ncaa.org/about/where-does-money-go). This money is the only on-the-field performance-based revenue distribution. A conference is awarded one unit for each NCAA tournament game that its member universities play. Conferences are paid for each basketball unit earned over a six-year rolling period. In 2021, each basketball unit was $337,141 (McGinty, 2021). Other financial distributions by the NCAA include money provided to any conference that competes in Division I basketball and money provided directly to a university based on the number of sports played and the number of scholarships offered. Universities obtain revenue through their affiliated conference, most notably conference broadcast rights agreements and sponsorships. In 2017, the Big Ten conference signed a six-year, $2.46 billion broadcast rights agreement with Fox and ESPN/ABC to televise football and CBS to televise basketball (Stubbs, 2017). Universities in the Big Ten are expected to earn more than $51 million annually in conference revenue dispersals (Chengelis, 2017).

Dr. Pepper is one example of a company that entered into sponsorship of college sports through agreements with the college conferences. Coca-Cola is a sponsor of the NCAA. Coca-Cola and Pepsi have the pouring rights at college campuses. Dr. Pepper's sponsorship activation with the college conferences is centered on a tuition giveaway contest. The contest that features students wearing Dr. Pepper branded jerseys and throwing footballs into inflatable replica soda cans is aired on national television during halftime of the college conference championship football games. Dr. Pepper also has a presence in college football as the presenting sponsor of the college football playoff trophy (Smith, 2014b). Jim Trebilcock, Dr. Pepper executive vice president of marketing, explained that the association with college football through the conferences is "our single largest investment from a marketing standpoint. We found an avenue in, and we owned it early on" (Smith, 2014b).

The universities sell their own sponsorships through agreements with a multimedia rights holder. A multimedia rights holder pays the university a guaranteed dollar amount in exchange for performing the duties of selling sponsorship and advertising for local television and radio broadcasts of games, ancillary programming such as coach's shows, digital, print, stadium and arena signage, and hospitality. Multimedia rights holders are able to grow their business by expanding the roster of universities that they represent and acquiring more media and event location rights from their current roster of universities. For example, many universities retain the pouring rights for soft-drink sponsors to their stadiums, arenas, and in some instances these agreements cover the entire campus. The University of Alabama receives between $15 million and $16 million annually from its multimedia rights holder, Learfield, in a contract signed in 2014. The fee is double what Alabama had been receiving for its multimedia rights (Smith, 2014a). Learfield acquired concessions and pouring rights for both soda and isotonic beverages from the University of Alabama in the new agreement.

Many universities also retain the lucrative uniform and equipment rights. Being the official uniform and equipment sponsor for a university is a major desire because of the strong brand image association created with the university, the considerable brand exposure through logos on the team uniforms, and the fact that college team uniforms and other merchandise are a major seller (Kirkpatrick & Eason, 2019). University sponsorship for uniforms and equipment are a very competitive product category for brands such as Nike, Under Armour, and Adidas. For example, both the University of Texas and Ohio State have contracts with Nike for more than $250 million over 15 years (Cohen & Germano, 2016). In 2014, Under Armour replaced Adidas by agreeing to a ten-year, $90 million contract to provide all uniforms, footwear, and apparel for Notre Dame (Tracy, 2014).

The Name, Image, and Likeness Regulatory Environment

Name, image, and likeness policy implementation exists in a complex regulatory environment. Sponsorship opportunities within sports are a function of what is permitted by leagues and governing bodies. Recent new sponsorship opportunities granted by professional leagues include brand placement on jerseys (Burns, 2021; Germano & Perlberg, 2016), on-the-field/playing surface (Thomas, 2018), and new product categories, such as sports gambling (King & Lombardo, 2018; Fischer & King, 2019) and crypto currency (McCormick, 2021). The NCAA, however, does not have unilateral oversight regarding name, image, and likeness policy provisions. Several states enacted laws, with some starting on July 1, 2021. Multiple pieces of legislation have also been introduced in both the United States House of Representatives and the Senate. The NCAA is seeking a federal law that will supersede state laws and

provide a singular national policy. The NCAA is concerned that the different sets of rules enacted by the states will lead to unfair practices in college sports.

The NCAA has desires for what it hopes a federal law would include. The NCAA most wants a system where there is no direct payment from the universities to student-athletes. The NCAA also hopes to maintain some fairness in recruiting, with student-athletes not deciding which university to attend based on the most attractive state laws for name, image, and likeness compensation. The NCAA is concerned about the financial solvency of university athletic departments. The NCAA is trying to ensure that there is not an outcome of less playing and education opportunities for student-athletes, such as through the elimination of sports teams. The NCAA fears that sponsorship revenue could potentially be diverted from the university and go directly to a select number of student-athletes as a company could view aligning with them to be more economically efficient and more effective for achieving its marketing objectives. There are important economic realities that universities are already confronted in the operations of college sports. It has been reported that more than 90% of Division I university athletic departments have expenses greater than revenue (McGinty, 2021).

In May 2019, the NCAA established a working group to examine the name, image, and likeness issue and offer a series of policy recommendations. In April 2020, the NCAA Board of Governors expressed support for the recommendations that were put forth. The working group's detailed recommendations featured the following provisions: (1) student-athletes can use their name, image, and likeness to operate camps, endorse brands, give private lessons, be paid for autograph sessions, and crowdfund for charitable organizations; (2) Student-athletes can identify themselves as participants in their sport, but they are not permitted to use any conference or university logos in promotions or personal appearances, including the wearing of jerseys; (3) There will be no direct payment from the universities to the student-athletes; (4) Conferences and universities cannot facilitate endorsement opportunities or promote these activities; (5) Agents will be allowed to negotiate deals on behalf of the student-athletes; (6) There will be no cap on the amount that student-athletes can earn, but they have to disclose their name, image, and likeness activities, along with compensation, to the university; (7) A regulatory body is to be established, either nationally or by conference, to evaluate the fair market value of a sponsorship so that a student-athlete is not receiving a substantially higher fee for an endorsement, which can be construed as a recruiting enticement; (8) Name, image, and likeness money cannot be linked to performance to eliminate any perception of pay-for-play. For example, through this provision a sponsorship cannot be crafted so that a basketball player's compensation is based on a number of points that he or she scores; (9) Endorsement of brands in controversial product categories will be prohibited, such as alcohol or sports gambling. In terms of transparency, the university has to inform student-athletes of the associations that are prohibited; and

finally (10) a third-party administrator can assist the university in the educating, monitoring, and reporting of student-athlete activities (NCAA Press Release, April 29, 2020). Companies have been formed with the design of being experts on the name, image, and likeness rules to assist universities with monitoring compliance and educating student-athletes (Smith & Fischer, 2020). Partnering with such firms creates another expense for university athletic departments.

Developing singular rules for all universities is a challenge because there are great disparities among university athletic programs' revenue generation and expenses, and in the revenue that is generated by individual sports. Student-athletes also have disparate prospects in terms of playing their sport professionally. The NCAA failed in passing a name, image, and likeness policy that would apply to all universities. The NCAA hoped that if it passed a policy the states might rescind their laws because the NCAA would now have adequately addressed the issue. Instead, on June 30, 2021, the NCAA simply announced that all student-athletes can benefit from their name, image, and likeness with those in states with a name, image, and likeness law following those regulatory guidelines. The student-athletes in states that did not have a name, image, and likeness law take effect on July 1, 2021, will follow the rules created by their university. The NCAA provided the universities in the states that did not have a law with very limited guidelines: (1) there would be no direct payment to student-athletes for performance or recruiting; (2) universities would not negotiate agreements between student-athletes and sponsors with agents and marketing firms permitted to negotiate their agreements; and (3) universities have to keep a record of all student-athlete name, image, and likeness deals (Smith, 2021a).

California was the first state to pass a name, image, and likeness law in September 2019. The California law allows student-athletes to be compensated for their endorsement of brands and appearances at autograph sessions. Student-athletes are permitted to hire agents to negotiate these deals. A provision in the law is that the NCAA or the universities in California cannot restrict or punish student-athletes who monetize their name, image, and likeness assets (Smith, 2019). The California law does protect existing university sponsorships by preventing student-athletes from making agreements with product category competitors of university sponsors (Gay, 2019). Although many states followed a similar framework presented in the California law, different provisions were introduced. The Colorado law offers the right for student-athletes to bring suit against the NCAA if their eligibility is threatened. New Jersey's legislation calls for universities to be prohibited from membership in any organization that prevents student-athletes name, image, and likeness compensation. The laws in Michigan and Minnesota explicitly state that student-athletes will not receive any money directly from their university. However, South Carolina, a state where name, image, and likeness compensation was first legislatively proposed in 2014, calls for student-athletes who play

football and basketball to receive $5,000 per year. New York proposes that student-athletes be paid by the universities at a rate of 15% of ticket revenue generated. The Wisconsin law would make it so that the student-athletes have to notify their university prior to signing an endorsement contract and that they could not enter into any agreement with a company that would be negatively associated with the university (*Street & Smith's Sports Business Journal*, 2019). Both the Texas and the Georgia laws require that student-athletes attend financial literacy and life skills workshops (McCann, 2021). Texas has in its law that universities could share a student-athlete's contact information with potential sponsors if he or she gives permission (Smith, 2021a). Louisiana state law permits student-athletes to use university logos, although the university has oversight on how the logos can be used (Smith, 2021a).

With this new property available, it is important to examine some sponsors strategies in selecting which student-athletes to partner with and how they are activating these sponsorships. One notable attribute of student-athletes is their presence on social media (Weil, 2021). A marketing executive from an agency that specializes in pairing student-athletes with companies for sponsorship opportunities estimates that 90% of name, image, and likeness agreements have a social media component, such as the student-athlete posting pictures with or using the brand product. Haley and Hanna Cavinder, twin sisters who play basketball at Fresno State, announced on July 1 sponsorship agreements with Boost Mobile and Six Star Pro Nutrition, a sports supplement company (Karimi, 2021). They had more than 3.4 million TikTok followers in the summer of 2021. The Cavinder sisters were in New York's Times Square, where their names were on a billboard announcing their Boost Mobile deal, and they appeared on multiple media programs to publicize these agreements. Clemson University football player Braden Galloway became a sponsor for hair, suit, underwear, and jewelry brands. Galloway had more than 160,000 Instagram and over 400,000 TikTok followers at the time of his sponsorship agreements (Mullen, 2021). Galloway wears a Theory brand suit when he walks into the stadium before a game and posts pictures on social media as part of this sponsorship activation. The Theory suit brand is trying to promote its lower-price point clothing for college-aged men (Mullen, 2021). The agent who negotiated the sponsorship deals for Galloway commented, "he's definitely that typical kid nowadays, that is influential. He wears the right sneakers, the right clothes, the right look and feel" (Mullen, 2021).

Paige Bueckers from the University of Connecticut was the first freshman women's basketball player to be named Associated Press National Player of the Year after the 2021 season. It is estimated that Bueckers will earn more than $1 million per year in endorsements while playing for Connecticut, more than she would earn from a professional salary (Bachman, 2021b). Bueckers had more than 900,000 followers on Instagram in the summer of 2021, a number greater than all of the starters on the men's basketball 2021 final four teams combined. Part of the appeal for sponsors to associate with Bueckers is

that the rules of the WNBA professional league prohibit players from entering the draft until they finish their college eligibility or are 22 years old. Whereas star men's college basketball players often leave school after one season, Bueckers will play four seasons at one of the country's top programs (Bachman, 2021b). Bueckers signed her first endorsement deal in November 2021, a three-year contract with StockX, an online footwear and apparel marketplace (Cooper, 2021). Later that month, Bueckers became the first student-athlete to become a sponsor of Gatorade (Bhasin, 2021).

Local restaurants became a prominent product category for student-athlete sponsorships. Chicken restaurant chain Bojangles signed University of North Carolina quarterback Sam Howell and Clemson University quarterback D.J. Uiagalelei as endorsers (Everett, 2021), while chicken restaurant chain Zaxby's signed University of Georgia quarterback J.T. Daniels (Higgins, 2021b). Wright's barbeque restaurant located near the University of Arkansas campus paid an estimated $5,000 to have the team's offensive line, one of its defensive linemen, and the starting and backup quarterback as endorsers (Higgins, 2021a). The student-athletes were given $200 gift cards and merchandise to promote the restaurant on their social media channels using #BodyByBBQ. After an initial event in which the student-athletes visited the restaurant and consumed over $1,000 worth of food, the restaurant reported an increase in its business (Higgins, 2021a). Mission barbeque, a restaurant chain in sixteen states, reached sponsorship deals with the University of Notre Dame and the University of Wisconsin offensive lineman (Higgins, 2021a).

The University of North Carolina implemented a group licensing model that has the benefit of combining the use of university assets (logos, trademarks, facilities) with the marketability of the student-athletes. This collective approach is thought to be more valuable for a sponsor as the brand association with the university and its athletes can be more clearly communicated (Cunningham & Underwood, 2021). The North Carolina group licensing plan requires at least three student-athletes from one team or six student-athletes from multiple teams to be a part of each agreement. A third-party company is responsible for negotiating the group licensing deals. Royalties from these deals are shared between the group members and the university (Smith, 2021b). Deals with ten companies were reached in product categories such as apparel, including Nike and Hanes, sports nutrition, and gameday party suppliers (Smith, 2021b). More than 20 universities with prominent sports programs, including Alabama, Ohio State, and Texas, have adopted some form of a group licensing model (Smith, 2021b).

The advantageous flexible and customizable characteristic that separates sponsorship from other forms of marketing has been evident in some of the other unique student-athlete name, image, and likeness activations that have been crafted. A sports nutrition company in Utah paid the 36 walk-on players on the Brigham Young University football team the equivalent of a full athletic scholarship (Higgins, 2021b). Gorilla Glue partnered with the Rich Eisen

sports talk show to give a "Toughest Player on the Planet Earth" weekly award to a college football player, with the winner receiving $1,000 (Smith, 2021a). Milner Technologies, a company with operations in Georgia and Florida, compensates student-athletes who then appear at events at a local YMCA. Florida State women's soccer player Jaelin Howell earns an estimated $5,000 from Milner Technologies in exchange for her making visits to a YMCA to teach kids soccer (Weil, 2021).

The Florida Panthers became the first professional team to partner with student-athletes through their FLA-Athlete program. University of Miami quarterback D'Eriq King became the program's first representative in August 2021. King is to appear at Panthers games, promote the team on social media, develop co-branded merchandise, and create a concession item at the team's home arena (Florida Panthers Press Release, 2021). In September 2021, the Panthers announced an agreement with every female athlete at Florida Atlantic University. The more than 200 student-athletes are invited to attend Panthers games and post about the team on their social media (Ledra, 2021). World Wrestling Entertainment, WWE, created a name, image, and likeness program where it partnered with 15 college athletes who play basketball, football, track and field, and wrestling, including Haley and Hanna Cavinder. The program is designed to recruit future talent for the WWE. The student-athletes will have access to the WWE's training facility in Orlando, Florida, and work with WWE personnel on brand building, media training, live event promotion, creative writing, and community relations. A student-athlete upon completion of the program could earn a WWE contract (WWE Press Release, December 8, 2021).

There could be challenges to using a student-athlete as an endorser, similar to those when using professional athletes. There is a concern if a student-athlete is involved in inappropriate behavior. There is also a concern if a student-athlete is injured or not performing well. Paige Bueckers and J.T. Daniels missed multiple games due to injury after signing their sponsorship agreements. Spencer Rattler was the starting quarterback at the University of Oklahoma entering the 2021 season. A preseason Heisman Trophy favorite, Rattler had the largest social media presence of any college football player entering the season (Smith, 2021a). Rattler reached deals with Raising Cane chicken tenders and a local car dealership that was already the largest automotive sponsor of Oklahoma sports. The car dealership added to its association with Oklahoma when it gave Rattler a Dodge Ram pickup truck and a Dodge Sport Sedan (Higgins, 2021c). The value of Rattler's sponsorships was questioned when he was benched during the season. The owner of the car dealership commented that his company might look to partner with the team's new starting quarterback, stating, "whoever is QB1 of Oklahoma football. I want that partnership. If OU was going 0-12, I would want that partnership" (Higgins, 2021c). Rattler became one of several players who had a sponsorship agreement with a local company, but then transferred to another university to continue his college football career (Higgins, 2021d).

Discussion

Student-athletes being able to use their name, image, and likeness to endorse brands creates another opportunity for sponsors to reach and engage with the college sports audience. Implementing name, image, and likeness policy is complex. Understanding the sponsorship practice provides insight into what the name, image, and likeness policy provisions need to include so that student-athletes can maximize their earning potential and so that it is appealing for sponsors to use student-athletes to achieve their marketing objectives. The unique sponsorship benefits of brand association, where sponsors are able to develop and communicate an alignment with a property, product category exclusivity, which eliminates brand competition, and activation, where partnerships are customized to achieve specific brand goals, need to be examined in the context of name, image, and likeness policy. In terms of brand association, name, image, and likeness policy should be crafted so that student-athletes are permitted to use the university logos, wear jerseys, or use campus facilities in their marketing endeavors. A sponsorship is devalued if there is not clear communication of a brand association between a company and a property that can be recognized by consumers. If a sponsor cannot properly promote its brand association, it might not be as inclined to engage in marketing campaigns using student-athletes, hindering their potential revenue opportunities.

Universities are concerned with their brand being associated with an undesirable product category (i.e., alcohol or sports gambling). Restrictions on student-athletes sponsoring certain product categories and using university logos in a certain manner appear to be legislatively acceptable. To illustrate, the Wisconsin law does not permit student-athletes to partner with companies in undesirable product categories. The Louisiana law allows student-athletes to use university logos and facilities, but the university has oversight on how they can be used. In terms of exclusivity, a provision in California's law is that student-athletes cannot endorse the product category competitors of university sponsors. This provision makes the sponsorship of a university more valuable because it includes access to all of its student-athletes. The law, however, limits the brands that student-athletes can partner with. One remedy could be that if a student-athlete partners with a brand that is a product category competitor of the university's sponsor, then he or she would not be permitted to use the university logo. This rule would be similar to how logo usage is done in professional sports. If a team and a player are both sponsored by the same brand, a player can use the team logo in his or her marketing. If a player is sponsored by a brand that is different than the team, he or she is not able to use the team logo in the marketing campaign (Fortunato, 2013). The University of North Carolina's group licensing model is designed to overcome this challenge by combining the use of all university assets (logos, trademarks, facilities) with the marketability of the student-athletes (Cunningham & Underwood, 2021).

The NCAA has concerns of how name, image, and likeness implementation will affect the structure of college sports. One concern is financial where sponsorship revenue is diverted from the university and goes directly to a select number of student-athletes leading to an outcome where the university has to eliminate some sports teams. A second concern of the NCAA is sponsors having a significant influence in recruiting, giving some universities an unfair advantage. Sponsors influencing recruiting raises the prospect of potential impropriety, a condition that does already exist, but can certainly be magnified in a system of student-athlete name, image, and likeness compensation. A greater presence for sponsors in college sports is a certain outcome of student-athlete name, image, and likeness implementation, no matter the specific policy provisions. An expanded role for sponsors in college sports amplifies the perspective of corporations having too much of an influence in higher education (Schiller, 1989; McAllister, 1998, 2010; Sperber, 2000). The marketing and regulatory implementation of name, image, and likeness is in its infancy. The marketing implementation landscape will continue to be shaped by the creativity of sponsors in how they use student-athletes to achieve their marketing objectives. The regulatory implementation landscape can still be altered if a federal law is passed. This remains the hope of the NCAA so that there is uniformity for all universities in all states. Any policy adjustments must recognize the principles of the sponsorship practice or the intended outcome of enhanced economic opportunities for student-athletes through name, image, and likeness usage will not be optimized.

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Chapter 9

Impact of Perceived Functional and Image Fit on Consumer-Focused Effectiveness for New NBA Sponsorship

Wen-Hao Winston Chou and James J. Zhang

Introduction

Sport sponsorship has grown into an almost-ubiquitous phenomenon of marketing communications around the global for the past two decades due in part to the rise of indirect forms of marketing when new technology continuously transform the way brand owners communicate with their target consumers (Chou et al., 2020; Johnson et al., 2020; Mao & Zhang, 2018). Increasingly more new corporations are keen to make monetary investment into sponsorship (Cornwell, 2020). They might be newly formed companies or exotic brands that collaborated with properties for the first time in some specific geographic markets. The annual sponsorship spending worldwide has risen 4.9% in 2018 to $65.88 billion from the $62.78 billion spent in 2017 (IEG, 2018). However, global sport sponsorship rights fees are falling from $46 billion in 2019 to $28.9 billion in 2020 as a result of the COVID-19 pandemic (Cutler, 2020). More than ever, the importance of evaluating sponsorship effectiveness needs to be highlighted due to the significant decrease of corporations' investment into sponsorship as a widely adopted marketing communication activity. Research focused on the evaluation of new sponsorships is even more important when investments become more conservative (Wakefield et al., 2020). New sponsors and many more potential sponsors need stronger evidence to be convinced that sponsorship could work as expected. The necessity for understanding the effectiveness of new sponsorship is undeniable for both decision-makers and academic researchers.

Fit has been one of the most important predictors of these consumer-focused sponsorship outcomes (Becker-Olsen & Hill, 2006; Braunstein et al., 2011; Speed & Thompson, 2000). A majority of previous studies have examined fit as a variable by focusing on its level (e.g., high, moderate, and low) and types (e.g., functional/image fit; native/created fit; sponsor-event/consumer-event fit). The categorization of fit might influence the evaluation of sponsorship effectiveness differently (Mao et al., 2013). Scholars have examined numerous factors to conceptualize and operationalize fit, and the two-dimensional

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definition of fit comprising both functional and imagery similarity between sponsor and property is one of the most frequently adopted categorizations (Bigné et al., 2012; Deitz et al., 2012; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Koo et al., 2006; Prendergast et al., 2010). For these studies, however, meaningful covariates, such as familiarity, identification, and product involvement, were not controlled simultaneously for when evaluating the impact of perceived functional fit and image fit on the three consumer-focused sponsorship outcomes. Given the lack of controlling for these covariates, accurately assessing how perceptions of functional fit and image fit are actually related to consumer-focus sponsorship effectiveness may be a challenging task.

In the context of the National Basketball Association (NBA), new corporations without natural functional or image fit with the property are still eager to invest in sport sponsorship. For example, State Farm became a sponsor of the NBA in 2010 and spent as high as $1 billion in 2018, making it the most active sponsor of the NBA (Janoff, 2018). Increasingly, more new sponsors are teaming up with the NBA each year. Nevertheless, considering the fact that NBA announced the suspension of the 2019–2020 season, the value that the league could deliver to its brand partners has been limited. With expectation of cost-cutting in sectors that invest heavily in sponsorship, signing new deals of sponsorship with the NBA in the future will need more thorough comprehensions. How the functional and image fit as perceived by potential consumers between a new sponsoring corporation and a sponsored property might influence the effectiveness of sponsorship becomes a puzzling question that could move a step forward from what had been known in related literature. With excluding consumer's bias (i.e., their familiarity, identity, and involvement with related entities), the inquiry into the impact of perceived fit should be more precise. Thus, the purpose of this study was to investigate whether perceived functional and image fit would work differently in terms of consumer-focused effectiveness for a new sponsor whose product is lacking a strong native fit in the context of professional sports league.

Review of Literature

The impact of fit on sponsorship effectiveness has been evaluated over time (e.g., Cornwell, 2020; Jagre et al., 2001; McDaniel, 1999; Speed & Thompson, 2000). Sponsors that are congruent with events benefit from a better image, and suggested negative impacts for those sponsors who have no or low congruence. Consequent studies confirmed that fit between sponsor and event enhances more favorable responses in different levels from cognitive, affective, to behavioral responses (Koo et al., 2006), such as better recall of sponsor (Johar & Pham, 1999), positive attitudes toward sponsorship (Cianfrone & Zhang, 2006), and positive purchase intention (Braunstein et al., 2011; Rodgers, 2003). As for the context of new sponsorship, previous studies

also indicated that perceived sponsorship fit has been one of major concerns when sport fans evaluate new brands that are potentially sponsoring their favorite league (Thomas & Roeseler, 2013). The impact of perceived fit is expected to be more impactful on the effectiveness of new sponsorship.

Functional Fit vs. Image Fit

A different number of dimensions to conceptualize fit have been used (Bigné et al., 2012; Mao & Zhang, 2018; Speed & Thompson, 2000; Wang et al., 2016). Among them, researchers tend to adopt a two-dimensional definition comprising product/feature similarity and concept/image consistency, which are termed as functional fit and image fit, respectively. Their impact on sponsorship effectiveness has been approved in numerous studies (Bigné et al., 2012; Deitz et al., 2012; Gwinner & Eaton, 1999; Koo et al., 2006; Prendergast et al., 2010). However, these findings could be questionable when applying directly to a new sponsor setting due to foreseeable methodological limitations. The definitions and measurements of functional fit and image fit vary in these studies, which might lead to ambiguous interpretations. One sponsor's functional fit could be defined as high when its product is actually used in the sporting event (Gwinner & Eaton, 1999) or when the sponsor's product or service has a pivotal role in the event (Cianfrone et al., 2008). These definitions could only be applied to those sponsors who have an obvious functional fit, which potentially overlooked the role of consumer's individual perception. Some researchers already indicated how high a functional fit that a consumer perceives could vary according to his/her individual experience and involvement with the sponsor or the property (Deitz et al., 2012). That is, consumers might still perceive functional fit from a sponsorship due to their individual life experiences, even though the sponsor's product or service was not used in the sponsoring event.

In this study, consumer's perception of fit was the focus. The functional fit is thereafter referred to perceived functional fit, which is strictly focused on perception of congruence between sponsor's product/service and property's sports, while perceived image fit is still referred to the perception of brand image congruence between sponsor and property, which is derived from the previous study (Bigné et al., 2012; Braunstein & Zhang, 2005). Following the idea, when consumers are gauging the functional fit, they are perceiving the relatedness between the product and service of these two entities. For example, when the Kumho Tire sponsors the NBA, how high is their perceived functional fit should be determined by consumer's estimation of the relationship between tire (product) and basketball (sport) in their mind. Similarly, for the image fit in this study, it is not determined on specific binary aspect, such as a sponsor and a property's country of origin (COO, either match or not) (Prendergast et al., 2010). Instead, perceived image fit depends on how similar consumers generally feel their brand images are (Bennett et al., 2003).

Covariates

Other than perception of sponsor-event fits, the literature has largely focused on several predictors of these consumer-focused outcomes, such as familiarity, identification, and involvement (Cornwell et al., 2005). In an effort to increase the accuracy of assessing relationship between variables of interest and response variables in this study, we measured the following four variables as covariates to control for their confounding influences.

Familiarity. The level of consumer's knowledge and experience related to either a sponsor or a property is likely to have different effect on consumer responses (Doyle, Pentecost, & Funk, 2014). Less familiar sponsors could be resulted in better consumer's attitude and purchase intentions (Carrillat et al., 2005). In contract, consumers who are more familiar with the property tend to respond negatively to low-equity sponsor's congruence with the property (Roy & Cornwell, 2004). The difference could be explained by the different level of consumer's related knowledge. When consumers are more familiar with a property, they would more likely to have knowledge about sponsorship related to the property and have pre-existing attitudes. For example, these consumers might not feel incongruent between State Farm and the NBA because they knew insurance company has a long history of sports sponsorship history. Fit has been used as a covariate in previous study studying the influence of familiarity with a sponsor or a property on attitudes toward the sponsor and the property (Doyle et al., 2014). Thus, when we focused on perceived fit in this study, familiarity with the sponsor and the property should be treated as covariates as well.

Identification. The influence of team identification on sponsorship effectiveness have been accounted for in many studies by using different terms, such as team loyalty (Biscaia et al., 2013), fan involvement (Dees et al., 2008), and fan identification (Braunstein & Zhang, 2005). And the results generally suggested that highly identified consumers tended to have better outcomes associating the sponsor of their favorite teams, leagues, or sports. Team identification is similar but different from the aforementioned covariate familiarity with property. For consumers who are familiar with a property, they might be more knowledgeable about the property. However, highly identified fans are not only more knowledgeable (cognitive level), but also passionate about all related entities (affective level). They tend to treat sponsors as an in-group member because they are assisting the beloved property by monetary investment (Madrigal, 2001; Mao & Zhang, 2018). That is, they might have formed beforehand positive attitudes toward new sponsors of their favorite league or team.

Involvement. The conceptualization of involvement varies in sponsorship-related literature, in which fan's involvement with the property was

tested as a predictor in the most of sponsorship effectiveness research (Dees et al., 2008; Grohs & Reisinger, 2014; Meenaghan, 2001). Since we have controlled for similar influence from team identification as a covariate, we focused on the sponsor's side by including "consumer's involvement with the sponsor's product" (known as product involvement) in this study. Consumers tend to have a higher involvement with products that are more expensive, durable, and self-expression-related (Lee, 2005). It was generally suggested that sponsors from low-involvement product category are likely to receive better consumer's attitude and purchase intentions through sponsorship (Grohs, 2015). Since the magnitude of product involvement could be partially determined by individual difference, and its moderating effect between perception of fit and effectiveness was suggested in fit-related studies (Dees et al., 2010), we accounted for the potential influence of product involvement as the fourth covariate.

Consumer-Focused Outcomes

New sponsorship could refer to first-time partnership between a sponsor and a property in the phrases of new, renewal, and termination (Athanasopoulou & Sarli, 2015), a change in sponsor for a property (Mason & Cochetel, 2006), or an unprecedented sponsorship opportunity such as jersey sponsorship in the Major League Soccer (Jensen et al., 2012). Specifically, in this study the new sponsorship is defined as an existing brand buildup sponsoring relationship firstly with the existing property. Previous research on new sponsorship was mainly focused on the side of sponsor and property, such as inner process of decision-making and negotiations (Athanasopoulou & Sarli, 2015) and impacts of new media and technology use in sponsorship (Dees, 2011). Fans' perception of new sponsorship has been noticed by researchers as well. How new sponsors might be evaluated by consumers and the significance of their evaluations influencing outcomes of that sponsorship effectiveness have been highlighted (Jensen et al., 2012; Thomas & Roeseler, 2013).

Consumer-focused outcomes were studied in academia of sponsorship, and they could be categorized into three hierarchical levels, such as cognitive, affective, and behavioral (Kim et al., 2015). For a new sponsor without a long history of sponsorship aligning with a property, expecting the immediate impact on actual purchase of the sponsor's product or service is unrealistic. Instead, understanding the overall effectiveness in the beginning phrase of their investment should be more meaningful for the purpose of evaluation (Mason & Cochetel, 2006; Thomas & Roeseler, 2013). Therefore, sponsor recognition, attitude, and purchase intentions were the three consumer-focused outcomes adopted as index for evaluating the effectiveness of new sports sponsorship.

Sponsor recognition. Congruence in functional or image aspect that is perceived from the sponsorship resulted in higher recognition of sponsor comparing with what incongruent counterparts could have. According to schema theory, when individuals receive new and various information from the process of communication, they tend to remember those new ones that are consistent to the preexisting schema. The model of hierarchical effects could be further used to explain a consumer's response to new information they received from communications (Lavidge & Steiner, 1961). Since the results of previous studies indicated that consumers who perceived higher sponsor-event fit have a better recognition of the sponsor, there should be no difference between the impact of functional fit and image fit on a new sponsorship.

Attitude toward sponsor. In context of sponsorship, the tendency is that high-congruence consumers perceived from a sponsorship should bring in their favorable attitude toward the sponsors (Speed & Thompson, 2000). During communication process, functional fit and image fit are characterized as new information that is related to similarity between two entities, and this new information, as long as were processed by audience, could be expected to influence their attitude. When consumers perceived strong functional or image fit from the sponsors to the property, they are more likely to have positive attitudes, which should be also expected under the context of new sponsorship (Braunstein & Zhang, 2005).

Purchase intention. As Ajzen (2001) suggested from the perspective of planned behavior theory, people's behavioral intentions to an object could be predicted by his/her attitude toward the object. In context of sport sponsorship, the previous empirical research also confirmed that attitude toward the sponsor is the strongest predictor of purchase intentions (Biscaia et al., 2013). Following the hierarchy-of-effects model (Lavidge & Steiner, 1961), it could be expected that consumers who have positive cognitive and affective reaction toward the new sponsor should intend to purchase the sponsor's product (Mao & Zhang, 2018).

Method

A cross-sectional quantitative survey was conducted in an attempt to determine how two types of perceived sponsor-event fit can predict the sponsorship effectiveness of the professional sports league after controlling four covariates. Young NBA consumers were used as a sample to evaluate their perceptions of the functional fit and image fit between the new sponsor, Kumho Tire, and the property, NBA, and the test administration was carried out to examine the effects of perceived functional fit and image fit on their

cognitive, affective, and conational responses to the sponsor. Consequently, two research questions for this study were explored:

1 Would potential consumers who perceived different level of functional and image fit between a new product sponsor and a professional sports league demonstrate different responses to this new sponsorship?
2 Would the impact of perceived functional and image fit on hierarchical consumer-focused outcomes of this new sponsorship remain different after controlling for familiarity toward sponsor and property, fan identification, and product involvement?

Stimuli

The use of actual sponsor and property in sport sponsorship research is common, and its importance has been highlighted (Biscaia et al., 2013). Using real stimuli could be further justified by its stronger effect sizes comparing to fictitious ones (Kim et al., 2015). The sponsorship of Kumho Tire on the NBA was selected because of NBA's popularity and Kumho tire's unfamiliarity, which could be easier to reveal the real impact of perceived functional fit and image fit on effectiveness of this new sponsorship. The selection was justified by a pretest based on familiarity of common tire brands that are involved in sports sponsorship other than be focusing on auto racing events, such as Bridgestone (The official tire of National Football League and National Hockey League), Goodyear (The college football of Rose Bowl and the NBA's franchise Cleveland Cavaliers), and Continental (The official tire of Major League Soccer) (IEG, 2017b). While Bridgestone, Goodyear and Continental are the top three investors in the sponsorship spending market, the South Korea–based Kumho (less than $10 million) is a relatively low-profile and unfamiliar competitor in consumer's mind among these tire manufactures who are concurrently sponsoring non-auto-racing events in the United States (IEG, 2017a).

Participants

A convenience student sample was used in this study, in which undergraduate students were recruited from more than 20 different academic departments across a university in the southeastern region of the United States. There were 733 returned questionnaires (48% for response rate), in which 675 were complete and then used for further analyses in this study. The descriptive statistics of their demographics indicated that 64% of respondents were female and the majority of them (98%) was from 18 to 25 years old (M = 20.71; SD = 1.91). The race of the participants included 68.4% Caucasians, 15.7% Asians, 9.5% African Americans, 3.3% Hispanics, and 3.1% Other. To a great extent, these characteristics were representative of young NBA consumers.

Table 9.1 Descriptive Statistics for the Sponsorship Effectiveness, Perceived Fit, and Covariates (N = 675)

Concept	*No. of item*	*M*	*SD*	α
Dependent Variables: Sponsorship Effectiveness				
Sponsor recognition (SRP)	3	2.29	1.56	.870
Attitude toward sponsor (ASP)	3	4.06	1.05	.956
Purchase intention of sponsor (PIP)	3	2.59	1.33	.876
Independent Variables: Perceived fit				
Functional fit (CFP)	6	2.71	1.38	.953
Image fit (CIP)	6	2.78	1.44	.962
Covariates				
Team identification (TID)	7	2.97	1.85	.954
Familiarity of sponsor (FAS)	3	2.36	1.49	.852
Familiarity of property (FAP)	3	4.76	1.91	.896
Product involvement (PIV)	5	4.86	1.49	.845

Measures

The questionnaire amounted to 39 items measuring two independent variables, four covariates, and three dependent variables. The measures of the variables were all adopted directly existing scales in previous studies and modified according to the purpose of this study. In order to minimize participant's carryover effect, we randomized the order of questions and rephrased randomly some items in reverse meaning. Appendix A displays all items in this questionnaire. After the data were collected, nine construct's Cronbach's alpha coefficients were obtained for testing the reliability (see Table 9.1). The results showed high internal consistency (α = .845 - .962), which satisfied the criterion of .70 suggested by Nunnally (1978).

Results

Correlational analyses were conducted among the nine variables and the results were reported as Table 9.2. All the nine variables were positively correlated with each other at significant level ($p < .01$) except for the correlations between product involvement (PIV) and each of 3 variables, such as functional fit (CIP), image fit (CFP), and purchase intention (PIP). Only the correlation between functional fit (CIP) and image fit (CFP) was slightly above the threshold (.804) when all other correlations were well below .80. In addition, as the variance inflation factors (VIF) were less than 10, multicollinearity among the variables in this study was tolerable and there should not be a significant threat to the consequent analyses of regression (Farrar & Glauber, 1967).

A series of multiple regression analyses were then conducted to test three pairs of hypotheses that investigated the relationship between perceived

Table 9.2 Bivariate Correlation of the Variables

Variable	*1*	*2*	*3*	*4*	*5*	*6*	*7*	*8*	*9*
Independent variables									
1. CFP	-	.809**	.192**	.163**	.123**	.051	.384**	.269**	.269**
2. CIP	.809**	-	.185**	.210**	.133**	.033	.407**	.328**	.347**
Covariates									
3. TID	.192**	.185**	-	.299**	.539**	.120**	.390**	.118**	.220**
4. FAS	.163**	.210**	.299**	-	.286**	.207**	.532**	.322**	.286**
5. FAP	.123**	.133**	.539**	.286**	-	.268**	.269**	.178**	.162**
6. PIV	.051	.033	.120**	.207**	.268**	-	.150**	.212**	.091*
Dependent variables									
7. SRP	.384**	.407**	.390**	.532**	.269**	.150**	-	.431**	.492**
8. ASP	.269**	.328**	.118**	.322**	.178**	.212**	.431**	-	.431**
9. PIP	.269**	.347**	.220**	.286**	.162**	.091*	.492**	.431**	-

** $p < .001$
* $p < .01$

functional fit, perceived image fit, and sponsorship effectiveness (i.e., sponsor recognition, attitude toward sponsor, and purchase intention of sponsor's product, see Table 9.3). For the sponsor recognition (SRP), the results signified that perceived functional fit (β = .138) and perceived image fit (β = .171) were all significantly predicting consumer's recognizing the Kumho Tire as the sponsor of the NBA ($p < .01$). For the overall model, F = 81.99 and was highly significant ($p < .001$). Sixty-five percent of the total variance in the model ($R^2 = .651$) were explained by combining these two constructs and the other four covariates.

For attitude toward sponsor (ASP), however, the results indicated that only image fit (β = .268) was a significant ($p < .001$) predictor of consumer attitude toward the Kumho Tire as the sponsor of the NBA. For the overall model, F = 28.02 and was highly significant ($p < .001$). Similarly, in the regression

Table 9.3 Regression Analysis for Sponsor Recognition (SRP), Attitude toward Sponsor (ASP), and Purchase Intention (PIP) as Dependent Variables

Variables	*SRP*	*ASP*	*PIP*	
	β	*β*	*β*	*VIF*
1. CFP	.138*	.010	-.048	2.925
2. CIP	.171*	.268**	.325**	2.962
3. TID	.211**	-.057	.106	1.485
4. FAS	.407**	.233**	.186**	1.184
5. FAP	-.009	.067	.007	1.519
6. PIV	.031	.143**	.029	1.105

** $p < .001$
* $p < .01$

Table 9.4 Multiple Regression Analyses Examining the Impact of Perceived Fit on Sponsorship Effectiveness after Partialing Out the Effect of Covariates

Variables	*ss*	*ms*	*R*	R^2	ΔR^2	*F*	*p*
Sponsor Recognition (SRP)							
Covariates	562.44	140.61	.585	.343	.343	87.37	**
Independent Variables	695.83	115.97	.651	.424	.081	81.99	**
Attitude toward Sponsor (ASP)							
Covariates	95.47	23.87	.360	.130	.130	24.96	**
Independent Variables	148.01	24.67	.448	.201	.071	28.02	**
Purchase Intention (PIP)							
Covariates	121.77	30.44	.320	.102	.102	19.10	**
Independent Variables	214.5	35.75	.425	.180	.078	24.49	**

** p <.001.
* p <.01.

analyses for purchase intention (PIP), only image fit (β = .325) was a significant ($p < .001$) predictor of this consumer-focused sponsorship outcome. For the overall model, F = 24.49 and was highly significant ($p < .001$).

Lastly, after controlling for the four covariates (i.e., team identification, familiarity with sponsor and property, and product involvement), perceived functional fit and perceived image fit still explained a significant amount of the variance in sponsor recognition (R-square change =.081, F(6, 668) = 81.99, $p < .001$), in attitude toward sponsor (R-square change =.071, F(6, 668) = 28.02, $p < .001$), and in purchase intention to sponsor product (R-square change = .078, F(6, 668) = 24.49, p <.001) (Table 9.4).

Discussion

In this study, we would like to further investigate how functional fit and image fit that perceived by consumer were related to their evaluation of a new actual professional sports league sponsor. The results indicated a positive answer to our first research question, in which we assessed whether perceived functional and image fit would be differently related to three outcomes of a new sponsorship. Initially with the cognition level, the perceived functional fit between Kumho tire and the NBA has a positive relationship with consumer's recognition of the sponsor according to the bivariate correlations. The respondents who perceived a higher functional fit were more likely to recognize the Kumho as the official tire of the NBA. The results are consistent with previous studies and could be explained by congruence theory (Rifon et al., 2004). In context of sport sponsorship, researchers tended to suggest that fit could be

deemed as an information, which influences how sport consumers store and access-related information in their memory (Rifon et al., 2004). They could easily identify who is the official tire sponsor when viewing an event of motor sports because of its appropriateness. In this traditional linear model, the sponsor-event fit suggests the higher fit brings the better result in the cognitive level (Dees et al., 2010). In this study, Kumho as a tire company which is unfamiliar to the US consumers is supposed to have relatively low functional or image fit with the NBA. However, the results still indicated that participants who perceived higher functional or image fit could recognize better the Kumho as the NBA official sponsor. As for other two effectiveness at the affective and conative levels, there was no significant correlation between perceived functional fit and either of them.

Unlike what we found on perceived functional fit, there was a positive relationship between perceived image fit of Kumho tire and all kinds of consumer's responses. When respondents perceived a higher degree of image fit from the Kumho's NBA sponsorship, they tended to have better recognition of sponsor, attitude toward the sponsor, and intentions to purchase its product in the future. This finding also corresponds to previous research that indicated that perceived image fit could lead to better outcomes on cognitive, affective, and behavioral level through the image transfer process (Grohs & Reisinger, 2014). Combined, these findings are critical because there is a difference between perceived functional fit and image fit in terms of their impact on effectiveness of this new sponsorship of the NBA. The difference should be noticed by sport sponsorship practitioners and field study researchers, which could be explained in two folds.

First, these differences can be theoretically justified by the Cognitive Dissonance Theory. For an individual, perceiving incongruity between a sponsor and a property could cause cognitive dissonance, which is unfavorite and he/she is then motivated to restore a state of consonance by changing an existing attitude toward one of the entities, either sponsor or property (Festinger, 1957). Although consumers can recall better on some incongruent pairs from the standpoint of perceived functional fit, they would not "like" the cognitive dissonance that the functional fit-related information caused to them. Without forming a positive attitude, purchase intentions could not be possibly created. In contract, for image fit-related information, since they are more broad and abstract, such as global, professional, powerful, or attractive, consumers could more possibly seek from common ground between the Kumho tire and the NBA from image-based aspect by themselves. Consequently, consumers themselves change the undesirable state of incongruity and then have a favorable attitude toward the Kumho tire to restore consonance.

Second, the difference of hierarchical new sponsorship effectiveness between perceived functional and image fit we found in this study can be also explained by the schema theory. A schema is defined as "a hypothetical

cognitive structure that guides perception, thought and action based on prior knowledge of stimuli gained through experience and media exposure" (McDaniel, 1999, p. 168). Previous study applied this notion of schema to explain how consumers process information from marketing communications by matching new information they perceived to prior knowledge they stored in the specific schema (Goodstein, 1993). Similarly, when viewers receive new information of sponsorship, they should engage in efficient processing by comparing the new information to memories of similar prototypic sponsorship. Consumers might receive previously sponsorship information from the other tire brands like Goodyear and then stored in their appropriate schema in mind. It is also reasonable to expect the knowledge stored in consumer's schema is easier to be applied for perceived image fit than perceived functional fit. For perceived image fit, since it is related to emotional reaction, consumer "feel like" they are matching in terms of image. Therefore, there are more existing information about perceived image fit that consumer could access in their schema when processing new sponsorship information like Kumho tire in this case, which contributed better responses on affective level than what they evaluated the perceived functional fit.

Research question 2 assessed whether the relationship between perceived functional/image fit and three consumer-focused effectiveness outcomes remain the same after controlling for four meaningful covariates including familiarity, identification, and product involvement. The results of this study demonstrated that these covariates were significant indicators of the NBA consumers' cognitive, affective, and conational responses of its new official sponsor Kumho tire. After partialing out their influences, the conclusion drawn from the first research question still stands. The finding extends contemporary research on fit by supporting the fact that better perceived fit may improve new sponsorship outcomes. After controlling for correct covariates, the results become more valuable to reveal how potential target consumers evaluate new sponsors and sponsorship basing on functional and image fit they perceived.

Managerial Implications

With a better understanding of how consumers' perceptions of functional fit and image fit work in their mind as processing new sponsorship-related information, this study provided important implications for practitioners in sponsorship and sport marketing. From managerial perspective, the results implicate that only perceived image fit could engage target consumer's favorite responses through different levels in the context of new sponsorship without perfect natural fit. When there is no very strong native fit between a tire company and a basketball league in this study, however, the better perceived image fit still had better overall effectiveness outcomes. Basing on our findings,

a new sponsorship tends to receive higher hierarchical outcomes (i.e., affective and conative responses) from those consumers who perceive higher image fit comparing with what those consumers who perceive higher functional fit. Some sponsorships share a high native fit before sponsors communicate with target audience via sponsorship-linked marketing because of their logical functional or image relationships with the events, such as a tire company sponsoring a car racing event. By contrast, some sponsorships without any native fit, such as a tire company sponsoring a basketball league, have to gain a high created fit after articulating this relationship through creative messages. Our results indicated that perceived image fit could be more effective than perceived functional fit in the beginning stage for the new sponsorship without a strong native fit.

From the perspective of sponsors, the sport sponsorship is an expensive investment and its return is relatively difficult to be predicted and evaluated. The process of selection and decision can be more illuminated through the implications of this study. This finding justifies the decision-making for those marketers who are willing to invest in associating themselves with sport leagues like the NBA when their brands without a perfect functional fit. As long as consumer could perceive a better image fit, the favorable consumer-focused outcomes will be possibly obtained. For that sense, the purpose of leveraging sponsorship later should be more focused on increasing a created fit through image-based similarity. Therefore, sport marketers should capitalize on the perceived image fit through sponsorship-linked marketing for better returns from target consumers when leveraging their investment of new sponsorship. In brief, our investigation was aimed to point out a different way to evaluate consumer's perception of functional and image fit, and estimate their effects on consumer-focused outcomes for a new sport sponsorship. We found that participants transferred their association deriving from the perceived functional/image fit to their evaluation of the sponsor differently. Future research regarding consumer responses to sport sponsorship should notice the different impact of perceived functional/image fit as a basic antecedent of sport sponsorship on consumer behavior.

Several limitations should be aware before applying findings and implications of this study. The student sample surely costs the generalizability of results. Additionally, we only examined a single new sponsorship which involves only one new sponsor and one long-existing professional sport league. More different types or numbers of sponsor and properties (such as a prominent sponsor partnering with a new property, or multiple new sports facility naming rights sponsorships) could be systematically evaluated and compared in the future. More suggestions on future study could be made by introducing other potential important factors that were not considered in this study (Chou et al., 2020). For example, the change of perceived functional and image fit for new sponsorship should be valuable information for

sponsors by assessing perceived sponsor-event fit at the beginning of sponsorship and at the conclusion of the sponsorship. It could be beneficial by using a latent growth modeling (LGM) approach on assessing effectiveness for new sponsorship, which might gain more practical and theoretical findings (Mazodier & Quester, 2014). For more comprehensively depicting the consumer's perception of new sponsorship, researchers should focus more on the various contexts of property and sponsor by conducting more longitudinal studies.

Appendix A Questionnaire Items and References

Variable	*Scale*	*References*
Functional fit	Do you think that the combination of tire and basketball is? Incongruent-Congruent Incompatible-Compatible Meaningless-Meaningful Not Complementary-Complementary Goes Together-Doesn't go together Illogical-Logical	Bigné et al. (2012)
Image fit	Do you think that the image of Kumho and the image of NBA is? Incongruent-Congruent Incompatible-Compatible Meaningless-Meaningful Not Complementary-Complementary Goes Together-Doesn't go together Illogical-Logical	Bigné et al. (2012)
Sponsor recognition	I can recognize Kumho Tire among other competing brands. I am aware of Kumho Tire. I have difficulty in imaging Kumho tire in my mind. I can recognize Kumho tire as the official tire of the NBA.	Yoo and Donthu (2001)
Attitude toward sponsor	7-point semantic differential scales Overall what was your impression of Kumho Tire? Unfavorable/favorable, bad/good, negative/positive	Kinney and McDaniel (1996)
Purchase intentions of sponsor's product	I will think to buy products from the Kumho Tire. I will try to buy products from the Kumho Tire. I will buy products from the Kumho Tire.	Alexandris et al. (2007)

(*Continued*)

Variable	*Scale*	*References*
Team identification	Sport Spectator Identification Scale 7 items, 8-point scale How important to You is it that your favorite NBA team wins? (Not important/ Very Important) How strongly do YOU see YOURSELF as a fan of the NBA? (Not at all a fan/very much a fan) How strongly do your FRIENDS see YOU as a fan of the NBA? (Not at all a fan/very much a fan) During the season, how closely do you follow the NBA via ANY of the following: a) in person or on television, b) on the radio, or c) television news or a newspaper, d) social media and APP? (Never/Almost Every Day) How important is being a fan of the NBA to YOU? (Not important/Very Important) How much do YOU dislike your favorite NBA team's greatest rivals? (Do not dislike/Dislike very much) How often do YOU display your favorite NBA team's name or insignia at your place of work, where you live, or on your clothing? (never/Always)	Wann and Branscombe (1993)
Familiarity of the event	To me, "NBA" is: Very unfamiliar/very familiar Very inexperienced/very experienced Not knowledgeable/very knowledgeable	Carrillat et al. (2005)
Familiarity of the sponsor	To me, "Kumho Tire" is: Very unfamiliar/very familiar Very inexperienced/very experienced Not knowledgeable/very knowledgeable	Carrillat et al. (2005)
Product involvement	Revised Personal Involvement Inventory To me "tire" is: Important/Unimportant, boring/interesting, relevant/irrelevant, exciting/unexciting, means nothing/means a lot to me, appealing/unappealing, fascinating/ mundane, worthless/valuable, involving/ uninvolving, not needed/needed	Zaichkowsky (1994)

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Part II

Emerging Trends


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Chapter 10

Harnessing the Power of Machine Learning in Sport Consumer Behavior Research

James Du, Nathan David Pifer, and Susmit S. Gulavani

Introduction

Like many scientific disciplines and industry sectors, the field of sport consumer behavior research (SCBR) has witnessed a rise in *machine learning*, the branch of artificial intelligence that automates statistical learning (SAS, 2022). Through the creation and use of programs that learn from data, identify patterns, and prescribe solutions, complex decisions are now being made with minimal human intervention. Though machine learning has been around since computer scientists began engineering programs to 'think' for themselves in the 1950s, modern advancements in practical technology have made machine learning methods more accessible to users and more functional with a variety of data. As such, machine learning algorithms are behind the customer service chatbots, email filters, and speech recognition technologies that have become part of our everyday lives (Jordan & Mitchell, 2015). They are also becoming critical components in the marketplace, using consumer data to push content recommendations and tailor advertisements to specific segments of the population. Their ability to mine and interpret textual data in online settings further enables them to alert organizations to consumer sentiments as they relate to new products or promotional messaging.

Machine learning techniques have also been embraced by researchers in the field of sports analytics. For instance, Pifer et al. (2020) opted to use machine learning algorithms to predict which major or minor league baseball classification players would finish in each season. Using the model's estimates, they calculated the opportunity costs of players who chose to pursue careers in professional baseball rather than joining the standard workforce. Others have tested machine learning algorithms for their abilities to predict which types of plays will be run in football games (Joash Fernandes et al., 2020) and which statistics are crucial to predicting the outcomes of tennis matches in relation to betting companies' odds (Gao & Kowalczyk, 2021).

The use of machine learning has also been met with enthusiasm in sport consumer behavior research. As noted by Chmait and Westerbeek (2021),

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> the application of AI in sports is not limited to topics of sports performance, athlete talent identification or the technical analysis of the game. The (off the field) business side of sports organizations is rapidly shifting towards a data-driven culture led by developing profiles of their fans and their consumer preferences.
>
> (p. 3)

Though recent efforts have seen machine learning address such complex tasks as online video consumption (Zhou et al., 2021), active leisure participation (Du et al., 2021; Kim et al., 2022), customer churn (Du et al., 2020; Nguyen et al., 2021), consumer sentiment (Floyd et al., 2021), brand involvement (Su et al., 2021), and social media engagement (Kennedy et al., 2021), the opportunity still exists for greater synthesis between big data, machine learning, and sport consumer behavior research (Watanabe et al., 2021). Therefore, in an effort to address this gap and further promote the use of machine learning in sport consumer behavior research, we have compiled a series of analyses highlighting the benefits, challenges, and utilities associated with this methodological approach.

The study of sport consumer behavior is a prominent topic among sport marketing academics (Funk et al., 2016; Trail, 2015). An overwhelming number of studies in the sports consumer behavior domain have focused on comprehending the psychological aspects of sports experiences, particularly the cognitive and emotive components (Funk & James, 2001; Funk et al., 2016). From a methodological standpoint, much of the sport consumer behavior research has concentrated on gathering data using surveys to generate correlational nomological networks but has failed to offer convincing scientific evidence for causality and predictive precision, as shown in experimental research (Funk et al., 2003; Ko & Lee, 2018). Machine learning tools can better address complex challenges (Hagen et al., 2020). Harnessing the power of big data and digital technologies, sport marketing scholars can collaborate with industry colleagues to expand the potential of business and research in novel ways. In turn, these applications using the proliferation of big data, including, but not limited to, improving customer targeting and communications, optimizing marketing and sales forecasts, and enhancing fan engagement and customer satisfaction, can profoundly transform the way in which sport organizations form and execute key business strategies.

It is difficult for sport marketing scholars not to confront the opportunities created by the readily available big data and significant innovations in data science and machine intelligence (Naraine & Wanless, 2020). Rather than viewing big data and advanced machine learning techniques as purely analytical tools, it is imperative that sport marketing scholars consider how research can be empowered by big data and machine learning to address questions that have been intractable without access to large-scale social experiments and democratization of artificial intelligence. For instance, using

ubiquitous micro-level data unavailable prior to the digital revolution could allow sport marketing researchers to better reconcile the tension between correlational description and causal prediction. Integrating theoretical understanding into the application of novel machine learning methods is especially important to separate predictors from causes. Bridging the divide between small-scale inquiry that offers an in-depth understanding of phenomena and massive-scale investigation enabled by big data and machine learning may be necessary for advancing understanding and knowledge generation (Mamo et al., 2021).

A Primer in Machine Learning

As an area of research, machine learning emerged from artificial intelligence started in the early 1950s. Artificial intelligence refers to the attempt to automate intellectual activities usually done by humans (Chollet, 2018). Many scientists believed that human-level intelligence could be attained by designing a sufficiently extensive set of manipulation algorithms based on explicit knowledge, thereby developing a movement termed 'symbolic artificial intelligence' (Singh, 2019). However, symbolic artificial intelligence proved challenging in elucidating clear principles for complicated, ambiguous issues such as picture categorization, voice recognition, and textual data analysis (Chollet, 2018). This led to the emergence of a new field named machine learning, which usurped a new era in artificial intelligence.

The objective of machine learning is to determine if a program can think independently of human instructions and comprehend how to do a particular task (Géron, 2019). In machine learning, the researcher inputs the data and the desired outputs, and the algorithm generates rules for optimizing the activity (Chollet, 2018). This contrasts with classical programming, where the researchers provide rules and a dataset, with the data being processed by these rules to produce outputs or responses. Machine learning is the science of training computers to learn using data (Géron, 2019). While machine learning is closely linked to statistics, it varies significantly from statistics in many aspects. Unlike statistics, machine learning is more adept at dealing with big, complicated datasets (e.g., a dataset of millions of fans' facial expressions, each with tens of thousands of pixels). Consequently, machine learning mainly focuses on data engineering and relies less on mathematical theory (Chollet, 2018). It is a field in which the concepts are often validated empirically rather than theoretically.

Benefits of Machine Learning

While machine learning can closely resemble traditional statistics, there are several advantages that set it apart. To start, machine learning operates on data without human involvement to make an objective analytical decision (Bose & Mahapatra, 2001). Second, machine learning aids in the analysis of

nontraditional data. As social media and the internet allow users to post pictures and images, businesses can no longer depend on textual data alone to better understand their customers when evaluating social media data. Sport organizations are losing out on a significant portion of information about their products, game experiences, consumers, and rivals if they do not have machine learning tools (e.g., deep learning algorithms) to conduct image analytics (Chollet, 2018).

Next, one must understand the tradeoff between model interpretability and predictive accuracy. Indeed, the choice of machine learning methods over traditional statistical models and tests is typically made to increase *prediction accuracy*, *precision*, and *greater efficiency*. Machine learning algorithms do an excellent job analyzing patterns in data and generating accurate predictions. Prior studies have alluded to the advantages of machine learning techniques over conventional statistics and mathematics regarding predictive accuracy. The speed with which they generate these predictions and their ability to parse through many different types and structures of data also lend an element of efficiency to the research process by reducing time spent on data processing and variable manipulation.

Lastly, machine learning algorithms can aid in solving the issues raised by academics, such as 'p-hacking.' Theoretically, researchers can adjust their model until it produces the required $p < .05$ to show the significance of the results (Choudhary et al., 2018). Such experimentation with the model stemming from the myopic pursuit of statistically significant discoveries increases the risk of reporting false positives. Such misconduct fails to appreciate their findings' practical and theoretical significance (Brodeur et al., 2020). While the researchers wanted to reject the null hypothesis, they wind up making a Type I error in the process. Machine learning techniques may provide a way to prevent committing the Type I error. Remarkably, by partitioning the dataset into training and testing sets, the researcher minimizes the likelihood of making errors or discovering false-positive findings.

Challenges of Machine Learning

While the aforementioned benefits are valuable, using machine learning has many challenges. Firstly, many machine learning algorithms need a large amount of data to function correctly. The algorithms usually require thousands of instances for even the simplest tasks and millions of examples for complicated problems such as picture or voice recognition (Géron, 2019). Thus, an insufficient quantity of the training data, which is not uncommon in sport management, represents a challenge for implementing machine algorithms. Secondly, choosing machine learning over traditional techniques often requires sacrificing some degree of interpretability. Whereas conventional methods like ordinary least squares regression quantify the significance and size of the inputs' effects on an output, machine learning techniques rarely offer such insights.

Thirdly, suppose the training data contains many mistakes, outliers, and noise. In that case, it will be more difficult for the algorithm to identify the underlying patterns, and as a result, the method will be less effective. Further, machine learning models can be overfitting or underfitting to the data. On the one hand, when the model is excessively complicated in comparison to the quantity and noise of the training data, the machine learning techniques may overfit the data. Overfitting occurs when a machine learning algorithm functions effectively on training data but fails to generalize effectively (Chollet, 2018). On the other hand, underfitting happens when a machine learning model is too rudimentary to understand the underlying architecture of the data (Géron, 2019). Finally, machine learning is prone to machine learning bias, also known as algorithmic bias, which arises when an algorithm generates systematically biased findings due to incorrect assumptions made throughout the machine learning process. Researchers and data scientists may design algorithms that reflect unintentional cognitive biases or prejudices (Chollet, 2018). Although these biases are often inadvertent, their existence in machine learning systems may have substantial implications.

Types of Machine Learning

There are different types of machine learning algorithms. Fundamentally, a common criterion to categorize machine learning algorithms is through the presence or absence of a dependent variable or labels in the dataset (Chollet, 2018). It should be noted that four classes of methods lie beneath the umbrella of machine learning.

Supervised Machine Learning. Supervised learning builds models to predict or estimate an output given one or more inputs. In supervised learning, the training data fed into the algorithm consists of the desired solutions, also known as labels (Dey, 2016). As a result, each training instance has both predictor variables and an outcome label. The supervised learning tasks may be classified into two types according to the type of outcome variable included in the dataset. On the one hand, researchers can implement regression-based algorithms if the outcome variable is a continuous variable and the goal is to predict a quantity. On the other hand, if the outcome variable is a binary categorical variable and the goal is to predict a category, researchers can implement classification algorithms in the research. Examples of classification algorithms are decision trees, random forests, and support vector machines.

Unsupervised Machine Learning. Unsupervised learning, on the contrary, contains inputs but no output. It is intended to learn from the relationships and structures present in data. The process of using algorithms to discover patterns in the datasets containing data points that are neither categorized nor labeled is known as unsupervised learning (Dey, 2016). Consequently, the algorithms can categorize, label, and group the data

points in the datasets without an external direction. Therefore, unsupervised learning enables the system to discover patterns within data sets independently, without the need for human intervention. K-means clustering and principal component analysis are popular algorithms used for clustering and dimension reduction in unsupervised learning.

Explainable Machine Learning. Explainable machine learning is a kind of machine learning in which the algorithm's findings can be comprehended by individuals (Belle & Papantonis, 2021). The 'black box' notion of machine learning, on the other hand, due to its mathematical complexities and proprietary nature, makes it difficult if not impossible for humans to understand, and digest, and leaves even its developers mystified about how an algorithm came to a particular conclusion. The associated uninterpretability could lead to unethical and catastrophic consequences (Rudin et al., 2022). The idea of algorithmic transparency plays a crucial role in explainable machine learning (Belle & Papantonis, 2021).

In order to have transparency, individuals need to be able to comprehend the model's internal dynamics. In other words, a model that uses algorithmic reasoning to forecast future instance performance based on the past instance performance meets the requirement of algorithmic transparency. Complex models, such as convoluted neural networks, on the other hand, include many hidden layers that make it difficult for individuals to comprehend what is going on within the model, resulting in the process being cognitively overwhelming and a paradox of excellent performance in training but poor performance in prediction using unseen data. Thus, a machine learning model is explainable only if knowledgeable people can grasp its meaning.

Reinforcement Machine Learning. Reinforcement learning is a machine learning method that enables computers to learn through trial and error in an interactive environment while gaining feedback from their behavior and experience (Chollet, 2018). It is a learning system capable of monitoring the environment, selecting, and executing actions, and receiving rewards in return (Géron, 2019). The system's objective is to maximize the reward. Reinforcement learning had recently received tremendous attention when Google DeepMind used it to teach a computer to play Atari games (Chollet, 2018). The aforementioned features and benefits of machine learning algorithms can be leveraged to advance sport consumer behavior research in the following ways.

Enhancing the Scientific Rigor of SCBR with Machine Learning

The automated discovery of structures and trends in the massive amounts of data is a critical element of machine learning and is presently driving applications in various mainstream fields, including marketing, management, and

economics (Belle & Papantonis, 2021). However, such a significant advantage is accompanied by a conundrum: How can sport consumer behavioral scholars augment scientific rigor by comprehending and accepting the judgments recommended by a machine learning algorithm? Prior to addressing this lingering question, we will outline and discuss the process of scientific inquiry within the post-positivist paradigm in an effort to navigate through some of the critical ontological and epistemological underpinnings that guide quantitative sport consumer behavior research. In accordance with the conventional post-positivist paradigm, the origin, nature, and limits of the knowledge base of sport consumer behavior can be explored to answer three fundamental questions: (1) How can we know what we know about rules and theories of sport consumer behavior is true? (2) Why do sport fans do what they do? (3) How can an investigator find out the most suitable way to reveal the truth of a behavioral phenomenon?

The ontology of the post-positivist paradigm is rooted in a notion that only singular reality and truth exist to be discovered where scholars should be situated in a neutral position independent from designing, measuring, analyzing, and evaluating functions inherent to empirical investigations. From an epistemological perspective, the inquiry process ought to be objective. Researchers should avoid playing an active role, if not entirely inevitable, in solving a focal research question upon which they are performing a scientific inquiry. Sport marketing scholars who follow the post-positivist paradigm subscribe to the conventional scientific method of adhering to rigid rules and principles to conduct empirical investigations. The evaluative criteria and testing procedure of robust sport consumer behavior research are centered around the standards of rigor of internal validity, external validity, reliability, and statistical conclusion validity (Zhang, 2015). Internal validity concerns itself with understanding how well instruments can capture a construct they are supposed to measure and the degree to which the included constructs can be discriminant to each other.

External validity then takes the concerns of internal validity and decides to what degree can the same research findings repeatedly appear within other research contexts and be consistent over time. A necessity for establishing the presence of reliability is to demonstrate the extent to which the internal consistency could be replicated. Finally, the statistical conclusion validity encompasses predictive validity, objectivity, concurrent validity, measurement invariance, method biases, and generalizability. In essence, the notion loops back to the concerns of the paradigm striving to be a neutral and un-influencing observer in an inquiry by confirming that the inquiry is free of biases, values, and prejudice but is equipped with high explanatory power and predictive precision. In that sense, the researcher's voice is the exclusive representation to offer prescriptive insights to predict behavioral outcomes.

However, in the current digital age, deciphering sport consumer behaviors is undergoing a paradigm shift through a multidisciplinary lens. The premise

of which challenges the current inquiry process within the conventional post-positivist framework. That is, sport consumer experience design represents a multivariate function of what sports organizations can perform to satisfy people's increasing demand for a quality experience and multitude of interactions among sport organizations, sport consumers, and technologically mediated physical sport contexts (Funk, 2017). This shift is augmented by the proliferation of consumer intelligence, increased knowledge on data literacy, advancements in artificial intelligence and machine learning, the emergence of interactive and immersive technologies such as multisensory virtual reality and augmented reality, and a broader extended world of the metaverse. The tension between a theoretically deductive understanding of sport consumer behaviors and a data-centric inductive exploration of previously unseen or overlooked behavioral patterns has the capacity to lead to remarkable progress in the knowledge production of distinctive sport theories. The complexity of this fundamental problem lies in an inherent trade-off between model predictive capability and precision and theoretically plausible explainability and interpretability, which in a nutshell involves and mimics causal inference procedures for pushing the existing theoretical boundaries.

Causal Inference in SCBR

The fundamental goal of behavioral science is to understand and decipher 'why' people behave in the way they act. The 'why' question indicates an inquisitiveness to identify and demonstrate a cause-effect nomological net among variables of investigators' interests (Byon & Zhang, 2019). Understanding the causal process may enable the establishment of a compelling empirical explanation for sport consumer behaviors. Ontologically, demonstrating evidence of causality benefits approaching the singularity of the truth by validating a phenomenon's theoretical foundation (Maziarz, 2020). Establishing a cause-effect relationship also strengthens a scholarship's validity, generalizability, trustworthiness, and scientific rigor while minimizing threats posed by various common method biases (Podsakoff, 2003). Hence, it is critical to emphasize causality to foster and promote relevant theoretical development and knowledge diffusion in the field of sport consumer behavior research (Funk, 2019).

Epistemologically, the contemporary approaches to understanding causality can be divided into two types: manipulationist and counterfactual (Maziarz, 2020). The manipulationist perspective acknowledges the conflation of causation and manipulability. Under this paradigm, causality can be justified using traditional experimental or quasi-experimental designs, in which conditions of causes are manipulated to evaluate their impact on reported attitudinal or observed behavioral outcomes while eliminating spurious relationships and accounting for confounding effects of theoretically supported correlates (Byon & Zhang, 2019). In a randomized controlled experiment,

each participant has an equal propensity to be assigned to either a treatment or a baseline group to assess the effect of manipulated causes. According to the manipulationist approach, three factors, including non-spuriousness, temporal precedence, and covariation, represent defining hallmarks of causation. Non-spuriousness postulates that there is no obvious credible confounding variable that directly affects the relationship between a cause and an effect. Temporal precedence refers to the notion that the cause must precede the effect. Lastly, the covariation condition assumes that the cause and the effect are meaningfully related to each other.

In addition to the traditional manipulationist approach, causal inference can also be established using counterfactual effects. A counterfactual statement is one in which a 'contrary to reality' premise is made (Varian, 2016). Put differently; the counterfactual approach examines what would have occurred to participants if no treatment had been administered. For instance, a researcher may discover that exposure to violent eSports games could result in higher levels of aggression. A counterfactual argument might be made that there would be no increase in aggression if the people were not exposed to VVG. The statement is subjunctive in nature, and the premise contradicts the facts. The validity of the counterfactuals is inextricably linked to the existence of causal connections (Maziarz, 2020). The counterfactual assertion in the example mentioned above suggests a causal relationship between exposure to VVG (the causative agent X) and higher levels of aggression (the effect Y).

Scientists have created designs and models that aid in applying and comprehending the counterfactual effects and the establishment of causality. The Rubin Causal Model (RCM) is an example of a counterfactual causation model. The RCM stresses that the people assigned to treatment or nontreatment groups have possible outcomes in observable and unobserved conditions (Imbens & Rubin, 2010). For instance, we could hypothesize that children from low-income families have lower participation in elite sports. If a child comes from a low-income household, the treatment variable is S = 1. To demonstrate a causal link between poverty and low participation in elite sports, the researcher must analyze the result in the absence of poverty (i.e., S = 0). That is, what would have occurred if the child had not been born into a low-income family? According to the RCM, a researcher may estimate the counterfactual effect by comparing the average result of the treatment and nontreatment of individuals in the population (Imbens & Rubin, 2010).

Counterfactual effects can be applied to the difference-in-differences (DiD) design. DiD is an analytical technique that helps establish causal relationships using observational study data (Varian, 2016). DiD consists of a between-subjects factor and a within-subjects factor where the participants are not randomly allocated to the groups. Kavetsos and Szymanski (2010) utilized a DiD design to examine the effect of hosting a sporting event on the residents' life satisfaction with the host city (Kavetsos & Szymanski, 2010). We can appreciate their research using the illustration in Figure 10.1.

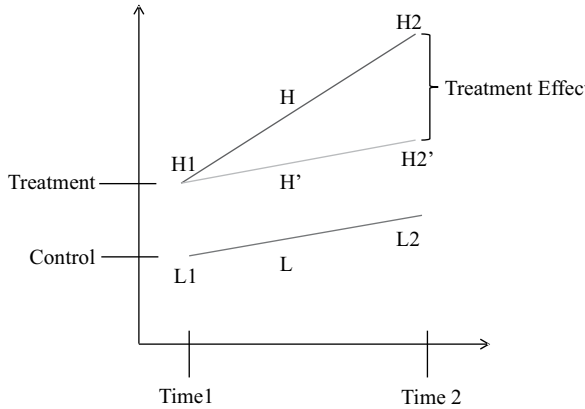


Figure 10.1 A Visual Illustration of Counterfactual Causal Inference Using the Difference-in-Differences Design.

The treatment group in the study consisted of the individuals whose country hosted a soccer world cup, and the control group consisted of individuals from non-host countries. The red line H illustrates the performance of the treatment group, and the blue line L demonstrates the performance of the control group. Points T1 and T2 show that the life satisfaction scores were measured before and after the event, respectively. H1 and L1 represent the life satisfaction scores at time point T1, and H2 and L2 display the life satisfaction scores at time point T2. It is essential to note that both the groups had different mean scores at T1 as defined by the distance between points H1 and L1. Therefore, the difference between H2 and L2 cannot be entirely accounted for as a treatment effect in the study. The green line H′ represents the counterfactual effect. That is, what might have occurred if the treatment group did not receive treatment. Thus, the difference between H2 and H2′ represents the treatment effect.

According to Funk et al. (2003), researchers studying sports consumer behavior have inferred causation using experimentations and multivariate statistical methods such as econometric panel regression and Structural Equation Modeling. However, the scholars have erroneously concluded causal relationships based on the presence of a strong correlation. It is important to delineate that establishing a relationship between variables cannot always lead to the inference of causality. Let us assume that a sport marketer is interested in investigating the relationship between the expenditure on a promotional campaign and attendance at a sporting event. The researcher may perform a regression analysis with the conventional linear regression method, with the following formula:

$$Y = mx + c + e$$

Where

Y = game attendance,
x = expenditure on a promotional campaign,
e = error term,
m = the slope or coefficient of x,
c = a constant.

Let us consider that the data show that the marketer expended $100 on a promotional campaign and recorded 1,000 attendees at a sporting event. Thus, the model y =10x adequately fits the data. However, it cannot be inferred that the promotional campaign expenditure is causally linked to the attendance figures at the sporting event. This conclusion is drawn because another variable, 'interest in the sport,' may affect the connection between the promotional campaign expenditure and the number of attendees at the sporting event.

It is crucial to realize that the issue of omitted variable biases is not just that a variable is absent from the regression analysis. The missing variable is included in the error term, which refers to the unexplained variance in the model. The principal issue is that 'interest in the sport' influences the outcome and the predictor. As a result, a simple regression analysis involving the promotional campaign expenditure and the attendees at a sporting event will not accurately assess the causal relationship. The prediction models (ranging from linear regression to deep learning) developed without domain expertise can estimate a function and may not always have a causal meaning (Varian, 2016). Many confounding variables will influence both the outcome and the predictor variables in most instances.

Causal Inference with Machine Learning

Jin (2017) examined 282 articles published in the *International Journal of Sports Marketing and Sponsorship* from 1999 to 2015 and found that 25.5% of the articles utilized correlation analysis and 18.4% used regression analysis, while only 6.4% of the articles conducted experimentation-based research. This statistic highlights the lack of focus on novel techniques such as machine learning for causal inference in sport consumer behavior research. When it comes to understanding causality, the machine learning models may be utilized in combination with different designs and approaches to explain the process of establishing a causal connection (Imbens & Rubin, 2010). Machine learning methods, in particular, may have the ability to challenge the way researchers infer causation by utilizing better prediction power than conventional techniques (Couronné et al., 2018; Varian, 2016). The following section discusses how machine learning algorithms can be used to explain the inference of causality.

Demonstrate Counterfactual Effects with Machine Learning. Yoon et al. (2018) described a novel method for fitting a model to the observable factual data while simultaneously accounting for the unobserved counterfactual outcomes. Their approach was based on the seminal article published by Goodfellow et al. (2014) on the Generative Adversarial Nets (GAN). GAN is a machine learning technique that dynamically discovers and learns patterns in the data such that the model may create new instances that might have been derived from the original dataset. More precisely, the GAN counterfactual generator tries to create counterfactual outcomes so that the model cannot identify which of the components is the accurate result when given a combination of factual and generated counterfactual outcomes (Yoon et al., 2018). The treatment effects can be estimated by comparing the feature information using the combined outputs of the factual and the projected counterfactual effects.

Use Regression Discontinuity Design with Machine Learning. The objective of sport marketing researchers is to study fan behavior and create marketing strategies to generate profits (Wann & James, 2018). The researchers, in particular, develop strategies so that they can engage in behavioral targeting of consumers (Narayanan & Kalyanam, 2015). Behavioral targeting involves examining an individual's behavior to evaluate which message will have the most significant impact on the individual (Smith & Linden, 2017). Machine learning models can produce scores for the behavioral targeting strategy. The machine learning model will contain various behavioral features derived from the consumer behavior data. The machine learning model can integrate the scores to produce an output that gives a composite behavior score. For example, treatment may be given when a consumer's score exceeds a certain threshold. In this way, machine learning may be used with regression discontinuity design to estimate the causal impacts of the promotional treatments in settings where the consumers are scored based on a battery of consumer attributes.

Create Instrumental Variables Using Machine Learning. In sport consumer behavior research, the mediation model has been commonly used to infer causality (Baron & Kenny, 1986). A causal claim can be made for the influence of the independent variable on the mediator and the equivalent of the independent variable on the dependent variable because the researchers can rule out the possibility of confounding factors affecting the causal claims due to the random assignment of individuals to the levels of the independent variable (Kisbu-Sakarya et al., 2020).

However, while performing the mediation analysis, sport marketing researchers fail to consider that the mediator is an endogenous variable. Hence, it is essential to identify whether the mediator is correlated with the error term of the dependent variable. If the two parameters were related, the fundamental

assumption of the ordinary least squares (OLS) approach used for regression analysis would be violated. The estimate of the slope of the mediator would be, therefore, biased. In this case, the researchers can perform mediation analysis using the instrumental variable procedure with machine learning. Machine learning algorithms that perform the function of variable selection could be used to identify potential instruments that impact the dependent variable only through their association with the independent variable. Thus, by integrating the ideas of the instrumental variable approach and machine learning algorithms, the robustness of the findings of the mediation analysis proposed by Baron and Kenny (1986) can be further improved.

Theory Development with Machine Learning and Visualized Storytelling

The notion that machine learning algorithms can be utilized only for prediction and methodological advancements represents a myopic viewpoint. Choudhary et al. (2018) argue that data-driven theory development using machine learning techniques can be conducted to discover new patterns in the data. Such an inductive reasoning process may be aided by the capacity of machine learning algorithms to examine the associative trends in the data. Conceptually, research demonstrates how new or hidden patterns in the data uncovered by machine learning techniques may serve as a foundation for theory development. By applying this reasoning to the study of sports consumer behavior, scholars may contribute to theory development using machine learning and related data visualization techniques.

Various forms of cloud-based tools and platforms (e.g., Tableau, Dataiku, Power BI, Qilk) can unfold the story of the data through automated visual analysis. The visualized storytelling approach uses the data more intuitively and effectively than the conventional way that presents the data in a matrix where researchers and data analysts have no visibility of data quality issues without conducting sophisticated statistical analyses. As a result, sport marketers can obtain insights that would have been hidden or lost using the conventional approach to test the boundary of the existing consumer behavior assumptions and solidify the distinctiveness of sport management theory and research (Cunningham et al., 2021).

An Empirical Illustration

The following section features an empirical illustration demonstrating how scholars can benefit from novel machine learning techniques to advance sport consumer behavior research. For illustrative purposes, the core research question was to identify factors driving season ticket holders' defection behaviors. We employed a proprietary panel of 260 season ticket holders obtained

from a professional lacrosse franchise based in Northeastern United States. Data consisted of information from two consecutive seasons in 2017 and 2018. Predictor variables were contained in the 2017 panel. The dependent variable defection behavior was recorded in 2018 with nonrenewal coded as one to validate the predictive accuracy of included correlates.

Independent variables included ticket package type, travel distance, customer gender, and length of membership in years. The franchise offers four-game ticket packages, namely 1 = silver package, 2 = gold package, 3 = diamond package, and 4 = coaches club package. These packages represent ordinal choices based on individuals' preference of seating locations, pricing tier, and ancillary benefits. Specifically, the coaches club package offers the most premium amenities and services, including the highest price per ticket, seats with a better view of the stadium, discounts on merchandise sales, and special greetings by the team staff, followed by diamond and gold packages. In contrast, the silver package offers the most miniature amenities to STHs. User-specific predictors consisted of travel distance, gender, and length of membership in years. Travel distance was an ordinal variable comprising ten even intervals based on the distance between STHs' residential address and home stadium. The category of traveling distance ranged from 1 = less than 4 miles to 11 = more than 40 miles. We also included a quadratic term in the model specification to test a potential nonlinear effect of travel distance on the defection. Lastly, gender was represented by a dummy variable coding female as the reference group.

We used the R package caret to build the traditional parametric variable-centric logit model and two supervised machine learning models (random forests and support vector machines). We conducted a series of comparative analyses to evaluate the performance of the random forest and support vector machine algorithms with the traditional logistic regression algorithm to elucidate the predictive accuracy and discuss the economic implications of the findings. We employed a 70:30 split to form training and testing datasets among the 260 STHs. Training data is used to build and fit the predictive model, whereas testing data represents a gold standard that provides an unbiased evaluation of a predictive model.

In the traditional logit model, the log odds of defection behavior were specified as a function of four variables described above. We employed up to 300 decision trees in the random forest model using individuals' actual nonrenewal behavior as a target. In the support vector machine model, we specified the Gaussian radial basis function (RBF) kernel to identify a hyperplane that maximized the margin between churners and renewals. We employed standardized coefficients with an alpha level of .05 to interpret the significance of each included correlates on churn in the logit model. We then used ten balanced bootstrap datasets generated from out-of-bag samples to determine measures of importance for random forest and support vector machines. To identify which independent variables had the most significant influence on

nonrenewal prediction for random forest and support vector machines. Lastly, we generated confusion matrices to justify the overall predictive precision for each analytical model using the testing dataset.

The final step in machine learning is evaluating the empirical model, which can be evaluated using prediction accuracy. The confusion matrix visually displays the comparisons made between the actual and predicted classifications based on the testing dataset. Table 10.1 provides an example of a confusion matrix. Based on this, the accuracy rate of the algorithm can be calculated by following formula: Accuracy = (TP + TN)/ (TP + TN + FP + FN) (Géron, 2019).

To evaluate the performance of machine learning models against the traditional logit model, we compared predictive accuracy across different model specifications. Tuning results indicated that a specification of 20 random decision trees was optimal to fit the random forest model with all five features included at each node split. As shown in Table 10.1, results indicated that random forests (prediction accuracy = 85%) and support vector machines (prediction accuracy = 68%) outperformed the logit model (prediction accuracy = 45%). The logit model made the most type I errors in over-predicting nonrenewals. In the testing dataset, it misclassified all 43 STHs that were renewed. The random forest model made the fewest errors in prediction. Overall, it predicted four customers to lapse who renewed and eight

Table 10.1 Results of Logit, Random Forest, and Support Vector Machine for the Empirical Illustration

Variables		*Logit (Odds)*	*Random Forest (Gini Decrease)*	*Support Vector Machine (FCBF)*
Season ticket package		−0.29**	9.43	−0.17
Travel distance		0.23***	27.09	−0.27
Travel distance2		−0.02***	16.33	−0.18
Gender		−1.54***	8.65	−0.38
Length of Membership		0.12	14.55	0.10
Confusion Matrix Predicted		*Actual*		*Prediction Accuracy*
		Renewal	*Churn*	
Logit	Renewal	0	1	45%
	Churn	43	36	
RF	Renewal	40	8	85%
	Churn	4	28	
SVM	Renewal	46	25	68%
	Churn	1	8	

Notes. $^{**}p < .01$; $^{***}p < .001$; FCBF=fast correlation-based filter. For the sample size for the full logit model=260; We used a 70:30 random split to test the prediction accuracy of logit and machine learning models. The sample size for the training dataset was 180; the Sample size for the testing dataset was 80 – RF=random forests; SVM=support vector machines.

customers to renew who ended up lapsing. The support vector machine model made more false-negative predictions than the random forest model, although it still performed well than the logit model.

Taken collectively, while the variable-centric logit model represents a computationally inexpensive technique, more advanced machine learning algorithms optimize predictive capability (see Table 10.1). Markedly, the results of feature selection in random forests indicated that the length of membership was assigned with a high importance score (Gini Decrease=14.55), signifying that despite its statistical insignificance in the logit model, STHs' membership tenure represented the third most relevant personal characteristic to correctly predicting an STH's risk of lapsing.

Concluding Remarks

The field of sport consumer behavior has significantly evolved into an unprecedented era of big data featuring abundance in variety, volume, velocity, and veracity yet benefiting from an increasing focus on requisite knowledge in data literacy, the proliferation of artificial intelligence, and the democratization of its derivative repertoire of machine learning tools. In the current book chapter, we explain how sport consumer behavior scientists can harness the power of various novel machine-learning-based methodological advancements to extract discoveries, make predictions, falsify theories, and enhance the scientific rigor through the lens of causal inference by leveraging data sets both massive and small. The explosion of publicly available consumer-centric data obtained from social media, immersive virtual and augmented reality devices, and connected wearable fitness technologies combined with open-access data engineering resources (e.g., R, Python, and Kaggle repositories) will challenge the conventional deductive reasoning and inquiry process under the post-positivist paradigm. While emphasizing machine learning, it is our optimistic hope that established and emerging sport consumer behavior scholars can find the information presented in this book chapter as valuable and enlightening and that with thoughtful designs and proper applications of these methods, the field can smoothly transition to a more streamlined, interactive, and transparent scientific utopia for theory development and knowledge discovery, in which researchers and practitioners can ultimately find a perfect balance between the inductive and deductive inquiry process and the equivalent between managing model interpretability and optimizing predictive utility.

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Chapter 11

Consumerisation of Information Technologies in Sports

Opportunities and Challenges in the Age of Digital Natives

Hakan Yılmaz and Cem Tınaz

Introduction

In an age of hyper-connectivity via online platforms and digital technologies, the social, governmental, commercial, and communicational structures all over the world have been significantly transformed by the amount and speed of information flow emanating from the infinite number of human-to-human, human-to-things, and things-to-things connections. With the integration of new technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI), natural language processing (NLP), sensors, robotics, virtual reality (VR), augmented reality (AR), internet of things (IoT), and blockchain, the new wave of marketing has been defined as "the application of human-mimicking technologies to create, communicate, deliver, and enhance value across the customer journey" and been dubbed Marketing 5.0 (Kotler et al., 2021).

Most business processes have been re-shaped during this period, and here sports business is no exception. As in almost every other industrial sphere, inter-personal, inter-organisational and intra-organisational interactions in sports have been re-organised by the penetration of digital technologies and smart devices. The introduction of these information technologies (henceforth IT) has not only influenced the way in which organisations interact with their external audiences (i.e. consumers) but also with their internal audiences (i.e. employees). Real-time connectivity and mobility have evolved communication, consumption, and business cultures by eliminating the time and space boundaries as well as by cultivating personalised and customised services. Beyond influencing almost all people, this cultural shift has entailed significant differences between younger and older generations.

The younger generations born into this digital world and grew with ubiquitous connectivity—the so-called Digital Natives—are used to receiving information fast, constantly staying in touch with others, multitasking, and seeking instant gratification (Prensky, 2001). They are distinguished from the Digital Immigrants, those who have learned these new technologies later in their lives rather than naturally absorbing them as the norms of their social environment (Prensky, 2001). Though the digital native categorisation may also be

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attributed to most Millennials—those born between 1980 and 1994—the "true" digital natives" are characterised as the successive Generation Z with their idiosyncratic technological, cultural, and consumption preferences such as favouring ethical, unique, access-based consumption over possessions of status or prestige-signalling products (Francis & Hoefel, 2018). Since they have grown up symbiotically with the internet, computer, and mobile technologies, these digital natives also maintain pragmatic and flexible approaches in their professional careers. Therefore, they expect to integrate personal devices and consumer technologies into their working environment as employees (Vogel et al., 2010). In this regard, most, if not all, organisations embrace the willingness and expectations of their employees to utilise personal mobile devices and software in their work and try to establish flexible and efficient IT management strategies (Weiß & Leimeister, 2012, 2014).

Bolstered with digital communication and data technologies, the "Want it all/Want it now" culture attributed to Millennials (Ng et al., 2010) created entirely new private and professional lifestyles. Thus, the instantaneous gratification of needs and desires has become a norm for these very first natives of the digital world, but none more so than their successor generation. Coextensively to the changing consumption motivations, career-related expectations of young generations have also become subject to the personalisation and customisation capabilities, and to the agility of the employer organisations. The flexibility of an IT system became a prominent factor of organisational commitment and performance. The diffusion of new technologies into business operations sparked the need for more autonomous management approaches and strategies at different levels and departments of business organisations. The diversification and growth of digital technologies have led to the adoption of consumer devices and services in the working environment either as supplementary or substitute solutions to central IT systems. After anticipating IT consumerisation as a megatrend for all businesses back in 2005, Gartner (2022) now portrays it as an undeniable and irreversible process in which consumer technologies shape the IT management of business enterprises.

Sport as a technology- and media-driven industry took its share out of this foregone conclusion in the IT management domain. The ever-growing need for data-driven operations and real-time interaction in sports business makes this transformation in the industry even more striking than in many others. Despite the significance of the impact of "Consumerisation of IT" (henceforth CoIT) on business enterprises and IT systems, implications of CoIT are yet to be probed in the context of sport management theory—at least to the best of our knowledge. Therefore, the aim for this chapter is to elaborate on previous CoIT literature's theoretical depictions and empirical studies towards a discussion of their significance in sports business. Accordingly, the following section presents some conceptual definitions of CoIT in chronological order from the existing literature, before moving on to their examination in the context of the sports industry.

The Concept of "Consumerisation of Information Technologies"

Internet-, application-, entertainment-related software, and information services sectors were among the fastest growing industries in the last five years, and their growth is expected to continue at this pace over the coming years (Damodaran, 2022). The breakthrough in consumer information systems has emerged by virtue of new mobile devices, connection networks, and cloud-based software. These services and technologies offer speed, efficiency, and interactivity in communication, collaboration and creation processes. The penetration of mobile devices, web-based services, and cloud-based applications has come to influence personal and organisational decision-making processes significantly (Ruch & Gregory, 2014). The flexibility and utility offered by consumer devices, services, and applications have led to employees' expectation of adopting these new tools in the workplace (Cummings et al., 2009). The proliferation of smart devices and high-speed connectivity services turned such digital consumer technologies into even more capable IT tools than the centrally governed corporate information systems (henceforth IS) of the last decades. With an emphasis on the dual use of such consumer technologies and services for both personal and business purposes, Moschella et al. (2004) defined this process as the "Consumerization of IT" in the IS literature.

This new trend, the utilisation of personal devices in the workplace, had been initially acknowledged as the "Bring Your Own Device" (BYOD) notion within a restricted perspective until the CoIT concept was included in Gartner's Hype Cycle (Ruch & Gregory, 2014) within a broader cognizance of all the software, and hardware solutions incorporated into the organisational processes. However, with the integration of web-based and cloud-based services into daily lives via smart devices, the consumerisation concept has been furthered to a greater extent. This paradigm shift necessitates a broader understanding of the concept—and a strategical approach—in which the diffusion of technology is observed from the consumers to the enterprises (Andriole, 2012). Thus, this new approach requires an alternative bottom-up approach instead of the traditional top-down IT strategies governed by internal IT departments (Köffer et al., 2015; Moore, 2011). Besides the operational and organisational utilities of new technologies and devices, their integration into organisations brought about potential data security risks (Orlikowski & Gash, 1994). These risks may arise through the increasing data breach and leak possibilities that threaten the competitive and industrial position of organisations and jeopardise their corporate and public images.

In addition to the organisational risks, the utilisation of personal devices and software in the working environment may also raise employee concerns. The data privacy and protection issues were rather addressed in consumer behaviour studies which indicate the significance of the strategies and policies addressing consumer concerns on personal data privacy in firms'

digital marketing and innovation performance (Bandara et al., 2020; Bleier et al., 2020). Although digitalisation and data-driven marketing offer greater targeting, segmentation, and positioning capabilities for enterprises, customer trust towards data privacy and protection protocols of organisations also play prominent roles in maintaining longer and stronger customer relationships. The salience of data privacy concerns was also demonstrated by earlier studies in the context of employee-organisation relationships (Ball et al., 2012). Organisations need to have secure and transparent data-management systems so as to foster employee identification and motivation. Prior to addressing the potential contributions and threats of CoIT on personal and organisational performance, its characteristic attributes should be delineated. In this regard, the ownership and the usage purposes of the relevant devices, applications and services are identified as the distinctive characteristics of consumerised IT systems from the conventional enterprise IT systems whereas the utilisations of personal devices and services for business-related purposes were described as CoIT (Niehaves et al., 2012).

Based on these characteristics, Nieheves et al. (2012) identified autonomy and competence as potential contributions of CoIT for employees, while pointing to the risk of work overload. Furthermore, they listed the organisational advantages of CoIT as improved employee satisfaction, ease of new technology adoption, employee availability, customer focus, and employee investments whereas the security risks, IT support system complexity, loss of process control, and performance consistency were addressed as potential disadvantages (Niehaves et al., 2012). Regardless of its pros and cons for today's organisations and professionals, CoIT is an inevitable phenomenon calling for particular attention and a strategical approach. Previous research has shown that perceived IT empowerment and perceived superiority of available consumer IT options over organisational IT systems significantly predict CoIT behaviour, which consequently influences the employees' innovative work behaviour (Junglas et al., 2019).

Consumerisation of IT in Sports

Digitalisation has intensified the sports industry's dependence on IT on and off the court with recent technologies, digital platforms, and data analytic solutions. Just as monitoring and optimisation of the on-court performance have been continuously advanced by high-speed data processing devices, HD cameras, and wearable technologies, fan engagement and experiences have also been digitalised via new broadcasting platforms, mobile apps, and social media integration. Beyond traditional spectator sports, the increasing demand for physical activity services has been augmented with mobile and smart technologies. Furthermore, the growing e-sports market boosts the pace for digital transformation and data-driven businesses in the industry. This transformation forces sports organisations to continuously embrace and invest

in digital technologies not only to meet the new expectations of digitally native sports consumers but also to maximise employee performance through liberating the working environments by allowing the use of personal devices and services.

In previous studies on IS, the CoIT concept was decomposed into five domains, namely hardware, software, data, people, and procedures (Niehaves et al., 2012). In contrast, Silver et al. (1995) alternatively suggested an organisation-focused perspective in which the given system is analysed on the basis of its functions (i.e. business processes, people, IS) within the higher-level supersystem, rather than focusing on its constituent parts (i.e. hardware, software, data, people, procedures). In line with this proposal—and given this is a preliminary work for CoIT in the sports industry—we focus on the influence of CoIT processes on people; the individual stakeholders who are the front-runners of IT consumerisation in sports organisations. Pioneering change agents in this all-encompassing consumerisation process are the sports spectators, athletes, participants, and non-athlete employees. The True Digital Natives with their communaholic, pragmatic, dialoguer, and mobility seeking consumption patterns (Francis & Hoefel, 2018) also act upon similar motives in their professional careers. This cultural shift must be comprehended well by the sports organisations in order to embrace the new culture and correspondingly adjust their businesses.

CoIT for Sport Spectators

Sports are an engagement-based industry in which the spectators are the focal actors of this engagement. The interactions between sports organisations and spectators have been augmented by the emergence of digital platforms, social media, mobile devices, and online applications along with the diminishing physical boundaries in online communication (Pegoraro, 2013). Previous studies indicate that sports fans simultaneously participate in online sports platforms, post on social media, and text or call other people while watching the games on TV (Gantz et al., 2012). The use of secondary devices for such purposes by the fans during the viewership of televised sports events is on the rise and there are positive and negative implications in terms of fan experiences and behaviours (Cunningham & Eastin, 2017; Rubenking & Lewis, 2016). Depending on the outcomes of the games, these online behaviours might occur as BIRGing (i.e., basking in reflected glory), CORFing (i.e., cutting off reflected failure), and/or CORFing (i.e., cutting off future failure) in different online domains (Porter et al., 2011; Spinda, 2011). For sports organisations—unlike the traditional gameday interactions focusing on mere entertainment and excitement—the new digital platforms enable uninterrupted communication with the spectators. The extended and fragmented fan engagement via online platforms obliges sports organisations to invest in their online presence in order to protect and develop their corporate and sponsorship value.

Since online engagement can be tracked and monitored over multiple domains, new opportunities and challenges have arisen for sports marketing. This has led most large-scale sports enterprises to build in-house social media or online communication departments and to hire digital experts and third-party agencies specialised in these fields. The vast amount of data emanating from the digital engagement with sports consumers not only offers new marketing capabilities and opportunities but also challenges the organisations' IS departments. Therefore, the marketing departments along with the IS departments need to adopt new digital infrastructure, hardware, software and skills essential for this new epoch. As with other industries, sports organisations can also benefit from the CoIT process by strengthening employee productivity, social and business relationships, online communications, and innovative behaviour at work (Junglas et al., 2019; Köffer et al., 2014; Leclercq-Vandelannoitte, 2015; Meske et al., 2017).

Today's sports organisations have to track online interactions, engagement and reactions in real-time to be able to spot and act upon the consumers' expectations and needs. Such continuous tasks, together with the high degree of mobility in the sports business, require that sports professionals deploy their own devices, software, and digital solutions with work purposes for the sake of efficiency and timeliness. E-commerce and digital advertising have conquered the sports business similarly to other industries. In order to maintain the community feeling and brand image, increase online sales, and recruit young talents, the internet and social media-based applications are essential in today's business environment. Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, YouTube, LinkedIn, Twitch, and TikTok are some of the primary social media platforms where a sports organisation must take its place to stay in touch with the community. Moreover, the revenue streams of sports organisations are increasingly moving towards e-commerce, in which the digital marketing practices play crucial roles. Search engine optimisation solutions, mobile marketing, content marketing, influencer marketing, and social media marketing have become some of the major skills which should be adopted by the sports organisations all of which entail greater emphasis on CoIT in sports.

Building a brand community is one of the key success factors in today's competitive markets (Schau et al., 2009). This community-building approach has also been utilised by many sports organisations and has been shown to increase fan engagement and attendance in previous studies (Katz et al., 2018; Yoshida et al., 2015). Within this framework, the roles of spectators are not defined as passive consumers of the value created by the sports organisations but instead regarded as active contributors to this value as the co-creators of it (Woratschek et al., 2014). With the aim of maximising this co-created value, sports organisations must be active on as many online touchpoints with consumers as possible in virtual platforms. For sports spectators, social media, web, and mobile platforms are the new domains of socialisation and community participation, enabling real-time information, interaction, and augmented

viewership experiences. Thus, today's sports consumers follow social media pages, download mobile apps, and subscribe to the web portals of their favourite teams and sports to improve their sports-watching experience. In turn, sports organisations benefit from the accumulated data from the online engagement with the fans by monitoring, measuring, and targeting different customer segments and profiles. Investments in these online and digital assets allow sports organisations to better position their products and services while offering new and well-configured sponsorship opportunities to their partners.

Together with the opportunities of customisation and personalisation of the fan experience, there are also challenges for sports spectators in what can be an increasingly fragmented engagement process. Far from engaging them, the endless number of e-mails, push notifications, social media pandemonium, accounts, privacy concerns and other burdens can be exhausting for some fans. Today, an ordinary sports fan should at least have some the apps and/or accounts for Twitter, Facebook, YouTube, Instagram, and the official apps of their favourite clubs or leagues to be able to stay fully updated and engaged. Some of these services require in-app purchases or paid subscriptions for unlimited or ad-free services. Moreover, sports consumers are generally required to have the most up-to-date devices and operating systems for full compatibility with the contents offered on these platforms. With the growth of e-sports and on-demand media consumption patterns through streaming platforms, many sports spectators also use Twitch, Amazon Prime, Netflix, Spotify, and many other OTT platforms to reach more sports content. This fragmentation of the spectator experience in sports entails the IT consumerisation for sports spectatorship by offering more immersive experiences in exchange for higher monetary, psychological, social, temporal, and privacy costs for the spectators. The CoIT processes for sports spectators involve but are not limited to the aforementioned platforms.

Many sports clubs and organisations now initiate Fan Tokens and Non-Fungible Tokens (NFTs) for their spectators to offer higher exclusivity and engagement. In North America, the NBA (National Basketball Association), for example, launched the NBA Top Shot platform to offer fans the chance to create unique digital collections of memorable games and moments from the league. These are some of the ways in which today's sports organisations try to cultivate and capitalise on fan engagement as a revenue-generating asset. A recent study shows that sports fans are more familiar with and interested in innovative products and services such as cryptocurrencies, NFTs, and blockchain-based businesses than non-fans (Silverman, 2021). Beyond traditional sports consumption patterns requiring a simple TV set, a radio, and/or daily newspaper purchases in former times, modern-day sports spectatorship necessitates possession of the latest mobile devices, mobile network subscriptions, high-speed connectivity, multiple accounts for web-based streaming platforms, mobile apps, smart TVs, gaming consoles, and social media

engagement for a full-blown fan experience. The quest for fan engagement in today's sports industry is a matter of gaining the shares-of-the-bandwidths as well as the shares-of-the-hearts. This complexity of interactions and the cluster of platforms and touchpoints may not only wear spectators out, but also present novel challenges for sports organisations in terms of infrastructure, know-how, technology, human capital, and supply-chain management.

CoIT for Athletes

Becoming a modern-day athlete requires both on- and off-the-field qualities. Beyond their physical and mental skills, professional athletes with their celebrity status also aim to build a credible image and create communication value. With the tremendous interest from consumers and remarkable investments from sports and non-sports brands, athletes not only represent other brands as endorsers but also become professionally managed human brands of their own (Thomson, 2006). Maintaining a positive brand image on- and off-the-field helps these athletes sign more endorsement deals as well as earning higher salaries (Parmentier & Fischer, 2012). The dominance of social media platforms in personal and corporate communications furthers the roles and interactions of today's athletes with the fans, media, and brands. The demassification concept, coined by Toffler (1980), can be witnessed in almost all communication domains, as well as in the sports industry—furthermore today with the influence of social media (Santomier & Hogan, 2013). The fragmentation and segmentation capabilities of social media have meant that sports-related marketing communication has evolved into a more complex and sophisticated process. The unmediated communication availabilities between the fans and the athletes enhance the interactivity and the influence mutually. Therefore, social media presence plays such a key role in a contemporary athlete's personal branding endeavour that most of them may spend more time online than they spend on field. With the widening opportunities of online publicity to and the narrowing gap with the audience, the branding of athletes has become a process intertwined with the branding of teams, leagues, sports events, and associated sponsors (Su et al., 2020). Such intertwined marketing communications can be regarded as a co-branding practice for the athletes together with the entities they represent or compete for (i.e. teams, leagues, sponsors, etc.).

The complex communication processes between athletes and organisations entail a mix of cooperation and conflicts. Many athletes share live videos, post tweets, comments, and content, whether related or unrelated to their teams, competitions, opponents, and/or events. Indeed, even athletes' personal posts—whether they ignite positive or negative interactions with the public—can also impact related organisations. Since these posts and online activities are conducted via personal devices and athletes' online accounts, navigating this unlimited communication sphere undamaged is

almost impossible for sports organisations. The growth and spread of high-speed connectivity, and the emerging 5G technology, even further the live broadcasting capabilities of mobile devices both in quality and in duration. Individual athletes can broadcast and reach up to millions of viewers via platforms such as Twitch, Instagram, or YouTube. E-sports culture has also contributed to this new hype around the athlete-broadcaster concept, which has recently carried over to traditional sports and athletes. With so many devices, platforms, technologies, and revenue streams available for individual athletes, consumer technologies invade the traditional IT and marketing communication strategies of sports organisations.

This new paradigm of "anytime/anywhere" broadcasting also challenges the contracted sports broadcasting domain, which has been regarded as being in a period of "horizontal, vertical, and congeneric integration" (Solberg, 2013). This shift, which can be conceptualised by a term adapted from the IS literature, "Horizontal Fragmentation", will definitely continue to influence the broadcasting systems and media consumption patterns in sports because of the erupting content creation and distribution. Though the distance between the fans and the sports organisations—both as co-creators of the value in sport—shortens with the new media technologies and platforms, the emergence of individual athletes as content creators and distributors stretches the sports broadcasting domain horizontally. As this new field broadens the potential of social and economic impacts that athletes can make, it also challenges them in terms of the adoption of new technologies and know-how. Furthermore, this new domain also complicates the sports organisations' centrally built and governed marketing communications strategies. From an economic standpoint, the sponsorship and endorsement investments in the sports industry might be directed more towards individual athlete-broadcasters rather than the conventional sports broadcasts with respect to the influencer and opinion-leader roles of athletes over the younger generations that they foster via online interactions. Thus, sports organisations should reconcile and compromise their corporate communication strategies by integrating such flesh-and-blood sports personas with direct, personal, and real-time influence on sports consumers.

Aside from managing their image, the athletes must also follow IT and smart devices in order to better monitor, improve, and optimise their athletic performances. Smart training tools and wearable technologies have already been in use by MLS teams since 2013—not just for individual performance improvement, but also for team strategy and performance monitoring thanks to the utilisation of smart jerseys, watches and body sensors at the trainings and competitions (Delgado, 2015). The adoption and use of such devices and software by the athletes to improve their competitiveness and health require significant time and effort. The amount and variety of such new technologies open up new areas of expertise for which the individual athletes need to cooperate or consult with a lot more experts than before. Whereas in the past

hiring social media experts, image-makers, digital marketers, a team of personal trainers and physicians, mentors, and lifestyle coaches were the exclusive marks of distinction confined to top-class athletes, in today's competitive environment these have become essential points of parity. This multifaceted transformation has led modern athletes to adopt and professionally use consumer technologies in their careers.

CoIT for Sport Participants

Though the impact of smart technologies in professional sports is undeniable, it is none more so than in participant sports in which the sport consumption occurs in a broad and activity-based context rather than a passive spectatorship. Wearable technologies, health and fitness apps, body sensors, and smart watches have penetrated into the daily lives of physical activity and fitness enthusiasts. The diffusion of these new technologies has been amplified even further by the growing need and demand for personal training services since the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. These new devices and solutions allow for personalised and customised services, while also offering greater socialisation possibilities through connected devices, platforms, and social media networks. The features comprise but are not limited to tracking and storing the information of heart rate, sleep cycles, blood-oxygen levels, and even individually performing electrocardiography (ECG) (Muts, 2021).

Not only do such new technologies and services enrich the overall participant experience, they also have the potential to increase the individual's self-awareness of their body. In a study focused on the roles of mobile applications for individuals' health-related behaviour, West and his colleagues (2012) adopted Green and Kreuter's (1999) "Precede-Proceed Model" and identified reinforcing roles of these apps on individuals' healthy eating, physical activity participation, personal health, and wellness-related behaviours. Such a wide range of features and devices with so many applications and utilities undoubtedly urge sports participants towards these new products and services. However, choosing between the alternatives and putting them into full use entails a considerable information load and learning process. Beyond health and wellness solutions, the consumers enriching their sports participation experience by using these smart devices, mobile applications and new sensors include but not limited to amateur runners, swimmers, divers, bikers, and many other participants of competitions and sports events. These new tools help users to track, store, monitor, analyse, improve, and share their physical performance data in and through digital platforms and potentially increase their involvement in and motivation with physical activities. The changing nature of sports participation via smart devices and services and the changing expectations of digital native consumers necessitate sports managers and marketers to offer more immersive and interactive digital experiences. Such transformations require intensive financial investments and organisational

changes for sports event organisers, facility managers, and sports entrepreneurs. On the flip side of this is the growth potential for the participation sports market and for many new sports start-ups.

CoIT for Non-Athlete Sport Employees

Spectators, athletes, and sports participants are idiosyncratic and distinctive stakeholders of the sports industry. Besides these unique stakeholders, there are also various types of white- and blue-collared professionals in sports that are being exposed to CoIT in a more similar vein to the employees of other industries. Therefore, previous studies on CoIT conducted in non-sports business contexts may shed light on the CoIT processes in sports organisations—at least for the non-athlete professionals. Since mobile devices and applications have essentially become physical, mental, and social extensions of individuals in daily life, their roles in the working environment cannot be set aside. Many employees utilise consumer IT products and services to enhance productivity, efficiency, and productivity at work (Junglas & Harris, 2013). In a study conducted over 4,000 employees across 16 countries, almost half of the surveyed professionals reported that personal consumer devices and software applications to be more useful than the tools provided by their corporate IT departments—to such an extent that more than a quarter of them (27%) are even ready to pay for their own devices and applications to use for work (Harris et al., 2011).

The sports industry is no exception to this, with its high integration of technology, media embeddedness, and digitalisation. Digital platforms offer sports organisations the chance to create and distribute more targeted content for different consumer segments, while extracting valuable data. On the other hand, operating and monitoring so many platforms is a formidable task for any organisation, with all the human, technology and intellectual capital requirements it entails. The central IT systems and devices are not always capable of providing the flexibility and timeliness needed for managing so many real-time interactions. Therefore, sports professionals deploy their own devices, applications, and online solutions to cope with this abundance of tasks. Furthermore, most of the major sports organisations must rely on outsourced services and consultancies from various third-party agencies, suppliers, and vendors for data-base installations, security and privacy configurations, social media monitoring, e-commerce infrastructures, and mobile applications.

The dynamic and interactive nature of sports challenges and forces sports industry employees to master the most current communication technologies and analytical skills if they want to better position their products and organisations. In addition to consumer analytics, performance analytics is also a rapidly growing field in the sports industry. While sports marketers have to develop their e-commerce, digital advertising, and social media skills to be

more competitive, coaches, trainers, scouts and agents are also forced to adapt to this digital movement. They need to adopt artificial-intelligence-based performance metrics and software, wearable technology solutions, smart devices, and HD cameras so as to optimise individual and team performances (Beal et al., 2019), create more effective training programs (Halson et al., 2016), better procure and rehabilitate injuries (Claudino et al., 2019), better predict competition results (Pretorius & Parry, 2016), and discover and develop young talents.

The integration of data-driven solutions in sports marketing is not limited to developing, improving, and promoting sports products on and off the field. The growing data storage and processing capabilities of the sports industry has enabled the development of new products and markets. Sports betting (Lopez-Gonzalez & Griffiths, 2018) and online fantasy leagues (Kwak & McDaniel, 2011) have emerged as prospective new markets and revenue resources for many different sports. Furthermore, new digital products such as Sports NFTs (Lee et al., 2021) and Fan Tokens (Tidy & Lane, 2021) have achieved significant growth and look set to become billion-dollar industries. These lucrative new revenue generating products can only be derived through a state-of-the-art data infrastructure and organisation. Transforming the real-time stats into data—and the data into commercial products—requires not only employees with high technology literacy but also collaborations with third-party organisations. All of these operations increase the pace and scope of CoIT for sports employees with the growing importance of real-time data processing and interactions through online platforms.

Beyond the advantages of IT solutions for the sake of better decision-making and innovation potential, the overcoming of space and time boundaries is a primary strength of mobile consumer products in comparison to the corporate IT systems with respect to the sports industry's high mobility and interactivity. Most sports professionals travel and work abroad so frequently for business purposes that they often utilise their own devices and services rather than their organisation's central IT tools and services. Consequently, the IT dependency of sports professionals increases with hardware and software requirements. With so many different platforms, devices, and software applications used in working environments, most sports professionals operate as an autonomous IT department with their own consumer devices, applications, software, and services.

Besides the autonomy and competence advantages provided for employees, IT consumerisation might also lead to negative consequences such as work overload and job-related stress (Niehaves et al., 2012). Along with the diminishing time and space boundaries, the responsibilities and duties of workers have also become space- and time-boundless. This might sometimes lead to a condition called "technostress"—the result of the extension of the workplace into other aspects of life via continuous connectivity which might cause higher levels of stress and workload (Tarafdar et al., 2007). In order to

support the employees to cope with this workload and job-related stress, sports organisations should facilitate regular education, mentoring, and orientation activities with the participation of HR and IT departments. Current and prospective employees' consumer IT adoption capabilities and levels should be examined during and after the recruitment process, since technological and digital literacies are some of the key attributes for successful professionals in today's dynamic economy.

Conclusions and Future Implications

In relation to the wave of changes sparked by consumer IT products and services in the sports industry, the prominence of CoIT were briefly presented in the previous sections for each of the aforementioned stakeholder groups. In this concluding section, the future research implications for CoIT will be discussed in the context of consumer relations, along with inter-, and intra-organisation relations in sports industry. The paradigm shift enhanced by the significant differences over the adoption and acceptance of new technologies between the so-called digital natives and immigrants have diffused into organisations irreversibly with the proliferation of ubiquitous information systems (Vodanovich et al., 2010). Distinct technology utilisation patterns of different generations have led to vastly different working and consumption cultures. Despite the fact that most decision-making and leadership positions are held by those who are bracketed as Baby Boomers and Generation X'ers, the largest portion of the workforce and consumer markets are made up of those from the digital-savvy Generation Y and Z. This digital divide has led to new opportunities and challenges for marketing practices (Kotler et al., 2021). In consideration with the growing importance of and interest in the co-created value of sports and its embeddedness in digitalisation (Stegmann et al., 2023; Uhrich, 2014), comprehension of CoIT processes plays a vital role in the success of sports marketing strategies and practices.

Either from customer-focused or from internal marketing perspectives, the integration of innovative customer IT services into sports products and organisations that are considered relevant to the expectations of Generations Y and Z has become essential for contemporary sports marketing. However, developing digitally augmented market offerings while coping with inter- and intra-organisational conflicts of interests and expectations can be a complex endeavour—between the intricate structure of sports organisations and the whole sea of industry stakeholders from spectators and professional athletes to amateur sports participants and non-athlete sport professionals. With respect to the transforming entertainment, leisure, socialisation, and media consumption behaviours of digital native consumers, digital technologies, and consumer IT services provide unprecedented personalisation and customisation possibilities through on-demand platforms and content but with a trade-off over the collective feelings and values conveyed by the traditional

sports in the past. In this manner, the costs and benefits of digitalisation in sports should be cautiously undertaken—with due consideration of the balance between individualised and collective sports experiences—with the aim of sustaining the social and economic impact of sports in the long term. The sports marketers of today should seek to improve both human-to-technology engagements as much as human-to-human engagement by harnessing the new technologies in their market offerings in ways that promote the co-creation of value in sports collectively. Nevertheless, the customised and personalised communication tools enabled by consumer IT services provide great opportunities for sport organisations to foster stronger relationships with these digital-savvy consumers.

The expansion of consumer IT services in spectator sports—amplified by digital fan engagement platforms such as mobile apps, fan tokens, and online content—is also accompanied by the growth of personal fitness, training, nutrition, and health-monitoring tools. The diffusion of these innovative products and services has been accelerated even further in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic. The digitalising impact of lockdowns, social distancing, and distant working regulations imposed during the peak periods of the pandemic appears to persist on the fitness and training industry for longer periods. Given that the spread of technologies such as 5G, AR, VR, blockchain, and AI will continue apace, CoIT seems set to remain a significant factor in the sports industry. Similar to CoIT's B2C implications, it also creates an undeniable impact on B2B interactions in the sports industry. Most of the sports organisations today need to adopt cloud-based services, CRM and ERP software, data analytics and visualisation tools, mobile app and web design and development capabilities, as well as social media marketing expertise. Such a concentration of new solutions and skills increases the external dependency of sports organisations. This is a process in which both the horizontal and vertical integrations expand in the sports industry, entrepreneurial activity has been sparked—with a proliferation of start-ups in the sports technology domain. An even more striking transformation is taking place in the sports broadcasting domain because of the growth of digital and online consumer IT systems. Decreasing costs of high-quality broadcasting via high-speed connectivity and new generation cameras threaten the exclusive rights of the traditional broadcasters and the centralised distribution of broadcasting rights. The digital natives' expectations of access, ease, speed, convenience, and affordability for products and services will seemingly transform the B2B relations in the sports industry, as with its B2C processes.

The intra-organisational influences of CoIT have been extensively studied in the domain of information systems research (Cummings et al., 2009; Harris et al., 2012; Junglas et al., 2019; Leclercq-Vandelannoitte, 2015; Meske et al., 2017; Moschella et al., 2004; Niehaves et al., 2012; Ruch & Gregory, 2014; Weiß & Leimeister, 2012). Despite the empirical findings in these previous studies focusing on CoIT implications on employee motivation, performance,

and behaviour, the idiosyncrasies of sports organisations with respect to their unique stakeholder groups (i.e. spectators and participants as value creators, athletes, trainers, and coaches as employees) and intra-organisational relations necessitate that these findings are interpreted with reservation. The celebrity status of athletes, high level of spectator identification with other organisational members, and strong engagement entail intricate relationships within these organisations. Therefore, the CoIT protocols and processes diminishing time- and space-boundaries while increasing interpersonal bonds must be comprehensively considered by the practitioners and academics in the sports marketing field. Despite the salience of CoIT for sports organisations, the academic studies in this field have remained scarce. Customer engagement, CRM, brand communities, value co-creation, intrapreneurial activity, and customer experience are some of the prospective domains of further research in sports marketing.

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Chapter 12

Sports Information, Social Communication, and Protection of the Olympic Brand

IOC Guidelines on Using Social Media during Olympic Games

Angela Busacca

Introduction

The Olympic Games of the contemporary era represent the main sporting event on a global level and at the same time reflect social and cultural evolution. Following the history of the Olympic Games throughout the 20th century and the first decades of the 21st century, it is possible to retrace the evolutions that have brought us from a society that experienced the first industrial machines to a highly technological society; from a society of inequality and patriarchy to a society of equal opportunities for women; from a society that experienced the first mass communication through newspapers to a connected and globalized society simply called the "information society"; from a society of factories, to a society of (increasingly) mobile and dematerialized wealth, with an imposing market influence.

The history of the 20th century offers us a picture of the countless social transformations that accompanied the years of the two world wars and the long period of peace (in the West) in the following decades; in parallel, the history of the Olympic Games follows and reflects those transformations: the suspensions for the world wars, the reflection of social tensions, the 1972 Munich attacks and the "cold war" in the editions of Moscow 1980 and Los Angeles 1984, the progressive affirmation of the (ever) more inclusive sports for female athletes, who until 1920 were "tolerated" and admitted only in some disciplines, the establishment of the Paralympics for the involvement of athletes with disabilities, the multiplication of communication channels issues and the dissemination of sports information and, last but not least, the progressive arise of the economic dimension alongside the dimension of pure spirit and social values of the Olympic Movement. The evolutions that took place in the 20th century were then consolidated in the first decades of the new century, characterized by the two directions of globalization and digitization but at the same time by a widespread sense of insecurity caused by terrorist conflicts and, in recent years, by the emergency healthcare situation. The Olympic

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Games, however, have maintained their character as a mirror of society and the latest editions have particularly highlighted some elements, including the growing influence of the market and the metamorphosis, indeed the mediamorphosis of sports information and sports communication.

The "story" of the Olympic Games, like indeed the story of major sporting events in general, has always had an extremely "mediable" character: first the narration of cycling in the radio era, then the so called "marriage of interest" with television, then the advent of digital broadcasts and online streaming and, lastly, social communication and the suggestions of virtual reality. This mediability character has made it possible to develop and consolidate a double audience: on the one hand, the public present in the sport facilities or who, in any case, directly attends the sporting event and, on the other, the public of the users who assist, in fact, in a mediated modality, through television, internet and new media in general. The balance between the two audiences of sporting events has turned upside down in recent decades, both in terms of numbers and in terms of revenues, the "second" audience, i.e. the mediated one, has recorded a sharp surge, becoming an essential element in major sports events. But, the communication that involves the second audience, i.e. that of spectators and users, does not only concern the fruition of the images of the sports event, since, precisely due to the multiplication of communications through new media, the flow of information has taken different characteristics, conveying, alongside sports information, also commercial communications and disintermediating, more and more, contacts between athletes and fans.

Social Communication

Between Information and Commercial Communication

Sports information conveyed through social media has become increasingly more fluent and communication increasingly direct, preferring image or video content over written texts. In this way, public attention and loyalty has become the main objective. Alongside information content, commercial content is increasingly present: social media are, in fact, a formidable promotional vehicle for brands and allow marketing activities aimed to be carried out to the so called "fan engagement" strategies, to lead the fan to become consumer. As stated by the doctrine, in communication via social media, which enhances the visual component more, corporate identity becomes more and more branding: the message conveys the brand and makes the consumer loyal to the brand even before the product or the service. This logic also characterizes the more recent approaches of the Olympic Movement to social communication: on the one hand, we have the implementation of the

communication network between athletes and supporters, on the other a use aimed at promoting the Olympic brand, in the different variations of the logo made up of the five circles and individual logos and distinctive elements of the various editions of the Summer Games and the Winter Games.

Symbols and logos of the Olympics take on a precise communicative value and assume significant and economic relevance; they are the exclusive property of the International Olympic Committee (IOC) and can only be used with a prior concession and/or agreement, so that any different use could be considered illicit and can be prosecuted. The evocative value of the Olympics is projected, however, beyond the simple representation of the logo and precisely against the possibility of (abusive) exploitation by commercial operators and networks that act as free riders. Thus, it is necessary to implement the system of protections already set up by the Treaty of Nairobi on the protection of the Olympic symbol.

The growing commercial value of the Olympic properties and assets, in fact, and the progressive consolidation of sponsorships and advertising contracts connected to the Olympics and related activities, requires the preservation of exclusive ownership situations held by the IOC and, at the same time, avoiding the occurrence of episodes of unaware but unlawful disclosure. In particular, precisely in consideration of the many opportunities offered by social media, which allow digital content to be conveyed and shared very easily, on the occasion of the latest editions of the Olympic Games, the IOC prepared a series of indications to regulate the use of social media by the athletes and by all the subjects involved, for various reasons, in sporting activities and, more generally, in the organization and management of the Games. The short guidelines relating to social communications concerned only communications of a personal nature and supported the more articulate guidelines relating to the use of images and video content for commercial purposes, by the companies sponsors of the event and by companies which, despite being sponsors of individual athletes, nevertheless were not sponsors of the Games. Furthermore, it seems appropriate to highlight how the guidelines on using social media created for the Tokyo 2020 Summer Olympic Games (later held in 2021) was of particular importance in consideration of the circumstances of the competitions and life in the Olympic village, following the pandemic emergency.

In the following pages, after a general consideration on the use of social media in sports communication and on the advantages/disadvantages of the direct communications between athletes and supporters, the guidelines on using social media proposed for the Tokyo 2020 Olympics will be analysed in detail, to highlight what the balance point is, identified by the IOC, between free expression of thought and protection of Olympic properties and assets and the commercial value of the Olympic brand.

Sports and Social Media

In recent years, the use of social media has become the preferred communication method used by clubs and individual athletes to create a more direct relationship with supporters, according to fan engagement strategies aimed at loyalty and interaction with the communities of supporters/followers (Prunesti, 2020; Ortenzi, 2017). The creation and management of social profiles (from Facebook to Twitter to Instagram up to the most recent TikTok) of individual athletes, sports teams and sports organizations represent elements of a communication strategy that can be used to obtain greater visibility and to realize marketing programs, creating interactions by promoting contests and competitions for fans or just sharing fan user-generated content. In relation to different social media, Facebook (FB) represents one of the first and probably the most used. The presence of athletes and teams on FB is constantly growing and alongside the most well-known personalities, for whom the different methods of constructing pages and social media accounts are used, there are also athletes and teams playing in minor leagues that can acquire unprecedented visibility as well as loyalty with the public, especially with home crowds, by using social media. For fan engagement strategies, FB offers various functional tools to convey the images of athletes and teams: not only private profiles, which suffer some limits imposed by the structure of the social network, but also fan-page and Business Suites that allow monitoring of the flows of connections and sharing, to define the best communication strategies.

Alongside Facebook, some other social networks have emerged in recent years e.g. Twitter, Instagram and TikTok. Twitter, chronologically the first of these three but currently in slight decline, allows the transmission of short text messages of up to 280 characters and presents as a social network particularly suitable for real-time interactions and one-to-many communications, thanks to the use of hashtags: it is an extremely efficient social network for searching for news and interacting with communities. While FB maintains its role as a more articulated platform in services, Twitter offers advantages of greater relationality in real time, thanks to its simple communication style and the possibility of interactivity with other platforms. Instagram was born as a social media for sharing images and brief videos with concise texts (Barbotti, 2018). It rapidly became one of the most used platforms, also in the sports field; it offers an interesting fan engagement modality through Instagram (IG) Stories, which are used by athletes and sports clubs to talk about not only great events or competitions, but above all daily life linked to sports and private life, moments that take place outside of sports performances and perhaps even outside the traditional media.

Lastly, but very important given the increases recorded by the platform, we must consider TikTok which presents as a platform to experiment mixes

between images and sounds, proposing short films made with unpublished materials or with re-editions and montages of already published contents (so-called lip sync), creating a new social communication language, particularly appreciated and used by younger people. From some statistics, it appears that TikTok is the social network that has achieved the highest engagement rate in the last year and, consequently, it represents a potential development channel for advertisers to experiment sports marketing strategies, alongside more traditional channels (Barbotti, 2020; Venturi Firriolo, 2013).

It is clear that today no one involved in the sports world can ignore, or pay little attention to, telematic communication and social media. The pandemic itself, imposing limitations of personal contacts and the possibility of aggregation, made it necessary to implement an online presence of all – athletes, teams, sports institutions – to strengthen total fan/follower engagement. It was no longer a question of merely communicating and informing, but now meant involving, retaining and profiling to be able to offer content that was ever more responsive to expectations and to propose detailed online direct marketing strategies. Total engagement strategies provide for integrated management of multiple social media to render the promotional message to fan audiences even more complete and to carry out the subsequent steps of a process aimed at converting the fan into a customer. For this purpose, communication activity that starts from information continues with involvement with the sharing of contents and social interaction that also aim at enhancing the presence and experience of the fan, and with profiling. This is the acquisition and processing of fans' personal data collected by filling in forms or registration forms which, on the one hand, offer the feeling of belonging to the community while, on the other hand, allow the owners to collect consents for the processing of the data collected. The last step is then reached, which is the conversion that takes place when a fan becomes a customer and purchases many services or products sold by the sports club, the organizer of the event or by the sponsors.

On these considerations, double attention needs to be paid on the part of sports event organizers as well as on the part of the teams themselves. This is fully understandable, with care of the communication plan and the promotion of contents placed firmly at the centre. Organizers and teams need also to protect themselves against all possible transmission of other social contents that may, directly or indirectly, affect the market and loyalty value of the former. Think, for example, of the possibility of posting videos of game phases in, possible, contrast with exclusive clauses on broadcasting of events or contents relating to the promotion of products and brands in, possible, competition with other sponsors of the events or companies. The growing dimension of sports business determines the opportunity to define rules at every level, capable of protecting all the economic interests involved and ensuring the users of social services in the best possible way. With reference to athletes, management of a social profile, choice and scheduling of content and

interaction with the community are all activities that have an impact on visibility and notoriety and, particularly for professionals, also an economic value with the branding of name and personal image (Battelli, 2019; Busacca et al., 2005; Nazzaro, 2012; Oshiro et al. 2021; Santomier, 2008; Santoro, 2020).

Similar to many other spheres, the phenomenon of influencers has established itself in the sports sphere with the emergence of so-called athletes-sports influencers. On a general note, the phenomenon of influencers constitutes one of the most original aspects of social media communication; the most common definition indicates them as a "popular character on the Internet, who has the ability to influence the behaviors and choices of a certain group of users and, in particular, of potential consumers, and is used in the context of strategies of communication and marketing", highlighting how the figure, which arose in the communication field, soon took on a commercial character. More immediate than advertising and (apparently) less structured than traditionally understood advertising, the communication of influencers is based on the popularity of the character and on the experiential dimension of the message: sharing daily life is the communication key that, alternating with commercial communication, enables the latter to penetrate more deeply into the audience of followers. While traditional advertising shows a sports testimonial intent on enhancing a good or service (object of the message) with an episodic character and in the context of a constructed and artificial reality, influencer marketing is based on continuous interaction and sharing of one's own experience and one's own life to "guide" the choices of the public (Bifulco & Tirino, 2019; Fiocca, 2018).

Moreover, regarding sports influencers (both athletes and non-athletes), the question concerning the boundary between communication and advertising emerges: if an athlete-influencer records and shares IG-stories in which they enhance their performance achieved thanks, say, to a new shoe, are they talking about an experience or making a commercial communication? If it clearly shows the logo on clothing worn in free time, is it communicating or promoting a brand? These doubts highlight the need to find a definitive line between free expression and commercial communication, above all in relation to the extreme variety of the contents that often disguise commercial communications such as IG-stories, posts on FB, TikTok contents, and, of course, the video reviews on YouTube channels. It is important to underline that in the case of commercial communication or advertising it is necessary to respect certain principles and rules of clarity and transparency towards consumers (first by communicating the commercial purpose even with a graphic symbol or an acronym such as #adv or #advertising).

The social profiles of the most famous athletes/sports-influencers are often managed by social media managers who look after every aspect, from creation/evaluation of contents to publication and interactions. Alongside these hypotheses, most of the social profiles of non-commercial relevance (or in the

case of so-called micro-influencers, i.e. subjects that have an audience of between 1,000 and 20,000 followers) are managed by the athletes themselves who proposes themselves as content creators, albeit with assistance or support. In any case, even for top player athletes and clubs or, more generally, for subjects involved in the sports system, it is necessary to manage social media with fairness and responsibility. In the case of illicit use, indeed, posts and social content can be assessed as an infringement of consumer rights and infringement of competition rights and, regarding sports system law, as a disciplinary offense with consequent sanctions and fines. Case history relating to disciplinary sanctions against athletes due to incorrect use of social media is particularly rich, ranging from top players to examples taken from the national federal sports jurisprudence. With regard to the former, we need only look at the case of Neymar, sanctioned in 2019 for having posted comments on the referee of a Champions League match who had awarded a penalty kick, which proved decisive for the opposing team.

The case law of individual national sports systems also offers many examples, again with reference to financial penalties: two example from Italy case law include the case of a team manager of a professional football team, who, in 2014, posted some offensive considerations on his own FB profile against the team coach and was sanctioned with a fine of more than €6,000 and, again, the case of the football player who clicked the "like" button under the Twitter post of a fan who made some accusations against the CEO of the sports club he played for and was sanctioned with suspension from the club (Biasi, 2019). Also in the Olympics, there was a peculiar case: the football player Morganella who, on the occasion of the 2012 London games, posted an offensive tweet with seriously discriminatory profiles against the Korean national team, and in general towards the inhabitants of Korea; he was subsequently sanctioned with expulsion from the Games and withdrawal of accreditation.

Tokyo 2020 Summer Games: Rules and Limits of Massive Social Media Use

The pandemic emergency caused by the SARS-CoV-2 (COVID) virus strongly impacted the organization of the Olympic Games: first of all, the postponement of the Tokyo Summer Olympic Games, the XXXII edition of the contemporary age from 2020 to 2021 (Gallego et al., 2020) and, once sports activity had resumed, the decision to hold the games in the absence of the public, both the Tokyo Olympics (summer of 2021) and the Beijing Olympics (Olympic Games of the XXIX Winter edition, February 2022). This unprecedented decision added another particular feature to these editions of the Olympic Games, creating a new balance in the dialectic of the double audience of sporting events in an unprecedented way. The so-called direct audience (public in the sport facilities attending live events) was practically eliminated and the media audience intensified (public following events on television or

Internet), probably marking the peak of the so-called "mediamorphosis" of sporting events (Busacca, 2020; Centorrino, 2007; Lalli, 2020).

In a context that has already recognized the media strength of sports news and the aggregative and economic force of sporting events, the Olympics in question presented as a testing ground for network operators, broadcasters and providers, and also for the organizers, called to deal with the silence of the facilities and with a media exposure that is no longer limited only to match chronicles or traditional moments of in-depth analysis and commentary, but, thanks to the massive use of social media, also with probably reaching 24/7 coverage of life in the Olympic village and the athletes who are the protagonists of the Games. Thus, the images and videos of Olympic competitions and athletes and also those of the award ceremonies, the opening and closing ceremonies and the various moments of the Games become usable only in a media dimension. Additionally, with the consideration of the growing diffusion of social media and digital media, a redefinition is required of the criteria of lawfulness, the limits of creation and broadcasting and online posting of all images and videos of the Olympic Games (traditionally reported as part of the Olympic properties of the IOC; Fidecaro, 2020; Delpy Neirotti, 2020; Vellano, 2005) in search of an equilibrium between freedom of expression on the one hand and market rules on the other.

Traditionally, the allocation of broadcasting rights of the competitions and the contents of the Olympic Games constitutes one of the most important items in the balance sheet of each edition of the Olympics (summer and winter). The creation of photographs and other (amateur) video content, for personal use, has always been "tolerated" precisely due to their lack of interference with the rights of broadcasters and information operators. However, in recent years, the boom in social media and online communications, with the possibility of global and immediate circulation of contents, has led to an entirely different situation that, without certain rules, could constitute potential and significant interference with the above-mentioned rights on Olympic properties. The London Summer Olympics 2012 was the first global sports event on a social level, but it was during the Rio 2016 Summer Olympics that social coverage exploded with unprecedented interactions between broadcasters and providers. Statistics recorded that the official Olympic.org website had more than 26 million visits, while the sharing of Olympic content on the various online platforms amounted to more than 7 billion video views (Hutchins & Sanderson, 2017).

IOC Guidelines on Social and Digital Media

In relation to the correct use of social media and, more generally, of new media, the International Olympic Committee (IOC) prepared a document with "Guidelines on social and digital media" on the occasion of the more recent editions of the Olympic Games, aimed at athletes but also applicable

to all persons accredited to the Olympic Games. In brief, it can be said that the Guidelines contain a series of indications on the criteria and limits of the use of social media, encouraging dialogue between athletes and followers, but at the same time setting a series of limits to the images and videos that can be disclosed through posts, video, or IG-stories; these limits are set for all social media, without distinguishing between lasting content or ephemeral content, such as IG-stories that last for 24 hours.

The text is crucial as it concerns the personal use of social media and contents created and conveyed by athletes, with general rules of conduct and prohibitions regarding "social" conduct that could lead to an infringement of financial clauses, above all the exclusivity one, on images and videos of the competitions or which could be qualified as journalistic or information activities. It should be remembered that the IOC is the exclusive owner of all image rights relating to the Games and the only one who can, therefore, enter into a contract to sell them as foreseen in Art.7 par. 2 of the Olympic Charter,

> The Olympic Games are the exclusive property of the IOC which owns all rights relating thereto, in particular, and without limitation, all rights relating to (i) the organisation, exploitation and marketing of the Olympic Games, (ii) authorising the capture of still and moving images of the Olympic Games for use by the media, (iii) registration of audio-visual recordings of the Olympic Games, and (iv) the broadcasting, transmission, retransmission, reproduction, display, dissemination, making available or otherwise communicating to the public, by any means now known or to be developed in the future, works or signals embodying audio-visual registrations or recordings of the Olympic Games.

Journalistic activity was permitted for information purposes, but only for accredited journalists (Blackshaw, 2010; Wuthurich, 2017).

The "IOC Guidelines on social and digital media" dictate a series of duties aimed at athletes and "others holding accreditation" at the Olympic Games regarding a specific sector: social media communications carried out for personal purposes. These duties of conduct on social media, alongside and complementary with IOC specifications, regard the commercial use of images and videos of the Olympics Games. Moreover, they include the different Playbooks, particularly regarding athletes and officials, drawn up by the Organizing Committee, the IOC, the International Paralympic Committee, and the Governmental Authorities of the host cities, for the safeguarding and protection of health during the Games.

The Guidelines issued by IOC were aimed at all athletes and others holding accreditations to the Olympic Games: this general consideration of holding accreditations allowed application of the provision to a larger number of

people in all the sports facilities, to guarantee exclusive rights on the images of Games as fully as possible. Regarding the latter, it is abundantly clear that the rules of conduct were to apply to all those who, albeit for different reasons, were present in the facilities and in the reserved areas for purposes not related to sports information and (professional) journalism; any other interpretation would have created unjustified disparities regarding the possibility of creating and sharing content relating to the competitions and, more generally, the Games. The different legal basis of the lawfulness of the content is not related to the status of the content creator (athletes, volunteers, other holder accreditation), but above all to the object of the content itself, making it forbidden to shoot in certain areas and situations. The intended purpose of most direct communication from athletes to fans is clear right from the beginning of the Guidelines: "Athletes and people accredited to the Tokyo Olympic Games are encouraged to share their experiences with friends, family and supporters through digital media and to keep the memory of their participation". In a globalized world that records more than four billion active users on social media, sharing by participants can constitute a sort of digital asset capable of increasing visibility and promotion of events and, consequently, increasing financial value.

The added value of communication carried out through social media by participating athletes and all accreditation holders (thinking, in particular, of volunteers) has been felt since the first editions of the 2000s, but it is only with the latest editions that greater attention has been paid to the regulation and criteria for using social media. In particular, the most significant increase in "social coverage" took place between the Beijing Summer Olympics 2008 and the London Summer Olympics 2012. For the first time, in the London Summer Olympics 2012, the Organizing Committee laid out some regulations aimed at limiting the use of social media by volunteers, to avoid the online circulation of content which could be potentially harmful to the exclusivity clauses set by the IOC. Both in the Rio Summer Olympics 2016 and in the PyeongChang Winter Olympics 2018 the IOC focused on the use of social media to protect "Olympic values and the rights of others".

The Guidelines of the Tokyo Summer Olympics 2020 were more specific: the text was divided into four points dedicated to content subjects, legislative reference and regulatory framework, personal use clause and consequences of breaking rules. Moreover, the Guidelines for the Beijing Winter Olympics 2022, while appearing to be less in number, actually include more limitations, with a division between permitted and prohibited conduct and, only in the margin do subjects and consequences of the infringement of rules appear. As already anticipated, these are specific documents that must be framed in the Olympic system of rules and analysed in conjunction with both the provisions of the Olympic Charter and with the individual regulations and codes

of ethics. Therefore, the following pages will focus on the Guidelines proposed in the last two editions of the Olympics, having as keywords contents, regulatory framework, personal use, violations, and sanctions.

Social Media Content

The first point concerns the creation of multimedia contents that athletes could create and share via social media; without distinguishing between the different types of social content, the Guidelines allowed "taking pictures" and "recording audio/video" using "non-professional equipment" and sharing this on personal social media accounts or sites web, with the exception of contents which included the areas of "playing field" and "Space behind fields", in relation to which the Guidelines offer definitions and exemplary indications. In combination with the discipline of Rule 40 of the Olympic Charter, this delimitation clarified territorial boundaries of areas belonging to Olympic properties (that only the IOC could avail of) and content boundaries of communication and personal sharing.

On these considerations, athletes could post a photo (own or of others) or an audio/video content respecting the indicated limitations: for example, it was possible to freely take pictures or film the reserved spectator areas in the facilities and in the Olympic village but not the awarding of a medal to a teammate or any moment of the inaugural parade. Moreover, it emerged that the prohibition relating to the "playing field" and the "space behind" was to be understood as referring only to sharing and not to the possibility of taking photos and making videos for personal storage on one's own personal device, without any online uploading and sharing activity. In this case, in fact, the athlete assumes responsibility for the custody of the content (image and/or video) and for the use of same and there may only be liability in the case of diffusion or sharing which can be attributable to their device. Thus, the take-away message of the initial presentation was sharing the experience, with limits to the shareable content, and preserving the memory, without any limit to the archived and non-disseminated contents.

The purpose of the Guidelines was to offer complete visibility of the Olympic event, beyond the competitions, encouraging direct communication and interaction with supporters. However, both in the Tokyo Summer Olympics 2020 and in the Beijing Winter Olympics 2022 those rules had to deal with the limitations imposed due to the pandemic emergency and contained in the Playbook, such as, advice on travel restrictions and limitations on group activities. Under normal conditions, the Guidelines would have undoubtedly been useful for all contents relating to life in the Olympic Village and the activities of individuals, teams, and national delegations in Japan and in China. Instead, due to the imposed restrictions, the social communication area was necessarily limited to the areas of permitted movements, in full compliance with all rules on prohibition of gatherings and meetings. Regarding this last point, it

should be noted that the Guidelines for the Tokyo Summer Olympics 2020 were issued before the outbreak of the pandemic and the ensuing health emergency and was aimed at the original organization of the Games and collateral activities.

Regulatory Framework

The second point has wider application, referring not only to the conservation and/or sharing of the contents of the Games, but in general to the use "in another way" of social and digital media "during or in connection with the Games" also including text posts (without images or video contributions), questions or surveys addressed to the public or repost of the "ask me a question" boxes, infographics or processing on images, digital file, and documents. The guide criterion, in these cases, was the use of the social network during or in connection with the Games. Referring to a series of documents and regulations, the Guidelines indicate five points containing duties which athletes had to conform their conduct to; before examining them in detail, we can already mention how these were, for the most part, prescriptions of a general nature that laid down the principles and rules for the correct use of social media and digital media in the sports system, and which were already present in national and international regulations.

With reference to the first point, the obligation to "respect the honour, integrity, reputation, privacy or confidential information and rights, including intellectual property rights, of each individual or organization" is indicated: with a presumably illustrative and non-exhaustive character, personality rights are recalled. In addition to these personal rights, also intellectual property rights are referred to, precisely to re-emphasize attention to the economic/patrimonial aspects that some digital contents can assume; the reference to intellectual property rights, moreover, assumes a paradigmatic value of all situations connected with protection of intellectual property and rights of creators (Apa & Pollicino, 2014; Chimienti, 2005; Chrisam, 2016).

The second point indicates the obligation to "respect the integrity and activities, including safety measures, of the Olympic Games": also, in this case there is a very general formulation, but this point assumed a decidedly new value in light of the then current health situation and the safety regulations adopted due to the pandemic to allow the Games to be held in safety, minimizing the risk of contagion. The reference to safety could only regard the rules of conduct of the mentioned Playbook ("Athletes and Officials") and, in general, the prescriptions of health authorities. In relation to integrity and activities, the provisions of the Olympic Movement Code on the prevention of match-fixing may be cited, with reference to the prohibition of betting as well as the dissemination of privileged information and failure to report.

The third point indicates the obligation to "guarantee that the content is free from hatred, prejudice, racism, political and religious propaganda,

division and discrimination": similar to what is foreseen in point 1, these are general limits to the freedom of expression, that respond to protection of a double interest. On one hand, there is individual interest, with reference to the subject called into question by the post or in any case of the shared content, and on the other, collective interest, the fight against the phenomena of diffusion of hate content or racism and discrimination, finding provision in the sports system already in Rule 50 of the Olympic Charter,

> Except as may be authorised by the IOC Executive Board on an exceptional basis, no form of advertising or other publicity shall be allowed in and above the stadia, venues and other competition areas which are considered as part of the Olympic sites. Commercial installations and advertising signs shall not be allowed in the stadia, venues or other sports grounds. No kind of demonstration or political, religious or racial propaganda is permitted in any Olympic sites, venues or other areas.

The last two points, also in the generality of the terms used, are more closely linked to the dynamics of the Games: in particular, it is a question of "not sharing or publishing contents of the Olympic Games on social/digital media accounts or websites of others" (specifying and increasing the prohibition of point 1) and not acting "as journalists or other communications officers during the Olympic Games, not even acting on behalf of any organization of communication", specifying the strictly personal nature of permitted social communications. In relation to the first point, a doubt could arise with reference to the scope of application of the ban: that is, whether it referred only to the commissive conduct of the athlete who posts the content on a non-personal profile or account, or is understood in a broader sense including all precautions that avoid the possibility of sharing and/or re-posting contents (sharing on FB, sharing on IG, re-posting IG). This second interpretation, although appearing more suitable for broad protection of the contents, nevertheless must allow identification of the technical limit of responsibility of the account holder who cannot be called to answer for any further sharing of the images created through indirect modes (screen capture or further recordings). On this point it should be remembered, once again, that the subject of the Guidelines is the sharing and use of social media and digital media for personal purposes and not for commercial purposes, which falls, instead, into the domain of the provision (general prohibition and exceptions) of Rule 40 of the Olympic Charter. The final point concerns the prohibition of carrying out activities like journalism or professional communication, i.e. a post from a non-professional source cannot be justified as one exercising their right of information, but, at the same time, the right of professionals had to be upheld according to the rules envisaged for the accreditation of communication operators by the IOC.

Personal Use and Penalties

The third point of the Guidelines specifies limitations relating to the personal use and storage of contents relating to the Olympic Games, excluding commercial or promotional purposes, with explicit reference made to "Commercial opportunities for participants". This last point regarded companies that were sponsors of the Games that could economically exploit images, logos and other Olympic properties, under license from the IOC and the Organizing Committee. The second sentence of the paragraph, although without expressly referring to Rule 40, nevertheless placed a series of prohibitions relating to the publication of messages and content on other people's sites and on the sites of non-Olympic sponsors, to which athletes could not address specific messages of thanks that recalled the Olympic context. On this point, some brief clarifications are called for to allow and coordinate the provisions of the Guidelines on social media and digital media with the by-law of Rule 40 and the guidelines issued by the individual National Olympic Committees.

For the entire duration of the so-called "Rule 40 period", which included the days of the Games and a few days before and after, e.g. for the Tokyo Olympics, 13 July–10 August 2021, partner companies of athletes, sports clubs, national representatives, and sports organizations, both nationally and internationally, were divided into two macro-categories: Olympic sponsors and non-Olympic sponsors. For the former, who entered into specific agreements with the IOC and the National Organizing Committee, the rules on commercial relations in the context of the Games were taken into consideration and, although within the limits set by the protection of the pure values of Olympism, the possibility of carrying out commercial and promotional activities was envisaged.

For non-Olympic sponsors, who, despite having relationships with athletes or teams or entities participating in the Games, were not in any relationships with the IOC and the Organizing Committee, it was possible to use the image of the athlete or team but without any contextualization that recalled the Olympic Games or that could generate the erroneous perception of a connection between the message and the Olympics in the minds of the public. Following the indications of the guidelines, the advertising and promotional campaigns could not include, either verbally or visually, Olympic properties, any references to host countries, the context and the landmarks, sports images, or competitions that might recall the Olympics. Likewise, the image of an athlete participating in the Olympics could be used only in the presence of certain requirements, such as the consent of the athletes themselves and compliance with the policies provided by the IOC and the Organizing Committee both in terms of exclusivity and in terms of prohibition of promotion of products in contrast with the Olympic spirit (tobacco, alcohol, betting, immoral activities), as well as the "generic" character of the promotional message

with, in particular, the absence of Olympic properties and the absence of any reference to the Olympic performance of athletes.

These rules, laid down for non-Olympic sponsor companies, were reflected in the Guidelines for participants, intending "to clarify only the use of social channels for commercial purposes, with the aim of defining roles and boundaries to possible Partnerships with non-Sponsor Companies". We have already seen how the diffusion of social media communication in the sports field has contributed to the consolidation of social marketing and in particular of influencer marketing, with a progressive growth in the value of contents posted by athletes on social media and the need to identify a boundary between personal communication, as a manifestation of freedom of expression, and promotional communication, for commercial and economic purposes. It follows that the mixture of the two methods could prove harmful and give rise to ambush marketing phenomena in the digital market particularly in the Olympic weeks (Abeza et al., 2020; Geurin & McNary, 2020; Nakamura, 2018; Schmidt et al. 2018; Testa, 2020).

By scrolling through the rules addressed to athletes, it emerges that only one thank-you post could be created on the personal channels for each non-sponsor company which could be shared on the athlete's various social accounts, but this post could not contain any contextualization relating to the Olympic Games: one photo containing tags of the non-Olympic sponsor company, which shows the athlete's face and the symbol of victory with the fingers of the hand, without any element that allowed to connect to the Games and no textual reference was admissible, while a post with the medal Olympic or with any indication, e.g. #Olympics2020, #Olympics2022, or a geolocation in host country, was not admissible, nor any reference to host countries and cities; even a photo of the athlete, hypothetically strolling through the streets of a host city or at the airport, with a tag or a message of thanks to the non-sponsor company was not admissible as it was in contrast with paragraph 3 of the Rule 40 by-rule. The content of the posts was limited to thanking the company, with the exclusion of any possible endorsement or product promotion, also in the case of goods and services not related to the sports field. Content limitation had a limited duration in time relating to the "Rule 40 Period". Once this period elapsed, it was also possible to openly post promotional content, taking care to always respect the regulations on commercial communications.

Lastly, the IOC document relating to the use of social and digital media provided a generic liability clause for any violation of the provisions contained in the document itself as well as "further guidelines of the respective National Olympic Committee and any applicable law or regulation" with a double remedy tool: first, a sort of "notice and take down" model, to remove the contested content from site and social pages; and, second, based on the circumstances, sanctions by IOC and its National Olympic Committee. On this latter point,

the extreme generic nature of the liability clause created some doubts. In relation to the request for removal, it is not specified which institution it was to come from, or rather, it was assumed that it should come from the IOC or the Organizing Committee. Moreover, it was not specified whether only a request from the IOC mandated the removal or whether there were other legitimate subjects. Again, with regard to removal, the Guidelines stated that it must take place "immediately", without any specification on the count of this deadline. Thus, did "immediately" mean that any delay was also to be considered, like the failure to remove it, a punishable conduct? Thus, what period of time was considered "reasonable" for timely removal? And what was to happen in the case of content shared by other users? In this case, the question may arise as to whether it was sufficient for the athlete to remove it from their social profiles or if they had to respond for permanent shares on other profiles.

In relation to this last point, an implicit obligation could be identified to set up appropriate mechanisms that prevent sharing on social media where possible. However, also in this case we should assume the presence and activity of a social media professional or, however, a good degree of knowledge and conscious use by all athletes and accreditation holders: once again it seems appropriate to consider that among them there were also volunteers who provided assistance. The indeterminacy of the subsequent remedial tools, left to case analysis and determination by the IOC or the national committees, allows us to realistically hypothesize the possibility that the athlete might receive a sanction that projects beyond the horizon of the Games. In the most serious cases, such as a post with racist overtones and incitement to hatred conveyed by a footballer, on the occasion of the London 2012 Olympics, the sanction was expulsion from the Games and withdrawal of accreditation.

Conclusion

Tokyo 2020 and Beijing 2022 represented a huge leap for social media coverage of the Olympics. Certainly, the emergency situation due to the pandemic and the absence of the public contributed to this increase. However, it is realistic to think that, even with the return to a normal situation, the social dimension of sports events will increase more and more, facilitated by technological developments. In confirmation of this, just a few days before the inauguration of the Tokyo Summer Olympics 2020 some Japanese laboratories announced that they had exceeded the internet speed record, reaching 319 Tbps, thus allowing much faster data transfer especially for huge amounts of data in a global dimension; furthermore, in the seven days preceding the opening ceremony, almost two million posts with the hashtag # tokyo2020 were uploaded, mostly from Japan.

The technological and telematic declination of major sports events continues incessantly towards new goals and new records, and it is not difficult to

imagine that the innovations that have characterized the latest editions of the Olympic Games, from extreme media coverage to the, still marginal, use of tools and robotics, will be further increased in the next edition, the Paris Summer Olympics 2024. We will probably see a more pervasive use of artificial intelligence tools applied to sport and, perhaps, the debut of e-sports as an Olympic sport. At the same time, the first hypotheses of social media services on subscription have been advanced: on compensation, monetary or otherwise, social platform could offer particular/different contents and more communication and interaction functions. This could lead to an evolution of Olympics social coverage and an increase in the value of interactions and contributions. Consequently, the definition of "personal use" of social accounts by athletes should also be reformulated, if linked to a service offered by subscription (not free). Nonetheless, what athletes, and, more generally, every sports system subject, have to respect is the responsible and conscious use of social media and digital communication tools, amounting to online fair-play, interacting with or engaging fans, being aimed at promoting the stories and values of sport that constitute, every time and in every communication modality, the invariants of the sports community and, in a broader sense, civil society.

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Chapter 13

Supplemental Attractions to Foreign Sporting Event Participants

Lessons in Branding from a Case Study of the World Rafting Championship in Japan

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Introduction

Sporting events have enormous impacts related to tourism. For example, the 2019 finishers report (n.d.) indicated that approximately 47% of New York City Marathon runners that year were from foreign countries. Martin and Hall (2020) reported the modest overall impact of this marathon on local hotel demand. Considering sport tourism, Higham and Hinch (2018) found that sport tourists were primarily motivated by a particular sporting opportunity as spectators or participants. However, sport tourists' travel decisions depend on a combination of sporting and non-sporting attractions. According to Germain et al. (2017), participants in the World Rowing Championships visited places such as restaurants and beaches in rural areas. Sporting event participants can be attracted as tourists to destination elements (e.g., heritage sites, iconic architecture, and theme parks) before or after the event (Chalip & McGuirty, 2004). In the field of sports tourism, Nogawa et al. (1996) studied the tourism behavior of sporting event participants. They found that these individuals had the potential to become active tourists despite time constraints and economic factors. However, there is no information related to the travel preferences of participants in sporting events. Gibson (2005) noted that college sports motivate both sports activities and other tourism activities among fans. However, Higham (2005) observed that sports-related tourism has not yet been the subject of sufficient empirical research and theoretical development. Many studies on sport tourism have been conducted since Higham (2005), but there are multiple perspectives and importance aspects of this research that need to be addressed according to Higham and Hinch (2018).

With regard to community development through sporting event tourism, host countries and cities need to encourage tourists to travel to additional places. Similarly, Nogawa et al. (2004) identified supplemental attractions for tourists, including secondary and tertiary attractions. In terms of bundling,

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sports have the potential to cross-leverage attractions and activities at the destination (Harrison-Hill & Chalip, 2005). Sports even have a synergistic effect on the host community, and local organizers expect that bundling sports and sporting events will promote tourism. Specifically, destinations and managers must seek to expand travel opportunities, such as scenery and historical attractions, to promote tourism (Buning & Gibson, 2015). Sport-based tourism can sustain the local culture of a destination (Hinch & Higham, 2015), but there are insufficient resources for understanding these issues.

Crompton (1979) noted push and pull factors of travel motivation. Sporting events include many types of attractions in addition to the events themselves. Cultural experiences are also important attractions. Nogawa et al. (2004) indicated that knowledge regarding sport tourists' preference for travel attractions is limited. Funk and Bruun (2007) studied international participants in running events. The cultural context of Peñaloza's (1994) research included language. Funk and Bruun (2007) reported that there were meaningful differences in cultural experiences according to the similar/dissimilar cultural backgrounds of respondents. Specifically, the attitude of participants in a sporting event toward the event's host country may encourage them to seek supplemental attractions despite differences between their cultural background and that of the host country. Gammon and Robinson (2003) provided a conceptual framework for sports and tourism. They offer various definitions of sport tourism. For example, in a soft definition, recreational engagement in a sport such as skiing is the primary motivation for travel. However, it might be necessary to consider different perspectives of participants in outdoor sporting events at the national or international level and athletes competing in mega-sport events, such as the Fédération Internationale de Football Association (FIFA) World Cup and Olympic Games. However, Getz (2003) pointed out that there is a lack of information about tourists at international sporting events. Many studies have focused on the impact of major sports events (Hinch et al. 2016), and many have focused on mega events and their economic impacts (Kim et al., 2013). Additionally, most of the previous research has collected data on individual sports, such as cycling or running (e.g., Buning & Gibson, 2015; Halpenny et al., 2016; Newland & Aicher, 2018), but the concerns of Getz (2003) have yet to be fully addressed.

This case study was aimed to identify the types of supplemental attractions that the participants in the World Rafting Championship, as a team sporting event, would visit while staying in Japan. This case study also aimed to explore the influence of cultural experience on the types of supplemental attractions. Rural areas in Japan are experiencing several social issues, such as depopulation and the movement of the younger generation to urban areas. Within this context, outdoor sports have the potential to attract tourists and contribute to the social and economic development of communities in rural areas. Yamaguchi et al. (2017) noted that community development through outdoor sport tourism in Japan not only provides employment opportunities for

local residents but also promotes local commitment to residency. Thus, outdoor sports such as race rafting can be examined to understand the current status of the promotion of sports tourism in communities in Japan. The findings of this research can aid destination marketing–related branding and sustainable community development through sport tourism.

Review of Literature

Flow-on/supplemental tourism

Taks et al. (2009) called tourism occurring around the time of a certain event "flow-on" tourism. They reported that classic tourism activities are motivated by a desire to learn about the destination and participate in classic tourism activities such as sightseeing and visiting museums. Buning and Gibson (2015) also reported on the trajectory of active event travel careers in cycling. They discussed the stages and suggested that destination management organizations should improve event management. Additionally, Newland and Aicher (2018) reported that the travel behavior of participants in sport events varied by athlete type (runner, triathlete, and cyclist). Overall, little is known about flow-on tourism in sport tourism. The research on sport tourists needs to consider segmentation, such as by classifying different types of sporting events (e.g., individual or team sports) or sport tourists (e.g., professional or armchair athletes). Additionally, the study of sport tourism has focused on dimensions such as sport as motivation to travel and time (Rheenen et al., 2017).

Foreign sport event participants have some constraints on their travel before and after the event. Huang et.al. (2016) noted that rural areas create a geographical constraint on tourism. Nogawa et al. (1996) also identified constraints related to both time and economic factors for participants in sporting events. Host countries and cities must manage these constraints for tourists. Lew (1987) suggested a framework for tourist attractions and noted that tourist attractions are not only represented by landscapes and special experiences but also involve transportation and accommodations. Event organizers can develop special tour programs to help event participants visit sites and cultural areas before or after games. From the perspective of event and government organizers, the type of athlete, type of sporting event, and length of the event should be considered when promoting tourism sites. Organizers can develop a tour with a shuttle bus between the sites of the sport event and spots for sport tourists, especially for foreign participants in the sport event.

This recommendation is related to Getz's (2008) idea of the need for "custom-design", high-target event experiences and the concept of flow-on tourism introduced by Taks et al. (2009). Taks et al. (2009) indicated the importance of a one-time event in the host city. In addition, they (2009) noted that the experiences of the destination itself tend to be outcomes of flow-on tourism before and after the event, along with repeat visitation and

positive word-of-mouth. This case study focused on the World Rafting Championship, an international competition that has been held in Europe, North/South America, Africa, and other regions. Thus, this case study can contribute to research concerning supplemental attractions with flow-on tourism in the context of race rafting in Japan's rural areas.

Cultural Experience

Culture has already been discussed by scholars of anthropology, sociology and psychology. According to Heine (2012), culture is defined "any kind of idea, belief, technology, habit, or practice that is acquired through learning from others" (p.3). Specifically, culture has a broad range of complicated structures. Regarding cultural experiences, scholars have indicated some differences based on tourist behavior and attitude (e.g., Lu et al., 2017; Reisinger & Turner, 1998, 2002; Tasng & Ap, 2007; You et al. 2000). For instance, Reisinger and Turner (1998) noted the importance of cultural differences in communication between foreign guests and hosts. Regarding the factors of memorable tourism experiences, Kim and Ritchie (2014) reported seven aspects, including novelty, the local culture, and meaningfulness. Specifically, the tourism experience has a broad range of complicated structures and is an important factor for understanding international tourists' behavior and attitudes. In addition, Funk and Bruun (2007) indicated that international sport event participants have consumer acculturation of Peñaloza (1994) foreign immigrants, such as confronting specific cultural factors in housing and language.

Sport Event Careers

The relationship between sport events and tourism has been a main research topic and has been investigated in the context of mega-sport events as well as small and medium-sized sport events. The research focuses not only on spectators but also on the participants in sport events. Getz (2008) and Getz and McConnel (2011) introduced the idea of event travel careers, which is based on the travel career trajectory of Pearce (2005). There are many types of fundamental motivations for travelling to events. Some leisure categories, such as serious leisure (Stebbins, 1982), can be applied to investigate travelers' careers at destination sites. Buning and Gibson (2015) used the event travel careers concept based on Stebbins' serious leisure concept and Pearce's travel careers concept and indicated that a combination of the two travel careers concepts can offer insight into patterns of motivation and career progress. These authors focused on amateurs as sport event travelers and found that they were motivated by their seriousness and commitment to the activity through structured practice. In the same vein, Weed and Bull (2009) noted that travelers are interested in the "associated experience" of sport tourism. They indicated that

sport tourists are motivated by the expectation of experiences before, during, and after the event. In addition, there are some demand-side factors in events (Getz, 2003). For example, uniqueness is an important factor in attracting many tourists to a related sport event. Socializing refers to opportunities to meet and see people.

Getz and McConnel (2011) reported the high involvement of serious sport tourists in competitive events in the context of mountain biking. Their study revealed that event-related travel was typical and widespread and provided insight into the attitudes and behaviors of event participants with respect to event travel careers. In addition, Patterson Getz and Gubb (2014) applied the event travel careers concept to study yoga participants. They found a relationship between the social world of yoga and event tourism. Recently, Aicher et al. (2020) investigated Travel Career Progression with social worlds. They reported that the social worlds types affected not only event distance but also flow-on tourism in the active sport tourism context. Overall, previous investigations of sport event careers found the same characteristics across different contexts. However, Weed and Bull (2009) noted that there are interactions among activities, people, and places on particular trips. Thus, participants' sport event careers have complex structures, and it is necessary to better understand the differences across activities.

Sport tourists are embedded in complicated structures. Gibson (2004) reported that sport is the primary purpose of sport tourists, while for tourism sportists, sport comes second. The micro- and macrolevel influences on different forms of sport tourism and destinations. Thus, sport tourists might consider certain factors when deciding to participate in sport events. Based on the characteristics of the host city and community, some sport events, including the World Masters Games and UEFA Euro, could attract a certain number and type of sport tourists. In particular, the World Masters Games attract more affluent sections of society (Gratton et al. 2001). Event organizers generally need to be more aware of the important roles of travel and events for sport participants (Getz & McConnell, 2011). Specifically, sport events are shaped by both participants and the host city/community as the event organizer. In other words, understanding sport event careers requires studying not only the behavior of sport tourists but also the sport event organization's strategy for bringing social and economic benefits to the host community.

Bundling Sport Events and Leveraging

Crompton's motivation theory (1979) involves the concepts of push and pull, which the author discussed in relation to tourists' motivation. Crompton explained pull factors as cultural destination motives that include novelty and education. In the same vein, Chalip and Guirty (2004) observed that sporting events are combined with other attractions and activities offered at the host destination. Guiltinan (1987) noted that "bundling is the practice of marketing

two or more products and/or services in a single 'package' for a special price" (p. 74). The researcher explained this with the example of a weekend hotel package combining lodging and some meals for one price. With regard to sports tourism marketing, Nogawa et al. (2004) identified the importance of tourist attractions in separating sport tourists from other tourists. They called these "supplemental attractions" and noted the importance of segmentation for determining the preferred attractions of the target market. Higham (2005) noted that sport functions as a tourist attraction and has the potential to attract a variety of people in different ways. Specifically, participants in sporting events may visit other places, leading to enhanced destination marketing for the sporting event.

In the same vein, Weed and Bull (2009) called this "supplemental sports tourism". They explained that sport tourism is part of a trip and an important factor in the trip decision-making process. Buning and Gibson (2015) noted that destination managers must understand the attitudes and behaviors of non-participant travel companions, which can have an important effect on active event tourists. Tourism attraction is one of the crucial factors in destination management. Additionally, Hinch and Higham (2015) noted that planners of tourism activities must consider that commercial exchange due to tourism is a business and that related industries or governments expect it to have an economic impact. The concept of exchange is based on MacCannell (1976), who explained that tourists want authentic and demystifying experiences through travel. More recently, Getz (2008) discussed event travel careers and examined the intrinsic motivation to travel for sporting events as part of a lifelong career. Thus, tourists visit some places for experience with a primary travel purpose at each level and travel career.

In terms of leveraging sport events, Chalip and Leyns (2002) asserted that a leveraging strategy has the potential to increase the total level of visitor spending. Chalip (2004) also explored immediate event leveraging and long-term leveraging. The two types of leveraging have different characteristics, and this theory must use a portfolio approach with destinations. According to Ziakas (2014), there is cross-leveraging among the community, the economy, and sport that can foster synergies among them. Misener et al. (2015) noted there are many relationships in event leveraging, resulting in social, cultural, environmental, political, economic, or sport-related impacts. Specifically, Kelly and Fairley (2018) reported mutual benefits between event and tourism organizations through partnerships or collaborations, while Taks and Teare (2022) noted a lack of necessary skills and resources toward leverage sport events. Similarly, Chalip and Costa (2005) indicated the importance of considering a destination's mix of products and services. Gibson et al. (2012) noted the importance of the triple bottom line in understanding the impact of sport and tourism. They also indicated the need to pay attention to the influence of the surrounding environment on sport and tourism. Regarding the social sustainability of non-mega sport events, Taks (2013) noted that such

events have more positive social impact and outcomes than mega sport events. Small- to medium-sized sport events have the capability to be "big fish in many small ponds". Additionally, Xu et al. (2016) indicated that a bundling event strategy can create a synergistic effect. Moreover, a hallmark sporting event has the possibility to promote sustainable development of regional tourism. The sporting event could be integrated with sightseeing spots, culture, accommodation, and so on (Lu, 2021). Overall, an event is a simple product. However, there are many related dimensions of host communities. Thus, event research should consider the surrounding environment to foster community development with events.

Segmentation of Leisure Behavior

Segmentation is an important step in understanding the attitudes and behaviors of sport event participants. Marketing segmentation can use the effective marketing strategies of product or service improvement to enhance satisfaction (Füller & Matzler, 2008). Gibson (2004) called gender, class, and race the "big three" in the analysis of sport tourism. Getz (2003) also indicated the importance of age and gender in shaping demand for events. The life stage concept has affected leisure activities and preferences. Some have studied the differences attributable to these sociodemographic factors (e.g., Miller & Brown, 2005; Freysinger Shaw et al., 2013). Some other factors related to social psychology can explain the segmentation of leisure behavior. For instance, Havitz et al. (2013) reported the effectiveness of participant segmentation. Filo et al. (2013) applied the psychological continuum model (PCM) to assess the sport tourist's destination involvement. They reported that progressive development of the destination involvement was an increasingly high place attachment and revisit intensions. Kyle et al. (2002) also noted that the involvement of runners can use segmentation and that this information provides event managers with detailed information on participants' attitudes and behaviors.

In terms of activity-based segmentation, Mumuni and Mansour (2014) used cluster analysis and reported characteristics of each cluster, such as different sociodemographic profiles and vacation travel preferences. As an aspect of active sport tourism, Gibson (1998) noted the importance of dividing sport tourists. A high level of commitment is one of the important factors when predicting tourism behavior in sport events. Funk et al. (2007) investigated individual difference factors such as culture leading to travel motivation in a hallmark Australian sport event. Namely, they found that the event organizers need to pay attention to cultural backgrounds of the event participants. In particular, the culture of the country in an international sport event could be considered with travel motivation and experience for event participants. Additionally, Terzic' et al. (2021) studied the tourist segmentation in Europe through the model of human values. They indicated the valuable of human

values for explain the motivation in sport- and tourism-related choices. Thus, the segmentation of leisure participants can use not only sociodemographic but also social psychological factors as independent variables.

Overall, there are many studies related to supplemental attractions. However, this study examines the preference of sporting event participants in travel areas such as Tokyo and Hiroshima. Furthermore, this study explores the types of preferred travel sites, such as shrines and night spots, before and after participation in a sporting event. This research has the potential to contribute a new perspective in the field of sport tourism. Specifically, this study contributes by discussing the new dimensions of flow-on tourism and bundling sporting events for participants.

Research Questions

Sport events are events for not only sports but also the host community through finding ways to complement the sport event to develop sports and tourism. In this way, Chalip and Leyns (2002) asserted that event organizers need to cultivate an appealing atmosphere and good relations with the host community to enhance the event. Thus, research on the behavior of sport tourists must investigate the current status of tourism behavior before and after the event. Its findings can be used in destination marketing strategies to create a synergistic effect between sports and tourism.

This case study proposes two research questions. First, sport tourists have motivations that include visiting primary, secondary, and tertiary attractions, as noted by Higham and Hinch (2018). Of course, sporting opportunities are the primary motivation to travel, but sport tourists also find opportunities to visit supplemental attractions (Nogawa et al., 2004; Weed & Bull, 2009) and engage in flow-on tourism (Taks et al., 2009). Previous studies have identified gender, generation, and nationality differences in such patterns. In terms of gender, Wang et al. (2016) reported meaningful differences in men's and women's travel motivations and responses to advertising with regard to cognitive image. There are also differences based on generation (e.g., Huagn & Lu, 2017) and cultural dimensions (e.g., Huang & Crotts, 2019). Gibson (2005) indicated the need to examine how gender, age, class, and race influence experiences. Leisure, which includes sport and tourism, is one of the major domains in human social science (Rozin, 2001). Specifically, sport and tourism have the potential to present indigenous culture. In the context of sport tourism, Funk and Bruun (2007) identified the role of culture in the context of international sporting events. Two research questions in this case study are as follows:

- Based on sociodemographic factors, what sort of supplemental attractions would participants of the World Rafting Championship look for while staying in Japan?

- How does cultural experience influence sport tourists' interest in supplemental attractions in the case of the World Rafting Championship in Japan?

Method

The event under study began in 1989 as a world championship (International Rafting Federation, n.d.). The championship involves four events: Sprint, Head-to-Head (H2H), Slalom, and Downriver. The events are divided into the following four categories: open men and women (over 15 years old), master men and women (over 40 years old), junior men and women (under 23 years old), and youth men and women (under 19 years old). Generally, the open class tends to include top athletes. However, some national master's teams include experienced water sports athletes. The data collection was carried out at the World Rafting Championship in Tokushima, Japan. This event lasted seven days and took place in October 2017. The river where the event took place is located 2 hours and 30 minutes from Tokyo by airplane and car.

Sample

We distributed a self-administered questionnaire and collected data from 318 participants (520 people from 22 countries participated in this event, as shown in Table 13.1, according to the Miyoshi City Tourism Association, 2017). The questionnaire was in English only due to the use of English as a standard language in the 2017 championship. All of the announcements, such as the race information for events, were in English. Thus, this case study used an English questionnaire. Data were collected from athletes in the waiting area for the championship and in a waiting area before the closing ceremony.

Questionnaire

In terms of measurements, this case study referred to Nogawa et al. (2004) and Kudo and Nogawa (2004), who established supplemental sites, as shown in Table 13.2. The items for supplemental sites such as Tokyo and Kansai were derived from the Lonely Planet guide to tourism areas for foreign tourists (2013), as shown in Table 13.3. The items for the supplemental areas and sites used multiple-choice questions, as in Kudo and Nogawa (2004). In terms of data analysis, the items for supplemental sites and data were transformed to a binary (yes or no) scale to count the number of respondents. This case study also applied three items from Funk and Bruun (2007) to investigate athletes' cultural experiences in Japan. These items used a 7-point Likert scale from 1: strongly disagree to 7: strongly agree. Regarding group categorization, this case study used a synthetic variable to represent three groups of cultural experiences. The results were as follows: 18.27 for average, 3.80 for standard

Table 13.1 The List of Participating Countries

Region	*Country*	*Masters*		*Open*		*Junior (U23)*		*Youth (U19)*	
		Men	*Women*	*Men*	*Women*	*Men*	*Women*	*Men*	*Women*
Central & South America	Argentine Republic	○		○		○		○	
Oceania	Australia			○					
Central & South America	Brazil	○		○					
North America	Canada			○	○				
Central & South America	Costa Rica	○		○	○			○	
Europe	Czech Republic	○	○	○	○	○	○		
Europe	Germany			○					
Asia	Indonesia	○	○		○	○	○	○	○
Europe	Italy			○	○				
Asia	Mongolia			○					
Asia	Nepal			○					
Europe	Netherland			○	○				
Oceania	New Zealand	○	○		○	○			○
Europe	Norway				○				
Europe	Russian	○		○	○	○	○	○	○
Europe	Slovak Republic					○			
Europe	Republic of Slovenia			○					
Europe	Turkey					○		○	
Asia	United Arab Emirates (UAE)			○					
Europe	United Kingdom	○		○	○	○	○	○	○
North America	The United States of America	○		○	○	○	○		

Recourse: Official participants list of International Rafting Federation.

deviation, and 20.00 for median. Thus, the scores of culture experience tended to be high. Finally, the item sums were used to divide the participants into three groups: respondents with 21 points were in the high group, respondents with 17 to 19 points were in the medium group, and respondents with

Table 13.2 Supplemental Sites of the Event

• Historic Sites	• Amusement	• Natural scenery
• Museums	• Shopping	• Sport Facilities
• Gourmet	• Shirin & Temples	• Night spots
• Other Japanese Rivers	• Others	

Note. This item modified from Nogawa, H., Yuda, A., & Kudo,Y. (2004).

Table 13.3 Supplemental Areas

• Tokyo	• Mt Fuji & Around Tokyo
• The Japan Alps & Central Honshu	• Kyoto
• Kansai	• Hiroshima & Western Honshu
• Northern Honshu	• Sapporo & Hokkaido
• Shikoku (exclude Tokushima)	• Kyushu
• Okinawa & southwest islands	

Note. This item uses the categories of Lonely Planet of Japan (2013).

fewer than 15 points were in the low group, which was less interested in tourism than the other groups.

Data Analyses

Data analysis consisted of three steps and was conducted via SPSS 24.00. First, a t-test and one-way ANOVA were conducted to determine the number of visits to supplemental areas and sites based on sociodemographic characteristics, such as gender, age, nationality, and the number of participants in the World Rafting Championship. Second, this case study utilized t-tests or one-way ANOVA to analyze how gender, generation, the area of the participating country, and race rafting career influence sport tourists' interest in supplemental attractions (RQ 1). Third, to answer RQ 2, this case study applied a one-way ANOVA to test how cultural experience influences sport tourists' interest in supplemental attractions.

Results

The results indicate that 57% (n = 180) of the respondents were male, 38% (n = 121) were female, and unknown were 5% (n = 17). Their average age was 40.58 years old. The majority of the respondents were office workers (74%, n = 182). Their average length of stay in Japan was approximately two weeks. The data on the respondents excluded Japanese participants and staff and coaches to focus on foreign athletes. Approximately 82% of the participants were visiting Japan for the first time. This case study investigated the relationship between supplemental sites/areas and demographic characteristics. In terms of sex, there was

no meaningful difference between male and female respondents (supplemental sites: $t = 1.65$, df = 299, *n.s.*; supplemental areas: $t = 0.66$, df = 299, *n.s.*). The results were similar among the age groups (under 19, 20s, 30s, and over 40) (F (3,314) = 1.41, *n.s.*; F (3,314) = 2.30, *n.s.*). Thus, there were no meaningful differences among the groups based on sex or generation (Tables 13.4 and 13.5).

The geographical areas were classified as follows: Africa, Asia, Europe, North America, Central and South America, and Oceania. There was a meaningful difference in the supplemental sites visited based on global area of residence (F (4,295) = 7.45, $p < 0.001$). In particular, there was a meaningful difference among participants from North America ($M = 3.85$), Asia ($M = 2.33$), Europe ($M = 2.29$), and Central/South America ($M = 2.03$) based on Tukey's post hoc comparisons. However, the supplemental areas visited showed no differences (F (4,295) = 2.30, *n.s.*). There was also no meaningful difference between first-time visitors and repeat visitors to Japan in the supplemental sites visited ($t = 1.22$, df = 312, *n.s.*) or supplemental areas visited ($t = 0.10$, df = 312, *n.s.*) (Tables 13.6 and 13.7).

Some scholars have indicated that tourism and leisure behavior are affected by cultural background (Funk & Bruun, 2007; Walker & Wang, 2008; Sheldon & Fox, 1988; Reisinger & Turner, 1998). The results for the relationship between the Japanese cultural experience and visits to supplemental attractions were

Table 13.4 The Relationship between Gender and Supplemental Attractions

	Male (n = 180)		*Female (n = 121)*		*t*	*P*
	M	*SD*	*M*	*SD*		
Supplement sites	2.72	(1.91)	2.38	(1.52)	1.65	n.s.
Supplement areas	1.65	(1.54)	1.77	(1.47)	0.66	n.s.

Note. n.s.: not significant, there were 17 missing data.

Table 13.5 The Relationship between Ages and Supplemental Attractions

	Under 19 (n = 161)		*20's (n = 64)*		*30's (n=72)*		*Over 40 (n=21)*		*F*	*P*
	M	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*		
Supplement sites	2.37	(1.81)	2.73	(1.88)	2.67	(1.68)	2.00	(1.45)	1.41	n.s.
Supplement areas	1.84	(1.65)	1.59	(1.20)	1.20	(1.51)	1.67	(1.49)	2.30	n.s.

Note. n.s.: not significant.

Table 13.6 The Relationship between Supplemental Attractions and Region of Participants

	Asia (*n* = 60)		*Oceania* (*n* = 30)		*Europe* (*n* = 136)		*North America* (*n* = 35)		*Central & SouthAmerica* (*n* = 39)		*F*	*P*
	M	(*SD*)	*M*	(*SD*)	*M*	(*SD*)	*M*	(*SD*)	*M*	(*SD*)		
Supplement sites	2.33	(189)	3.00	(1.53)	2.29	(1.69)	3.85	(1.80)	*2.03*	(1.60)	7.45	***
Supplement areas	1.80	(1.14)	1.60	(1.35)	1.78	(1.60)	1.89	(1.60)	1.05	(0.60)	2.30	n.s.

Note. ***: $p < 0.001$, n.s.: not significant, there were 18 missing.

Table 13.7 The Relationship between Supplemental Attractions and First Visitor/ Repeater of Japan

	First visitor (*n* = 256)		*Repeater* (*n* = 58)		*t*	*P*
	M	*SD*	*M*	*SD*		
Supplement sites	2.72	(1.80)	1.67	(1.51)	1.22	n.s.
Supplement areas	2.24	(1.67)	1.69	(1-40)	0.10	n.s.

Note. ns: not significant, there were 4 missing data.

meaningful for different aspects of the supplemental sites ($F = 5.16$ (2,272), $p < 0.01$). Tukey's post hoc comparisons revealed differences of 1% between the low ($M = 1.85$) and the medium ($M = 2.66$) culture experience groups and of 5% between the low and the high ($M = 2.62$) cultural experience groups. Specifically, interest in Japanese culture was related to the supplemental attractions visited, such as historical sites near the sporting event area. However, there was no meaningful difference in the number of supplemental attractions visited according to cultural experience ($F = 0.20$ (2,272), *n.s.*) because the area where the rafting championship was held is far from Tokyo and other areas. The event organizers chartered a shuttle bus service from the event city to the international airport in Kansai (shown in Table 13.8).

Discussion

This case study aimed to explore the types of supplemental attractions the participants in the World Rafting Championship would visit while staying in Japan. This case study also aimed to explore the influence of sociodemographic background and cultural experience on the types of supplemental attractions. Specifically, this case study focused on foreign participants in the World Rafting Championship for lessons of destination branding in Japan.

Table 13.8 The Relationship between Supplemental Attractions and the Level of Cultural Experience

	Lower level (*n* =67)		*Middle level* (*n* =77)		*Higher level* (*n* = 131)		*F*	*P*
	M	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*		
Supplement sites	1.85	(1.55)	2.66	(1.94)	2.62	(1.70)	5.16	**
Supplement areas	1.76	(1.68)	1.68	(1.53)	1.63	(1.38)	0.20	n.s.

Note. ** $p < 0.01$, n.s.: not significant.

The current study proposed the first research question as follows: based on sociodemographic factors, what types of supplemental attractions would the participants of the World Rafting Championship visit while staying in Japan? The findings of this research provide a current picture of supplemental tourism before, during, and after the Rafting World Championship in Japan. There was a difference in tourism behavior related to sociodemographics, such as participants' region of origin. In particular, the participants from North America had the highest scores, and those from Central and South America had the lowest scores. This finding could be the result of different factors, such as length of stay in Japan and travel budget. On the other hand, no meaningful differences among participants based on region were shown for supplemental attractions. In terms of gender, age, and racing career, there were no significant differences. Gibson (2005) indicated the influence of sociodemographic characteristics. In a previous study, Wang et al. (2016) reported the difference in gender in the context of expectations towards a travel destination. However, Japan has a very traditional and unique culture. Most of the event participants, Western and non-Western, were potentially interested in Japan and Japanese culture. Approximately 65% of the research respondents were from Western countries. The participants' countries of origin might affect the study results. Overall, many participants in the Rafting World Championship might be interested in supplemental attractions without the influence of sociodemographic characteristics.

The second research question was whether cultural experience affects sport tourists' interest in supplemental attractions in the World Rafting Championship in Japan. This case study did not find meaningful differences in the supplemental areas visited despite a significant difference in the supplemental sites. The research focused on international tourists at a sporting event. There are several factors affecting foreigners' travel to rural areas in Japan, including a lack of information on supplemental sites and areas. However, there were significant differences between the middle and low groups and the high and low groups in the level of culture experience in supplemental sites. This result supported Funk and Bruun (2007). Thus, cultural experience is an important factor in understanding international participants in sport events.

The venue for this event was in a rural area of Japan, and participants might not have obtained enough tourism information to prompt visits, even though there was information available online in English. Tourism agencies need to learn how to attract tourists from other countries. Such practices could alleviate language constraints in Japan. On the other hand, sporting locations could provide a source of affection for participants (Bale, 2003). Aşan and Emeksiz (2018) reported that participation in outdoor recreation is linked to the vacation tourism market. Thus, the majority of sport event participants may be interested in the host venue and supplemental areas and adopt a similar tourism style. This case study supported some of these perspectives.

Funk and Bruun (2007) studied the differences in motivation to participate in sporting events based on the cultural backgrounds of similar or dissimilar groups. The results revealed some differences between the two groups. The results of this case study support their results. Culture has been connected with the human mind (Kashima, 2000). Thus, cultural differences might lead to differences in the tourism attitudes and behaviors of international tourists. In terms of flow-on tourism, Buning and Gibson (2015) reported meaningful differences among types of tours in cycling tourists–related destination preferences. The results of this case study did not show meaningful differences in some sociodemographic information. This might be caused by differences between individual and team sports. The race rafting participants tended to visit as teams. Thus, no effects of sociodemographics on flow-on tourism were found. In addition, approximately 82% of the participants were first-time visitors to Japan, which could affect the similarities in the results.

Regarding the practical implications, most participants were interested in and visited Japanese sites and areas. This finding can be useful in developing strategies for tourism promotion. There might be differences and similarities in attitudes and behaviors towards tourism across nationalities and geographic areas. Thus, event organizers and tourism agencies need to segment and understand the motivations of international sporting event participants to promote secondary or tertiary attractions. In particular, this research used a case study of a small, international one-time sporting event in a rural area to provide a reference for event organizers. According to the report on international marketing of sport tourism of the Japan Sport Agency (2018), most respondents were interested in outdoor sports such as skiing, snowboarding, and mountain climbing. However, they indicated issues related to the language barrier and rules or manners in Japanese society. Small, onetime sporting events in rural areas need to consider these issues more than large sporting events in urban areas do.

In particular, there are many traditional and modern cultural attractions in Japan, not only in metropolitan areas such as Tokyo and Kyoto but also in rural areas such as those near hot springs, shrines/temples, and mountains. Getz (2003) reported five factors that affect travelers' event-related purchases or trips, including uniqueness and learning. Uniqueness refers to opportunities to

experience something different, and learning refers to opportunities for authentic experiences. Destinations have many attractions for tourists and participants in sport events. Event organizers should consider participants' needs and wants as well as time, skills, goods, and services when providing tourism experiences (Andersson, 2007). Studying supplemental tourism, or flow-on tourism, can also help better understand the relationships among host destinations, events, and the consumers who patronize them, as noted by Taks et al. (2009). Organizers need to understand visitors' intentions and interest in tourism activities beyond the event, as these concepts suggest. This leads to the idea of Getz (2008) regarding the necessity of considering event characteristics in formulating event strategies. In this case, the Rafting World Championship is an international, onetime, rural, and small-/mid-sized sport event. These characteristics are important for managing sport events and supplemental tourism and flow-on tourism.

Furthermore, participants in these types of sporting events fall under the hard definition of sport tourism proposed by Gammon and Robinson (2003). Most of the participants in this case study were not professional athletes. Thus, this case study's use of the segmentation of sports events may help organizers understand the characteristics of participants in various types of events. In addition, the framework of sport tourism must consider each country and region (Robinson & Gammon, 2004). The research site of this case study requires consideration of information on sport tourists participating in race rafting and tourists involved in commercial rafting. Furthermore, some types of segmentation are useful for understanding leisure behavior and attitudes. On the other hand, leisure and recreation can be segmented in various ways, such as by leisure seriousness and recreation specialization. Amateur athletes have a varied profile with respect to specialization versus diversification (Anderson & Getz, 2020). Event organizers should classify the type of participants in each event.

There are some research limitations to this case study that resulted from the descriptive statistics. Future studies should indicate explanatory results and investigate how to develop rural communities through outdoor recreation and sport research. Research should also evaluate residents' perspectives on community development. This research topic could help revitalize rural community development through outdoor recreation and sport. Regarding the research method, this research used only the English version of the questionnaire because it would have otherwise been necessary to prepare at least ten versions for the different teams. Future research should ensure that participants correctly understand the meaning of the questions. The level of understanding of the questionnaire is important when collecting data from participants at international sporting events. This case study could not collect data from Japanese participants because some of the Japanese team members lived in the area of the sporting event. Future research could compare international and Japanese participants. Additionally, the sample sizes were too

imbalanced and small. The International Rafting Federation website states that it has a membership of 50 countries. This was a small international sport event. However, data collection in future research must pay attention to sample size and balance for the analysis. Finally, COVID-19 is now spreading all over the world. International tourism faces serious and complex challenges. Thus, researchers and practitioners in the field of sport tourism must explore tourists' attitudes and behaviors after the COVID-19 pandemic. Furthermore, they need to develop strategies for flow-on/supplemental tourism.

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Chapter 14

Sport Migration Influences on Cultural Brand Image

A Quantitative World-Systems Analysis

William Crossan and Tomas Ruda

Introduction

Each year in May Czechs gather in pubs and city squares, crowding around TVs to watch their nation compete in the IIHF World Ice Hockey Championships. Achieving anything less than a medal is considered failure, a blow to national pride, extolling a tax on the national brand. The furor is so great that in the weeks leading up to the championships, including the first week of the competition, Czechs looks to the NHL, anxious to see which of their players have been eliminated from the Stanley Cup playoffs. Such eliminations free the players up to join the national team. Czech hockey fans devote almost as much attention to these exported players as they do to the actual performance of the national team. In contrast, in the fall of 2020, the Czech national baseball team traveled to Italy for the final round of the WBSC Baseball Europe/Africa Qualifier, where a finish in the finals would secure their identity as the only team sport from the Czech Republic to qualify for the 2020 Olympic Games, boosting the brand recognition of baseball in the country. With very little media coverage, the Czech team, led by their Canadian coach and a single MLB minor league player, finished third and narrowly missed qualifying for the Olympics. As seen in these two examples, globalization and sport migration have both parallel and divergent ascendancy on sports brand both within and between cultures.

In this chapter, we illustrate how the push and pull factors of migration flux in conjunction with Wallerstein's World-Systems theory as well as the cultural order of individual sports in a nation (Shannon, 2018; Wallerstein, 1990, 1993). The cultural order of sports in a nation is a battle for relational space between a people, a place, and a sport; thus, for national sport federations, properly reading and utilizing sport migration flows is a matter of brand management. By sport migration, we are referring to the voluntary movement of athletes, as highly skilled labor. This type of sport migration has been referred to in previous literature as sport labor migration, or sports as migration (Agergaard et al., 2023). Using regression analysis and correlations, we compare the effects of sport migration across the four sports of football, ice hockey,

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basketball, and baseball over 21 years in the Czech Republic. The effects of sport imports and exports are compared between sports at the national level and league level, in relation to competitive balance, league attendance, registered players, and international rankings over time. Understanding the direct and indirect effects of migration with regard to the relationship between core/periphery and cultural sport migration can assist federations in creating policy, as well as teams in determining strategy for maintaining competitive balance, each contributing to brand management.

Within Czech sporting culture we have identified football and ice hockey as primary sports, meaning they receive the predominant media attention and are most closely associated with national identity and cultural brand image. Consequently, these two sports also have significantly higher numbers of registered players than other sports. Basketball is classified as a secondary sport in the culture, meaning it has high levels of participation amongst the public, and competitions are contested on a professional level throughout the country, but has much more limited media coverage than the primary sports. Baseball, the final sport in our study, is classified as a developing sport in the culture; there is a professional league, but participation levels and media coverage are significantly lower than the primary and secondary sports. These categories of primary, secondary and developing are imperative to interpreting sport through World-Systems theory. These categories also help us understand the brand image of each sport within the nation. In the previous 21 years, increases in Czechs participating in all four of these sports as exports were between two- and six-fold, while increases in foreigners coming into the top Czech leagues ranged from 70% to nine-fold. Thus, it is axiomatic for national federations, leagues, and teams to garner a firm understanding of this phenomenon if they are to maintain or increase the demand for the sport brand they steward.

Review of Literature

Sport migration has been salient for many years, but it remains inconsistent based on location and cultural sport position, while continuing to increase both quantifiably and across wider geographic distances. Each sport is battling for fans and youth participants, but from different starting points depending on the primary, secondary, or developing nature of the sport in the given culture. Carter (2011b), and Poli (2010), identify structural inequalities within and between countries which contribute to much of the global flow of migrants. Understanding World-Systems theory can prove helpful to the sport manager in both interpreting and proactively anticipating these migration developments for sport growth. Sport position within and between cultures contributes to nation branding and the cultural image of the sport as a brand. Sport managers as such are battling for brand position internationally, within the nation, and between teams, with sporting migrants flowing multi-directionally at each level.

World-Systems Theory

The World-Systems theory identifies push and pull factors stemming from global socioeconomic power relations (Chepyator-Thomson & Ariyo, 2016; Cornelissen & Solberg, 2007). Wallerstein distinguished between core and periphery regions, as well as semi-periphery and external regions outside the system (1993). Between core, semi-periphery, and periphery exist relationships of dominance and subordination. The countries which benefit most from the global economy lie at the world's core, and through international trade, other countries are maintained in a subordinate position. The main goal of countries at the core is to maximize profits through business beyond their domestic economies. This is evidenced when English Premier League football is broadcast to 212 territories worldwide, netting the UK $5 billion from 2016 to 2019 (Curley & Roeder, 2016). The semi-periphery regions are composed of ambitious states trying to improve their situation in the world division of labor by supplying products hoping eventually to obtain positions of industrial producers. Bond et al. (2018) illustrate how Brazil has emerged as the world's central producer of football players, while still remaining in the economic semi-periphery of the world system. Periphery regions primarily serve as suppliers of core raw materials. This has been illustrated repeatedly through the stripping of African football talent (Darby, 2007b; Schokkaert, 2016), or Kenyan distance runners (Bale & Sang, 2013; Chepyator-Thomson & Ariyo, 2016).

One approach in applying the World-Systems theory is to examine countries and migration in relationship to GDP. This was done by Hoffmann et al. (2002) who examined 76 countries in relationship to their population, GDP and FIFA World Cup Success. They found no linear relationship between these variables, and that GDP, in and of itself, is not sufficient for explaining football success. This can be evidenced by looking at football in China, India, or the United States. Another important characteristic of the World-Systems theory as described by Bale (2002), describing the geographic diffusion of football, is that it diffuses from the world core to the periphery, while the workforce flows in the opposite direction. Application of this concept is not confined to the spatial diffusion of sport. If so, the representation of a sport contest (e.g. a media image) would be considered as the final product intended for consumption, and the player only as one of the raw materials necessary for production. According to this understanding, the countries at the core should be capable of producing and exporting sports products, e.g. television broadcasts. On the contrary, states on the sport semi-periphery and periphery should play the role of producers of raw materials, thus ensuring the production of player talent. Therefore, the specific means of domination in the world sport system can be considered, in addition to the system of trading players, the dominance of the sport's core by the modern media and the power distribution by international governing

bodies (Carter, 2011a; Cornelissen & Solberg, 2007). A World-Systems approach here thus often parallels and explains historical relationships (such as colonialism), and therefore where migrants go (Crossan, 2020; Crossan & Ruda, 2019; Darby, 2007a; Lanfranchi & Taylor, 2001).

In terms of GDP, the Czech Republic was classified as periphery at the beginning of this study (Chase-Dunn et al., 2000), and progressed to semi-periphery by the midpoint of the study (Nielsen, 2011). Examining the Czech Republic in terms of GDP per capita, the country is ranked 35th (The World Bank, 2018). Similarly, the Czech football world ranking, puts them in the 45th place (April 2020), and the average FIFA world ranking since the ranking's creation, in 20th place (FIFA, 2020). In contrast, the Czech ice hockey team is ranked fifth in the world in April 2020, while the average position since the ranking was created in 2003 is fourth (IIHF, 2020).

Considering the data above, the football world ranking corresponds with the World-System, but placing the Czech Republic in the semi-periphery is divergent from the ice hockey world ranking, where the Czechs are among the core. Thus, as GDP is insufficient in and of itself for applying World System's theory to sport, even limiting our evaluation to primary sports, we will attempt to define the sport world system in terms of country and league sport rankings within the world order of each sport.

***Football*:** Magee and Sugden (2002) place the core of football in Western Europe, with production emanating from the English Premier League, Spanish La Liga, German Bundesliga, France's Ligue 1, and Italy's Serie A. The top producers of football resources (players) are Brazil, France, Argentina, and Serbia (Poli et al., 2017). The top Czech league ranks 15th in Europe, and 38th as a player resourcer (Poli et al., 2017), placing Czech football in the semi-periphery of global football. As shown by Crossan and Ruda (2019) Czech exports players to core and semi-periphery football countries, while importing primarily from periphery and semi-periphery.

***Ice Hockey*:** The core of ice hockey production emanates from the USA's NHL, followed by the Russian dominated KHL. Ice hockey has a significantly lower global consumption than football or basketball. The top producers of ice hockey players are Canada, the USA, Russia, Sweden, Finland, and the Czech Republic. The top Czech league is 5th in Europe (Champions League Hockey, 2019), and the Czech Republic is the 5th largest resourcer of international ice hockey talent (*QuantHockey*, 2020). As such, the Czech Republic is a core producer of ice hockey talent, exporting relatively high numbers of top players to the core leagues, and importing primarily from other core ice hockey countries as well as some semi-periphery nations (Crossan, 2020; Crossan & Ruda, 2019).

***Basketball*:** In terms of the World-Systems theory, basketball is firmly seated at the core, with the USA's NBA importing the best players from around

the world as well as dominating production through broadcasting deals in 215 countries in 2019–2020 (Murray, 2019). Not only that, the USA produces the most players for teams around the world (*Usbasket*, 2020). The Czech Republic sits in the periphery of the basketball world system, with only five players ever making it to the NBA, and consistently relying on second-tier, surplus Americans to lead their top league (Crossan & Pecha, 2016), which ranks 12th in Europe (*Eurobasket*, 2020). So, we can say the secondary sport of basketball in the Czech Republic is at the periphery, exporting to the semi-periphery, while importing from the core and semi-periphery.

***Baseball*:** The Czech Republic is decidedly in the periphery of international baseball, a sport whose core sits in two of the top three GDP countries in the world: the USA's MLB and Japan's Nippon league. The top producers of baseball labor, after the top countries where it is played, are South Korea and many countries from the global periphery of South and Central America. The Czech Republic has yet to export its talent to either of the top world leagues, averaging one player a year exported to the MLB's minor leagues and two players in history making it to Japan's minor league. Yet, in a baseball-poor Europe, the Czech Republic fares well, consistently placing in the top five alongside the Netherlands, Italy, Spain, and Germany (*Baseballeurope*, 2019). Czech baseball imports players from the core and semi-periphery (though from their lower-quality surplus), while exporting a very low number of players to lower-level leagues at baseball's core.

Within this grid of cultural sport position (primary, secondary, or developing), and World-Systems theory (core, semi-periphery, and periphery) we endeavor to locate each of these four Czech sports, examining parallel and divergent migration effects on each sport at a national level and a league level. Based on past sport migration research, which most often only examined one sport, and did not place that sport within both the cultural and World-Systems grid, four previously measured quantifiable variables have been identified: world or international ranking, number of registered players, competitive balance, and fan attendance.

World Rankings

Assessing sport migration per its effect on world rankings is not a new concept, as Maguire used it in some of his earliest research on the topic (1994, 1996). World rankings are most affected by national team performance at world championship and Olympic events; thus, when a nation is ranked in a sport year after year at or near the top of the world rankings, the sport becomes part of the cultural brand of the nation. Maguire argued that periphery African nations often saw decreases in the performances of their national teams with

the players' increased obligations to their European teams, who were paying them more (1994). Citing Italian football (Maguire, 1994), and British ice hockey (Maguire, 1996), he argues that while import players may bring short-term gains in national team performance, long-term dependence on these players at the league level leads to the underdevelopment of young national players for the national team.

By contrast, using quantitative data, world rankings have been used more recently to show that when national team players play in higher leagues outside their nations, there is a strong correlation with positive national team performance (Berlinschi et al., 2013; Gelade & Dobson, 2007; Omondi-Ochieng, 2018). Baur & Lehmann (2007) examined the 32 nations competing in the 2006 FIFA World Cup and found that higher ratios of both exports and imports directly correlated with world rankings. The GDP of the origin or destination of football migrants, however, did not significantly contribute to explanation of FIFA world rankings (Baur & Lehmann, 2007). Conversely, Alvarez et al. (2011) found that basketball imports in national leagues contributed positively to international team success in a study examining 20 years of European basketball in 47 countries. They argued that since most of the imports in European basketball are coming from the USA, where they are not good enough to play in the top NBA teams or on the US national team, this excess production of talent benefits nations which are not at the core of the basketball world system (Alvarez et al., 2011). Such findings would primarily benefit sporting semi-periphery and periphery nations.

Registered Players and Youth

Maguire quoted proponents of the use of Canadian players in British ice hockey who desired to make the league more attractive to sponsors and media, while presenting youth with role models "to spur the development of indigenous talent" (Maguire, 1996, p. 347). Then using quotes from individual players, he demonstrates how the use of such import players had the exact opposite effect, discouraging young players from continuing to play as they saw foreigners used in their top leagues rather than nationals. His conclusions, however, do not reflect the placement of the sport in the cultural or world system.

By comparison, Njororai (2012) illustrates how Kenyan success in athletics contributed first to increases in migration, then mass participation. He shows how the economic position of the country coupled with international success of Kenyan athletes has led to increasing numbers of youth taking up the sport with the intention of migration in order to improve their economic condition. Others have identified Kenyan runners as part of the Kenyan national brand (Rein & Shields, 2007; Richelieu, 2018); thus, these young runners are taking up the sport with a goal of becoming brand ambassadors.

Competitive Balance

Competitive balance is of particular importance to league officials, as it has been shown to correlate highly with fan interest, league attendance, and revenues (Andreff & Scelles, 2015). High levels of league competitive balance contribute to brand prestige for the given national league. Further competitive balance has been shown to correlate well with the expansion of the market through the use of foreign players across sports and continents (Berri et al., 2005; Flores et al., 2010; Maxcy, 2002). There are, however, specifications to these findings, such as Addesa (2011) demonstrating that it was not the number of foreign players, but their quality which positively affected competitive balance. Additionally, Haan et al. (2012) found in studying European football that player mobility increased competitive balance in large countries, while decreasing it in the smaller nations.

Fan Attendance

Klein (1991) stated that in the Dominican Republic, where baseball is a primary sport using imported Americans from the baseball core, fans often showed little interest in the game. Similarly, Takahashi and Horne (2006), also analyzing baseball as a primary sport in Japan, stated that both fan attendance and TV viewing of the home league decreased as more Japanese players were exported to the US MLB. They argued that fans were more interested in seeing their star players playing at a higher level than in watching the lower-quality Japanese league (Takahashi & Horne, 2006). By contrast, Cornelissen and Solberg (2007) include fan attendance increases as one of the commercial factors that have increased congruently with athlete migration in European football. Frick (2007) found that fan attendance of the German Football Bundesliga was not affected by the increase of foreign players, nor by the decrease of German players in the league.

Method

The use of foreigners in the Czech Republic across the four sports of football, ice hockey, basketball, and baseball is studied from 1998 through 2019. Migration data is analyzed on two levels using correlations and regression analysis. Data are compared at the league level for effect on competitive balance, average fan attendance, and number of national players. The effects of migration are also examined at the federation level in relation to world rankings and registered players. Football and ice hockey are considered national sports: both sports have a very high level of registered players and also the most valued broadcasting rights. Basketball was chosen as a representative of cultural secondary sport. It is a traditional sport in the Czech Republic, ranked 9th in terms of the number of registered players (České Unie Sport, 2020),

and the broadcasting is less frequent and less valued than the two primary sports. The last chosen sport is baseball. This Olympic sport is very popular internationally, but considering the number of registered players (ranked 30th), and media coverage in the Czech Republic, baseball is considered as a developing sport.

The following variables were chosen for study: World ranking (WR), Registered players (RP), Registered youth players (up to age 19) (RY), Total number of Czech players playing outside the country (CPO), Total number of Czechs playing in the top Czech league (CTL), Total number of foreigners playing in the top Czech league (FPI), Competitive balance of the top Czech league (based on relative standard deviation) (CB), and Average attendance at top league games (AA). In order to be counted, players needed to be included on the team roster at the end of the regular season, and have played in at least one game that season.

Results and Discussion

When previously examined (Crossan & Ruda, 2019), it was found that the primary sports had larger numbers of imports and exports primarily due to their primacy. The primary sports of football and ice hockey produced a high level of talent who were in high demand across a wide spectrum of countries. These exports were replaced by equivalent talent from nations ranking lower in the sport hierarchy, and found to be less expensive than home-grown youth (Crossan & Ruda, 2019). Yet, a significant finding of the previous study was that the majority of imported talent (average 52% in football, and 76% in ice hockey) actually came from neighboring Slovakia which, while culturally very similar to Czech, still had lower-level national leagues and world rankings in their shared primary sports (Crossan & Ruda, 2019). Meanwhile, in the secondary sport of basketball and the developing sport of baseball, the imports originated from nations with higher national rankings than Czech, and were brought in by coaches and managers in an effort to gain a competitive advantage over their league competition. The Czech Republic rarely relied on neighboring Slovaks (average 17% in basketball, 7% in baseball).

Czechs Playing in the Top Czech League

Table 14.1 shows that football and ice hockey are played by many more Czech players in the highest Czech league (CTL) than the sports of basketball and baseball. Table 14.2 is important in understanding some of these differences as each sport has different size teams and league sizes also vary by sport. Additionally, the higher number of ice hockey players than football players is explained by larger ice hockey rosters and free substitutions, as compared smaller rosters and a maximum 14 players per match in football.

Table 14.1 Descriptive Statistics for the World Ranking Variables

N = 21 seasons	*Mean*	*SD*	*Maximum*	*Minimum*	R^2
CTL					
Football	364.1	33.13	411	277	0.609
Hockey	407.7	14.67	429	375	0.005
Basketball	133.4	17.63	165	95	0.186
Baseball	166.9	9.71	188	152	0.213
FPI					
Football	74.2	27.55	121	25	0.836
Hockey	62.9	21.69	96	18	0.901
Basketball	42.3	14.46	71	11	0.371
Baseball	21.7	13.18	46	5	0.828
CPO					
Football	88.1	36.84	146	29	0.165
Hockey	270.5	44.21	325	164	0.059
Basketball	52.2	23.45	100	8	0.201
Baseball	5.2	4.68	12	0	0.580
RP					
Football	453405.9	68742.15	550851	332966	0.036
Hockey	52104.2	8536.74	61982	33822	0.326
Basketball	34888.4	3296.19	44576	30735	0.148
Baseball	4418.1	1441.06	7744	3081	0.628
RY					
Football	139840.5	23402.09	188956	96638	0.066
Hockey	21679.2	3473.81	25598	14459	0.496
Basketball	17359.8	3042.93	24537	13244	0.148
Baseball	2348.3	771.09	4376	1466	0.362
AA					
Football	4876.1	575.96	6033	3840	0.010
Hockey	4842.1	419.16	5455	3980	0.581
Basketball	732.6	109.01	912	532	0.423
Baseball	109.4	17.47	134	81	0.089
CB					
Football	1.84	.21	2.22	1.42	0.402
Hockey	1.74	.43	2.58	.998	0.169
Basketball	2.43	.39	3.52	1.83	0.014
Baseball	2.41	.25	2.93	1.91	0.001
WR					
Football	18.9	13.18	46	2	0.654
Hockey	3.81	1.75	6	1	0.664
Basketball	46.21	12.93	61	21	0.643
Baseball	19.73	4.13	27	14	0.325

Note. R^2 is between time and the given variable.

Foreigners Playing in the Top Czech League

Table 14.1 shows that the most foreigners (FPI) play in primary sports, and less in secondary or developing sports. But if we look at the share of foreigners

Table 14.2 Czech League and Team Size

Sport	*Number of Teams*	*Average Roster Size*
Football	16	28.3
Hockey	14	36.5
Basketball	12	14.9
Baseball	8	23.0

compared to the total number of players, almost 25% of basketball players come from abroad, in contrast to 16% for football, 13% for ice hockey, and 11% for baseball. Additionally, the percentage of foreigners who are Slovak is much higher in the primary sports than the secondary. Table 14.1 also illustrates that FPI has the highest overall values of linear regression of all variables measured in every sport but basketball, indicating how rapidly the number of foreigners has grown over the period studied.

Czechs Playing Outside the Country

Table 14.1 also presents the total number of Czech athletes playing outside the country (CPO). The dominant cultural position of ice hockey in the Czech Republic explains its ranking as the number one exporter. This is understandable, considering that the Czech league is considered the 5th best league in the world, and the national team ranks 5th in the world. Other sports in the Czech Republic lag far behind ice hockey in these international standards. Now the effect of imports (FPI) and exports (CPO) on our other variables will be evaluated by correlation comparison between primary, secondary, and developing sports.

While both FPI and CPO increased across all sports over time (Figure 14.1), FPI increases were most significant in the primary sports (Football, .914, and Ice Hockey, .949). In the secondary sport of basketball, the growth was not as rapid (.609), most likely because the flow of imports started earlier (Crossan & Pecha, 2016). The developing sport of baseball had FPI interestingly correlated similarly to football over time (.910). The converse was true in terms of correlations with CPO (Figure 14.2) over time, where developing (baseball .762) leads secondary (basketball .448), and primary (football .407, ice hockey .242). These correlations mirror those of imports to exports (CPO to FPI), which shows that across all sports examined, foreigners are primarily being imported in order to replace the Czechs leaving to play in higher leagues of the core countries. The drain on talent from this semi-periphery country is most evident in football and basketball where the leagues are much weaker in the world system than that of ice hockey.

The developing sport of baseball presents a fascinating contrast to the other sports as it is the only sport studied which has positive correlations in all three

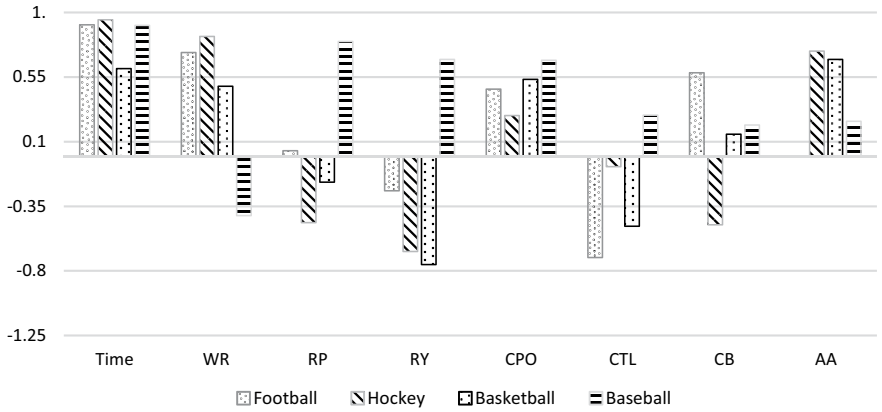


Figure 14.1 Correlation of Imports (FPI) on Other Variables.

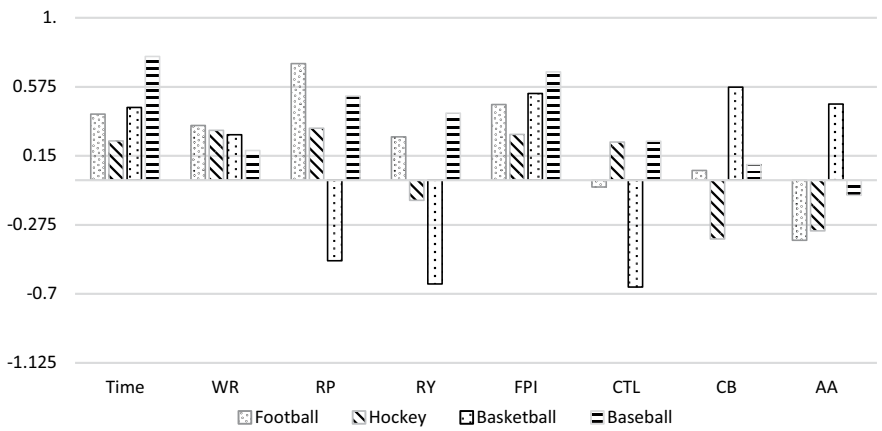


Figure 14.2 Correlation of Exports (CPO) on Other Variables.

labor categories (FPI to CPO .667, FPI to CTL .285, and CPO to CTL .240). While these second two correlations are weak, the positive correlations in all four confirm the status of the sport as developing and both flows of migration as helpful to the growth of this sport, which will become even more evident when we look at participation in relationship to labor flows.

Registered Players and Registered Youth

Considering the total number of Czech players playing outside the country as a ratio to the number registered players (RP), ice hockey exports 5.2 players per 1,000 registered, followed by basketball (1.4), baseball (1.2), and football (.2)

(Table 14.1). Considering football has more than 400,000 players registered than ice hockey, granting them a much larger potential migration pool, again the strength of ice hockey in the world system is validated.

Football has the most youth players (RY) among all the sports in the Czech Republic. Ice hockey and basketball have very similar RY values. The share of RY to RP in each sport is particularly fascinating. Baseball has the highest share of youth participation at the rate of 53%, then basketball with 50%, ice hockey 42% and football lags with 31%. This shows us a very different ranking than popularity or total registered players, and confirms baseball as the most developing sport of these four.

As was alluded to above, the only sport which both flows of migration correlated well with sport growth as measured in terms of registered players and registered youth was the developing sport of baseball (FPI to RP .798, FPI to RY .673, CPO to RP .518, CPO to RY .413). This is significant, as it appears to indicate that for developing sports migration is a positive strategy toward sport growth. The opposite can be said about the secondary sport of basketball, where all four correlations between labor flows and player registrations were negative. It does not appear that foreigners in the top Czech league encourage young players to take up this secondary sport (FPI to RY -.756), which is consistent with the findings of Falcous and Maguire (2005) in British basketball many years ago. The two primary sports of football and ice hockey were positively correlated with exports, but their correlations with imports were negligible. This can be explained by the larger numbers of homegrown talent available in primary sports, as well as the high media visibility of large numbers of successful exports in core countries.

World Ranking

World ranking is very significant considering the effect on fandom, as was exemplified in this chapter's opening paragraph. There is huge euphoria each year during the ice hockey world championships, because the Czech national team always has a chance to win a medal. When we compare this to fandom of the UEFA championships or World Cup, fewer Czech viewers watch these games (Bureš, 2019). In this case, there appears to be a relationship between WR and sport fans: the greater the chance of winning a medal, the more national fans watch the event.

These international events also prove very important for Czech players who desire to migrate to better leagues. There is a correlation between team success at the World Championship and out migration (Crossan, 2020). It should be remembered when examining Figure 14.3, and this set of correlations, that lower world rankings are preferred by both fans and national governing bodies. For that reason, we have placed WR on the left Y-axis in descending order, while migrants (FPI and CPO) are on the right Y-axis in ascending order. Seasons are in ascending order on the X-axis.

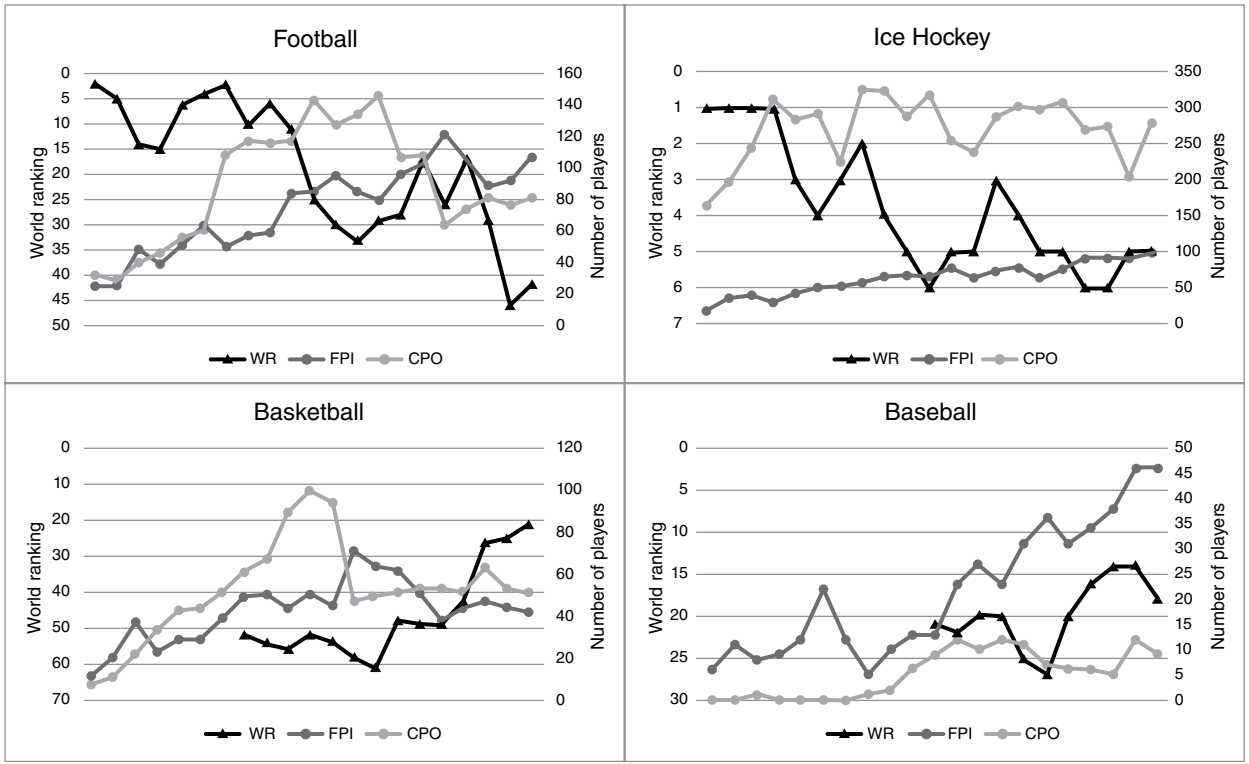


Figure 14.3 Relationship of World Ranking to Migration.

In terms of correlations between immigration (FPI) and world rankings, the only sport in which we can find any positive is the developing sport of baseball (FPI to WR -.415), where foreign players appear to have aided Czech players in achieving better WR. In all other sports, the immigration of players is correlated to worse world rankings. These correlations are stronger within the primary sports and imports (football FPI to WR .721, ice hockey FPI to WR .833). The correlations between exports (CPO) in all sports measured and WR were relatively weak. When we examine the shape of the plotlines in Figure 14.3, these correlations are explained a little more transparently. In the primary sport of ice hockey, where export players are moving from core to core, WR mirrors CPO. Conversely, in the developing sport of baseball WR mirrors FPI. This is in contrast to other studies (Berlinschi et al., 2013; Gelade & Dobson, 2007; Omondi-Ochieng, 2018), but consistent with World-Systems Theory.

When examining football, we must remember this sport represents the biggest, most competitive global industry of all sports examined. Thus, as the Czech Republic moved between WR of 2 and 15 during the first ten seasons examined, there is very little variance between the level of play of these top 15 national teams in the world. Thus, Czech footballers were in high demand and the CPO in these seasons were primarily going to core football nations. As WR fell below 30, a trend is observed where football CPO increasingly migrated to semi-periphery football nations. In terms of FPI and WR, the strong .721 correlation indicates that more import players in the Czech leagues negatively affected WR. When we examine the data more closely, we observe that while CPO initially went to core nations, their replacements, FPI were coming from the football periphery. It is not until the final two years of this study that a few top teams brought in foreign players from the semi-periphery. The Czech league has traditionally been viewed as transitive for players from periphery football nations who are looking to migrate, but have been initially overlooked by the core football nations. This has a compounding effect which helps explain the high correlation between FPI and WR; young players are no longer playing alongside developed players ready to be taken by the core countries, but rather they are playing alongside inexpensive periphery players who are lottery picks to make their Czech teams significant profits. Lotteries leave many people poor as evidenced by the falling WR of Czech football.

In the other primary sport, ice hockey, CPO follows the development of WR with a delay. As the Czech Republic is at the global core of ice hockey, and CPO migrate to other ice hockey core nations, it is evident that increasing numbers of Czech players are drafted to the NHL and KHL when Czech performs well in major ice hockey championships. In the first four seasons while the Czech Republic was ranked number one in the world CPO increases, then again in 2005 and 2006 when medals were won, CPO spikes again. Poor national team performance, and consequently declining WR, are followed by

decreases in CPO until they win again in 2010. However, in contrast to football, the FPI in ice hockey come from other ice hockey core countries; thus, FPI correlation to WR is weaker, even though they are both primary sports in the country.

While the secondary sport of basketball has moderate correlations between WR and CPO/FPI, the plotlines do not offer conclusive further explanation. In contrast, in the developing sport of baseball, WR clearly climbs as FPI increases. As more players are given opportunity to play alongside FPI coming from core countries, their own level of play increases. In the sport of baseball, the negative correlation between FPI and WR can be explained by the fact that the talent gap is large between FPI and Czech players, meaning foreign imports are most impactful in a developing sport.

Competitive Balance

Table 14.1 shows that primary sports are more balanced then secondary sports. Ice hockey is slightly more balanced then football. Baseball and basketball are less balanced, and this can be considered a deterrent to fandom of these leagues. Similar to WR, CB is better when the numbers are lower; thus, we have again put the variable measured against imports (FPI) on one Y axis, and CB on the primary Y axis to illustrate their relationship.

The relationship between imports (FPI) and CB was significant in the two primary sports (Football .580, Ice Hockey -.479), and insignificant in the secondary and developing sports. Both football and ice hockey had higher mean CB as their cultural primacy naturally creates more competition and less performance fluctuation as a result of imports. This can be seen in Figure 14.4 for basketball and baseball where rapid increases in FPI had visible negative effects on CB. Yet it remains that the increase in foreigners in football negatively affected CB, while in ice hockey the increase correlated to increased CB. We hypothesize that this contrast is a result of the World-Systems positioning of these two sports. Czech ice hockey, at the sport's global core, imports from other core countries; thus, the imported players do not disrupt an already high level of competitive balance (also evidenced by the relative few numbers of foreigners in top ice hockey statistics by Crossan and Ruda, 2019), while in football the import players are statistically much more visible. Additionally, as indicated previously, in football the imports are more of a gamble. In Czech football, managers are looking for bargains from periphery countries, as compared to basketball or baseball, where the imports typically come from core or semi-periphery countries. However, in football and basketball, we can state that top teams improved their scouting in the second half of the years studied, moving away from gambling on cheap labor, to importing more proven players who had already played in other semi-periphery European countries. In both these two sports, this trend change resulted from one team being willing to spend more money on these proven imports, which

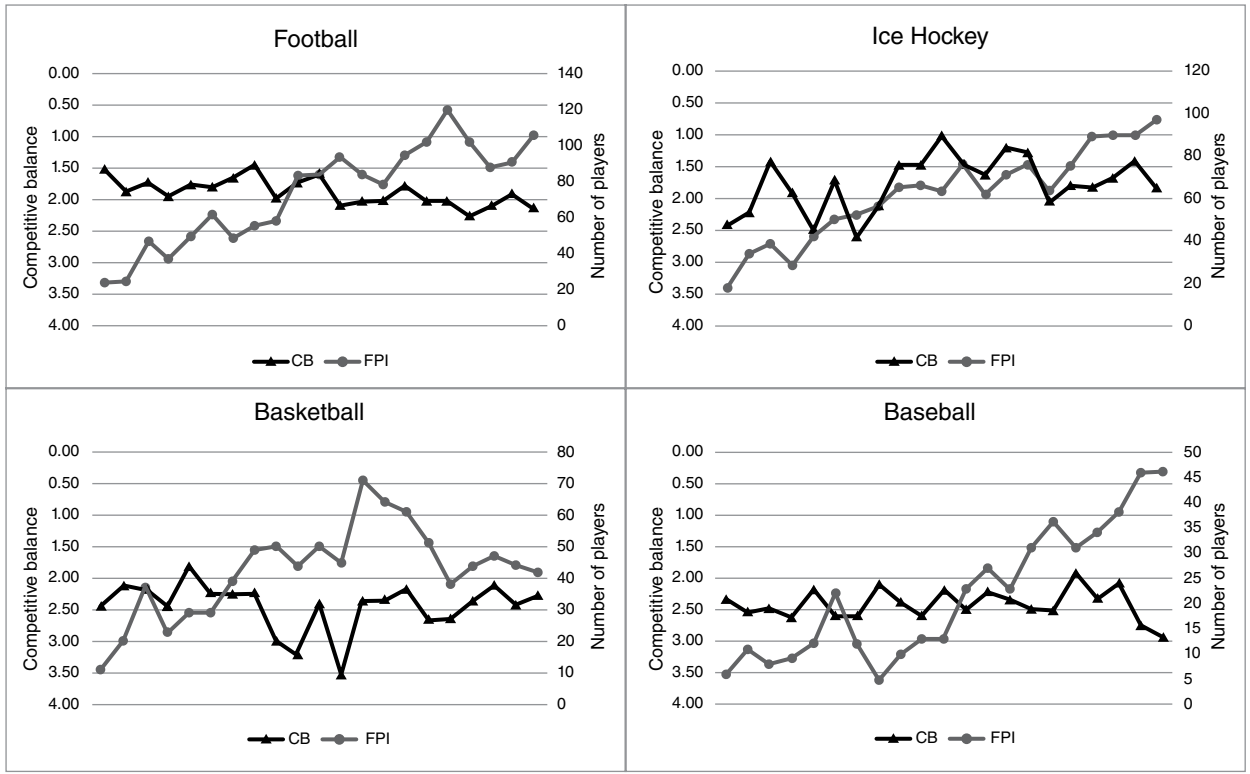


Figure 14.4 Relationship between Competitive Balance and Imports.

increased their winning percentage over other teams. This parallels the findings of Addesa (2011) who was examining Italian basketball which is closer to the basketball core than Czech, but probably similarly placed in the World Systems hierarchy to Czech football.

In ice hockey, because both FPI and CPO are moving between core ice hockey countries, we see significant negative correlations with CB. The CPO make room for young, very talented players (relatively more talented than the young talent from the other sports). Teams bring in FPI from core countries not because their own young talent is not good enough to maintain CB, but because the imports from other core countries is cheaper than paying the development fees required to obtain young talent from other clubs (Crossan & Ruda, 2019). Thus, we see the sport World-System as teams from a sport at the core in a semi-periphery country want to assure they maximize profits in dealing with the core countries while striving to maintain competitive balance.

Before leaving the CB variable, it is imperative to bring to light the significant correlations between CB and WR (Football .507, Ice Hockey -.449, Basketball .426, and Baseball .017). In football and basketball, increasing migration flows decreased competitive balance at home. Yet this brought worse world rankings for football, while it correlated to better world rankings for basketball. In ice hockey, increasing migration flows resulted in better competitive balance at home and worse world rankings. Examine this through a World-Systems perspective where Czech ice hockey is at the core, Czech football in the semi-periphery and basketball in the periphery, then we extrapolate the following: in order for the Czech Republic to remain at the sport core without being at the economic core, it cannot afford to artificially sustain fan interest via competitive balance by importing foreigners while their production of registered youth continually decreases.

Average Attendance

Table 14.1 illustrates that primary sports are much higher attended than secondary sports. Football has the biggest stadiums with average capacity of 11,000, and average attendance at 44%. Ice hockey has average capacity of 7,400, with arenas approximately 65% full. Czech attendance incomes comprise 7% of average football budgets, and 10% of ice hockey budgets. Basketball arenas used in the highest league have an average capacity of 1,951 people and are on average 40% full. Baseball, being a developing sport, only began to keep official attendance records in 2008, and as seen in Table 14.1, their average attendance is far lower than those of the other three sports.

In terms of match attendance, we are interested in the interplay of fan interest as represented through attendance with imports (FPI), and exports (CPO), but it must be remembered that each import is taking the roster spot of a Czech player (CTL). The correlations suggest that Czech fans like seeing foreigners in ice hockey (.731) and basketball (.673). The incongruence

between attraction to foreign players in ice hockey and indifference to the same phenomena in football may best be explained by the previously mentioned effect of foreigners on competitive balance in these two sports. Fans are attracted to games with higher competitive balance, and while the use of foreigners brought increased competitive balance in ice hockey, it correlated with higher disparity between teams in football. At the same time, only in basketball do higher export numbers appear to correlate to more fans at the game (.459). These same basketball fans are not drawn to the games where more Czechs are on the floor (-.600). So only in the secondary sport of basketball can we see a clear migration preference by the core fans. In the two primary sports of football (-.370) and ice hockey (-.312) we see a slight effect of fans staying away from stadiums when more players are exported (CPO). This would appear logical, as they would prefer to consume the higher quality product where their best players are contributing to games being broadcast from the core countries (specifically broadcasts of the NHL, and football games from the UK, Germany, and Spain). So, we can conclude that in primary sports, exports draw fans away from the stadiums, while in secondary sports it builds interest in the sport. The overall attendance numbers in baseball are on average too low to be considered in the correlations.

Sports Management Implications

As Table 14.3 summarizes, exporting players for a semi-periphery country can be beneficial at the sport development level in terms of aiding world ranking and increasing the supply of players regardless of the cultural position of the sport or its position within the world system. Thus, we can state that exporting players is positive at the sport level in a country. However, these exports may result in negative fan attendance at the league level in primary sports when the players are leaving to perform in core countries, which in turn broadcast a higher-level product back into the sending country. In the secondary sport of basketball, exporting players appeared to negatively affect competitive balance, but positively affect league attendance. Thus, it appears that there will continue to be a tension between federation officials encouraging top players to play outside the country in order to improve national team performance and gain more players for the sport, and league officials and team managers who desire to hold on to these same players in order to improve league attendance numbers. However, given that team budgets are not dependent on attendance in the primary sports of the Czech Republic, it is assumed that team owners can make more money by selling these players abroad, rather than keeping them home.

Importing players in order to replace the exported national players is more beneficial and more common in the secondary and developing sports, than in the primary sports where the talent pool is deeper. These imports aid the development of national players, and thus world ranking when the sport is

Table 14.3 Summary of Migration Effects at the Sport and League Levels

Sport	*Sport position*	*World-Systems position*			*Sport level*			*League level*	
					WR	*RP*	*RY*	*CB*	*AA*
Football	Primary	Semi-periphery	Exports to (CPO)	Core and Semi-periphery	+	+	+		-
			Imports from (FPI)	Periphery	-			-	
Ice Hockey	Primary	Core	Exports to (CPO)	Core	+	+		+	-
			Imports from (FPI)	Core	-	-		+	+
Basketball	Secondary	Periphery	Exports to (CPO)	Semi-periphery	+	+	-	-	+
			Imports from (FPI)	Core and Semi-periphery	+		-		+
Baseball	Developing	Periphery	Exports to (CPO)	Core (lower level)	+	+	+		
			Imports from (FPI)	Core	+			-	

secondary or developing, but are harmful to world ranking when the sport is primary. In secondary and developing sports, the imports coming in from core countries are often playing alongside national team players and developing youth players, thus raising the level of play. In contrast, the imports in primary sports are not playing alongside national team players as these have all been exported. Rather than playing alongside developing youth players, they are actually taking playing time from them. Thus, it behooves federation officials to limit imports more heavily in primary sports, but regulate their use less in secondary and developing sports, as long as the imports continue to come from core countries. In terms of evaluating the use of imports at the league or team level, the results are less conclusive. We were surprised to see that the use of imports did not have a more positive correlation with competitive balance as the length of our study was long enough to eliminate the first mover effect (Forster & Pope, 2004), and in all sports studied the use of foreigners on teams was not limited to teams at the top of the league. The use of imports was attractive to fans in the secondary sport of basketball, and teams can market these foreign players to improve game attendance. We hypothesize this would also be true in the developing sport of baseball, where fans of the sport are regularly exposed to higher levels of play via the internet and social media, and enjoy seeing American pitchers pitching 90mph as compared to Czech pitchers pitching 65mph in their top league. Unfortunately, there are so few fans in this developing sport that bringing in foreigners will not increase attendance enough to even cover their cost.

Conclusion

Wallerstein's World-Systems theory remains helpful to sport managers at the sport and league levels in both interpreting and anticipating migration developments proactively for sport growth, and cultural sport brand management. Yet in using a World-Systems approach, the manager must evaluate all decisions on the basis of cultural position of the sport within both the sending and receiving country, not simply based on economic factors. This cultural position of the sport as a brand correlates with media attention, fan attendance, and registered players.

Based on a World-Systems approach, the cultural position of the sport, and these results we can state the following: Primary sports in a country will produce more talent, and thus have more exports for the rest of the world. While previous literature indicated that the home culture may be less receptive to foreigners in their primary sports, often visible as decreases in fan attendance, we did not find this true in our study. In comparison, secondary and developing sports need foreigners in order to increase the standard of play, developing national talent and positively affecting world rankings. Bringing foreigners into secondary and developing sports is more disruptive to league competitive balance, as other countries have better players than the host country.

The host country does not produce enough talent, so migrants are needed. These factors need to be considered by league officials as they establish policies regulating the number of imports allowed by each team. Each sport has a different starting point in the culture based on the popularity of that sport in the culture and the parallels and divergences with the World-System. Thus, policy changes which regulate imports will affect each sport differently in terms of world rankings, registered players, competitive balance, and game attendance.

Each of these markers interacts with the cultural position of the sport and the World-System to provide feedback that can be used to aid growth of the sport and league as cultural brands. One argument, paralleling World-Systems theory, which is used at both the league and team level in the two primary sports for allowing more foreigners, is that this has allowed the leagues to expand in a cost-effective manner, so that more young players can gain experience in the highest league without compromising competitive balance. The Israeli coach of the Czech national basketball team is encouraging the dismantling of the indomitable Nymburk basketball team which has won 17 consecutive league championships, in order for the nation to continue to climb in the world rankings. The Nymburk team, composed almost entirely of national team players and foreigners, with an average winning percentage of 95.6%, is a disrupter of league competitive balance, corresponding to the lowest average home attendance in the league and the highest average away attendance. However, with the explanation that these national team players cannot continue to improve in the periphery home league, the national team coach encourages national team players to move to periphery leagues closer to the core outside the country. Such a strategy prioritizes the brand image of basketball in the culture over the brand image of the Nymburk team. Federation heads are making policy decisions in regard to migration in sport which will contribute to the ability of a sport to gain ground as a brand internationally, as well as a cultural brand. Sport managers are brand managers, at the federation, league, and team levels; thus, the policies and decisions they make surrounding sport migration will have effects on the sports they steward. When the sport is a primary sport in semi-periphery nations, these sports are often a part of the cultural brand of the nation where foreigners coming into the league dilute the national brand, and national players playing out in core nations serve as brand ambassadors.

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Chapter 15

Impacts of COVID-19 on Sports and Sponsorship

Sara Keshkar

Introduction

In December 2019, Wuhan, Hubei province, China, became the center of an outbreak of pneumonia of unknown cause, which raised intense attention not only within China but internationally (Wang et al., 2020). The new coronavirus, called COVID-19, has since spread around the world (Singhal, 2020). Since the beginning of the pandemic, the sports industry, along with many other industries, was affected by the outbreak of the COVID-19 virus and suffered serious economic and social, as well as organizational problems. This chapter discusses the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic on sports industry and its different sections. The COVID-19 pandemic caused all sport organizations to temporarily cease operations. Each organization was affected differently; however, regardless of the nuances of their respective business models, the virus choked off their essential revenue streams. Organizations took various steps to improve the situation, such as firing staff, reducing salaries or hours of work, offering voluntary and involuntary redundancies, standing down or furloughing staff, and mandating staff to take annual or long service leave (Dickson, 2021).

Keshkar et al. (2022a) compared the performance of sports organizations in the top 20 countries with the most elite sports according to the World Ranking of Countries in Elite Sport 2020. They studied public and private organizations whose performance was reflected in the media during the pandemic. Results indicated that performance of sports organizations was divided into two main categories: sports-related activities and social responsibility. Performance in terms of canceling events and closing sports centers were found to be similar across most countries. However, in countries such as Sweden, New Zealand, Serbia, the Netherlands, Argentina, and the Czech Republic, sports centers stayed open with precautionary measures imposed as the virus spread (Keshkar et al. 2022a) (Table 15.1).

Research showed significant differences in the social responsibility activities of sports organizations. However, the majority performed similarly when it came to boosting social morale and providing financial aid. Sports clubs

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and stadiums in many countries supported those who had lost employment, while in countries that saw large numbers of cases, sports centers evolved into temporary hospitals. Sports organizations in Germany, Italy, Japan, the United States, the UK, and Spain have encouraged citizens to use transportation such as walking or cycling to help combat COVID-19. Germany in particular has increased bicycle lanes in some cities and provided more space to ride. Moreover, some stadiums have been used as testing and research centers for the virus, as well as morgues for deceased patients (Keshkar et al. (2022a).

Countries have responded to the global pandemic in varying ways, each unique to its own social and cultural context and capabilities. In places with prompt lockdowns and physical activity restrictions, most activities were confined to the home. In other nations, gradual and flexible regulations were put in place to allow physical activity in open public spaces, abiding by social distancing. Professional sports federations and leagues with strong industry presence embraced the need to adjust to government guidelines, while attempting to lessen the economic blow from the shutdown. Events were reorganized, and plans for resuming activities were established (Morales et al., 2020).

Sports Events

The COVID-19 pandemic, since March 2020, has had a significant influence on sports events globally. This has changed the parameters of planning, financing, organizing, and carrying out domestic and international sports competitions. For example, major sporting events such as the 2020 Olympic and Paralympic Games have had to be canceled or postponed. Even some events that were only planned for 2021 have been postponed for precautionary reasons or due to scheduling conflicts (e.g., the UEFA Women's Euro 2021, FIBA EuroBasket 2021, the World Games 2021 and the World Athletics Championships 2021) (European Council, 2021). Professional leagues worldwide suspended their seasons, resulting in hundreds of thousands of job losses and the canceling of public sporting events. A decrease of nearly 24,000 sporting events was expected in December 2020 compared to the pre-crisis projection of 50,000 (Lange, 2020).

The Tokyo 2020 Olympics and Paralympics, initially planned for July and August 2020, were postponed due to the global coronavirus pandemic. In July 2019, the Japanese government expected lasting economic, social, and cultural benefits from the event (Arba, 2021a). The Tokyo Olympics 2020 organizing committee had budgeted roughly USD 15 billion for running the Games for 17 days. However, due to the postponement, experts estimate that the Games lost at least USD 35 billion (Sorkin & Kessler, 2021). The 2022 Winter Olympics faced numerous challenges, despite vaccinations being available in most countries. China implemented its "zero COVID" policy to control Omicron's spread, but there were still worries regarding hosting the event (Traub, 2022). Beijing 2022 organizers worked hard to create a risk-level system for

Table 15.1 Similarities in the Performance of Sports Organizations during the Global Outbreak of COVID-19 (Keshkar et al., 2022a)

Categories	*Data*	*Czech*	*Argentina*	*China*	*Netherlands*	*Canada*	*Korea*
Activities related to sports	Domestic and international sporting events Cancelation	*	*	*	*	*	*
	Closure of recreational and sports centers	-	-	*	-	*	*
	Prohibition of group sports and encouragement to exercise individually	-	-	*	-	*	*
	Encouraging walking instead of public transportation	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Encouraging cycling and Increasing bicycle lanes in cities	-	-	-	-	-	-
	competitions without spectators or with limited spectators or with robots and dummies	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Government grants to sports producers and Reduction of club taxes	*	*	*	*	*	*
	Reduction of salaries and staffs	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Using the capacity of digital technology in sports activities	-	-	-	*	-	-
	Preventive measures and compliance with health protocols	-	-	-	-	-	-
	Use of new tools and methods for disinfection of sports venues	-	-	*	-	*	*
	Informing, medical advice, and planning and developing a return to normal strategy	*	-	-	-	-	-
Activities related to social responsibility	Motivate and guide the community to follow the protocols	-	-	*	*	*	*
	Sports training at home by athletes	-	*	-	*	*	-
	support campaigns and financial support	*	*	-	*	*	*
	Meeting the needs of medical and research centers by clubs	-	*	-	-	-	*
	Transformation of stadiums into temporary hospitals	-	-	*	-	-	-
	Turning stadiums into shelters for the injured, a police station and food and health warehouse	-	-	-	-	-	-

Belgium	*France*	*Russia*	*Serbia*	*New Zealand*	*Australia*	*Brazil*	*Spain*	*UK*	*USA*	*Sweden*	*Japan*	*Italy*	*Germany*
*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	-	*
*	*	*	-	-	*	*	*	*	*	-	*	*	*
-	-	*	-	-	-	*	*	*	*	-	*	*	*
-	-	-	-	-	-	-	*	*	*	-	*	*	*
-	-	-	-	-	-	-	*	*	*	-	*	*	*
-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	*	*	*
*	*	-	-	-	-	-	*	-	*	-	*	*	*
-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	*	-	*
*	-	-	-	-	*	-	-	*	-	-	-	*	-
-	-	-	-	-	*	-	-	*	-	-	-	-	-
-	-	-	-	*	-	-	*	-	-	-	*	-	-
-	-	-	-	*	-	-	-	-	-	*	-	-	-
*	-	-	-	-	-	*	-	-	*	-	-	*	*
*	*	*	-	*	*	*	-	*	-	-	*	*	*
*	-	*	*	*	-	*	-	-	*	-	-	*	*
-	*	-	*	-	-	*	-	-	*	*	*	*	*
-	*	-	-	-	*	*	*	*	*	-	*	-	-
-	-	*	-	-	*	-	*	-	-	-	*	-	-

participants and venues, then supplied necessary safeguards (Liu et al., 2022). Omicron's high rate of transmission made the repercussions of China's zero-COVID policy more costly, while diminishing its benefits (Cheng, 2022). The COVID-19 pandemic has caused immense disruption to sporting events; however, it has also birthed a new type of sports fan experience – virtual sporting events. Companies have developed virtual realms, allowing fans to connect with leagues and athletes while enjoying games from the comfort of their homes (U.S. chamber of commerce, 2020).

Elite Athletes

People in lockdown were exhausted and stressed due to the prolonged home quarantine. With no other option to control the virus outbreak, some athletes aided medical personnel on the frontlines, as well as those financially impacted, by contributing donations and inspiring social action. Many athletes emerged in different roles in different societies and acted as national and international influencers during coronavirus pandemic. In other words, with so much societal unrest in pandemic era, professional athletes had no longer been able to sit on the sidelines about important social issues. Now more than ever, these sports stars would be expected to use their celebrity status for social good to talk about issues that were both important to them and relevant to their fans (Keshkar et al. 2022b; U.S. chamber of commerce, 2020).

In a study on the role of athletes in society during the pandemic, Keshkar et al. (2022b) showed seven different roles of the world's elite athletes (Figure 15.1) including comedian (who tried to entertain people), neutral observer (who had no reaction to the situation), sport trainer (who tried to help people

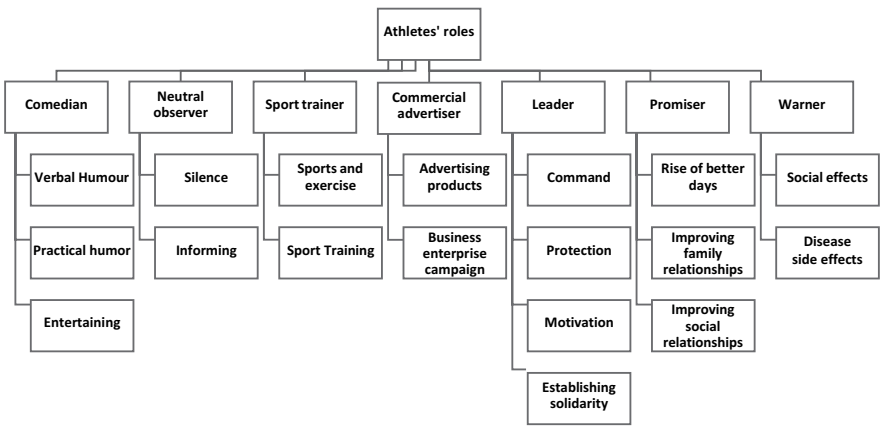


Figure 15.1 The Role of Athletes in the Period of Coronavirus Outbreak (Keshkar et al., (2022b).

by doing exercise at home), commercial advertiser (those who participated in commercials of special sports equipment for home training), leader (who led people to think wisely and communicate logically), promiser (those who promised for hope and better life in future), and warner (who warned people about the dangers of the disease).

While many of the world's elite athletes played a key role in helping people cope with the spread of the disease and helped them develop their abilities and social communication and health care (Keshkar et al. 2022b), there were also athletes who faced negative social reactions for their behavior. When Novak Djokovic, a professional tennis player from Serbia who had been an anti-vaxxer and COVID-skeptic, attempted to attend the Australian Open in January 2022, it caused a strong social reaction. The Australian border authorities detained him and denied him access to the tournament due to his lack of proof of vaccination, resulting in protests from many and complaints that their sports hero did not respect the rules (Brezar, 2022).

Sports Media

During the pandemic, reporters and columnists shifted their coverage from small health stories (e.g. a sports injury) to large-scale public and global health issues, which they may be less familiar with. Sadri et al. (2021) demonstrated in their research that sports news saw a notable change in coverage, with economic and fairness frames giving way to health, safety, and quality of life frames as primary topics. They revealed that sports content rapidly changed in accordance with the pandemic's global threat, despite sources remaining stable. To protect against infection, reporters at sporting events had to keep their distance from athletes, coaches, fans, and other organizers. The pandemic completely altered the way reporters cover sports: in-person interviews vanished; one-on-one sit-down chats became rare; locker room scrums were replaced by Zoom calls; and in-depth interviews were no longer possible. These changes have had a major impact on sports journalists' ability to do their jobs.

Sports and Leisure

The COVID-19 pandemic brought damaging effects to championship and professional sports. However, leisure and recreational sports enjoyed a boost in participation during the home quarantine period (Ling, 2020; Government information base, 2020). During the pandemic, leisure sports had to be done at home with limited equipment. Mutz et al. (2021) found that younger age people maintained their leisure time sport and exercise levels better than older people. The young groups increased their home-based workouts and outdoor endurance sports, whereas the older ones could not find suitable replacements for their sporting routines.

Many people used leisure sports to stay healthy and pass time during quarantine. Some exercised alone at home, while others attended virtual fitness classes or used online clips or TV sport channels. Others followed sports elites who provided live workouts through social media, bringing sport activities into the home.

Sport and Society

The COVID-19 has had a major impact on all aspects of social life, and many countries have experienced social issues as a result. Nevertheless, sports and physical activities have been crucial in improving the lives of many. Here, we examine the effect of sports and physical activities on various social groups during the pandemic.

Elderly Sports. Older adults are particularly vulnerable to the virus, facing greater risk of serious infection, reduced access to healthcare, and considerable social and economic hardship (Reginald et al., 2021). In such situation, promoting "social distancing" at a population level and "self-isolation" of older adults to mitigate its spread was a suitable decision. Despite the importance of these Public Health and Social Measures (PHSM), many governments emphasized on challenges to maintaining a physically active lifestyle, particularly for older adults (Cunningham & O' Sullivan, 2020). During the pandemic, young people had far greater access than older adults to infrastructure for sports and physical activities, such as parks, mountains, seas, rivers, and sports clubs. Emphasizing the risk of infection, older adults were more restricted in their public exercise options. A French study demonstrated that even online sports and games among older adults saw a decrease in participation compared to other activities (Statista, 2021a).

A study on elderly athletes living in Tehran during the COVID-19 pandemic revealed that pandemic-related restrictions caused several changes to their behavior, lifestyle, and social relationships. The lack of information and limited access to sports activities evoked feelings of fear of death among them (Norouzi Seyed Hosseini, 2021). Some countries implemented new programs and policies to reduce health inequalities and social isolation. In 2020 the Welsh Government launched Wales' Healthy Weight, Healthy Wales Action Plan 2020–22 to reduce health inequalities and social isolation by allocating funding to Sport Wales, distributed among the 22 local authorities. This money would fund projects such as online classes for over-60s to help them work out in their homes until April 2022 (Sport Wales, 2021).

Youth and Children Sports. A study conducted by the University of Wisconsin found that, on average, children are spending 6.5 hours less per week on sports during the pandemic, and that three in ten parents say

their children are not interested in sports. Children from higher-income households are spending more than two hours per week additionally on sports compared to children in lower-income households. The physical activity of high school athletes has decreased by 50% and has led to 65% of high school athletes reporting anxiety symptoms, with 25% moderate to severe. This research reinforced the link between physical and mental health (Dorsh & Blazo, 2020; Solomon, 2021). Research in Australia showed the impacts of the pandemic on mental health and sport participation. It revealed emotional struggles faced by families and youth athletes, the reconnection of family units and social networks, difficulties associated with re-engaging in sport with increased regulations, and the need to reimagine the purpose and meaning of sport for families and communities (Elliot et al., 2021).

COVID-19 has intensified the inequity in children's access to sports. Most countries have observed that kids from low-income households have less access to sports. The economic hit caused by the pandemic has led to massive job losses or salary cuts, making it difficult for parents to finance their children's sports activities. Such situations often force children to leave school and abandon sports in order to take up jobs (Centre for Sport and Human Rights, 2020). The full repercussions of the COVID-19 crisis on children's participation in sports are yet to be seen. Worries have been voiced about financial difficulties and academic repercussions, but only time will tell what the true effects are.

Education. During the pandemic, educational technologies have become an essential tool to provide education at a distance. Kerres and Buchner (2022) found that institutional, national, and cultural conditions are critical in understanding how the pandemic has impacted education. They suggest two visions for the role of educational technology in education post-pandemic: a pre-digital reconstruction of returning "back to normal", or a post-digital transformation of the educational system. Gomes et al. (2021) argued that countries cannot merely restore education to pre-pandemic conditions, considering the changing circumstances. The education sector faces challenges to recover from the COVID-19 pandemic disruption. Enthusiasm is building for a "new normal" of teaching practices (Blain et al., 2022). Online learning posed difficulties for physical education, sports, and health students, since computers don't allow for movement activities (Prasetyo et al., 2022). Aguirre-Loaiza et al. (2021) found that the post-pandemic educational context will rely heavily on virtual tools, which could lead to sedentary behavior. Educational policies should therefore prioritize body activities in traditional subject areas such as math and biology.

Athletes with Disabilities. COVID-19 had a severe impact on athletes with disabilities. In a study conducted by Urbański et al. (2021), 88.6% of Paralympic athletes training for Tokyo 2021 had to train at home, while

12% stopped their regimens completely. Additionally, only 5.4% had access to facilities. A similar situation was found in Special Olympics' athletes, of which 42% (2.5 million globally) lost access to sports programs in 2020 (ESPN, 2021). This disparity highlights the challenges athletes with disabilities face in terms of reduced activity and access to sports facilities and equipment. The World Para Sports experienced significant economic problems due to the COVID-19 pandemic, resulting in the cancellation of competitions in five of the ten included sports. This led to a dramatic decrease in revenue from EUR 5,956,361 in 2019 to EUR 884,151 in 2020, representing a drop of 85.2 per cent (IOC, 2021).

Gender. Women in sport have gained unprecedented attention in the past years of the pandemic. According to a UN Women report (UN women, 2022), there are five areas that have been affected by COVID-19: leadership, gender-based violence, economic opportunities, media participation/representation, and girls' involvement in sport. Results demonstrate that fewer women are involved in assessing the pandemic's impact on sport and planning for the future than men, which may leave women and girls behind. Evidently, policies that do not consider female opinions or involve them in decision-making are less effective and may cause further harm (UN, women, 2020). COVID-19 has had a visible effect on economic opportunities, a topic now up for discussion. A FIFPRO survey on the effect of the pandemic on women's professional football reveals that wage cuts, job losses, and poor communication are harming female footballers in multiple countries, possibly negating recent gains toward gender equality (Fifpro. 2020). Forty-seven percent of surveyed nations saw salary reductions or suspensions, 24% saw contract changes or termination, and 27% experienced reductions or complete loss of nonfinancial support, such as meals, housing, health insurance, and gym memberships (Reykjavik Global Forum, n.d.).

In 69% of countries, communication between leagues/clubs and players was rated as "poor" or "very poor". Federations in 52% of surveyed nations failed to reach out to their female national team players. Additionally, more than a quarter of countries didn't include women's clubs in their return to play protocols. Moreover, league seasons were canceled rather than revived, as was often done in men's games. Furthermore, female players are not receiving enough physical and mental health support due to pandemic-related uncertainty. Health support was not provided at all in 40% of countries studied, while 84% didn't provide mental health support (Fifpro 2020; CARP, 2021; Reykjavik Global Forum, n.d.). Nottingham Trent University research reveals 80% of elite female athletes see inequality in men's and women's sports hindering the growth of women's sport. Additionally, 66% worry about the financial effects of COVID-19 and 91% sense a gender pay gap (Bowes et al., 2021).

The UN Women Report 2020 focused on women's participation in sports, and the COVID-19 pandemic had a major effect on it. This included implications for elite female athletes, not just regarding their physical activities, but also in economic and social areas. Statista Research Department's Report (2021b) showed that women had less time to devote to sport than men during the pandemic, thus increasing the inequality between genders. The COVID-19 pandemic has had a negative impact on media coverage of women's sports globally, according to the International Women's Media Foundation (Oomman et al., 2020). Research from Symons et al. (2021) revealed a slight decline in coverage of women's sports in Australia at the start of the pandemic, and low levels persisted even without live events. This suggests media organizations defaulted to traditional practices that do not prioritize coverage of women in sport.

Parry et al. (2021) analyzed British media coverage of women's football during the pandemic to study how it was framed. The results identified five dominant frames in the context of COVID-19: financial precariousness, commercial prioritization of men's football, practical considerations, debating the future of women's football, and concern for players. This research proposes diversifying the sports journalism workforce to reduce hegemonic masculine culture in the industry. Despite the negative impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic on women's sports and media coverage, female athletes remain determined to improve their position in international sports. Reports on the Tokyo 2020 Olympics show that the gender gap is the lowest in terms of participants yet seen: 5,494 women and 5,982 men (Arba, 2021b). This suggests that even with limited media coverage, women's sport is progressing toward its future.

Animal Shows. Animal owners and sports/entertainment venues accrue income from animal shows. Rodeo, Greyhound racing, pigeon racing, and animal fighting are all examples of animal sporting events. Animal show events are a popular form of gambling, with billions spent globally each year (European Society of Dog and Animal Welfare, n.d.). The animal sport industry suffered during the pandemic, with a 25% decrease in attendance and revenue compared to 2019 (Annual Report, 2019). Dog race betting turnover in Great Britain dropped to roughly 231 million British pounds between April and September 2020, likely due to the impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic on sporting events (Lock, 2021).

Racing activity ceased from March to June 2020 as a result of the restrictions imposed to counteract the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic, resulting in a significant reduction in the number of race meetings (Annual Report, 2020). The impacts of COVID-19 on the NSW Thoroughbred Racing Industry continued through 2020/21. While there was a gradual reopening of racecourses to the public, the caps on overall

numbers and density limits significantly impacted the number of patrons that were able to attend racecourses. Those restrictions meant that feature races such as the 2020 staging of The Everest and The Golden Eagle and the 2021 staging of The Championships and The Golden Slipper were conducted before capped crowds of only 25% of pre-COVID-19 numbers. Feature regional race meetings were also held with lower crowd numbers (Racing NSW, 2022).

The market size of the horse racing track industry in the United States was valued at over USD 3 billion in 2020, reflecting a decrease over the previous year's size of approximately USD 5 billion (Lange, 2021). Over the past decade the turnover from off-course horse race betting in the United Kingdom (UK) has significantly decreased from 5.74 billion British pounds in 2009 to roughly one billion in September 2020. A similar trend can be seen with off-course dog race betting. The most recent drop in 2020, however, was likely a result of the coronavirus (COVID-19) pandemic and its impact on sporting events (Lock, 2021).

Impact of COVID-19 on Sports Marketing Mix

During the pandemic era, manufacturers and marketers in sport industry encountered a special situation when they couldn't produce sport products and market them as usual. because people didn't go to the sport clubs, events and competitions, pools, and every place they had got used to participate for doing sport or physical exercises or watching games and competitions in pre-pandemic era. In other words, they didn't use the sport products as usual. So sport consumers were staying at home while producers and marketers were trying to find some solutions to sell the products to them. Remaining at home and avoiding of social communication were the main reasons why the pandemic affected the elements of the marketing mix which was based on the different models, introduced as 4ps, 5ps, 7ps, etc. The marketing mix is a set of strategies and activities which, based on 4ps model that is considered in this chapter, covers: product, price, promotion, and place (distribution). These are commonly referred to as "The Four Ps" (MIHAI, 2013). COVID-19 made lots of changes in elements of marketing mix in sports. Some of strategies manufacturers used to market their products during the pandemic were as follows:

Product

Closing clubs and sport facilities was the main reason for changing the shape of sport goods and services. Most of the people preferred to continue their physical activities at home. For this, they needed special equipment which could be used at home. A research conducted by Keshkar et al. (2021) showed that producing sport products during the pandemic covered not only the need of people whom stayed at home but also those who encountered cultural

considerations. Production of sport equipment and goods was divided in two main categories: (1) outdoor sports equipment which was used by people who chose the outdoor places for sport and exercise, e.g., portable and outdoor Gym Box for those who work out in indoor gyms (Hamit, 2021) and portable home pools (Faus & Aeppel, 2020). (2) Production of home sports and exercise equipment that was used by people who had to stay at home during the pandemic. For example, weights or dumbbells, treadmill or yoga mats were the most sold sport equipment in UK during the pandemic (Tighe, 2022). Also, some manufacturers chose a new strategy to fulfill the needs of those who had to stay at home. So, Sports manufacturers changed the characteristics of their products and made them suitable for home consumption. For example, a pool and water sport company in Iran changed the size of its tubs and hydrotherapy cabins for home use. This way they could sell lots of hydrotherapy equipment to the people who needed to use water therapy but couldn't go to the pools which were closed during the pandemic (Hydro gym, 2020).

Another type of sport production was sport services which included therapy and health services such as massage and rehabilitation of the disabled, which were done at homes. On the other hand, there were two kinds of services such as sport events and fitness classes which changed wholly according to the special situation in the pandemic. Sport events were held in stadiums without fans and spectators. But after a while fans could participate in the events with some limitations in numbers and the place where they could sit and watch the competitions. Fitness classes changed from a club sport to a home-based sport. People could participate in online fitness classes at home with low price (Keshkar et al., 2021). Another product which was sold to lots of people during the pandemic was the eSport games. In 2021, the global eSports market was valued at just over USD 1.08 billion, an almost 50% increase from the previous year (Gough, 2021).

Price

In the beginning of the pandemic, some sports product manufacturers reduced the prices of their products so that people in quarantine could buy them, but this strategy did not have long-lasting effects, so they had to choose better pricing strategies. Sports clubs reduced the number of participants in each class and therefore increased the price of classes. In this way, people who participated in the classes had a good financial situation, but the lower-income group turned to online classes that were cheaper, and gradually used sports videos at home that could be downloaded for free from Internet websites. Thus, in this way, the pricing of sports classes could be assumed on both sides of a continuum. The highest price was related to attending club classes, and the lowest price (or free) was in the case of using internet sports videos. The pricing of sports goods and equipment was initially discounted, but gradually returned to pre-pandemic levels as the pandemic period lengthened,

indicating that discount pricing could not last long in times of crisis. So, it is better for manufacturers to use different pricing strategies in times of crisis to both meet the needs of the environment and prevent their economic losses (Keshkar et al., 2021).

Place and Distribution

The effect of the pandemic on the "place" element was very significant. The need to respect social distance completely changed the definition of the "place" where sports products are offered. At the beginning of the pandemic, sporting events, which always took place in stadiums and sports facilities, were stopped and gradually presented to spectators through cyberspace. But after a relatively long time, the spectators were able to attend the stadiums and watch the matches while maintaining social distancing and wearing masks. Sports classes were not held in clubs and were replaced by online classes, and even over time, a certain group of people were able to attend club classes on the condition of maintaining social distancing, and those who could not afford to pay for club classes became customers of online ones. For a long time, sports shops gave way to virtual stores, and the supply of sports goods was mainly done in online stores. Even products delivering to customers changed a lot. That is to say, instead of receiving the product from the store, people would receive it by post or courier (Keshkar et al., 2021).

Promotion

The element of "promotion" in sport marketing mix was affected by COVID-19 pandemic and in most parts appeared in a new way! Some of the promotional activities went on using virtual reality (VR) technology. In the pandemic era demands for video games grew. So, few studies explored the potential of virtual reality (VR) games to promote sports engagement and health among young adults. Results of studies showed the potential of VR sports games in positively influencing sports engagement and health among participants with the vigor and dedication positively influencing health (Hanifah et al., 2022).

On the other hand, some promotional strategies leaned on public potential and talents. For instance, Some African youth began to demonstrate the power of sports in front of the camera and showed off their exquisite exercising skills, such as juggling football. These youth were actually participating in the Online Sport Challenge against COVID-19, which was organized by UNESCO Regional Offices in Abuja and Nairobi. The Challenge called for African youth aged between 15 and 35 to make videos of themselves displaying their innovative skills and creativity by taking part in any sporting activity of their choice, as a contribution to strengthen their health and resilience during the confinement, and post the videos online for a social media campaign (UNESCO, 2020).

Sport challenges and campaigns were another type of promotional activities during the COVID-19 pandemic which organized by sport celebrities. Cristiano Ronaldo's "push up challenge", Roger Federer's "wall challenge", Lionel Messi and Marcus Rashford's "Stay at Home Challenge", and also many others from different sports and countries participated in different challenges to promote exercise and sports or health and safety during the pandemic (Keshkar et al., 2022b).

Impact of COVID-19 on Sports Sponsorship

Some of the authors agree that sponsorship is an important part of the promotional mix (Belch & Belch, 2007; O'Guinn et al., 2009; Ouwersloot & Duncan, 2008). Sponsorship is defined as "investing in a sports entity (athlete, league, team or event) to support the overall organizational objectives, marketing and promotional strategies" (Shank, 2009, p.324). Sponsorship is an important component of Marketing Mix (Gardner & Shuman, 1988). It is a key part of any sports organization's promotion strategy. Nowadays, sponsors are ubiquitous in sports events of all sizes, and often essential for an event's success. It offers financial backing to a range of organizations and activities, such as sports. Historically, large corporations have been the main sources of funding for the most prominent sponsored events. Nowadays, sponsorship has become more important due to the variety of products and the growth of industries, and the need for promotional activities has grown (Gardner & Shuman, 1988).

The outbreak of COVID-19 in 2019 inflicted extensive damage across various industries, including sports. As the virus spread across the globe, sponsorship for various sports events was deeply affected. A survey found that global sponsorship leaders recognize the far-reaching effects of the COVID-19 pandemic on the sports sponsorship ecosystem, prompting a shift to more meaningful partnerships (Dawes, 2022). Partner on Purpose, a consultancy dedicated to aiding brands in forging meaningful and influential partnerships, convened a survey of 600+ renowned executives in the sponsorship and marketing sphere. The survey was performed in partnership with Loughborough University. Of the survey respondents, 93% agreed that the pandemic has had a profound impact, with the vast majority also agreeing it has made partnerships between sponsors and sports organizations more challenging. However, 75% agreed that the pandemic has created new opportunities as well. A total of 70% believe the pandemic has already changed the nature of partnerships between sponsors and sports organizations, and 96% see partnerships between brands, athletes, and sports organizations becoming more purposeful, innovative, and fluid (Dawes, 2022).

Surveys of industry professionals conducted in April and May 2020 uncovered two key implications of COVID-19 on sport sponsorship: (1) shifting sponsor-ship priorities and (2) reduced sponsorship investments. Initially, most sponsors intended to redirect their sponsorships toward COVID-19 relief

and frontline workers, instead of their original plans, as they felt their previous commitments would be inappropriate or wasted opportunities. Additionally, sponsors expected a decrease in the expenses of sponsorships (e.g., activation and rights fees) (O'Reilly & Abeza, 2020). When the International Olympics Committee (IOC) in collaboration with Japan postponed the 2020 Olympics due to the COVID-19 pandemic, this was expected to lead to an economic loss of 641 billion yen (5.8 billion USD) as a result of expiring sponsorship agreements. Moreover, the delay had the potential to result in a loss of over 900 million USD committed by 70 local sponsorship partners in Japan (Statista, 2021b). In addition to the one-year delay, When the Games took place, Japan still had a critical situation. Consequently, the event was altered, including the elimination of promotional activities and a ban on ticketed spectators. (Murakami, Park, & Slodkowski, 2021).

Sponsors have been adversely affected by pandemic-related alterations and delays due to limited exposure and reach caused by the absence of in-person spectators and promotional events. Moreover, sponsors are crucial in providing financial assistance to Olympic athletes, including covering expenses such as training, travel, and event participation. For instance, when the Olympics' 2021 rescheduling caused corporations to reconsider their contracts, Toyota and Visa announced extensions of their endorsement contracts with over a dozen Olympic and Paralympic athletes, providing reassurance amid uncertainty around the rescheduled Tokyo Games. Athletes were initially worried about these contracts expiring after the 2020 Olympics, which was delayed until 2021 (Burton, 2020). Not only does the sponsor's decision with respect to how they navigate the pandemic (e.g., extend existing sponsorship agreements versus canceling them) have financial implications for the sponsor organization, but it also impacts their brand image (e.g., consumers or future athletes may not want to support or be associated with brands that did not display empathy during the pandemic) (Su and Kennedy, 2022).

The COVID-19 virus had a global impact on all types of sporting events, such as the Olympics, college athletics, school sports, organization competitions, and championship clubs – many of which had sponsors. Sponsors have suffered, especially those relying on a combination of event exposure, player endorsements, and retail sales (Dašić et al., 2020). Adidas, for example, closed its retails stores across the world, while their sponsorship deals collapsed in the vacuum of event and competition closures, not the least of which were the hopes attached to the 2020 Olympics and Euro 2020. During the worst period of the pandemic, 70% of the company's stores were closed. However, Adidas ramped up its digital efforts, driving its products to a record 160 markets around the globe based on a personalization-at-scale model that yielded more than a 90% increase in e-commerce sales (Skinner & Smith, 2021). Moreover, the coronavirus pandemic had not only negative repercussions but also brought about new methods of sport sponsorship. In other words, The COVID-19 crisis has inspired new sponsorships in the sports world.

As mentioned earlier, COVID-19 forced sport organizations to adopt digital technologies to host events, stay connected with fans, and maintain operations without in-person meetings. To make up for the lack of physical presence, organizations used creative solutions that opened up new sponsorship opportunities. For instance, Zoom sponsored the Formula One World Championship (F1) and created the Virtual Paddock Club, which enabled fans to access behind-the-scenes action during races. Restrictions due to COVID-19 have led to an acceleration and emphasis of sport digitization and personalization, creating new sponsorship opportunities. More creative, authentic, and empathic sponsorships are now demanded by consumers, giving way to new sponsorship opportunities. Women's sports, as an interesting and attractive sport dimension, despite the limited existing sponsorships reflect the growing popularity of women's sports. The sustained success of women's sports through COVID-19 (e.g. The Women's National Soccer League Challenge Cup, which drew a considerable record audience during COVID-19 pandemic), indicates a demand for this product and thus underscores it as a quality sponsorship opportunity. Esports sponsorship is another growing area in the sport industry. Advertisers are prioritizing digital advertising opportunities. Unlike physical sports, which were heavily disrupted due to the threat of COVID-19 transmission, online gaming allowed players to maintain social distancing and continue competing. As such, eSports were able to persevere through COVID-19 in a way that physical sports were not (Su and Kennedy, 2022).

Conclusion

The emergence of the COVID-19 pandemic in the world was associated with various effects on the sports industry. On the one hand, sports products that were offered in the form of goods or services were accompanied by changes or sales problems, and on the other hand, the behavior and needs of consumers changed. In order to manage the situation and prevent further economic damage to the sports industry, as well as to prevent social harms and ensure the health of the community in which sport plays an important role, the strategies for producing and marketing sports products were inevitably changed and rearranged according to social needs. Although some changes in production and marketing strategies did not last long and returned to their original form after a while, many products and marketing methods as well as the way the products were delivered to the consumers underwent lasting changes that could be used in the post-pandemic era. But beyond that, the COVID-19 pandemic showed that managers of sports organizations and sports manufacturers must always be prepared for possible future crises so that they do not face deadlocks in managing and developing the sports industry. For this purpose, it is necessary to identify the resources and potentials of sport organizations. It is also necessary to pay attention to the emergence of difficulties and

possible future issues in the organizational planning that can hinder the achievement of organizational goals, and for this purpose it is necessary to consider solutions to manage future issues and crises.

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Chapter 16

Resilience in the Face of Adversity

Examining the Effects of COVID-19 on Physical Activity and the Sporting Industry in Singapore

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Introduction

The coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19) is a respiratory disease that is the latest global health threat recognised in December 2019 (World Health Organisation [WHO], 2020a, 2020b). Similar to previous respiratory diseases, it causes severe acute respiratory syndrome (SARS) and is highly transmissible through human interaction (Parnell, Widdop, Bond & Wilson, 2020). Research showed that COVID-19 infects the individual's cells with a spike protein that links to the angiotensin-converting enzyme 2 (ACE2) receptors expressed on human cells (e.g., epithelial cells of the lung, cardiovascular system, kidneys, central nervous system, gut and adipose tissues) (Remuzzi & Remuzzi, 2020; Dwyer, Pasini, De Dominicis & Righi, 2020).

Recently, it was found that ACE2 act as catalytic functional receptors for SARS coronaviruses (SARS-CoV). The binding effect of ACE2 and SARS coronavirus 2 (SARS-CoV-2) seems tougher than SARS-CoV with more alterations in several amino acids residues (Gheblawi et al., 2020; Dwyer, Pasini, De Dominicis & Righi, 2020). Hence, the COVID-19 outbreak quickly escalated to over a million cases worldwide by the beginning of April 2020 that caused major disruption to the human population, medical research, and communities. As the virus was epicentred in Hubei Province of the People's Republic of China and continued to spread infectiously to other countries, WHO declared COVID-19 a global pandemic on 11 March 2020 (Cucinotta & Vanelli, 2020; Velavan & Meyer, 2020; Gheblawi et al., 2020). Underlying conditions such as hypertension, diabetes, and cardiovascular diseases were among the top conditions among patients diagnosed with COVID-19 that required hospitalisation (Chen et al., 2020b).

It is evident that reducing the risk of this global spread is vital, and previous literature states that large gatherings pose danger to the general public health during similar outbreaks of contagious diseases (e.g., Ebola and SARS) (Barabasi, 2015; Parnell, Widdop, Bond & Wilson, 2020; WHO, 2020a, 2020c). With fewer

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or no large crowd gatherings, it would also help to prevent or reduce the possibility of virus transmission through these mass gatherings (Ebrahim et al., 2020; Qualls et al., 2017; Pandey et al., 2014; Markel et al., 2007). Due to the high number of confirmed COVID-19 cases, several countries, including the United States (US) and China, imposed temporary strict travel restrictions to curb the spread of the virus. Countries have seen a dramatic reduction in the number of travellers and tourists due to the restrictions; however, this was to help slow down the spread of the virus. In addition to these restrictions, governments worldwide started to implement containment to mitigation strategies such as social distancing, wearing of masks, quarantine orders, school closures, telecommuting, and lockdowns (Fauci, Lane & Redfield, 2020).

Singapore had the first imported COVID-19 case reported on 23 January 2020 that eventually led to a series of locally transmitted cases and clusters. The Singapore government steadily increased the number of mitigation strategies to curb the spread of COVID-19, which led to the circuit breaker measure that was similar to a complete lockdown (Chen, Yap, Hsu & Teo, 2020a). People could only leave their houses for essential work (e.g., frontline workers), buy food and/or groceries. The public could also only partake in individual physical activity (PA) such as walking, jogging, running, or cycling. Moreover, no group exercises were allowed during the circuit breaker. In addition, mask wearing was mandatory; people had to adhere to social distancing rules, stay-home-notices, quarantine orders, safe entry check-ins, and contact tracing. Safe entry check-in is a national monitoring system to manage and track individuals visiting places (GovTech Singapore, 2022). Many shops and businesses were highly affected during this period of time.

These strict measures also made a huge impact on the sporting industry, including international sporting events such as the Tokyo Olympics 2020 and Wimbledon. Many of these major competitions and events had to either be postponed or be cancelled (Sato et al., 2020). Drape et al. (2020) also reported that world's sporting organisations declared losses of US$13b in the US sporting leagues, US$28.6b in earnings, costing nearly 1.5 million jobs in US. Furthermore, losses of more than 1 billion euros were reported in some of Europe's major football clubs (Skinner & Smith, 2021). Company sponsors also suffered similar losses or bankruptcy particularly if they were highly dependent on major sporting events, player endorsements, and retail sales as consumers had to stay at home and economies closed down (Dašić, Tošić & Deletić, 2020; Donthu & Gustafsson, 2020).

The use of technology (e.g., video conferencing technology) had helped to improve several challenges faced during the COVID-19 pandemic, such as communication and exercise (Carillo et al., 2020; Hacker et al., 2020; Keesara, Jonas, & Schulman, 2020; Waizenegger et al., 2020). In addition, research has also indicated that virtual gaming worlds also highlight professional athletes' performance, training education, and healthcare (Billieux et al., 2013; Vignais et al., 2015; Flavián, Ibáñez-Sánchez, & Orús, 2019). A study conducted a semi-structured interview among 11 elite cyclists on their perceptions and

evaluations on virtual world vs. real-world sports. These athletes viewed virtual sports positively; however, there is potential manipulation regarding inaccurate performance or data representation (Westmattelmann et al., 2021). This reality-virtual continuum in virtual sports can be further classified into augmented reality (AR – environment augmented by virtual objects generated by computer graphics) and augmented virtually (AV – a virtual world generated by a computer).

Digitalisation on sports can have an impact on various components involved in the sports industry. In the aspect of organisational component, digitalisation may change roles and responsibilities of stakeholders such as coaches, athletes, sponsors, staff, and various government sectors. It may also entice new stakeholders such as broadcasters and service providers to join the company (Xiao et al., 2017). Digitalisation may also affect other areas such as technological component (physical skills, equipment and knowledge); symbolic component (secrecy – concealment of sports tactics and skills, display and rituals – digital communications with feedback); and rituals – well-known gestures and routines in a sport; educational component – acquisition of specific sports skills related to stakeholders (Westmattelmann et al., 2021). These available digital data enhance transparency in sports by reducing imbalanced information (Xiao et al., 2017). Hence, many of such companies in the sporting industries have switched to virtual platforms to drive their sales and ramp up their technological advancements to retain their consumers. One example is Adidas, a renowned sporting goods company, where their sponsorship deals reduced drastically and 70% of the company's physical stores closed. However, they thrived by enhancing their digital platforms that saw an increase in 90% in e-commerce sales (Skinner & Smith, 2021).

In Singapore, the circuit breaker made a great impact on public sectors, schools, recreational centres, businesses, tourism, food and beverage sectors, etc. Looking into the education sector, all Singapore government schools were mandated to implement home-based learning (HBL). New technologies and applications had to be implemented within a short duration. All students had to attend lessons virtually from their homes. The minority who did not possess a learning device or had no conducive place for HBL returned back to school to attend virtual lessons in a well-structured manner. Respective schools provided Information Technology support, commonly known as IT support. Physical education lessons (PE) were also conducted over video call platforms such as Zoom and Google meet. The challenges faced for conducting PE online included, repetitive and limited activities due to lack of sporting equipment and space, limited educational content, and lesson time wasted on numerous trial-and-error methods for a more inclusive and fun session (So & Jeong, 2020). These were accompanied by poor participation and interest of students (Yu & Jee, 2021). The sudden change in educational landscape threw many into disarray due to the lack of understanding of the characteristics of online learning and the factors that facilitate effective and efficient virtual PE lessons (So & Jeong, 2020; Yu & Jee, 2021).

Similar to other countries, Singapore's sporting events and competitions were deeply affected due to the restrictions. All of the competitions and events had to be cancelled or postponed. Moreover, indoor gyms, indoor halls, dance studios, indoor exercise classes, and public fitness corners were closed to the public. In an effort to sustain companies' financial performance and brand engagement, a number of organisations and companies turned towards online brand community engagement through virtual sports races and events (Baldus, Voorhees & Calantone, 2015; Khan, Rahman & Fatma, 2015). With these restrictions, health experts postulated that the COVID-19 pandemic could result in long-term, lasting effects on physical and mental health (Wang et al., 2020). Furthermore, this virus seems to be highly contagious with high morbidity and mortality rates (Sim & How, 2020), which also caused feelings of fatigue, headaches, attention disorder, hair loss, and dyspnoea (Lopez-Leon et al., 2021). Recent studies had also revealed that quarantine measures to counteract COVID-19 had negative effects on mental health where there was an increase in anxiety, depression, insomnia, and stress (Wang et al., 2021; de Lima et al., 2020; Füzéki, Groneberg & Banzer, 2020). With Singapore's stringent COVID-19 restrictions and COVID-19 presence, it is likely to result in long-term negative mental health effects, which may reduce work productivity (Bubonya, Cobb-Clark & Wooden, 2017) and influence physical health (Ohrnberger, Fichera & Sutton, 2017). Due to the recency of the event, research in the effects of a pandemic in Singapore in the areas of PA and sporting industry is scarce.

Reduced PA levels result in adverse health effects such as metabolic, cardiovascular, musculoskeletal fitness, and immune system (Füzéki, Groneberg & Banzer, 2020). Thus, it is essential for people to perform PA even during a pandemic to maintain some form of physical fitness and keep a healthy state of mind. The strict measures to prevent SARS-CoV-2 from spreading could force a reduction in PA levels, which is unfortunate as regular PA can boost the human immune system by counteracting comorbidities (e.g., cardiovascular diseases, diabetes, hypertension) (Woods et al., 2020). As many sports organisations were faced with numerous challenges to continue sports and exercise with normalcy, this study would also look into platforms that were utilised during the circuit break. Therefore, this study aimed to investigate the following:

- The impact of COVID-19 pandemic on the levels of PA among adult Singaporeans in Singapore.
- The coping strategies used during the circuit breaker that may have an impact on the sporting industry in Singapore.

Method

This study was conducted among participants residing in Singapore using the Google Forms web survey platform, with a convenience sampling of

Singaporean male and female adults aged ≥21 years old. A total of 1000 participants completed the survey; 997 participants' data was calculated; 3 were excluded as outliers (Table 16.1). This study also obtained approval from the Institutional Review Board (IRB) from Nanyang Technological University (NTU), Singapore (IRB Reference Number: IRB-2020-05-038). Participants also provided their consent prior to commencement of the survey.

Table 16.1 Descriptive Characteristics and COVID-19 Exposure among Participants in Singapore (N = 997 Participants)

Variable		*N*	*%*
Gender			
	Female	511	51.3
	Male	486	48.7
Age			
	18–24	192	19.3
	25–34	425	42.6
	35–44	228	22.9
	45–54	124	12.4
	55–64	21	2.1
	65 years or older	7	0.7
Education			
	Less than a high school degree	416	41.7
	High school degree	221	22.2
	Associate degree	160	16.0
	Bachelor's degree	163	16.3
	Graduate degree	37	3.7
Marital status			
	Single	579	58.1
	Married	409	41.0
	Other	9	0.9
Number of people co-habiting during the lockdown			
	0	39	3.9
	1	121	12.1
	2	222	22.3
	3	254	25.5
	4+	361	36.2
Lived with a pet			
	Yes	213	21.4
	No	746	74.8
Employment and income changes since COVID-19			
	Employment changed and income decreased	43	4.3
	Employment changed but no change in income	0	0.0

(*Continued*)

Table 16.1 (Continued)

Variable		*N*	%
	No change in employment but income decreased	191	19.2
	No changes in employment nor income	537	53.9
	Others	226	22.7
Personal COVID-19 exposure			
	Went out less than once a month	36	3.6
	Went out at least once a month	254	25.5
	Went out at least once a week	701	70.3
	Had a contact with COVID-19 patient or had to quarantine for 14 days	1	0.1
	Diagnosed with COVID-19 or experienced COVID-19 symptoms	78	7.8

Note: Values are number of participants (n), percentage (%).

A brief description of the study was explained to the participants at the beginning of the questionnaire comprising the purpose of the study and the voluntary nature of the participation. The questionnaire was developed in English, indicating that participants had to be proficient in the English language. Participants had to complete a compulsory informed consent on the first page of the survey to indicate their voluntary participation in the study. Participants were also assured that their responses will be kept confidential. The link to the online survey was disseminated by members of the research team with their personal contacts through various social media platforms such as WhatsApp, Telegram, and Facebook. The survey took approximately 15 minutes to be completed. Thereafter, descriptive analyses of participants' demographics, psychological response data, coping strategies, and levels of PA (intensity level and MET-minutes/week) were analysed.

The questionnaire included questions on the participants' personal demographics, individual psychological responses, coping methods, and levels of PA during the Singapore circuit breaker measures. Anxiety and depression were measured using the valid Adult Patient-Reported Outcomes Measurement Information System (PROMIS®) Short Form v1.0–Anxiety 4a and PROMIS® Short Form v1.0–Depression 4a, with Cronbach's alpha of 0.93 and 0.95, respectively. These forms were provided by the PROMIS® Health Organisation (Pilkonis et al., 2011; The PROMIS Health Organization, 2021). Both scales contained four questions on a symmetrical 5-point Likert-scale (range = 4 to 20) with higher scores representing greater anxiety or depression symptoms (Füzéki, Groneberg & Banzer, 2020).

Resilient coping was measured using the 4-item Brief Resilient Coping Scale which had a Cronbach's alpha of 0.76 and test-retest reliability of 0.71. The scale used a symmetrical 5-point Likert-scale (range = 4 to 20), with

higher scores representing a greater level of resilient coping (Sinclair & Wallston, 2004). Questions on PA included frequency, intensity, time, type of PA, and with whom they exercised. Furthermore, other questions included coping strategies that the participants utilised during the circuit breaker.

All participants' PA data were calculated as mean ± standard deviation (SD) and percentage. The comparison of PA levels pre-COVID-19 and during circuit breaker, intensity level of PA, and PA with children in the same household were also calculated as percentage. Additionally, participants' MET-minutes/week during the circuit breaker were calculated as shown below (Ainsworth et al., 2011). Participants who were unsure of the duration expended on all three PAs were omitted. Participants (n = 795) who were unsure of one or two components were still included in the calculation, with only the relevant components being omitted. Only participants' PA results were analysed for this chapter.

Walking MET-minutes / week during Circuit Breaker
= 3.3 * walking minutes * number of days walking

Moderate MET-minutes / week during Circuit Breaker
= 4.0 * moderate-intensity activity minutes * number of days doing moderate-intensity exercise

Vigorous MET-minutes / week during Circuit Breaker
= 8.0 * vigorous-intensity activity minutes * number of days doing vigorous-intensity exercise

Total MET-minutes / week during Circuit Breaker
= Sum of Walking + Moderate + Vigorous MET-minutes / week

Results and Discussion

Results indicated that for PA, 51.4% of female participants and 42.8% from the 25 to 34 years of age range (Table 16.1). 40.3% of participants (n = 1000) reported their PA as almost the same and 23.8% of participants reported an increase in their PA (Table 16.2). 24.1% of participants did not partake in vigorous PA, 21.0% of participants did not partake in moderate PA, 23.4% of participants did not walk, and 49.5% of participants did not

use online visual programmes (OVP) as part of their PA (Table 16.3). 61.5% of participants (n = 795) completed >500 MET-minutes/week of PA during the circuit breaker (Table 16.2). 35.9% of participants (n = 287) carried out PA with their family members (Table 16.4). Coping strategies reported in the questionnaire were categorised under 19 distinct categories. Based on the responses from 997 participants, the three most prominent coping strategies adopted by Singaporeans were PA participation (73.4%), visual media consumption (72.0%), and interaction with friends through digital media (44.4%) (Table 16.5).

PA has been proven to improve an individual's overall health, which contributes to a reduction in cardiovascular diseases, lowered blood pressure, and improving left ventricular hypertrophy (Hegde & Solomon, 2015). Furthermore, PA has positive influence on insulin levels and metabolic syndrome (Ahmed, Blaha, Nasir, Rivera & Blumenthal, 2012). More importantly, PA has shown to be beneficial in enhancing clinical conditions that are mostly associated with COVID-19. Therefore, it is possible that physically active individuals may have a better control on high-risk comorbidities that intensifies vulnerability to severe COVID-19 as compared to sedentary individuals (Dwyer, Pasini, De Dominicis & Righi, 2020). This study's results revealed a higher percentage of participants that maintained their level of PA (40.3%), which coincides with another article that indicated an expected increase in PA participation in 2021 (Figure 16.1; McKinsey and Company, 2020).

Literature identified possible reasons to an increase in PA and/or maintaining PA frequency. The lack of entertainment propelled individuals to look for ways to alleviate boredom to stay fit and healthy. With travelling as one of

Table 16.2 Comparison of Physical Activity Levels Pre-COVID and during Lockdown, and Metabolic Equivalents (MET)-minutes per Week

Comparison of Physical Activity Levels Pre-COVID and during Lockdown	*Percentage (%)*
Almost the same	40.3
Decreased	25.5
Increased	23.8
Don't know / Hard to tell	10.4
Total	**100(1000 participants)**
Total MET-minutes/week	
0	20
1 – 250	5.4
251 – 500	13.1
> 500	61.5
Total	**100(795 participants)**

Note: Values are in percentage (%).

Table 16.3 Physical Activity according to Exercise Intensity by Participants during the Circuit Breaker

Vigorous Physical Activity (Number of Days)	*Percentage (%)*
No vigorous physical activity	24.1
1 day	10.4
2 days	21.0
3 days	19.9
4 days	5.8
5 days	7.8
6 days	5.0
7 days	3.3
Don't know / Not sure	2.7
Moderate Physical Activity (Number of Days)	
No moderate physical activity	21.0
1 day	17.4
2 days	20.2
3 days	20.2
4 days	6.0
5 days	4.1
6 days	6.7
7 days	4.0
Don't know / Not sure	0.4
Walking (Number of Days)	
No walking	23.4
1 day	7.9
2 days	17.7
3 days	16.5
4 days	7.5
5 days	9.5
6 days	2.9
7 days	14.2
Don't know / Not sure	0.4
Online Visual Programmes (OVP)	
Never	49.5
Most of the time	8.2
Sometimes	30.0
About half the time	4.0
Always	7.4
Don't know / Not sure	0.9

Values are in percentage (%).

the major contributors to the spread of the disease, there was a reduction in frequency for trains and flights due to the decrease in demand for travel (Tian et al., 2020). Furthermore, recreational sports and PA in groups had also been cancelled or prohibited, which may have sparked off interest in individual PA during the lockdown. Confinement within one's country meant looking for avenues to distract and stay active through the pandemic;

Table 16.4 Physical Activity of Participants with Children in the Same Household (n = 287)

	No activity	*1 day*	*2 days*	*3 days*	*4 days*	*5 days*	*6 days*	*7 days*	*Don't Know / Not Sure*
Vigorous Activity									
n	113	31	92	18	0	4	7	8	14
Percentage (%)	39.4	10.8	32.1	6.3	0	1.4	2.4	2.8	4.9
Moderate Activity									
n	49	72	83	54	0	7	8	14	0
Percentage (%)	17.1	25.1	28.9	18.8	0	2.4	2.8	4.9	0
Walking									
n	56	15	87	61	27	13	4	24	0
Percentage (%)	19.5	5.2	30.3	21.3	9.4	4.5	1.4	8.4	0
With Whom Were These Physical Activities Carried Out									
	Individually			**Family Member(s)**			**Don't Know / Not Sure**		
n	170			103			14		
Percentage (%)	59.2			35.9			4.9		

Note: Values are in number of participants (n), percentage (%).

however, community and private fitness centres were closed as part of the government's effort to manage and prevent further widespread of the disease (Hammami, Harrabi, Mohr & Krustrup, 2020).

It is established that COVID-19 had disrupted many sports organisations' sporting events, ceased international sports activities and caused a global crisis in the world (Belli, Mızrak, & Saraçoğlu, 2020; Mataruna-Dos-Santos, 2020). Many major and minor sporting events were either postponed or cancelled, which adversely affected the clubs and organisations. Hence, this led to a decline in tickets, stadiums, fans, and broadcasting revenue (Belli, Mızrak, & Saraçoğlu, 2020), including economic losses for industry owners, athletes, coaches, producers, sponsors, etc. Even if sport was allowed, spectators had to sit within proximity to others and thus the game was played in mostly empty stadiums that affected ticketing sales (Keshkar et al., 2021). However, adaptations took place and the sports industry started its events in a contemporary way with new implemented restrictions in place. Hence, organisations were compelled to reinvent their business models into "the discovery of a fundamentally different business model in an existing business" (Markides, 2005).

Table 16.5 Categories of Coping Strategies Adopted by Participants in Singapore (N = 997)

Coping Strategy	*N*	%
Physical Activity	732	73.4
Visual Media Consumption	718	72.0
Interaction with friends	443	44.4
Interaction with family	300	30.1
Cooking/Baking activities	278	27.9
Reading activities	272	27.3
Work-related activities	229	23.0
Aural Media Consumption	228	22.9
Physical rest or sleep	193	19.4
Eating/Drinking activities	162	16.2
Participation in Hobbies/Recreational activities	150	15.0
Playing Games (digital, tabletop, board, etc.)	146	14.6
Self-education	130	13.0
Household work/chores	123	12.3
Shopping activities (physical or online)	118	11.8
Others	114	11.4
Playing Musical Instrument(s)	87	8.7
School Assignments	27	2.7
Uncategorised	3	0.3

Values are number of participants (n), percentage of participants (%).

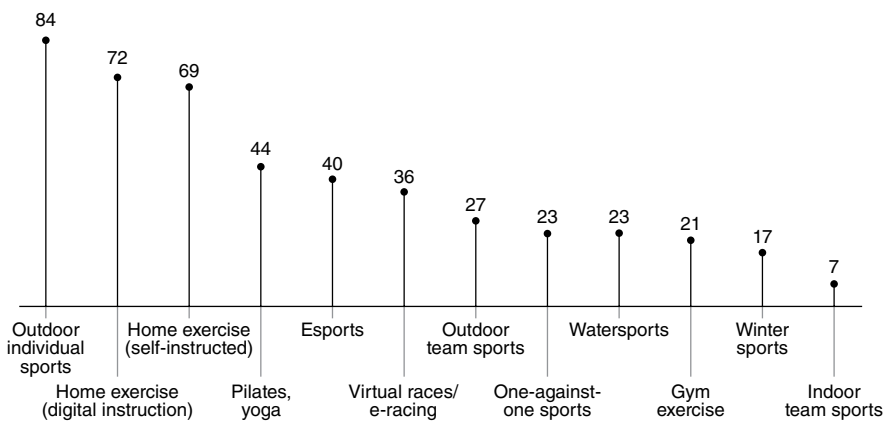


Figure 16.1 Expected Increase in Physical Activity in 2021 vs. Pre-COVID-19 (Joint report from McKinsey and the World Federation of the Sporting Goods Industry, n = 130).

Thereafter, campaigns were even developed by National Olympic Committees (NOCs) to promote Olympism and PA among their respective communities. For example, the Australian Olympic Committee created their own campaigns that advertised Australian Olympians to inspire Australians to "train like an Olympian at home". This aimed to inspire their people to continue exercise and PA through workouts at home (Australian Olympic Committee, 2020). Various athletes created their own positive sporting videos (e.g., skills training, body weight exercises, challenges, and home exercises) and posted them on various social media platforms for the public's view (Hayes, 2020). Athletes who are seen as role models provide an inspirational effect that is engrained among the public that they may be inspired to participate in sports or PA (Giuliano, Turner, Lundquist & Knight, 2007; Hogan & Norton, 2000). Grassroots participation in PA should be influenced by sporting success of the athletes, athletes seen as role models, and hosting major sport events (Wicker & Frick, 2016). Giuliano, Turner, Lundquist, and Knight (2007) also reported children with role models from childhood are more likely to participate in sports at higher levels in the future.

In Singapore, there were campaign videos that showcased Singaporean athletes preparing for the 2020 Tokyo Olympics Games. Some of these campaign videos were played in local schools to inspire the students to participate in PA and/or sports regularly. Singapore's Health Promotion Board (HPB) launched an online campaign, "Stay Well to Stay Strong", to promote healthy habits and lifestyle practices such as hygiene habits, balanced diet, active lifestyle, and sufficient sleep. The activities were available as online resource and follow along classes. The latter were live streamed on various days and different time periods (HPB, n.d.). With consideration of varied fitness level, workout plans were catered to different exercise profile groups, i.e., beginner, intermediate, advanced, families, individuals, children, adults, and senior citizens (HPB, n.d.). As part of the education plan, hospitals in Singapore use their website to promote and encourage exercise during the COVID period. A team from the Department of Physiotherapy, LIFE centre at Singapore General Hospital, published several articles for educating the public about different modes of exercise, which can be efficient and safe when conducted indoors (SingHealth, 2021a; SingHealth, 2021b). An initiative from the National University Hospital (NUH) encourages the geriatrics to stay engaged and healthy both physically and mentally. NUH provides a series of 30-minute exercise videos, sit-down exercise, no-equipment exercise workout, and chair exercises which were made available in four main languages – English, Mandarin, Malay, and Tamil (National University Hospital, 2022).

According to McKinsey and Company (2020), there has been a digital leap during this pandemic as many sporting companies have taken a shift towards virtual fitness due to social distancing and stay-at-home notices. Additionally, businesses that thrived during this period were online-based businesses (e.g., food delivery, online entertainment, online education, online shopping, and

online solutions for remote working) (Donthu & Gustafsson, 2020). Online workouts have been popular, especially when they offer inspiring and creative elements that allow remote exercising at home. Furthermore, more sports trainers are switching to home-based/online exercises on virtual platforms such as YouTube, Facebook, Twitter, and other forms of social media, exercise apps for mobile phone or tablet, and video conference–type software (e.g., Zoom, Microsoft Teams, Google Meet, Vimeo) to demonstrate how vigorous-, moderate-intensity home activities can be conducted. According to Bloomberg (2021), the major tech company Apple introduced a virtual fitness subscription service, "Fitness+" designed for Apple Watch, iPhones, iPads, and Apple TV. Since the beginning of COVID-19, about 80% of fitness consumers live-streamed workouts as compared to 7% in 2019; 72% fitness clubs owners offered virtual group workouts as compared to 25% in 2019. All of the above-mentioned activities could have attributed to the adaptations in the sport industry and participation in PA.

To maintain levels of PA, the co-curricular activities (CCAs) in Singapore schools were conducted via Zoom, as large group gatherings were not permitted. This allows the instructors or coaches to conduct their lessons virtually and the students are able to continue some form of sports training, dance movement or activities. More virtual events like fitness and dance workshops, event live-streaming, and online campaigns were rolled out for the public. Other activities such as Active Enabler Programmes (AEP) support proposals for sports activities and the Nurture Kids Campaign engaged pre-schoolers and their families through sport with safe measures in place. A game app, GameOn Nila, was also developed to allow the public to complete activities at selected nature discovery trails and opportunities to win prizes. Online workshops for the Seniors' Sports Day were also conducted, and these sports included pickleball, qi gong, and table tennis (The Straits Times, 2021). Virtual races such as 5 km and 10 km runs were also organised for participants to use designated apps to clock their distances and timings for submission. This allowed sport organisations to continue managing sporting activities and creating some revenue. Simultaneously, these events also encouraged and motivated the public to move and exercise.

Although there may be limitations such as lack of space or specific training equipment, the use of modern technology to promote PA interactively as well as to record physical parameters can help to indicate the level of fitness (e.g., pedometers, health tracking devices, health apps and other wearable devices) (Dwyer, Pasini, De Dominicis & Righi, 2020). These are promising digital tools to enhance and measure home-based workouts, although more research needs to be conducted on the specific recommendations on their use and long-term goals. Additionally, properly organised virtual races are suitable for pragmatic and serious competitions during the COVID-19 pandemic and virtual competitions allow athletes to maintain their level of fitness, which supplement their physical training (Westmattelmann et al., 2021). With technological

enhancements made to sports and PA, it may motivate the members of the public to continue or maintain levels of PA. Furthermore, this study also indicated that 49.6% of the participants have used online virtual programmes at least half the time during their exercise workouts.

From this major outbreak, there is a need to review and make necessary changes to sports organisations (Parnell, Widdop, Bond & Wilson, 2020). Due to all these changes, many people in the sports industry were affected. Risk assessments were also rolled out if sporting organisations were to organise large gatherings for sports events. These event organisers had to take the following points in consideration during risk assessment for sport mega-events (McCloskey et al., 2020; WHO, 2020c, 2020d): (a) COVID-19-specific considerations (safe distancing, mask wearing, duration, etc.); (b) specific action plan for COVID-19; (c) risk communication and community engagement; and (d) risk mitigation strategies. Such strategies would be essential to help organise sporting events, while adhering to all the safety management measures to ensure everyone's safety during a major infectious disease outbreak.

Sports Singapore (SportSG) addressed immediate challenges for the future, particularly in the sports industry. SportSG collaborated with various communities to offer skills upgrading courses for sports personnel and trainers using SkillsFuture funding. These courses range from digital marketing to service excellence as well as sports science (SportSG, 2021a). An immediate provision of more than 500 opportunities were provided with job opportunities listings that were rolled out progressively on Workforce Singapore's (WSG) SGUnited job portal. Grants and subsidies were given to those who could create ideas to inspire Singaporeans through sport physically and/or mentally. Some organisations had developed virtual competitions by incorporating technology while abiding to the safe management measures. Further recommendations could include a two-year recovery plan for sports and PA in Singapore and in other countries:

- Competitive sports – continued funds for athletes and sports personnel for training and competitions
- Grassroots-level sports – provide support to grassroots organisations in terms of sponsorship and grants for organising more sporting events
- Sports for all – membership fees subsidies for all members in the community clubs or providing free exercises sessions for certain age groups (e.g., below 12 years old, 65 years and above) (Begović, 2020).

Conclusion

Overall, it was found that there was a higher percentage of participants who maintained their levels of PA despite the circuit breaker in Singapore. It is encouraging to have 61.5% of participants (n = 795) participate in PA and

expend more than 500 METs-minutes/week. In addition, no significant disruptions were observed among the participants with children despite the inclusion of HBL for all educational institutes. Staying active is essential during a novel pandemic; however, there should be guidelines implemented to ensure the safety of individuals participating in PA (Wong et al., 2020). Singapore has managed the participation of PA with a variety of guidelines which may have contributed greatly to the results (SportSG, 2021b). Sporting industries in Singapore have been affected by the public health guidelines; however, some of them have adapted and moved their businesses electronically. Furthermore, virtual sports can mediate physical interactions and performances between real and virtual worlds as athletes can still participate in their respective sports virtually, which may help athletes to cope better during the pandemic (Westmattelmann et al., 2021). It was also perceived that virtual sporting events and online audience were an opportunity to cope with financial losses during the pandemic due to most of the cancelled live sporting events (Horky, 2020; Timpka, 2020). It was proposed that virtual sporting events will complement traditional sporting events even after the pandemic (Westmattelmann et al., 2021).

Strategic social media could be one of avenues that sporting industries and sports organisations could focus on to encourage higher levels of PA among the community. Hence, it has become a need for organisations (e.g., schools, businesses, and healthcare providers) to be digitally savvy (Donthu & Gustafsson, 2020). Sports organisations could adopt this approach to be used in mass media PA advertisements to promote PA to the public. With such novel simulcasting opportunities, it increases the chances to provide more exposure to sponsors and allow for more public display. Hence, the findings from this study showed that PA and social interactions are key strategies that Singaporeans use, which support its incorporations into future interventions to maintain good mental health and maintain levels of PA during global health crises, therefore building a stronger body immunity system against such viruses.

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